

ELUSAN - RISING

SUKRAN TRILOGY – BOOK 1 (Part 1)

ARYAN

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DEDICATION

*To my Friend, Wife and Son,
and to those who inspired me
without whom this book would not be completed.*

World Of ORINN



LEMURIAN VALLEY



JOURNEY BEFORE DESTINATION

RISING

PART-1

Prologue

"One man's revolution is another man's terrorism."

-- Evander Primus

(First King of Sukra)

Across the shoreline, a forbidding expanse of trees and plants stood guard, their dense arrangement determined to shield the moonlight to sully its entangled floor with nothing more than a few rays. The forest was old; one was tempted to call it primeval. The wisdom of the Elvan yore sang of the surreal powers of the trees in this forest, the most mystical of all forests in the realm of *Orinn*.

The forest's mystique was a subject of endless debate among erudite minds, who were even more divided in their opinions about its creator. Yet, there was no denying the palpable power that emanated from this enigmatic woodland, a power that only the most sensitive beings could perceive.

Norrin had no time to marvel at the imposing grandeur of this ancient forest, for he was too busy dashing furiously among the towering trees to escape the woodland that had transformed into a treacherous snare.

The Elvan ranger, drawing upon the grace inherent to his species, charged silently through the shrubs and trees, but he frequently glanced back to check if he was still being pursued by the unseen menace.

Even though the dark forest seemed to bear down upon him with its oppressive presence, he was relieved to find no signs of his pursuer.

Did he succeed in eluding his foe in the woods? After all, no creature could match the prowess of an Elvan ranger in the dense embrace of a forest.

Moreover, Elvans felt an innate kinship with any forest, and this forest was as ancient as the Elvan race itself. Yet, for some unfathomable reason, he had an uncanny feeling he did not belong in this woodland, as if the very soil beneath his feet held an inexplicable hostility towards him.

Usually, no one would dare hunt an Elvan in a forest. Yet, an ominous presence hunted them now—*an entity of unparalleled might than anything he had ever encountered.*

A creature born from the very essence of pure darkness embarked on a relentless killing spree, eliminating Elvan scouts who dared trespass into its domain.

He had barely managed to escape the clutches of this sly creature while the rest of his friends fell prey to its ravenous hunger. They paid the price for ignoring their intuition, the subtle warnings that something was amiss within the forest's depths.

Many of his fellow scouts had been influenced by an unfounded prejudice that no hunter could ever best an Elvan in the woods, but this dark creature was not just any ordinary creature.

Unlike the other scouts, Norrin remained undiscovered when he detected a disturbing aura of corruption seeping into the very heart of this ancient forest. He had managed to keep a low profile until he fled from the depths of the forest and slowly made his way back to the shoreline,

where the rest of his brethren were waiting for him to complete his task – to scout the forest for any dangers.

And he had succeeded where the rest of the Elvan scouts had failed—*vanishing from the sinister clutches of the creature stalking them.*

Haunted by the gruesome way his friends were slaughtered, Norrin grappled with a mix of shame and fear for fleeing from the terror that was pursuing him. But his fear overwhelmed his shame. Though he fled the pursuing terror, the memory of the carnage he had witnessed like a coward weighed heavily on his conscience.

Norrin wiped the sweat from his brow and crept stealthily out of the forest, straining to hear any sound that would reveal the presence of the horrible monster pursuing him.

Even though he had evaded the creature so far, he couldn't shake the unsettling sense that he was being observed by something malignant, as if an unseen eye was watching his every move.

Norrin controlled his dread, wondering whether his mind was playing tricks on him when he was already on edge, and resolved to find his way out of this forest with extreme caution.

The cold wind breezed around him in a chilling dance, as if it was mourning the intrusion of an Elvan into this ancient forest.

Even though Elvans were accustomed to the intense cold of winter, Norrin clenched his teeth as the wind slowly caressed him, its touch as delicate yet as relentless as a spider encasing its prey in its silken embrace.

Moonlight gradually illuminated his surroundings as he distanced himself from the forest's heart, revealing the proximity of the forest edge where trees stood less densely.

Relief flooded him as he realized he neared his destination—the shores overlooking the forest, a sanctuary he longed to reach unharmed.

Suddenly, a twig snapped to his right. Norrin, freezing in place, sought refuge and hid behind the trunk of a massive Barcassi tree whose branches spread about him like claws. He strained to detect any nearby presence that might have caused the disturbance.

Did the creature discover his trail?

Silently surveying the glade, he spotted a dark mist enveloping the nearby trees. The mist seemed to writhe and coil, as if it was alive, its tendrils reaching out like the arms of a monstrous entity.

Darkness swallowed him as if an evil being's hand had cast black veils over the moon. And he could not see beyond the swirling dark shadows a few hundred yards away.

Even his renowned Elvan eyes faltered in penetrating the lingering gloom. He understood this was no ordinary woodland creature; it possessed an affinity for dark magic with its power as potent as the darkness itself. Norrin's pulse quickened as he gazed indecisively at the foreboding mist closing in from all sides.

Should he risk fleeing through the dense mist to reach the forest's edge, where his Elvan comrades might offer refuge, or should he attempt to hide until the creature lost his trail? The malevolence of the mist seemed more menacing and formidable than the creature itself.

Don't be fooled by perception like a stupid Sukran! Norrin chastised himself. *All perceptions are lies forged by one's mind.*

Norrin was convinced he couldn't conceal himself from the creature pursuing him any longer. Now that it had detected his scent, it would be impossible to lose the beast.

Norrin grimaced as he recognized that his only chance of survival lay in swift escape rather than waiting for it to discover his location. Drawing a crimson scarf from his coat, he gazed at it solemnly—a memento from his slain friend, Larkin.

He desperately believed that his close friend, Larkin, would no doubt prefer Norrin's escape over sharing Larkin's gruesome fate, and the scent of blood on the scarf would only attract the creature.

Tying the bloody scarf to a small rock he picked from the ground, Norrin hurled it eastward. Utilizing his Elvan magic, he commanded the trees to propel the stone further east, creating a commotion that echoed like thunder through the silent forest. The trees began to wave their branches and batting the stone nestled inside the red scarf further east.

Anxiously awaiting the creature's response, Norrin observed the dark mist hastening toward the forest's eastern edge. As the creature fell for the decoy, he expelled a heavy sigh and, stealthily retreated from behind the Barcassi tree and crept out of the clearing silently.

He steadied his racing heart. Without the scarf, Norrin knew he would have been captured by the mysterious creature.

Thank you, Larkin!

It's time to ascertain whether the monstrous entity possessed the grace to match an Elvan fleeing through a dense woodland at full tilt.

As soon as he stepped past the clearing, he threw caution to the wind and sprinted toward the forest's edge, hoping for refuge from his Elvan comrades.

Norrin sensed the creature catching his scent and turning around to pursue him; it was already less than a thousand yards behind him.

Instead of maneuvering around the trees, Norrin used his Elvan magic to command them out of his way and they duly bend sideways to let him pass. He made a beeline for the one possible place of salvation.

As he passed the trees that had bent sideways to allow him to leap over their trunks, Norrin commanded them to strike the beast advancing on him.

Despite his attempts to command the trees block the creature's path using his Elvan magic, Norrin heard the sound of branches and trees shattering to splinters, but he didn't dare to stop even to peek at the creature as it steadily gained on him. He knew the sounds of shattering branches indicated the creature's inexorable advance.

Unlike Norrin, the colossal shadow tore through the trees, reaching for the Elvan fleeing its grasp.

Fear fueled Norrin's sprint, the impending danger offering an unprecedented surge of adrenaline to help him elude his hunter.

Bright moonlight heralded the forest's end a few thousand yards ahead. Norrin strained to run even faster, leveraging his Elvan grace and power to reach the awaiting comrades while beseeching the trees to shield him from the relentless pursuer.

The creature, frantic to capture its prey before it escaped its clasp, closed in as Norrin

approached the forest's edge. As he reached within a few hundred yards of the forest edge, a massive hand grabbed Norrin's legs, violently hurling him to the ground.

Struggling against the firm grip, Norrin felt the hand, as black as night itself, dragging him back into the depths of the forest despite his desperate efforts to dislodge the monster.

He could not even catch a glimpse of the creature as absolute darkness surrounded it. Although he had heard of creatures wielding various degrees of magic, this one appeared to command the shadows with an intimate familiarity.

Norrin wailed in desperation as he was apprehended a mere few hundred yards from reaching his escape. His cries for aid went unanswered, and the monstrous creature dragged him back to the heart of the ancient forest.

The thickness of the fog not only devoured Norrin's courage but also stifled his scream. Unsheathing the blade at his hip, he futilely slashed at the hand restraining him. His astonishment grew as his metal blade barely made a mark on the dark hand.

The ominous hand forcefully slammed his sword-wielding hand into a nearby tree. Norrin's cry pierced the air as the impact shattered his wrist, forcing him to relinquish his weapon. Faced with no alternatives, Norrin summoned the branches of the surrounding trees to grab him and free him from the monster's formidable grasp. Yet, the dense fog enveloping him thwarted their assistance.

Stunned by the creature's formidable strength, Norrin felt himself being dragged deeper into the woodland. Realization dawned upon him that escape was futile, and his only recourse was to warn his companions against entering this haunted forest and share his gruesome fate.

"Ferruso Bolter!" Utilizing his mana, Norrin uttered a spell in an attempt to launch a firebolt into the sky, but to his surprise, the shadowy mist cocooning him prevented the fire ball he conjured from escaping its embrace.

"What kind of creature are you?" Norrin pondered the creature's unfathomable might. There seemed to be no eluding this entity, a master of darkness unlike anything he had encountered before.

The creature halted its dragging and turned to smirk at Norrin. From the depths of the encircling darkness, malevolent green eyes glowed with a hatred that sent shivers within him.

God save his companions on the shores!

Ethadriel, deeply attuned to the energies within the dark woodland, pondered the uphill challenge it posed to his cohort. While the Elvan contingent disembarked from their ships in hushed silence, his gaze lingered on the forest's imposing presence across the clearing.

The scent of this land, a fragrance that had been absent from his memory for so long, filled his nostrils, and to his surprise, he realized he had missed the sweet aroma of this Lemurian forest. Vivid memories of his last, more enjoyable excursion to these shores flickered across his mind.

How many centuries it has been!

"Lord Ethadriel..." A melodious voice broke the silence from behind him, and a hint of a grin curled on his white lips. His pearly white hair danced around his face as he turned to greet the stunning Elvan princess gliding towards him.

She may be one of the many princess in the Elvan kingdom, sharing royal blood with the ancestry of the Elvan Kings and queens of the past, but she appeared as regal as the queen herself.

Ethadriel acknowledged his ward. "Princess Naomi, I trust your voyage was as serene as the moon herself."

Despite Naomi's attempts to project an air of maturity befitting a hundred-year-old Elvan, Naomi's youthful features revealed her true age of around fifty. Ethadriel couldn't recall ever sending such a young Elvan to these perilous shores.

But he understood the circumstances that had compelled the Elvan Queen to dispatch such an untamed young Elvan into the realm's most unforgiving woodland: *duty*.

Duty is paramount above all others.

Naomi tossed her hair, revealing her long, pointed ears, a telltale sign of her Elvan heritage to any casual observer.

"The voyage was turbulent, but we are not on a pleasure cruise here," Naomi proclaimed with a hint of wisdom beyond her years. "We are here to fulfill our duty, no matter how arduous it may be."

Ethadriel smiled at the young Elvan maiden, who seemed to possess at least the wisdom to recognize the importance of their mission.

"A word of caution, Princess," he advised. "These shorelines are not for the faint of heart, and this silent woodland is far from harmless."

Naomi nodded in acknowledgment of the ranger's words, her gaze lingering on the enchanting shoreline before her, savoring her first glimpse of these lands.

While a hundred more Elvans disembarked from the ships along the shoreline and prepared for the upcoming march into the silent forest, she let herself merge with nature along the gorgeous shoreline.

After years of being raised in isolation from other kingdoms, Naomi yearned to encounter a member of another race. Relations with the other races of the realm were strained at best, and they had deteriorated significantly in recent decades. The Elvans had been embroiled in a war with the Sukrans, who considered themselves the most powerful kingdom in the magical realm of Orinn.

Sukrans, loyal to their true calling as a power hungry and warrior species, began encroaching on the Elvan kingdom, seeking to expand their territory. The Elvans were reluctant to wage war against their former allies, but they were ultimately forced to engage in conflict with the Sukrans.

Naomi had long pondered how alliances forged by their forefathers could withstand the test of time and survive the greed of their descendants. The Sukran race had demonstrated that even the most honorable individuals could be corrupted by power.

Besides, the Sukran's insatiable appetite for magic further exemplified their nature. The

Sukrans relentlessly exploited their innate elemental magic to enhance their lives, their excessive use and misuse of magic threatening to destabilize the very fabric of the realm.

The misuse of magic by the Sukrans had further strained relations among the magical races.

Unfortunately, their lack of understanding of magic's intricacies led the Sukrans astray. Magic was not meant to alter the fabric of the world; it was meant to be nurtured and guided to transform the world for the betterment of all living creatures in the realm.

Naomi was not surprised when the Sukrans declared war on the Elvans decades ago. In her eyes, the conflict with Sukra was inevitable.

The Mayans, the third and the only other sentient race in the realm, fascinated her the most. The Mayans utilized bonding magic to share their power with the creatures that inhabited the wild forests.

While the Mayans were the most primitive of the three races, they were also the most loyal and steadfast. Naomi couldn't comprehend how the Mayans had resisted the urge to evolve for so many centuries. Even the Elvans, who outlived all other races, had been unable to escape the evolutionary power of time.

But the Mayans had stood the test of time, surpassing even the Elvans in their unwavering determination and unwavering commitment to duty.

No surprise the Mayans were considered the most noble and resolute race in the kingdom.

Time changed everything, but not the Mayans. The Mayans' determination and resolve were indeed immortal.

"How long will it take us to reach the Mayan kingdom?" Naomi inquired, turning to the pensive Elvan standing beside her.

Ethadriel remained silent for a prolonged moment, his fingers absentmindedly tracing the handle of the long saber concealed on his right hip.

"Five days at most."

"Then we'd best get started and make haste," Naomi urged.

"Indeed, it is prudent to resume our expedition into this foreboding woodland with all haste, but I await the return of my scouts from their reconnaissance mission," Ethadriel asserted, his voice laced with a hint of unease. He had dispatched twenty of his most seasoned rangers into the wilderness, tasked with scouting for any potential threats lurking within the enigmatic forest and charting the most judicious path towards the Mayan kingdom, nestled deep within the heart of this verdant labyrinth.

Princess Naomi sighed at the old ranger mulling in silence and questioned, "Lord Ethadriel, why do you appear troubled? Surely, nothing could possibly harm our mystical Elvan rangers." She gestured towards the Elvans disembarking from the ships and diligently offloading the provisions. "And we've brought a hundred of our best warriors with us." She pointed to the Elvans disembarking and offloading the food supplies from the ships.

Ethadriel rolled his eyes and sighed at Naomi's naiveté. "Princess, do you comprehend the reason why our esteemed queen has entrusted a hundred of our finest warriors to accompany you on this journey to the Mayan kingdom?"

"Queen *Elanor* has always been one to err on the side of caution." Naomi shrugged nonchalantly, her response failing to satisfy Ethadriel's expectations.

Ethadriel shook his head in disapproval. "Princess, do you believe you are the first Elvan princess in the past few decades to venture upon these shores to fulfill our ancestral duty?"

Naomi's surprise was palpable, her voice stammering as she inquired, "But... what purpose does my presence serve if others have already accomplished the task at hand and fulfilled our duty?"

Ethadriel, having hoped the princess was adequately informed of the expedition's inherent risks, clarified, "You have been sent here, accompanied by this contingent of soldiers, because we are uncertain whether our duty has been fulfilled."

"*Nonsense!* How can we remain oblivious to whether the Elvans dispatched before me have fulfilled their..." Naomi's voice trailed off as Ethadriel's words struck her like a blacksmith's hammer striking an anvil.

An awkward silence descended upon them, punctuated only by the rustling of leaves and the distant calls of wild birds. Naomi's trepidation was evident as she finally mustered the courage to ask, "*Have none of the Elvan emissaries sent to these shores returned to our kingdom?*"

"No, they haven't returned to our kingdom!" Ethadriel shook his head and gestured toward the looming forest. "We lost communication with all the five Elvan emissaries shortly after they ventured into the Lemurian forest."

Naomi stood speechless as she peered at the silent forest. She had not been apprised of the possibility that she might never return to her kingdom. The two fell into a tense silence, facing the forest, contemplating the perils that could be lurking within.

Observing the shrewd expression on Ethadriel's face, Naomi grasped the reason the queen had sent one of her finest warriors to escort her. Initially attributing it to the queen's overprotectiveness, she now realized Ethadriel was there to enhance her chances of returning home after their mission. Despite the uncertainty, she found comfort in being escorted by one of their mightiest warriors.

Meanwhile, Ethadriel sighed heavily. "Soldiers, prepare to enter the forest in five minutes."

Naomi's heart raced with a mixture of terror and disbelief. "But, Lord Ethadriel, the scouts have not yet returned."

Ethadriel rested his arm on the sheathed long saber at his left hip. "Princess, they will not return. Elvan rangers are never late."

Naomi gazed at her protector in disbelief, the ground trembling beneath her feet.

"It seems we must confront the mystery of the forest without any information and forewarning," Ethadriel declared, his voice barely a whisper.

"But..." Naomi stuttered.

"Fear not, Princess," Ethadriel reassured her, clenching his fist around his longsword. "A hundred Elvans will safeguard you against any creature that haunts this woodland."

Naomi resembled a kitten entangled in a web as she regarded the darkness that enveloped the trees along the trail, closely followed by the Elvan cohort.

Ethadriel strolled behind her, his gaze unwavering as he surveyed their surroundings. The remaining hundred Elvans moved in silence, their Elvan grace evident in every step. Naomi and Ethadriel maintained their position at the center of the procession.

Naomi took pride in her ability to use her ranger skills to advance undetected, avoiding the attention of the forest's predators. She had no desire to draw attention to their large group of Elvan intruders.

Despite the moonlight illuminating the trail, the Elvans on the front ranks used their mana to create simple but effective blue lights, following Ethadriel's instruction to conserve energy on their way to escort the princess to the Mayan kingdom.

An unsettling edge permeated the air, causing the Elvans' hackles to rise. The cold seeped into their bones as they traversed the eerie, silent woodland, with only the occasional rustle of leaves or distant bird calls breaking the silence. Born and raised in forests, the Elvans sensed that something was awry in this untamed woodlands.

Naomi couldn't shake the unsettling feeling that something trailed her every step into the heart of the forest. She wished the Mayans had established their civilization on the forest's border, making her journey much easier.

Ethadriel tilted his head, surveying the surroundings as they delved deeper into the forest. "Strange," he muttered to Naomi. "We haven't encountered a single animal thus far."

Acknowledging Ethadriel's observation with a nod, Naomi turned, her gaze sweeping across the forest devoid of any animals. With each stride, she felt the weight of the woods pressing down on her soul. Had the animals abandoned this part of the forest, or had they been chased away? Her imagination conjured terrifying explanations for the animals' absence.

Twelve miles from the shore, the Elvan contingent continued their silent journey through the forest. Their pace slowed when one of the Elvans in the front signaled the group to halt.

Naomi observed as the squad leader, Veradin, crouched for a moment before rising to his feet and approaching her with an Elvan longsword. "What's the matter, Veradin?" Ethadriel inquired.

"What's the matter, Veradin?" Ethadriel inquired.

Veradin, the squad commander, stammered, "Lord Ethadriel, this sword belonged to Norrin."

"Norrin?" Naomi questioned the squad leader. "Who's Norrin?"

"Princess, he was one of our scouts. The finest scout of the lot deployed into this woodland."

Ethadriel took the sword from Veradin. "Revelia Trailesium..." he whispered. A white ball of light enveloped the sword before rising above their heads.

The light swirled and danced before darting towards the front lines of their escort. Veradin's gaze followed the ball of light until it struck the ground, where he retrieved Norrin's sword. If anyone could track down the missing scouts, it was Lord Ethadriel.

To everyone's dismay, the orb of light continued to circle where the sword had been

found. After a few seconds, it began buzzing around the surrounding trees before suddenly exploding and fading away.

Veradin and the other Elvans gasped in surprise, while Ethadriel displayed utter bewilderment.

"What happened?" Naomi asked.

"Lord Ethadriel is the finest ranger in our kingdom," Veradin replied. "His magic to locate missing objects is unrivaled. Yet, it seems his magic has been thwarted and forced to extinguish itself."

"Forced?" Naomi echoed.

"Yes, Your Grace," Veradin growled. "We are not alone in this wilderness."

Naomi felt a chill as she realized that a supernatural creature was preying on them. Ethadriel raised his hand, closed his eyes, and yelled, "Demacus Revelia!" A gust of wind encircled the Elvan group. "We shall know if any presence is lurking nearby," Ethadriel stated.

Ethadriel, his eyes closed and hand raised, bellowed, "Demacus Revelia!" A whirlwind encircled the Elvan group.

"We shall discern any presence that lurks nearby," Ethadriel declared as he instructed his wind spirit to soar to every corner of the forest for a mile surrounding them, seeking out their mysterious intruder.

As the Elvan group awaited Ethadriel to reveal the whereabouts of their mysterious visitor, the potent gust of wind returned, crashing against them with twofold ferocity.

All but Ethadriel, shielded by a sphere of white light, were thrown back by the staggering blow.

Scrambling to their feet, the Elvans surveyed their surroundings warily, shocked by the unseen foe's ability to counter Ethadriel's magic.

A tense silence consumed the clearing, only broken by the murmuring stream flowing a few hundred yards east.

"*Elvans, retreat to your kingdom...*" boomed a raspy, chilling voice, echoing through the air.

Naomi shuddered as the soulless, malicious voice resonated around her.

"Flee while you still have a chance," it rasped sinisterly.

Ethadriel, recovering from the unexpected magical defeat, commanded, "Elvans! Form a circle around the princess!"

Swiftly, the Elvans obeyed, surrounding Naomi in a tight, shield-like formation.

"*Ferrosium Raiselia!*" Ethadriel roared whilst Naomi scrutinized the surroundings with alarm. A torrential wave of fire surged from his hand, encasing the formation in a fiery shield.

Naomi watched with bated breath as Ethadriel's inferno purged the shadows from the clearing. The fiery shield offered a comforting sense of security. She realized that while Ethadriel's wind magic had been countered, he was distinguished for his formidable fire magic. His control over the fire spirit was potent enough to obliterate forests; surely a creature lurking within one such foreshadowed little threat?

"*Hmm... an Elvan fire high mage,*" replied the malevolent voice.

A brief silence ensued before a windstorm materialized before the Elvans' fiery shield.

The windstorm grew in magnitude and began absorbing the air surrounding it.

The Elvans were slowly drawn into the windstorm's massive vortex before they thrust their swords into the earth to avoid being sucked into it.

Ethadriel clutched Naomi's forearm, battling to maintain the fire shield. Naomi gasped in surprise as when the windstorm sucked the air and choked the flames, the shield dissipated.

"*Foolish fire mage*," the demonic voice cackled, "*you forget that fire cannot exist without air*." The wicked man's windstorm circled the Elvan formation to tease the astounded Elvan warriors.

Ethadriel rumbled under his breath, recognizing the source of the magic. "This is *Sukran magic*!" Shock laced his voice, incredulous at the display of power from a race considered inferior to Elvans.

This revelation spurred confidence in the remaining Elvans, relieved to face a Sukran rather than the more formidable foes their imaginations had conjured.

A wave of relief washed over Naomi as the odds of escaping her adversary unscathed multiplied exponentially. "*Dispersia Narehiem!*" Ethadriel roared, pointing at the windstorm. With minimal effort, he commanded the wind spirit to dispel the windstorm.

The Elvan warriors cheered as their commander quelled the windstorm. However, Ethadriel remained focused on the threat, a frown marring his face as he contemplated the potency of his adversary's magic, capable of shattering a shield which even the most powerful Elvans struggled to overcome.

Ethadriel recognized it would be unwise to underestimate their foe.

"*Ferrosium Revellia!*" he yelled, clenching his hand as he summoned the fire spirit once more.

A ring of flames erupted from his hand, engulfing the entire clearing. Though intense enough to scorch stone, Ethadriel controlled the flames to leave the trees unharmed.

The Elvans saw a portion of the fire halted at the far end of the trail from spreading further by some unseen force.

"Sukran, surprised to have your location uncovered?" Ethadriel taunted their foe as the flames revealed the location of the invisible creature.

A chilling silence followed as shadows gathered at the far end of the trail. Finally, a humanoid figure revealed itself, shrouded in a dense web of darkness.

The Elvans gulped as their enemy's silhouette blended with the surrounding shadows in the glade, only a pair of spooky, blazing green eyes visible through the gloomy darkness at the far end of the glade.

Ethadriel attempted to ease the mounting tension. "Sukran, we hold no ill will towards you or your countrymen. We simply journey to the Mayan kingdom."

He offered a chance to the Sukran, "Step aside, and you can boast to your barbaric brethren that you crossed paths with the Elvans and lived to tell the tale."

Though little love existed between the races since the Elvantis War, fighting this Sukran was not their mission.

The shadow snarled back. "*There is nothing to boast about if I let Elvan weaklings roam freely in my land.*"

Ethadriel raised his hands, calming the Elvan warriors who bristled at the insult and yearning to to decimate their foe.

"*Veradin, teach this naive Sukran about the potency of Elvan magic!*" Ethadriel commanded.

Veradin extended his palm towards the shadow, conjuring a bolt of lightning that surged towards their enigmatic adversary.

A dense barrier of shadows materialized around the Sukran, effortlessly absorbing the lightning's fury. Gasps of astonishment rippled through the Elvan ranks, witnessing the seemingly invincible force of lightning being neutralized by mere shadows.

Ethadriel's brow furrowed as he observed the Sukran's continued display of formidable power. An unsettling aura emanated from this individual, suggesting that he was no ordinary Sukran.

"Soldiers, unleash your arrows and magic!" Veradin commanded his warriors.

The Elvans swiftly drew their bows, releasing a volley of enchanted arrows imbued with primal energies. The arrows soared towards their foe at lightning speed, yet none could penetrate the impenetrable black shield.

Unlike his fellow Elvans, Ethadriel had never harbored the prejudice that Elvan magic held inherent superiority over Sukran magic. However, the sight of a single Sukran effortlessly deflecting hundreds of Elvan magic arrows was beyond comprehension.

The Elvans lowered their bows in stunned silence, their combined efforts rendered futile by their opponent's mastery of shadows.

"*Now, it's my turn,*" the shadow hissed menacingly.

Multiple shadowy orbs, each ten feet in diameter, materialized and smashed into the Elvan formation, shattering their hastily erected magical shield like fragile paper.

"*How is this possible? How can formless shadows harm another being?*" Ethadriel muttered in disbelief, his eyes wide with astonishment.

He watched in horror as the shadowy orbs began to drag his fellow warriors away like helpless children caught in a relentless river current. Soon, gaping holes riddled his formation. The unfortunate soldiers struggled desperately to escape the shadowy grasp, their efforts proving futile against the irresistible pull and were were dragged out into the waiting hands of the darkness beyond the glade.

Naomi screamed in terror as she witnessed the black orbs snatch away several of her companions. Reading about wars and heroes was one thing, but witnessing her comrades fall to such bizarre sorcery was a chilling reality that she realized was not prepared to encounter.

Ethadriel flung his arms wide and bellowed, "*Awaken, Woodlorium!*"

In response to his command, branches sprouted from the surrounding trees, expanding rapidly to envelop the disorganized Elvans in a protective shield.

Ethadriel swiftly instructed his warriors to reform their formation, and the trees intertwined their branches, forming a dome-shaped barrier made of sturdy bark.

The trees successfully deflected their adversary's shadowy orbs, providing much-needed respite for the Elvan troops. They had heard tales of Sukrans using their elemental magic to move stealthily through shadows, but witnessing one employ shapeless shadows to drag Elvans to their

doom was a horrifying revelation.

Naomi regained her footing and observed the trees of the forest arriving to their defense, shielding them from their adversary's dark sorcery.

She adjusted to the sudden darkness that enveloped the Elvan group as the trees blocked out even the moonlight's faint glow.

The battle fell into an eerie silence as their foe ceased his magical assault on the trees guarding the Elvan warriors.

Naomi could feel the tension in the air, a palpable weight that pressed down on her entire being

"*Yet another foolish move, fire mage,*" the sinister voice ridiculed, its mockery echoing through the clearing.

A sudden scream pierced the air, shattering the tense silence. All eyes turned towards the source, their hearts pounding in unison as they witnessed an Elvan soldier being sucked into the ground, his disappearance as swift as a vanishing shadow.

A few nearby soldiers rushed to assist their comrade, but it was too late to prevent the man from being buried alive. The earth engulfed the Elvan soldier, leaving no sign of him.

Panic gripped the Elvan ranks as a chorus of screams erupted from various corners of their formation. The sight of their comrades being devoured by the earth sent shockwaves of fear through their hearts.

Ethadriel observed the despair etched on the faces of his warriors, men trained to protect their lives with their mana, the magical essence that fueled their spells. Yet, none had been trained to combat the earth, now transformed into a ravenous beast, swallowing their comrades whole.

Even the Elvans who had raised shields of mana were no match for the earth's insatiable hunger. Their magical barriers proved futile as they spiraled into the depths of the ground, their protective spells rendered powerless against the earth's relentless grip.

What use was magic if one couldn't even stand on the earth? And they had not brought any earth mage to aid them in preventing such a catastrophe.

Ethadriel cursed himself for failing to heed the Sukran's warning about his foolish mistake. In his haste to shield his men from the dark sorcery, he had summoned the trees to their aid. However, the trees and their branches cast dark shadows within their formation, shadows that the cunning Sukran had exploited, using his shadow magic to leap between them and sow chaos among the Elvans.

Ethadriel waved his hands, summoning a massive orb of light that illuminated the clearing, banishing the encroaching darkness that had aided their adversary. Yet, their Sukran foe was nowhere to be seen.

"*Too late!*" The malicious voice cackled, sending shivers down their spines.

Ethadriel spun around, his heart sinking as he discovered that twenty-five of his warriors had vanished without a trace, whisked away by the Sukran's dark sorcery.

The sudden silence that followed was more unsettling than the chaos they had just

witnessed. The Elvans stood frozen in place, their minds grappling with the inexplicable disappearance of their comrades.

Pure terror filled their mind on realizing that this Sukran was not an foe to be surpassed easily like the rest of his brethren.

Amidst the tense silence, a deafening crash echoed through the clearing, and the Elvans watched in horror as massive boulders slammed against the trees shielding them, splinters raining down like deadly shards.

The tree shield, once a symbol of protection, began to buckle under the relentless assault, its branches groaning under the immense weight of the boulders slamming into it.

"Elvans, use your mana to create shields around yourselves!" Ethadriel instructed his soldiers, his voice laced with anxiety.

The Elvans, their survival instincts kicking in, swiftly summoned their mana, forming multicolored shields around their bodies. They understood that such crude use of mana would drain their magic rapidly, but the impending collapse of the tree shield left them with no choice.

After what seemed like an eternity of relentless bombardment, the tree shield finally crumbled, shattering into fragments as twenty-foot boulders rained down upon the huddled Elvans.

Ten of the massive rocks collided with the Elvans' magical shields, disintegrating upon impact. However, each impact chipped away at their precious mana reserves.

More boulders followed, each one met with the same fate, pulverized by the Elvans' dwindling but unwavering shields.

As the final salvo of boulders hurtled onto them, the Elvans whose mana had been depleted were forced to discard their shields, their faces etched with grim determination.

They stood defenseless, their fate hanging in the balance, their only weapons against this formidable foe was their swords and their courage.

The battle fell into an uneasy silence, the Elvans' eyes fixed on their mysterious adversary, standing at the far end of the clearing, surrounded by fallen trees.

Ethadriel sensed the fear that gripped his warriors, their spirits dampened by the loss of their comrades and the rapid depletion of their mana.

As a high mage, he knew it was his duty to protect his soldiers, to find a way to subdue their enemy without further bloodshed.

"*Arrestum Woodlorial...*" Ethadriel whispered the ancient incantation, his voice resonating with power.

The trees behind the mysterious creature responded to his command, their branches sprouting and writhing, reaching towards the shadows that surrounded their foe.

"*Arrestum Woodlorial...*" Ethadriel chanted once more, and the branches surged forward, engulfing the shadows in a tangle of woody branches.

The shadow struggled against the trees' relentless grip, but more branches sprang forth, entwining themselves around his hands and legs.

The shadow, realizing the futility of his resistance, resorted to his earth magic, summoning a hand of pure black stone from the depths of the earth. He slammed the black stone-hand against

the branches, but to no avail as more branches replaced the one he shattered. Additional branches materialized, subduing the magical stone hand.

As the shadow strained against the trees' relentless hold, Ethadriel growled, his voice echoing through the clearing, "You should not have taken away my warriors. I intended to spare you for your misguided and naive attempt to halt so many Elvans, but now you must be punished for the innocent lives you have taken."

The shadow, his voice dripping with disdain, abruptly ceased his struggles and let out a chilling cackle. "*Fire mage, do you truly believe these pitiful trees are sufficient to subdue me?*" The darkness hissed, its menacing tone sending shivers down the spines of those who dared to listen.

As the shadow strained against the trees' relentless hold, Ethadriel growled, his voice echoing through the clearing, "You should not have crossed paths with us, Sukran. Your arrogance has brought about your downfall."

Ethadriel unleashed a barrage of molten firebolts, each one capable of scorching even the hardest granite. The fiery projectiles struck the shadow, causing explosions that illuminated the clearing with an eerie orange glow.

The Elvan soldiers, their mana reserves dwindling but their spirits unbroken, rallied behind their commander and joined in the assault. They fired volley after volley of flaming arrows using the last vestiges of their mana, the enchanted arrow tips piercing the shadow's defenses and sending plumes of smoke swirling around the Sukran.

As the Elvan soldiers saw the shadow deflect Ethadriel's firebolts, they used the last of their mana and assisted their leader by firing volley after volley of flaming arrows at the shadow, who struggled to free himself from the tree that had imprisoned him to the spot.

When the arrows struck the black shield, they detonated and spewed flames around the Sukran.

A dense cloud of smoke engulfed the shadowy figure, concealing him from view. The Elvan warriors, their hearts pounding with a mixture of trepidation and anticipation, awaited the smoke to clear, their eyes fixed on the spot where their enigmatic adversary had vanished.

Naomi, her young mind still reeling from the sheer intensity of magical power unleashed in the heart of the clearing, could scarcely comprehend the spectacle she had just witnessed.

The Elvans united together to eliminate the incredibly powerful Sukran while he was cornered. After eventually running out of mana, the Elvan warriors panted and ceased firing bolts at the Sukran.

As the smoke gradually dissipated, the Elvans strained to pierce through the lingering haze, their hopes for the Sukran's demise flickering like embers in the wind. But their hopes were dashed when the shadowy figure emerged, his glowing green eyes piercing the dim light filtering through the forest canopy.

"Is this the best that the illustrious Elvan troops could devise against a single Sukran?" The shadow taunted, his voice dripping with disdain and mockery despite still being restrained by trees. "Your feeble attempts to defeat me are nothing more than a child's plaything."

Veradin, his face etched with despair and disbelief, could not fathom how any being could withstand such an onslaught of magic. Their arrows, spells, and even the combined might of their

fire bolts had failed to subdue their adversary.

Ethadriel, his mind racing, realized that brute force alone would not be enough to vanquish their adversary after they had squandered their mana uselessly. He needed to think strategically, to exploit the shadow's weaknesses.

"Let's discover if the Sukran is also impervious to our weapons," Ethadriel declared, his voice resonating with newfound determination.

The Elvan soldiers charged forward, their longswords gleaming in the moonlight. But as they closed in on the shadow, a surge of water erupted from a nearby stream, forming massive orbs that rolled towards them like unstoppable juggernauts.

The Elvans, caught off guard by this unexpected attack, were forced to slow down, their advance halted by the relentless tide of water. The twenty-foot orbs crashed over them, sending them reeling and drenching them to the bone.

Ethadriel, his brow furrowed with concern over the Sukran's unexpected use of water magic, conjured a shield of blazing fire to protect himself and Naomi. The water orbs, propelled with immense force, collided against the barrier, sending a plume of scalding steam billowing into the air.

The drenched Elvans, their bodies shivering from the frigid assault, exhaled a collective sigh of relief as they realized the water had not caused them any harm. With renewed vigor, they pressed forward towards their captured adversary, their determination unwavering despite the Sukran's formidable powers.

"Do you truly believe your tree magic could subdue me?" The shadow hissed, his voice dripping with disdain.

"The trees have successfully restrained both your shadow and earth magic," Ethadriel retorted, his voice firm and resolute. "You require fire magic to burn the trees, but you have overlooked the Sukrans' inability to create energy."

Ethadriel responded, "You can just transform energy, and without a source of fire nearby, there is no way for you to escape the trees pinning you down."

The shadow's green eyes, pulsating with an eerie intensity, flickered mirthlessly.

"Perhaps it's time to shatter your illusion of reality, fire mage," the shadow replied, echoing Ethadriel's earlier words. With a clenched fist, he unleashed a surge of power.

The Elvan troops regarded the shadow with apprehension.

Naomi watched in horror as a torrent of heat erupted from the drenched Elvan soldiers, the warmth in their bodies and the water clinging to their bodies were sucked away. At once, their faces contorted in agony, their bodies freezing in place, transformed into lifeless snow sculptures.

The shadow willed the fire pouring from the troops to set fire to the tree branches restraining him.

The fire quickly spread to all the trees in the area, igniting the entire clearing.

Naomi's heart pounded with terror as she witnessed her comrades morphing into frozen statues before her very eyes. The grotesque sight, so unnatural and horrifying, left her speechless.

The flaming trees, fueled by the heat extracted from the Elvans, illuminated the clearing, casting an eerie orange glow upon the frozen statues of her Elvan escorts. She realized that she

would forever remember this terrifying scene all her life.

Ethadriel regarded the glade in dismay as he realized he had been vanquished magnificently by a man he had grossly underestimated.

The blazing trees that held the darkness were ripped from the ground as a swarm of earth-cast hands ascended and pulled the trees beneath. The earth-cast hands were of hard rock formed by the Sukran's earth elemental magic and were commanded to smash at all the trees and drag them into the ground.

One by one, the trees behind the shadow were consumed by the earth, leaving no trace of their once vibrant presence.

Finally, liberated from the last branch that had held him captive, the shadow flexed his shoulders, his muscles rippling beneath his dark cloak. He turned towards Ethadriel, his green eyes glowing with an ominous intensity.

"I have survived your magic," the shadow declared, his voice echoing through the clearing. "Can you survive mine?"

Ethadriel, overwhelmed by grief and the weight of his failure, ignored the Sukran's challenge. Instead, he approached the statue of his second-in-command, Veradin, whose face still bore an expression of bewilderment at the sudden enchantment that had transformed him into a frozen Elvan within a fraction of a second.

As Ethadriel's fingers lightly touched Veradin's statue, it crumbled into dust, leaving him grasping the remnants of his long-time friend.

"Fire mage," the shadow's voice pierced the silence, "you are correct. Sukran elemental magic can only transform one energy into another."

"So, can we not transmute the warmth surrounding your drenched comrades into fire?" The shadow taunted.

"For a prepared and astute mind, nothing is impossible." The shadow proclaimed

"Of all the places in this forest, why do you think I revealed myself to you in this particular glade?" The shadow gestured towards the nearby stream.

"There is an abundance of elements in this glade that a Sukran could utilize." The shadow enlightened the Elvan high mage.

Ethadriel's unbridled rage intensified as he realized he had failed to safeguard his men. He let out an anguished howl at the silhouette of the shadow hovering ten feet above the ground.

Ethadriel unleashed a volley of pure molten fire at the dark shadow encased in a black shield made of pure darkness. The enraged Elvan ranger was able to conjure more fire than ever before thanks to his desperation and rage.

Ethadriel acknowledged his defeat at the hands of his undeniably stronger adversary. There was only one course of action left for him before succumbing to the monster.

Ethadriel devised a plan to distract the Sukran long enough for Naomi to flee to the safety of the ships awaiting her on the shores.

He instructed his fire spirit to gather all the flames erupting from the ablaze trees and engulf the monster lurking within the dark shield.

If the trees were to be consumed by flames, he intended to utilize the resulting fire to

annihilate the monster who had ignited them.

Ethadriel observed the shadow struggle to block the flames emanating from his palm and the trees.

"Naomi..." Ethadriel shouted, "Run back to the ships while I hold off this monstrosity for as long as I can."

Naomi needed no further encouragement, having been utterly petrified by their adversary.

She turned and attempted to escape back to the coast, but before she could escape the blazing glade, gigantic black stone hands rose like a wall around the clearing, preventing her from fleeing.

"Did you truly believe you could easily evade me? The offer to let you flee back to your kingdom has expired." The shadow hissed even as it struggled to contain the flames unleashed by the Elvan high mage.

Meanwhile, Naomi fired magical bolts at the hand blocking her path and pulverized it to pieces.

She dashed towards the opening with renewed hope but was lifted off the ground by a powerful gust of wind.

Naomi screamed in terror as she dangled hundreds of feet in the air in a violent windstorm.

"Lord Ethadriel!" Naomi cried out to attract the attention of the fire mage who was battling to subdue the evil monster.

Ethadriel conceded defeat upon hearing that Naomi had been captured once more by the cunning Sukran, and he exhaustedly ceased summoning fire from his hands.

The fire around the shadow vanished in an instant.

Ethadriel was startled to discover Naomi suspended hundreds of feet above the ground. He was about to summon his wind spirit to liberate her when the shadow behind him let out a chilling laugh.

"Fire mage, would you rather murder the girl by dispersing my windstorm with your wind spirit? The poor girl will fall to her death." The shadow mocked the fire mage.

Ethadriel recognized the truth in the shadow's words, yet he had no choice but to attempt it.

He had already failed to protect his comrades, and he had only one task remaining to be fulfilled. He could not allow the last surviving member of his squad to perish while he was still alive.

Ethadriel summoned his wind spirit to dissipate the whirlwind holding the princess in place.

"No!" Naomi screamed as she plummeted hundreds of feet towards the ground when Ethadriel's wind spirit shattered the windstorm holding her.

Ethadriel waved his hand towards the nearby trees to catch the princess before she hit the ground. One of the nearby trees, blackened by the Sukran's fire, hurled its branches at the princess, but most of them were too late to catch her.

Naomi braced herself for impact as the ground sped towards her, but a branch suddenly

seized her leg and flung her into the air to slow her descent.

Naomi cried out as she landed on the ground with significantly less force than anticipated and opened her eyes in relief to discover that she was unharmed.

"Elvans and their penchant for commanding the trees." The shadow tutted and shook his head.

Ethadriel staggered towards Naomi and helped her stand. Ethadriel turned to defend the princess against the smirking monster.

"*Fire mage, it seems your mana has run dry.* How do you intend to protect the young Elvan girl?" The shadow inquired as he approached them.

Ethadriel hissed, "I am certain that you will soon vanquish me, but I will take you with me so that Naomi can fulfill her duty to the realm."

"*Duty?*" the shadow sneered.

"Are you referring to the duty that your predecessors to this forest failed to complete?" The shadow of the Sukran smirked.

Ethadriel and Naomi were taken aback by this revelation from their mysterious foe.

"What do you mean?" Ethadriel frowned in disbelief. He tried his best to discredit the information which spelled the doom of his predecessors sent to this forest.

"Yes Elvan, your mind is not fooling you!" the shadow boomed, its voice echoing through the ancient trees. "*Over the last few decades, I have slain every Elvan sent by your queen to fulfill your race's solemn duty in the Mayan kingdom.*"

By the great one! Naomi gasped in disbelief at the revelation.

Ethadriel knew he had to buy time, to stall this monstrous entity as long as possible. Someone had to carry out their duty, no matter the cost. The thought of the consequences of their failure made him shudder.

The Elvan ranger, his mana depleted, knew his connection to his fire spirit had been severed. Yet, he stood tall, his resolve unwavering.

With a swift motion, Ethadriel unsheathed his long metal saber, its polished blade gleaming in the fading sunlight. He held it defiantly against the terrifying dark shadow that toyed with a warrior of his caliber.

The shadow let out a mocking laugh at the fire mage's futile attempt to defend himself. "I must commend your foolhardy courage, fire mage," it sneered.

The shadow halted several feet away from the Elvans, its movements fluid and predatory.

Ethadriel's eyes burned with determination. "I will protect Naomi until the very last drop of blood drains from my veins," he vowed, his voice echoing through the clearing.

"Oh, we can't have that, can we?" The silhouette teased, its voice dripping with malice.

With a wave of its hand, the shadow conjured a powerful gust of wind, which swirled around them, encircling the statues of the fallen Elvan soldiers.

"Fire mage," the shadow hissed, its voice laced with menace, "if you do not lower your sword and surrender, you will witness my windstorm shatter your men to pieces, their frozen forms crashing to the ground and shatter."

Ethadriel was speechless, his eyes wide with horror as the shadow's words sank in. He

turned to gaze at the statues of his comrades, their frozen faces staring back at him, their eyes filled with a plea for deliverance.

Ethadriel wrestled with an agonizing decision, torn between defending the princess from this formidable Sukran and granting his soldiers their final wish—to reach the afterlife.

But he was aware that he had already lost his companions, and the only thing left for those troops was their wish to be delivered to the after-realm.

Ethadriel struggled with the decision that was posed primarily to blacken his soul. He stared at the statues that seemed to be pleading with him to send them to the after-realm.

The shadow's words echoed in his mind, a stark reminder of the consequences of his actions. His soul ached with the weight of his decision, a decision that could potentially doom his comrades to an eternity of imprisonment in their frozen forms.

Could he deprive his warriors' final hope of reaching the after-realm?

Elvans were continually looking for a means to leave their earthly remnants and ascend into the after-realm, but his treachery may curse them to remain statues forever. And even worse, their statues would crumble to dust if any wild animal touched them.

"*Duty is paramount*," Ethadriel whispered more to himself, his oath guiding him towards the right path, even if it meant making a heart-wrenching sacrifice.

With a heavy heart, Ethadriel raised his sword and pointed his blade at the shadow, steadfast in his resolve to exchange the souls of his warriors to fulfill his duty—to defend Naomi at any cost.

The shadow's expression shifted from mockery to a grudging respect. "Well, well," it muttered, its voice laced with surprise. "I admire your resolve, fire mage. For your courage, I shall honor you by not using magic in our duel."

With a swift motion, the shadow drew a black blade from the swirling darkness around it. The longsword, as dark as the night itself, emitted an aura of power and menace.

Naomi watched in fear as the shadow and Ethadriel faced each other, their blades poised for battle. She knew that the fate of their quest, and perhaps their very lives, rested on the outcome of this duel.

Drawing his own blade, Ethadriel charged towards the shadow, a flicker of hope burning within him. He believed that his Elvan grace and skill might still allow him to save the princess.

This Sukran had defied expectations, wielding magic far more potent than any Elvan had ever encountered. But could the Sukran withstand the unparalleled speed and dexterity of an Elvan swordsman?

The shadow danced with Ethadriel, its powerful and precise sword forms countering Ethadriel's Elvan grace. The pair moved in a whirlwind of steel, their blades clashing with sparks flying.

The duo engaged in a prolonged dance, their swords clashing and echoing through the air before gracefully withdrawing from the intense duel.

"Sukran, how do you manage to match the speed of an Elvan?" Ethadriel, astonished, questioned the Sukran veiled by shadow. He had never encountered a Sukran moving with such swiftness.

"I have my strengths," the shadow replied to the fire mage. "You are an excellent swordsman, but unfortunately for you, I am far superior."

The combatants engaged in a duel, and Ethadriel perceived the shadow to be moving quicker than in the preceding minutes.

Naomi had harbored hope that Ethadriel would prevail with his sword when magic seemed insufficient, yet as the shadow's assault quickened, Ethadriel faltered in maintaining his sword forms.

Tears streamed down Naomi's face as she witnessed the shadow strike Ethadriel's wrist, compelling the fire mage to drop his sword and kneel.

She fired a fireball toward the shadow while he seemed distracted by Ethadriel.

But the shadow veered away from the fireball and extended a hand toward her.

A gust of wind struck her from behind and knocked her to the ground. Ethadriel attempted to use the diversion by kicking the shadow's head, but the shadow swayed clear of the kick and thrust its black blade into the fire mage's thighs.

Ethadriel's anguished cry filled the air as he was impaled on the ground. The Sukran slowly ventured near Ethadriel's face smelling and tasting the scent of despair from Ethadriel

"Finish it!" Ethadriel snarled, helpless. He didn't wish to be toyed by the Sukran anymore.

"I commend your courage, fire mage," the silhouette replied slowly. "Such bravery deserves admiration and, perhaps, a second chance." Ethadriel stared at the shadow, close enough to catch its scent.

"I will not only spare you but also permit you to continue your journey to the Mayan kingdom and fulfill the duty that you revere so much," the shadow sneered.

A renewed sense of optimism flickered within Ethadriel. "*You'll spare us?*" he sputtered.

"Only if you can solve my riddle correctly. I like to reward courage but won't waste my compassion on a fool," the shadow cackled in a sinister tone.

"Why?" Ethadriel regarded the monster's sudden compassion with skepticism, considering the loss of his entire cohort's at its hands.

"I've demonstrated my superiority over the Elvans in both magic and weaponry. Now, I wish to prove my intellect surpasses even the renowned minds of the Elvans," the shadow declared.

Ethadriel momentarily frowned before realizing the shadow had underestimated the wisdom of the Elvan people, known for discerning the true names of elemental spirits which allowed them to command various magical spirits.

"Ask your riddle, Sukran." Ethadriel readied himself.

The shadow gruffly nodded, retrieving a golden orb from its dark garment. Splitting the orb in half, it presented the base of each half to the impaled Elvan. "Fire mage, one half of the ball's base is gold, while the other half is silver."

"I want you to guess which of my hands holds the golden half of the orb."

The shadow hurled both halves into the air and began to rotate them around each other with wind magic.

Ethadriel pursued the golden half of the orb, but the halves rotated so quickly that it

became impossible for him to keep up. He soon lost track of the golden half of the orb. The shadow grabbed each of the two halves of the orb in both hands and clenched them in his fists.

"Fire mage, which hand holds the orb's golden half?" the shadow inquired deviously.

Ethadriel contemplated hard, understanding his answer would determine their fate. As he prepared to choose the shadow's right hand, the shadow extended its left. "If I were you, I'd pick my left hand."

Astounded by the shadow's voluntary disclosure, Ethadriel suspected deception that the shadow must have been trying to confuse him into reconsidering his answer. With more assurity, he confidently pointed to the shadow's right hand.

Despite the shadow's suggestion, he confidently pointed to its right hand. "You're lying. The golden half is in your right hand."

"You are lying. You are holding the golden half of the orb in your right hand."

The alcove was filled with tense silence as the two surviving Elvans regarded the shadow's right hand.

The shadow smirked at the fire mage and opened its right hand to display the silver half of the ball.

Ethadriel's hopes diminished when he glimpsed the shadow's left hand, which revealed the golden half of the orb.

"What a shame!" The shadow merged the orb halves and tucked it under its cloak. "I like you, fire mage. I might even miss you," the shadow sighed, removing its blade from Ethadriel's thighs.

A dark hand made of stone rose from the ground and effortlessly dragged Ethadriel into the confines of the earth.

"No!" Naomi shouted in disbelief at losing her last and only defense against this devilish monster. The shadow craned his neck to examine the sole Elvan survivor sobbing in terror.

The shadow approached the girl, who dropped to the ground after realizing she had no hope of defeating the devilish monster when even a mighty warrior like Ethadriel had failed to scratch the monster.

"What have we got here?" The shadow lifted Naomi's chin with its shadowy hand.

"Has your Elvan race stooped so low as to send infants into hostile territory?" The shadow regarded her with contempt.

"I'm not a child. I am fifty years old. And I am a princess of the Elvan kingdom," Naomi retorted, mustering courage to confront the mysterious monster.

Hissing in an attempt to frighten the monster, Naomi continued, "Every Elvan will hunt you down if you kill me."

The shadow chuckled. "Princess, I've slain many Elvan princesses sent to these shores than you can even fathom."

Surveying the glade, the shadow added, "I don't even recollect any Elvans sent to capture me over the years. In fact, no Elvan in your kingdom knows the fate of your predecessors."

Naomi lowered her head in denial of the truth offered by the monster. She was about to be added to the list of missing princesses sent to these shores.

The shadow once again raised the princess' chin. "Besides, you sound like you are the only princess in your kingdom."

Naomi glared defiantly at the monstrous figure, summoning all the courage within her. The shadow responded with a sly smirk, seemingly unimpressed by her false bravado.

"Do you understand why, among all the princesses in the Elvan kingdom, you were sent to these shores?" inquired the shadow.

"I am the strongest and most dutiful of all Elvan princesses," Naomi declared with pride, clinging to her sole accomplishment to date. Possibly her only accomplishment in life. .

"You fool!" scoffed the shadow. "You were chosen because you were the most expendable princess in your realm."

Stunned, Naomi grappled with the revelation. *Could it be true?* Was she chosen merely for her expendability?

"Let me guess. Is your mother a distant cousin of the Elvan Queen?" The color drained from Naomi's face as she realized the truth in the shadow's words.

She had been naive to think her skills earned her the honor of fulfilling the Elvan duty.

The shadow noticed the answer in her expression and callously hurled Naomi away from him in contempt.

"I can even endure the odor of Elvans on my lands, but not the odor of idiots," the shadow ridiculed her.

Enraged, Naomi rose to her feet, drew her long saber, and charged at the shadow. However, a wave of its hand conjured a windstorm, pushing her back and lifting her five feet above the ground against her will.

The shadow approached the princess and raised his dark blade to finish the night's tedious work.

"Wait!" Naomi pleaded as she struggled to breathe due to the strain exerted by the windstorm. "I will prove that I am not a fool!" Naomi gasped.

The shadow paused, considering her plea before shaking his head. "I don't wish to waste time!"

"Grant me the same opportunity as Lord Ethadriel, and I will correctly solve your riddle," Naomi implored.

"Do you believe you can solve a riddle that a three-hundred-year-old Elvan couldn't?" The shadow stifled a laugh.

"I can. I will solve your riddle," Naomi asserted, taking a decisive gamble on her fate.

The shadow studied her before sheathing its blade. It gestured, dispelling the windstorm, causing Naomi to crash onto the ground.

"If you can solve my riddle, I will permit you to return to your kingdom."

Naomi observed attentively as the shadow split the golden orb, hurling its halves into the air and swirled it in a circle within a windstream. As the windstream accelerated, she struggled to keep track of the golden half, feeling a tense flutter in her stomach.

The shadow grabbed both halves in each hand, asking, "Which hand holds the golden half of my orb?"

Naomi swallowed hard, torn by the decision.

As she grappled with her choice and finally resigned to her fate, the shadow grinned at her resigned demeanor, claiming, "The golden half is in my left hand, Princess."

The shadow grinned at her expression of resignation and resolved to heap further agony onto the young Elvan princess. "The golden half of the orb is in my left hand, Princess."

Naomi glared at the shadow who was further confounding her already befuddled thinking. She recalled how the shadow had deceived Ethadriel, anticipating that the fire mage would not believe his words.

She contemplated the possibility that the shadow would adhere to the same pattern by speaking the truth.

Any reasonable person would deduce that a mind as malevolent as the shadow's would never utter the truth, consistently leaving doubt in their wake. However, she acknowledged the chance that the shadow might have lied this time to deceive her into selecting the hand he presented as a falsehood.

After a minute of contemplation, she concluded that a mind as twisted as this malevolence would perpetually seek to distort the thoughts of others.

She guessed the shadow would derive even more satisfaction if he could beguile others with the truth and bring about their demise, making them rue not trusting his word.

Her confidence in her rationale surpassed her reliance on good fortune in choosing the golden half. With greater assurance, she pointed at the left hand of the shadow.

She felt the shadow stiffen until he gently unfurled his left hand, revealing the golden half of the ball.

Naomi breathed a sigh of relief before anxiety crept into her mind, questioning whether the shadow would uphold his word.

After all, he was a Sukran, a race notorious for breaking promises.

The shadow smirked incredulously at the thoughts racing within the princess' mind. "Have no fear, Princess. I always uphold my word, unlike the rest of my brethren."

"Will you permit me to return to the land of the Elvans?" Naomi questioned, incredulous at the bizarre turn of events.

"Only if you do me a favor," the shadow grinned.

Naomi's smile faltered as she harbored a distaste for the term 'favor'.

"Favor?"

Once again, the shadow delved into his cloak and retrieved a cylindrical metal canister. "Yes, I will allow you to return to your kingdom if you pledge to deliver this message to your queen."

The shadow tossed the metal canister to Naomi, who deftly snatched it in mid-air.

"You wish for me to deliver a message to the Elvan queen?" Naomi inquired, relieved that the favor wasn't as burdensome as she had anticipated.

"A simple message to your queen to stay out of my affairs," came the Sukran's blunt response.

Naomi regarded the shadow for a time, contemplating whether she should push her luck.

"On whose name should I bear this message to my queen?" Naomi bit her lower lip, wondering if the shadow would reveal his identity.

Uncomfortable silence lingered for a few seconds until the shadows dissipated, unveiling the Sukran's face and upper torso. Naomi gasped, expecting a monstrous visage but finding instead that of a wrinkled and aged man. Save for a massive mole on his forehead, his face appeared unremarkable. And when he adjusted his cloak, she noticed his right hand having six fingers.

Six Fingers? She had never heard about any human having six fingers.

"Inform your queen that Fanadaar sends his regards," the Sukran replied.

Naomi nodded, stowed the metal canister in her cloak, and stood up. She glanced at the spot where Ethadriel had been dragged into the earth, realizing she couldn't rescue him from his fate.

Remorse flooded Naomi's mind as she observed the statues of her frozen Elvan companions. She felt she was betraying them by fleeing her duty even after they had sacrificed their lives to ensure she fulfilled hers.

She vowed to the slain Elvans that she would implore the queen to dispatch additional troops to deal with this old man's arrogance and dark sorcery. And she promised to return one day to take their statues back to their homeland.

Casting aside her shame, Naomi turned to offer the shadow a final nod. She retreated from the clearing that had awakened her to the harsh realities of life.

"Princess!" Fanadaar called out.

Naomi halted, dread filling her as she faced her tormentor. One could never predict a monster's devilish mentality, and Fanadaar was a monster even if he didn't appear as one.

"Princess, you have not yet sworn to deliver my message to your queen."

Regaining composure, Naomi nodded. "I, Naomi Reverial, swear on my honor as an Elvan princess that I shall deliver your message to the Elvan queen herself."

Fanadaar nodded and shooed the princess. "Well then, off you go."

Naomi fled from the clearing and raced to the shore, where Elvan ships stood guarded by a small number of her kin.

From the shadows, Fanadaar observed the princess retreating to her ship, rousing the slumbering crew.

True to her word, Naomi hastily abandoned the shores, commanding the sailors to return her to the Elvan kingdom.

As ships left the shore, Naomi stared at the retreating woodland that had awakened her to the harsh realities of life.

She sensed the monstrous Sukran watching her from the forest's tree line as she caressed the metal canister absentmindedly.

A moment of pride passed through her for outwitting the monster when even a high mage like Ethadriel failed.

Naomi gripped the metal canister hard as the Mayan shoreline disappeared.

"Monster, I shall return with additional forces to avenge the slain. I will not break my

pledge to you or those fallen Elvan warriors." Naomi swore furiously at the monster that had altered her life in one night.

Fanadaar chuckled, using his light magic to zoom in on the princess' face as if he were standing right in front of her. He knew Naomi wished to return with additional troops after learning of her predecessors' fate. Despite realizing the repercussions of his decision to spare her, he was forced to allow the Elvans to discover their adversary's identity after many decades.

Besides, he had promised to spare her if she correctly answered his riddle.

And a promise is a promise. He may be a monster, but an honorable one.

Fanadaar retrieved the golden orb from inside his cloak and split it into two halves.

He gazed down at the bases of both halves of the orb. The base of each orb switched between silver and gold repeatedly as a result of his malevolent manipulation of the metal orb.

"I've made a promise that I intend to uphold." Fanadaar's cryptic remark sent a chill through the forest as he watched the retreating ships.

Elanor tenderly caressed the silky, multicolored scarf once more for the umpteenth time that morning, revisiting the agonizing memories of a colossal error that, despite the passing of numerous years, still lingered in her consciousness. She grappled with the realization that no amount of rationale could absolve her betrayal. A sharp, piercing ache rose in her heart every time she recalled the expression of contempt hurled at her by the one she cherished the most.

She knew the prospect of earning forgiveness seemed elusive, even if she were to endure the harshest of punishments for the remainder of her long life.

Duty is Paramount!

Nevertheless, duty remained paramount, invariably triumphing over sentiments. This sagacity had been instilled in her since infancy, although she had briefly peeked into the wisdom of other cultures.

Regretful images flooded her mind—of her life being wrested away in front of her, and her helplessness and impotence in defending it. Conversely, she reproached herself ceaselessly for relinquishing her life's happiness without a fight.

With a heavy sigh, Elanor delicately fondled the smooth scarf once more, affectionately fastening it around her wrist. Many among her brethren disparaged the artistry of the multicolored scarf, yet she cherished and treasured it all the more, for it was crafted by the hands of a ten-year-old girl—the very child she had betrayed to assume the mantle of an Elvan Queen.

Oh! How could I have let my duty destroy my love and happiness?

She reluctantly dragged herself to the farthest corner of the bedroom, where a colossal painting adorned the wall. Gazing at the depiction of a two-story wooden house nestled amidst a vast farm in the Sukran kingdom, she discerned the tranquil lifestyle portrayed—a tapestry of daily

tasks being carried out by numerous individuals in a farm.

Elanor was certain that her brethren might perceive the picture best depicted the chaotic nature of Sukrans, but she alone comprehended an order within their apparent chaos. A sense of beauty with order and chaos mingled together to form a flawless symphony that no one in the Elvan kingdom had managed to accomplish.

A Sukran's chaotic existence was far more wonderful than an Elvan's tranquil life.

She was engrossed in her musings when she heard a knock on her door.

"Enter," Elanor sighed as she continued to gaze adoringly at the picture.

She heard the graceful footsteps of an Elvan behind her, but the footsteps faltered.

"*Not again, Elanor,*" a gentle voice reproached her.

Elanor turned to greet her consort, General Gildor Aerin. "You are well aware, Gildor, that this is the only thing that allows me to perform my duties as Elvan Queen. If not for this picture, I would have grown senile years ago."

Gildor shook his head disapprovingly at the blonde-haired beauty. Despite his best attempts to assuage her grief, she clung tenaciously to her past. "Elanor, you are anything but a nice, contemplative soul." Gildor chastised his wife and queen.

Elanor gazed affectionately at the man genuinely concerned about her happiness, unaware of the terrible and irredeemable acts she had committed in the name of duty to earn any forgiveness, let alone hope for happiness.

"Well, now that I've drawn your attention back to our beautiful kingdom, it's time for us to proceed to the throne room."

"*The throne room?*" Elanor arched her eyebrows. Rarely did the throne room witness activity so early on such a delightful spring morning.

"Yes, I summoned the council at the request of Lord Cirdan, who requested a meeting of the council to address something important."

"Lord Cidran has requested a meeting? It must be an intriguing, if not the most delightful, affair." Elanor replied.

Gildor shook his head, conceding to himself that he didn't hold Cidran's capabilities in as high regard as Elanor did. Being a soldier prevented him from fully embracing a spy within the council. "Cidran deems everything important," Gildor snorted. "I would wager my precious time with you that the meeting will be nothing but dull."

Elanor exhaled deeply. "Don't be so narrow-minded, Gildor. You and Cidran both excel at what you do."

Elanor regarded the picture solemnly. "Moreover, duty is paramount. Duty takes precedence above all else." She scrutinized the picture of the two-story residence before leading her husband to the Elvan royal chamber.

"*Lord Cidran*, why is this council convened at such an early hour?" Gildor inquired of the spymaster, while Elanor, displaying a bored demeanor, occupied her ivory throne.

In the resplendent throne room, the eminent council members occupied their respective stone seats. The white marble walls reflected the hues of multicolored leaves adorning the branches of surrounding trees. A gentle breeze wafted in, carrying the sweet scent of the floral-sprayed water from a beautiful fountain at the room's center.

Fragrances from the trees and the fountain imbued the hearts of the inhabitants with contentment and tranquility.

Cidran approached the throne, a round and stout figure in contrast to the usually slimmer and stronger Elvans on their kingdom. Unfazed, Elanor observed his approach, pondering how the spymaster's physique often irked a soldier like Gildor.

"My Queen, my trustworthy spies informed me that the ships carrying Princess Naomi Reveral are returning to the harbor," Cidran answered.

This unanticipated piece of information piqued everyone's interest in the room.

"How could have Princess Naomi completed her mission so quickly?" Lord Erandall voiced skepticism.

"*No Way!*" Lady Merryl, shaking her head, doubted the feasibility of accomplishing the assignment in a fortnight. "There's no way Naomi and her escorts could finish their assignment in a fortnight."

"So, the question is: did the naive young princess forsake her duty due to the minor challenges she may have encountered in Mayan land?" Lord Erandall questioned the spymaster.

"Perhaps, we'll garner answers to our queries if we allow Cidran to conclude," Elanor reminded her council members, commanding them to cease their dithering.

The council fell into a hush in response to their queen's gentle rebuke, evoking a faint grin from Cidran, who always held her in high regard despite her seeming disinterest in fulfilling her duties as their queen.

"Thank you, Your Majesty. I am unaware of the specific cause for the princess' swift return, but I have learned that all three ships dispatched to the Mayan kingdom are returning."

"I'm curious as to how Lord Ethadriel permitted Naomi to persuade him to abandon their mission and return empty-handed," Gildor pondered aloud.

"I've also discovered that only the crews of the three ships are returning, which is why I've convened this council meeting so early in the morning," Cidran emphasized, stating that there were no reports of the presence of one hundred Elvan troops ordered to accompany Princess Naomi.

"*What?*" Wild gasps echoed around the throne room.

The notion of Lord Ethadriel and his Elvan companions being stranded on the land of Mayans prompted a tense silence among the council members.

A sense of foreboding enveloped Elanor at the mention of ill tidings being conveyed by Princess Naomi.

Cidran concluded his update, "I have left instructions for our palace guards to escort Princess Naomi to this council meeting as soon as she arrives at the harbor."

As if on cue, the imposing doors of the throne room opened, and two palace guards escorted a visibly harrowed Naomi to the queen.

Naomi bowed to the queen by placing her right hand on her breast and inclining her head. "My Queen."

"Princess Naomi, may the Blessed One always watch over you and yours," Elanor greeted the young Elvan princess.

"Your Majesty, you are correct. If the Blessed One hadn't been keeping a watchful eye on me for the past few days, I wouldn't be standing here now. I bring ill tidings of the fate befallen not only of our cohort dispatched to the Mayan kingdom but also my predecessors assigned to fulfill the same mission I have so spectacularly failed to accomplish."

Elanor frowned as she observed the princess' emotions unraveling. She discerned a profound sense of remorse, embarrassment, and a hint of fury directed against her. Elanor could sense the displeasure of the council members who looked down upon the young princess for speaking disrespectfully to her queen.

Elanor huffed at her subjects. *Elvans and their unwavering obsession with adhering to etiquette at all times!*

"My dear, please share your ill tidings so we may share your burden and alleviate your guilt and anger."

Naomi exhaled deeply, realizing that she had allowed her emotions to take over, and she was even more grateful for the queen's willingness to share her burden. "It's a long and dreadful tale, My Queen."

"...I departed the Mayan shores with more disgrace than those that carried by the all the Elvans put together who were sent to those shores." Naomi sank to her knees, surrendering to her guilt.

The council fell into a profound silence as each member contemplated the report regarding a Sukran who had been mercilessly slaughtering all the Elvans sent to the Mayan shores for the past few decades. Some were astonished to discover that the monstrous Sukran had triumphed over Ethadriel, revered as one of the most formidable warriors in their kingdom. Furthermore, they were shocked to learn that their warriors had been transformed into statues.

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Furthermore, they were shocked to learn that their warriors had been transformed into statues.

However, Elanor's focus remained on the princess, the poor girl's guilt causing her to crumble. Overwhelmed with compassion for the young girl forced to confront the harsh realities of life, Elanor acknowledged her mistake in sending such a young Elvan princess on such a perilous assignment. Rising from her throne, she approached the princess, kneeling and embracing

her.

"You have nothing to be embarrassed about. It was my fault to underestimate the significance of this mission. I should have dispatched more soldiers to escort you to our allied nation, but I never imagined that the Elvans sent to those shores would not only be killed but also be denied entry into the after-realm." Elanor consoled the princess.

Withdrawing from the embrace, Elanor gently lifted Naomi's chin. "You have exceeded our expectations by returning with the truth about the fate of our dear brethren sent to those lands."

Gildor nodded absentmindedly as he reflected on the events that had transpired on the shores of the Mayan kingdom. "Your reasoning skills impress me, Princess Naomi. You have solved a riddle for which I am yet unable to provide a definitive answer."

Naomi smiled faintly upon hearing Gildor's appreciation.

Cidran awaited the culmination of the queen's and her husband's benevolent gestures to uplift the spirits of the crumbling princess.

Cidran drew attention to himself and articulated the most pressing query on his mind. "Why does that monstrous Sukran endeavor to impede our journey to the Mayan kingdom?"

"And more crucially, is this Sukran acting independently, or is he following the commands of the Sukran King to sow discord and create a rift between the Elvans and Mayans?"

Gildor nodded with keen interest. "You might have a valid point, Lord Cidran. I dread this is Sukra's convoluted plan to sever the alliance between the Mayans and Elvans. Valerian Primus, King of Sukra, will rest easy only after isolating our kingdom from the sole other human race in the realm."

While many councilmen concurred with Gildor, Elanor shook her head in contemplation. "I do not think so. We've only recently engaged in war with the Sukrans, resulting in the Elvantis War. However, this Fanadaar has been obstructing Elvans en route to the Mayan kingdom even before the war's inception."

"True, my queen!" Cidran smiled at the extraordinarily perceptive queen. "What does this Sukran gain by preventing us from fulfilling our duties?"

The entire council lapsed into contemplative silence in response to Cidran's inquiry.

Naomi seemed to regain her composure as Elanor offered a comforting pat on her back.

Elanor looked around at her council. "One thing every monster craves is more power. And the greatest power in the entire realm lies within the Mayan kingdom."

A tense hush enveloped the room as everyone pondered this dire news that impacted the very fabric of their lives.

"If this is the deed of a solitary and old Sukran, then we should dispatch a legion of a thousand Elvan warriors to scour the Lemurian forest and apprehend the monster. Let's impose a penalty that imparts a lesson to his countrymen from never meddling in Elvan affairs," Gildor proposed a solution to the unforeseen quandary confronting them.

"Are you jesting, Lord Gildor?" Naomi found her voice once more. "This lone Sukran vanquished a hundred Elvan warriors with potent magic effortlessly. And you propose deploying merely one thousand additional soldiers to capture that Sukran monster?"

"Do not underestimate the Sukran monster. I witnessed how effortlessly he repelled Lord Ethadriel's fire magic, as if the esteemed fire mage were a child toying with flames. And we all know that no Elvan has ever managed to overcome the fiery shield of Lord Ethadriel." Naomi grew agitated, recalling the carnage she had witnessed by the old Sukran monster.

Gildor grunted in dissent. "Do you expect us to cower before this old Sukran's magic and allow him to dictate our fate?"

Cidran endeavored to alleviate the tension within the room. "General Gildor, do not be harsh on Princess Naomi. She has endured much, and thus allowed her emotions to dictate her mind."

Cidran added. "But her point is valid. If an old man can quell the fire magic of Lord Ethadriel, he must be a formidable magical being." Cidran expressed his viewpoint.

"Are you suggesting that Elvan magic is inferior to Sukrans' elemental magic?" Gildor disregarded Cidran with a dismissive sweep of his hand.

"Lord Ethadriel may not have been adequately prepared to confront this Sukran, but when we dispatch more warriors to the Mayan kingdom, we will be better prepared to draw him out of hiding and impart a lesson that would make his brethren think twice about challenging Elvans," Gildor boasted.

"After all, Sukran's elemental magic is child's play compared to Elvan magic," Gildor stated to the council members who nodded in agreement with the Elvan General.

Elanor sighed. "This prejudice was indeed our undoing a few years ago. No magic is inherently superior to another. If our magic were superior to other races, why were we defeated by the Sukrans during the Elvantis War?"

"No, we did not lose the war. The war has not yet concluded." Gildor defended his stance.

Elanor waved her hands in disagreement. "Who retreated from the war?"

"Let us not deceive ourselves. We merely retreated to the safety of the magical shield encircling our kingdom, knowing full well that the Sukrans would be incapable of breaching the shield and discovering the true location of our kingdom."

Gildor shook his head vehemently. "We were unprepared for the advancement in Sukran magic, but compared to the potency of our naming magic, their advanced Sukran elemental magic is still child's play." Gildor protested more to convince himself than the queen.

"Maybe, and maybe not. However, there is no denying that we were vanquished by a race we deemed inferior."

"It is pointless to boast about our magical superiority over the Sukrans unless we vanquish them." Elanor berated their prejudiced minds.

Elanor was met with silence, as no one in the room could dispute her argument.

"I do not endorse the idea that Sukran magic is mightier than our magic, but it would be absurd to presume that our magic is mightier than the Sukrans as well." Elanor declared.

"Each style of magic has its advantages and drawbacks. Therefore, let us not assume that our magic will prevail against Fanadaar's magic."

"Magic is a tool, and a fool wielding a powerful tool remains a fool. Magic is inconsequential. Strategy is crucial, and Fanadaar appears to surpassing us in terms of strategy."

"He seems to be a step ahead of us. And it has taken us so long to discover the identity of our enemy, while Fanadaar has been thwarting our plans the entire time and laughing at our incompetence to identify the true reason behind the disappearance of those Elvans sent to the Mayan lands..."

Elanor surveyed the throne room. "Let us not go to war with Sukra simply because we could not deal with a single old man. Still, let us formulate a plan to deal with this elderly man. We must first discover his motivation for preventing us from visiting the Mayan kingdom."

Naomi marveled at the queen's sagacity. She had heard tales of Queen Elanor's prowess and wisdom, but this marked the first instance she beheld it in person.

Naomi ascended to her feet. "My Queen, I might be able to shed more light in comprehending why this monstrous fiend has been decimating our warriors." She delved into her silk cloak and extracted a metal canister.

"My Queen, Fanadaar has sent you a missive."

The entire council was left stunned by the monster daring to send a message to their queen.

Cidran advanced, grabbing the metallic container before Elanor could.

"*Revelia Cursium...*" Cidran murmured, and in a moment, a blue radiance enveloped the metallic canister before transitioning into a white glow.

Cidran waved his hands to dispel his spell and observed the white light fade away around the metal canister.

"The metal canister harbors neither curse nor poison," Cidran asserted.

Naomi witnessed the spymaster uncork the canister and retrieve a parchment from within.

He tossed the metallic canister to the ground, producing a resonant chime as it rolled on the floor.

Naomi observed the spymaster perusing the parchment but was taken aback to find Cidran at once craning his neck and gaze at her in astonishment.

"Princess Naomi, are you certain this is the message from the man who identifies himself as Fanadaar?" Cidran queried skeptically.

"Yes, Lord Cidran."

"Did you unseal the metal canister housing this scroll?"

Naomi shook her head. "No. I abhorred being in its presence, but I pledged to convey his message to the queen."

Elanor noted the spymaster's unease upon perusing the scroll, prompting her to choose to read the message herself and decipher its meaning.

"Lord Cidran, kindly hand over the scroll to me," Elanor requested her spymaster.

Cidran cast a glance at Naomi before handing over the scroll to the queen.

Naomi was even more astonished to witness the queen gasping at the scroll when Elanor perused the message on the scroll.

Naomi could no longer endure the suspense and queried the queen. "My Queen, what does the message convey?"

Elanor passed the scroll to Naomi, who flipped it over to inspect it. It was her turn to gasp

as she found a blank parchment bearing no message.

"Where is the message?" Naomi spluttered in bewilderment.

Elanor observed the princess' reaction and was content that Naomi played no role in removing the message from the metal canister.

"My dear Naomi, did you ever part with the metal canister from your person during your return from the Mayan kingdom?" Elanor questioned the princess, with Gildor and other council members converging to examine the empty scroll bereft of a message.

Naomi shook her head. "No, I retained it on my person from the moment Fanadaar handed it to me."

"Is the old man ridiculing our race by conveying an empty message? Is he attempting to provoke us into deploying troops to capture him for mocking us?" Gildor erupted in rage after being insulted by a Sukran. "If so, he has succeeded. He will soon face the wrath of the mighty Elvans."

Elanor frowned as she contemplated the significance of the message, while each member in the room vented their ire at the Sukran for ridiculing them.

She redirected her gaze to the princess, who still held the scroll to her face, inspecting if it was written with invisible ink.

Elanor had a suspicion that something was awry with Naomi's account of events. *What did she miss from Naomi's tale? Naomi's tale and the empty message didn't add up.*

Suddenly, a random thought crossed her mind. *Why was Naomi spared?*

Why did the old Sukran alter his strategy of slaying all the Elvans sent to the Mayan kingdom mercilessly for so many years? He had never spared any Elvan to return to her kingdom and share the misfortune of encountering such a monstrous Sukran.

Why did the Sukran change his strategy suddenly?

Elanor felt a flutter in her gut when she realized they had no knowledge that a Sukran was impeding her brethren from reaching the Mayan kingdom until Naomi returned with the revelation.

They only discerned his identity because Fanadaar spared Naomi to return to the Elvan kingdom.

"Silence!" Elanor snapped to restore order to the council murmuring their ire at the old man for mocking them with empty message.

"Naomi, are you certain you were spared due to your ingenuity?" Elanor asked the young princess.

Naomi nodded as she explained the rationale behind her choosing the right hand of the monster and answering correctly to Fanadaar's puzzle.

"I could discern from his expression that he did not anticipate me solving his riddle. And he detested having to spare me, but at least he adhered to his word."

"Maybe, he was an honorable monster!" Cidran frowned.

"There is no such thing as honorable monster." Elanor shook her head. "A man becomes a monster because he lost his honor already."

Elanor tried to identify any flaws in the princess' reasoning for choosing the hand

containing the golden half of the orb. She concluded that the princess was fortunate to have selected the correct hand, given that her reasoning was not foolproof. *Yes!* Naomi must have been just lucky to have made the right decision.

Elanor exhaled audibly when she realized that the scroll harbored no malicious intent.

She was about to return to her throne when another notion struck her.

She whirled around to look at Naomi. "*Are you certain that no one trailed you back to the Elvan kingdom, Naomi?*"

Elanor turned to pose a question to the princess, causing the council members to shudder at her train of thought.

After a moment of furrowing her brow, Naomi shook her head. "I doubt anyone followed us over the sea to the Elvan kingdom."

Gildor waved his hand. "There is no need to worry about anyone tailing Naomi into our kingdom. Our magical shield would confound the Sukrans and cast them adrift on the open sea forever."

Cidran confidently added, "Moreover, we would have been aware by now if someone had breached the magical shield into the Elvan kingdom."

Elanor continued to harbor concerns but opted to disregard the mysterious scroll borne by Naomi.

No Sukran sorcery could unveil the princess' route to the Elvan kingdom.

She was on the verge of expelling the scroll from her thoughts when she realized her blunder and smacked her head in disdain. It was she who should have grasped the significance of the blank message scroll. After all, she possessed more knowledge about Sukrans than everyone in the room combined.

She hastened forward and snatched the scroll from Naomi. She harnessed her mana to set fire to the parchment.

The entire room was taken aback by the queen's disconcerted behavior, as she typically maintained a tranquil demeanor. Yet, there she was, hurrying like a teenager and setting scrolls ablaze.

The first to fathom the rationale behind the queen's actions was Cidran.

"My Queen, do you suspect the blank scroll has been tampered with? I detected neither curse nor poison within the scroll." Cidran frowned. "I can assure you it was not tampered with in any manner."

"No magic has been employed to manipulate the scroll. But I believe the scroll is what our mysterious foe intended to use to infiltrate our kingdom protected by a magical shield."

"Fanadaar must have realized he would require an alternate means to infiltrate our kingdom, as he cannot force his way past the magical shield into the Elvan kingdom."

Everyone endeavored to grasp the queen's statement.

"I suspect that the cunning Sukran spared Naomi so that she could return to the Elvan kingdom and furnish him with the means to discover the true location of the Elvan realm, protected by our magical shield."

Naomi exclaimed, "Do you truly not think I outsmarted the monster? Instead, you think

he deceived me?"

Elanor nodded resolutely. "Yes, Naomi. A monster willing to slaughter so many Elvans would have little regard for upholding his word or honor. He forfeited his honor when he killed another being to achieve his goals. Therefore, I am certain he would not have spared you if he did not believe he could employ you in some manner to achieve his objective."

Suddenly, the Elvan throne room reverberated with a loud, malevolent chuckle.

"*Not bad for an Elvan queen, Elanor.* Not bad at all! *But you're a tad too late.*" A malicious voice sneered.

Elanor swept her gaze across the regal chamber, her heart pounding in sync with the malevolent cackle that continued to reverberate through the room. The voice, dripping with malice, triggered a surge of fear in Naomi, who recognized it all too well and screamed in terror.

"*Fanadaar!*" Naomi screamed in terror and disbelief.

"Indeed, my precious princess, your nightmare has returned." Fanadaar taunted, his voice laced with a devious chuckle. "You've fulfilled your role as my guide, leading me to your hidden kingdom."

With a sudden surge of magical energy, a pulsating blue orb materialized ten feet above the ground, its center morphing into a seven-foot-tall black door.

"What kind of sorcery is this?" Gildor frowned, his brow furrowed in confusion. He had never encountered such peculiar magic.

"This doesn't resemble any Sukran magic I've ever seen," Cidran remarked, his voice laced with uncertainty.

Elanor's eyes widened as the black door solidified before her. "*It's a portal,*" she declared, her voice firm. "A portal created by Sukran space magic."

"*Space magic!*" Gildor scoffed, shaking his head in disbelief. "Space magic is a myth. No one, not even the Sukrans, has mastered it."

For centuries, scholars had theorized about the existence of space magic, the ability to traverse vast distances instantaneously by manipulating the fabric of space itself. Despite their relentless pursuit, space magic remained an elusive enigma.

Elanor, her gaze fixed on the expanding black door, countered, "Clearly, it seems space magic is no longer a myth."

"Even Valerian Primus, the mighty Sukran King, cannot control space," Gildor insisted.

"*Elvan, there are far more formidable beings in this realm, than the Sukran King.*" a wicked voice hissed, seemingly closer than before. "And I am much more powerful than what the Sukran King could ever hope to be."

The Elvans sensed a tinge of contempt and rage in the voice of the mysterious danger. Clearly, the Sukran stranger was not amicable towards his own king.

Gildor and the other council members drew their daggers from their sheaths with a grumble, regretting the foolish law that prohibited carrying swords to the council meeting.

"*Soldiers!*" Gildor yelled, and a score of Elvan warriors stationed outside the throne room entered at once.

In response to Gildor's call, a score of Elvan warriors stationed outside rushed into the

throne room, their presence exuding an air of determination.

"Larian, summon the queen's guard to the throne room." Gildor grabbed a sword from the palace guard and instructed him to retrieve the thousands of soldiers guarding the palace and its' grounds. The guard at once raced out of the throne room to retrieve the palace guards.

The rest of the Elvan warriors, their bows drawn and arrows nocked, formed a protective circle around the queen, their eyes fixed on the floating black door.

With a dramatic flourish, the black door swung open, unleashing a torrent of shadows that engulfed the throne room, plunging the entire throne room into an eerie darkness.

The Elvans were stunned to find darkness engulfing them, as if night had arrived far earlier than normal. The Elvans observed a huge, human-like shadow enter the throne room through the black portal.

The shadow rubbed its palms together while relishing the exquisite throne room. Only the monster's bright green eyes indicated its whereabouts.

"So, the Elvan throne room finally succumbs to darkness after all these centuries," the shadowy figure rumbled, its voice echoing ominously.

As silence greeted him, he continued with a smirk. "I must concede that your throne room seems to be better suited for my shadows, doesn't it?" the figure declared, its glowing green eyes piercing the gloom.

Naomi screamed as she relived the most horrifying experience of her life. In fear, she sought refuge behind the soldiers, who stood guard around the queen, their arrows poised against the encroaching shadows.

Gildor, ever resourceful, snapped his fingers, conjuring a ball of blue light that illuminated the Elvans' immediate surroundings, dispelling the oppressive darkness.

"How did you locate our kingdom after we destroyed the scroll?" Elanor inquired, her voice firm despite the fear that gnawed at her.

"You made a mistake by destroying the scroll," Fanadaar replied with a wicked grin. "You should have destroyed the metal canister, not the scroll."

"You used your metal magic to track the metal canister?" Elanor gasped in disbelief.

"Indeed," Fanadaar confirmed, his voice laced with arrogance. "I forged that metal canister myself, and I can track it anywhere in this realm. And last I checked, the Elvan kingdom was still within this realm."

Elanor berated herself for her oversight, realizing that the canister, not the scroll, was the key to discovering the location of their hidden. Her blunder could cost her kingdom one of their most closely guarded secrets.

Naomi couldn't remain silent any longer. "You tricked me into choosing the right hand with the golden orb," Naomi accused, her voice laced with anger.

"Young princess, you chose the wrong hand holding the golden half of the orb," Fanadaar confirmed as he extracted the golden ball from his cloak.

"But you showed me the golden orb in the hand I picked," Naomi protested, her voice trembling with indignation.

Fanadaar split the orb in half, revealing its dual halves to the Elvans. Each half shimmered,

transforming from silver to gold and back again to silver as Gildor's blue light danced upon them.

"If I can track a metal canister across the vast expanse of the realm, can't I manipulate the hue of this metal orb to my liking?" Fanadaar taunted, his voice dripping with smug satisfaction.

"You scoundrell!" Naomi hissed, her eyes blazing with fury. She tried to lunge towards the man who had so skillfully outwitted her, but Elanor intervened and grasped Naomi's hand, restraining Naomi's impulsive act. This man, despite being surrounded by some of the realm's most formidable Elvans, exuded an air of unwavering confidence that was both unnerving and captivating.

"Indeed princess, your misguided decision to uphold your word and convey my message to the Elvan queen herself has paved the way for my entry into your kingdom," Fanadaar admonished the princess, his words laced with a hint of mockery. With that, he tucked the golden orb into his pocket, a symbol of his triumph.

Fanadaar reveled in the grandeur of the Elvan throne room, his eyes taking in every intricate detail of its opulent design. The room was abuzz with an air of palpable tension as the Elvans exchanged furtive glances with their enigmatic adversary, who had infiltrated their kingdom without permission.

Whether it was Sukran magic or not, Gildor was wary of a mysterious adversary with the ability to construct a portal between two distant places.

"Unleash bolts of energy at the enemy!" Gildor grumbled, his anxiousness evident as he sought to rid the kingdom of the Sukran before chaos ensued.

The warriors directed mana-powered magical bolts at the shadow, but none penetrated past the black shield surrounding their adversary. Their magical assaults were absorbed by the shield, rendering their bolts ineffectual.

Despite each council member firing energy bolts at the dark shield in a collective endeavor to destroy the dark shield made of shadows, the formidable strength of the black shield thwarted their every attempt.

"Did Naomi neglect to inform you that your Elvan fire magic holds no sway over me?" Fanadaar scorned the Elvans, a contemptuous gaze accompanying his words.

The council members realized the futility of attacking their adversary as they were only squandering their mana. So, they decided to utilize their remaining mana to summon their elemental spirits to defend the queen.

From the portal, more shadows slithered into the throne room, further darkening it even further. Even Gildor's blue light struggled against the encroaching darkness.

Elanor sensed the escalating tension as her guards and council members conjured shields of pure energy to protect her, using their dwindling mana. She recognized the need to act quickly and avert the dire fate that befell Ethadriel and his companions.

Elanor, with determination, unleashed a bolt of pure energy aimed at the exquisite fountain at the far end of the room. The destruction of the once-beautiful fountain left everyone in stunned silence.

Commanding her wind spirit, Elanor extinguished the fire lamps, plunging the room into complete darkness. Only Gildor's blue glow provided any illumination.

Everyone was stunned by Elanor's offensive, and they all turned to discover the throne room's gorgeous fountain destroyed to pieces.

"Love, have you gone insane to intentionally destroy our beautiful fountain with your own hands?" Gildor inquired, perplexed by his wife's actions.

Ignoring her husband's question, Elanor turned her attention to Fanadaar, who returned her gaze with newfound respect. Elanor challenged the Sukran, "Monster, you will not have the aid of your water and fire elementals to freeze us into statues."

Confronting the uninvited Sukran, Elanor proclaimed, "I am aware that extracting water from the earth takes a great deal of time, a privilege you shall not enjoy in my kingdom."

The other inhabitants regarded her with awe as she removed the two elements Fanadaar had used primarily to vanquish Ethadriel and his companions on the Mayan shores.

"*Well done, Queen Elanor,*" Fanadaar acknowledged her quick thinking. "Not bad at all for a prejudiced Elvan queen."

"But I am not confined to using just water and fire elements," Fanadaar smirked, waving his hand at the guards and council members. "*Elvans, it's my turn to unleash my magic.*"

A massive black windstorm gathered in the center of the room, striking the shields raised by the queen's guard and council members. Even though the mana shields of the Elvans were able to stop the windstorm, the Elvans were forced to expend a great deal of mana to maintain their shield against the windstorm, which gained strength with each passing second.

Attempting to emulate Ethadriel, Elanor raised her hand, hoping to disperse the Sukran's dark windstorm with her wind spirit. To her astonishment, her spirit struggled to disperse the shadows within the windstorm.

"This whirlwind is composed of more than mere air. It is also composed of shadows," Fanadaar explained, elucidating the Elvans on the nature of the formidable windstorm. "Therefore, the shadows within the black windstorm serve as a barrier, blocking your wind spirits from influencing the air that sustains the windstorm."

As the Elvans began to run out of their mana, one by one, they lost connection with their spirits, making it impossible for them to perform any magic. Soon after, the shield protecting the Elvan queen vanished.

Enraged at the Sukran's mockery in their throne room, Gildor unsheathed his blade and transformed into a massive man of solid stone before charging at Fanadaar.

"Gildor, wait!" Elanor yelled, but Gildor paid little heed. Gildor dashed at the Sukran and swiped his sword horizontally, using the strength borrowed from his earth spirit. The floor rattled as the Elvan general turned into a two-hundred-pound giant in an instant.

Gildor swung his sword, empowered by his earth spirit, causing the floor to quake.

Unfazed, Fanadaar deftly avoided Gildor's sword at the last instant and, raised a tiny mound on the floor using his earth magic, causing Gildor to trip and crash onto the elegant white marble floor which shattered at once.

Undeterred, Gildor sprang to his feet and retaliated by swinging his blade at the intruder.

Fanadaar once again drifted from the path of the Elvan warrior who had traded speed for strength. Fanadaar drew his black sword from its scabbard and prepared to meet Gildor, who

glared back at him.

Gildor roared and swung his blade again. "Your little sword cannot survive the force of my strike, aided by my earth spirit."

"Moreover, my earth spirit makes my body impervious to any metal in the world," The general bragged to the Sukran who dared to enter their throne room without permission.

Fanadaar raised his black blade to intercept the Elvan general's powerful sword swing.

The black blade resisted the strength of Gildor's power, eliciting astonishment among the Elvans.

"*Is that a Weamris sword?*" Gildor recognized that Fanadaar wielded a dark blade forged from the singular metal capable of thwarting his sword swing. Weamris metal was the only metal rumored to be indestructible. In fact, many researchers believed that the Weamris metal that did not originate from this world. A metal from a rock that had crashed onto their planet so many eons ago.

And being alien to this world, it was impervious to both magic and weapons of this realm

"*Yes, this is one of the fabled swords lost to the sands of time,*" Fanadaar smirked.

Realizing his vulnerability, Gildor understood the formidable challenge posed by the legendary blade. Fear spread among the Elvans, anticipating a confrontation against the mightiest of legendary blades possessed by their foe.

Only a scant few blades were crafted from Weamris metal, and somehow, this enigmatic Sukran cloaked in shadows had not only unearthed one of those storied swords but had also modified it to mirror the darkness he inherently commanded.

"*Now, it's my turn to make you dance,*" Fanadaar taunted as he dexterously engaged Gildor, his movements too swift for the Elvan general to counter.

Fanadaar relentlessly attacked various parts of the general's stone body, chipping away little bits of stone piece by piece from the general's stone body.

"Narath, take a couple of your warriors and assist Gildor," Elanor instructed the queen's guard, recognizing Gildor was greatly outmatched against the Sukran's swordsmanship skills.

When the guards hesitated to step away from their posts of guarding the queen, Elanor barked at the guards "This is an order, you fools!"

Narath acknowledged her command and signaled for five of his warriors to advance on Fanadaar.

Fanadaar, sensing the approaching soldiers, turned to face them.

He snarled as he conjured a powerful gust of wind, effectively hindering the troops' swift advance.

Fanadaar then struck Gildor in the leg, sending him crashing into the bodies of two approaching queen's guards.

The Sukran halted the sword thrust at his hip and swiftly evaded the attack from another soldier on his right.

When Elanor witnessed two guards stealthily approaching Fanadaar from behind, preparing for an ambush, a surge of hope filled her being. However, her joy was short-lived as she watched an earthen cast hand rise from the ground, snatching the two sneaking soldiers and

tossing them out of the chamber's door.

The impact of the throw rendered the two warriors unconscious.

While Gildor struggled to free himself from the two soldiers he had brought down with him, Fanadaar employed his wind spirit to slam the remaining two guards against the nearby walls.

Their Sukran adversary turned to see Gildor slowly regaining his footing as the two guards lay motionless, knocked out cold by the impact of their general's crashing stone body.

Fanadaar waited with a smirk for Gildor to retrieve his sword and face him once more.

"Shall we continue our lesson on prejudice, valiant general?"

Gildor snarled in response to the insult and charged towards the Sukran who was making a mockery of him in front of his wife.

But the duel was brief, for Fanadaar's swiftness outpaced the injured general. As Gildor grappled to defend himself, Fanadaar skillfully employed his blade to chip away at the Elvan general's sword in that same spot and made it vulnerable slowly, before culminating in a final, dramatic flourish of sword swing that cleaved the general's sword in twain.

The entire chamber gasped collectively at the Sukran who had destroyed a renowned Elvan sword that had never been defeated in combat.

Gildor hurled the pommel at the Sukran to distract him and kill him off with a single punch. However, Fanadaar deftly swatted it aside and swerved out of Gildor's oncoming charge. A swift slash to Gildor's other thigh forced the general to slump to his knees, his wounded legs unable to support the weight of his stone-like form.

Fanadaar, with a well-aimed kick to the general's torso, sent the general sprawling to the ground. Gildor lost control of his magic when he ran out of mana. He reverted to his natural form, covered in wounds.

Placing his blade menacingly at Gildor's throat, Fanadaar smirked at the room's astonished occupants, reveling in the astonishment that enveloped the room.

"You might need magic to turn yourself and your heart into stone, but my heart is already made of stone. It would serve you well to yield, general!"

The remaining guards hissed in anger and charged him, but Fanadaar conjured several smaller dark windstorms that dragged everyone but the queen and Naomi into its vortex.

The vortex ensnared all but the queen and Naomi, dragging the disoriented Elvans along the room's corners. They were too disoriented to use their magic to escape the windstorm combined with shadows, which whirled in multiple directions.

With a flick of his hands, Fanadaar summoned a burst of wind, sealing the chamber door. Capitalizing on his advantage, he summoned an earth elemental in the form of a ten-foot pure dark hand, which began hauling the stone chairs over to the locked door and systematically barricading the entrance with stone chairs.

Elanor regarded the barrier erected on the entrance, thwarting any reinforcements for her queen's guard to enter the throne room anytime soon.

Fanadaar, with a mocking sneer, surveyed the turmoil within the room before he declared, "The Elvan throne room, the seat of power for the Elvan race, has plunged into darkness and chaos at the hands of a single Sukran. *Do Elvans still regard your magic to be superior to that of the*

Sukrans?"

Except for the queen and the princess, the room's other occupants were tossed about roughly and found themselves not in a position of challenging Fanadaar's assertions. Yet, Elanor, amidst the self-aggrandizements of their adversary, maintained a stoic silence.

"Your Elvan naming magic using spells imbue you with complete command over the magical spirits of the realm, empowering you to perform feats that defy comprehension," Fanadaar declared, his blade aimed at the groaning Gildor. "With a mere flick of your fingers, you can obliterate an entire mountain. In contrast, Sukrans can only tap into a minuscule fraction of the elemental energy that flows around us in our world, a pale imitation of the vast magical reserves at your disposal."

"While Sukrans merely coax and influence the elemental spirits to their will, you could command them with absolute authority once you've deciphered their true names."

"However, Sukrans possess a distinct advantage over your kind. You must devote years to understand and discover the true names of the spirits you seek to command. Moreover, subjugating multiple spirits simultaneously proves challenging without a vast reservoir of mana. The potency of your magic is directly proportional to the mana coursing through your veins, for the mana is the very essence that fuels your control over the spirits. The more potent your magic, the more mana you expend, gradually depleting your access to the spirits that perform your magic."

"The most glaring weakness of Elvan magic lies in the time required to conjure its might. While your magic is undeniably extraordinary, the time it demands to manifest its power can be too long enough to prove to be your undoing."

"In contrast, Sukrans, though limited to harnessing a minuscule fraction of the elemental energy that surrounds us, can manipulate it with a mere thought. Due to the absence of magical mana in our bodies, we are not reliant on it to access our magic. We employ our exceptional minds to manipulate the elemental energies that permeate our world, granting us unparalleled endurance compared to your race."

Fanadaar surveyed the scene, his voice echoing with conviction. *"Sukran magic is durable and swift, while Elvan magic, while potent, is hampered by its sluggish nature."*

Fanadaar aimed the tip of his blade at the weary Elvan general and concluding his comparison. Elanor, terrified at the sight of her mate held at sword point, recognized the need to restrain herself instead of acting rashly like her courageous but misguided mate. She decided to buy time to save Gildor and her people from this formidable foe.

Elanor understood she was the lone survivor who could defend her kingdom from this monstrous creature. *It was time to distract Fanadaar's attention.*

"Are you finished bragging? Could we move on to the purpose of your visit to my kingdom?" Elanor asked.

"*You can't blame me for expressing the obvious, can you?*" Fanadaar nonchalantly shrugged. "Is it wrong to highlight the Elvans' misguided prejudice in their magical superiority over other human races?"

Elanor regarded the shadow. "All races have their prejudices. I am certain that the Sukran

race has its share of prejudices."

Fanadaar shrugged at the queen. "*Humans, despite their races, are no different to each other!*"

"Why have you sought to meet me, Sukran?" Elanor inquired. "There must be a reason you must have spared me from the same fate as the rest of the Elvans in this room!"

"*I have come to deliver my message personally,*" Fanadaar declared, pressing the tip of his blade on Gildor's throat. Naomi cowered behind the queen.

"And what is the message, Fanadaar?" Elanor inquired, feigning courage despite her consort was being threatened at sword's tip.

"*I want you to cease sending Elvans to the Mayan kingdom,*" Fanadaar announced, his demand hanging in the tense air.

Elanor kept her composure while acknowledging that Naomi's depiction of the Sukran was accurate—a monster at heart.

Elanor, though composed, shook her head vehemently. "We will not be intimidated by your threats. We have a responsibility to preserve the realm. Besides the Mayans would want us to honor our promise."

"So, the Mayans matter more to you than your spouse who is the general of your kingdom?" Fanadaar provocatively pressed the tip of his blade against Gildor's throat, who lay motionless after expending all his mana to thwart the Sukran.

Elanor's heart fluttered at the notion of letting her husband to succumb for the sake of duty. Her gaze fixed upon Gildor, who nodded valiantly in response.

With tears streaming down her face, Elanor whispered to her husband, "*Duty is paramount.*"

Gildor mustered the courage to grin at his beloved wife. And he felt it was fitting that he would also perish by her words.

Fanadaar was caught off guard by the queen's willingness to sacrifice her husband in the pursuit of duty.

For the first time since his arrival, which had cast Naomi's life into turmoil, the princess observed a flicker of uncertainty in the Sukran's demeanor.

"*Are you willing to sacrifice your husband to honor your ancestor's promise?*" Fanadaar inquired, staring disbelievingly at the Elvan Queen.

"A monster like you may not comprehend that our forebearers may perish, but their promises always endure," Elanor remarked sourly.

"Duty surpasses all else," Elanor quivered as she uttered words that threatened to snatch away her happiness yet again.

"Hmm... so, you seem indifferent to your husband's life, unwilling to forsake your forefathers' promise," Fanadaar mused.

"Elanor, what happened to your vow to shield your people from adversaries? Do you prioritize the well-being of your people, or are you merely bound by the promises made by your forebears?" Fanadaar prodded.

"The Sukrans cannot attack us since they do not know our kingdom's precise location. No adversary has yet breached the magical barrier around our kingdom." Eleanor replied.

"Yet, a Sukran now stands within the revered Elvan throne room." Fanadaar waved his

blade derisively at the queen, proclaiming, "All I need to do is inform the Sukran King about the exact location of your hidden kingdom, and Primus would usher in the war you fled many years ago."

Elanor grasped the gravity of the situation. The Sukran had recklessly withdrawn his blade from her husband's throat.

"You can only ever reveal the location of our kingdom if you flee from my kingdom." Elanor hissed at the Sukran, realizing she was poised to expose his fallacy and prejudice by affording an Elvan Queen time to harness her magic.

She unleashed a bolt of lightning at the unsuspecting Sukran, blasting him ten feet away from her spouse.

Unlike the bolts hurled by the Elvan warriors, hers embodied the combined force of wind and fire spirits, conjuring a lightning bolt capable of leveling a city.

Naomi watched in astonishment as the queen dealt the first blow to the seemingly invincible man since the moment he appeared on the shores of the Mayan kingdom.

The lightning bolt harnessed the might of her wind and fire spirits, forming a force capable of obliterating cities.

Elanor glared at the man who had ruined her sanctuary. "Fanadaar, you erred by granting me time to gather my magic and destroy you," she growled.

She approached her husband and extended a hand to help him stand up.

Gildor stood and gazed wistfully at her. "Our simple plan succeeded, didn't it?"

Elanor smiled at her husband, who had taken a risk to empower her with the time needed to harness her magic.

"You were valiant but foolhardy. Nonetheless, our plan appears to have triumphed." Elanor pointed to the Sukran's limp body.

Fanadaar rose gently to his feet, having tasted the might of a well-prepared Elvan for the first time.

Fanadaar groaned as agony pulsed through his body, despite his black shield absorbing most of the lightning bolt. The Elvan Queen's strategy impressed him.

Elanor intended to confront and eliminate the Sukran before he could utilize portal magic to escape the kingdom. After the chaos the Sukran had sowed in her throne room, she had no intention of allowing the Sukran to flee her realm.

"Neramel Lightnuasium!"

Hundreds of lightning bolts continued to bombard the black shield that Fanadaar had raised at the last moment.

Elanor saw with satisfaction as the lightning struck the dark shield before it began to travel through it. She could feel the power being absorbed by the black shield and was confident that the might of her lightning bolts would obliterate the Sukran.

"Did I not state earlier that Elvan magic is exceedingly potent?" A voice behind her snickered.

Elanor spun around in shock to find Fanadaar standing unscathed amid another swirl of shadows, while her lightning bolts penetrated his decoy shield.

Elanor redirected her lightning blow to the new black shield, astonished to see numerous

other dark, shadowy shields materializing around her.

Elanor grumbled, realizing her magic lacked the ability to discern between the authentic Sukran and the illusions which soon started to grow in hundreds and each surrounded her.

"Fanadaar, I may not have the magic to distinguish between your decoys and your true self, but I am not limited by the power that flows through me."

Elanor fired bolts of lightning at all the black shields surrounding her in the throne room.

Naomi was astounded by the queen's ability to manipulate wind and fire spirits, creating thousands of lightning bolts that struck all the black shields in the throne room.

After sustaining the shields for some minutes, she heard a reprimanding voice.

"Hmm, a display of strength that no Sukran could even dream of matching. But why should we exert ourselves to defeat you when your foolish decisions result in your own downfall?"

On cue, the ground and the throne room started to shake violently, sending the queen and her Elvan companions to the ground.

Fanadaar hovered in the air, suspended five feet above the marble floor of the throne room.

Fanadaar's lips curled into a derisive smile as he observed the fissures appearing across the walls and floors of the throne room.

"What is happening?" Naomi exclaimed, desperately clinging to the ground.

The chamber echoed with Fanadaar's maniacal laughter. "You have failed to recognize the true purpose of this black shield enveloping me, Queen Elanor"

Elanor frowned at the confident tone of Fanadaar's words. She abruptly stopped her lightning bolts.

Although the lightning ceased within the chamber, the throne room continued to quake for several more seconds.

"Once again, you are too late!" Fanadaar grinned, dismantling most of his illusory shields.

As the majority of Fanadaar's fake shields ceased to exist, several shadows faded from the room, leaving the room a little more brightly illuminated.

"The black shields aren't crafted to fend against your lightning bolts; they wouldn't endure a moment against your formidable magic," Fanadaar chuckled, his voice resonating across the room.

"What is their purpose then?"

Fanadaar unraveled the truth to the terror-stricken denizens of the throne room. "These black shields serve as portals to various sectors of the Elvan kingdom."

"If I can traverse the portals between two places in space, why can't your lightning bolts traverse the same portal and strike the spot where the gateway on the other side of the portal opens?" Fanadaar revealed his devious scheme to the queen.

Elanor was struck speechless and paled instantly. "Where did you place your portals in my realm?" she muttered.

"Elanor, you've not been assaulting me with lightning streaks, but rather, assaulting the magical shield safeguarding your kingdom. I've opened several portals at various sections of your kingdom right next to the magical shield. All of your lightning bolts have traversed my portals and

have been striking your precious magical shield," Fanadaar disclosed with a malicious chuckle.

Elanor gazed at the Sukran, dumbfounded.

"No Sukran possesses the magic to destroy the magical barrier shielding your kingdom. Yet, if an Elvan can erect such a potent magical barrier, why couldn't the Elvan Queen dismantle it with the same potent magic?" Fanadaar taunted, unveiling his plan to exploit her to destroy the only thing protecting her land from its ruthless adversaries.

"What have you done?" Elanor sank to her knees upon recognizing her blunder.

"How delightful it would be for your Elvan history to dub you as the queen who single-handedly shattered the magical barrier safeguarding your kingdom," Fanadaar smirked.

Fanadaar approached Elanor, but Naomi and Gildor attempted to protect the desolate queen.

With a wave of his hand, Fanadaar directed two windstreams toward Gildor and Naomi, pulling them into a vortex and dragging them across the room.

Elanor raised her head to witness the delighted monster reveling in the havoc it had wreaked upon her once-tranquil kingdom.

Fanadaar lifted the queen's chin with the tip of his sword to meet his gaze.

"I command you to cease sending Elvans to the Mayan kingdom. Otherwise, I shall inform the Sukran King that the Elvan kingdom's impervious magical barrier is no more. And there is a kingdom ripe for the taking."

Elanor hissed, attempting to break free from the monstrous clutches, but all she could manage was to shake her head.

Elanor stammered, "I will not forsake our duty to the realm, even if it means going to war with Sukra and sacrificing countless Elvans to the war."

Elanor observed a burst of rage on Sukran's face and felt scared for the first time since Fanadaar's arrival in her throne room.

In a fit of rage, Fanadaar removed his sword and grasped the Elvan queen's throat, lifting her off the ground.

"You may not have been willing to forsake your duty when I threatened your husband's life. You may not relent even when I threaten numerous Elvans who'll perish in war with Sukra."

He dispelled the shadows around him, revealing his face to the queen, declaring, "I know a way to compel you to abandon your forefathers' pledge to the realm."

The Elvan queen gasped, gazing at the inconspicuous face of the Sukran who had thoroughly vanquished the Elvans in their domain.

Naomi was right—truly a monster at heart, if not in appearance.

And she felt six fingers clasping on her throat. *A six fingered human!*

Fanadaar hurled the Elvan Queen onto the ground, then drew another metal canister from his swirling, shadowy cloak.

Fanadaar hurled a metal canister into the chest of the queen. "Queen Elanor, this is the true message I came to deliver to you."

Elanor frowned, unclasping the metal canister and extracting a scroll from within.

If Naomi's earlier delivery of a blank scroll surprised her, the contents of this new scroll

staggered her.

As she perused the scroll's contents, tears streamed down her face. She lifted her head to implore the man who seemed to know a great deal about her.

"I'm aware of your little secret, Queen Elanor," Fanadaar growled before the queen could react to his final gambit.

"Please, don't do this!" Elanor pleaded with the Sukran.

Fanadaar shrugged, ambling back toward the revolving portal door in the center of the throne room. *"I shall if you force me."*

Elanor scrutinized the picture depicted on the scroll. It mirrored the painting of the two-story Sukran house she used to gaze at longingly for hours in her chamber.

How had the intruder uncovered her closely guarded secret? Most Elvans were oblivious to her... Her mistake. Her misdeed. Her betrayal.

Halting before the portal, Fanadaar addressed the emotionally wrecked queen.

"Remember, if I detect even a single Elvan traveling towards the Mayan kingdom, you know where my portal door will transport me next," Fanadaar warned, pointing to the scroll tightly held by the queen.

"Please, Sukran, do not do this!" Elanor begged the merciless Sukran, who was threatening the very fabric of her existence.

"You couldn't stop me in your kingdom. Do you believe you can stop me in my kingdom, where you have left your heart vulnerable?" Fanadaar issued a threat.

"Don't you realize your actions are dooming this realm?" Elanor barked at the monster.

"Do I appear as a man concerned with the fate of the realm?" Fanadaar scoffed at the queen's naiveté once more before striding towards the portal door.

Elanor knelt aghast at Sukran's utter disregard for the realm's fate. Soon, her helplessness was replaced with unbridled fury. She pointed her hand at the intruder.

"Fanadaar!" Elanor couldn't keep her emotions in check any longer, howling at the man endangering the very fabric of her life.

"Fanadaar. I cannot understand why you are toying with my heart. But I am aware that you are dooming the entire realm to fulfill your desires."

Elanor harnessed the mana within her and uttered a curse that no Elvan had dared utter for millennia.

"Cursium Sonlia!"

"I curse you upon my Elvan grace that your deeds will force you to lose the one thing you cherish most in life. I curse you that your life will be doomed henceforth. Even your death will be doomed. You will be left with nothing but damnation."

The queen pointed her finger accusingly at Sukran, poised to exit through the portal.

"You shall meet your reckoning before you die, Fanadaar!" Elanor bellowed with rage.

A blue light originated from the soul of the Elvan queen, rustled toward Fanadaar, and struck him. The blue wind swirled about him for a few seconds before settling into his soul.

Fanadaar froze in his tracks and turned to take a long, hard look at the queen.

"Queen Elanor, I have already faced my reckoning," Fanadaar responded, his sourness barely

discernible.

Elanor frowned upon hearing Sukran's words.

"But you've forgotten that curses always rebound to the cursor. *Prepare to face your reckoning when this curse rebounds at you.*"

"Until the next time we meet." Fanadaar shared a prolonged look with the devastated queen before stepping through the portal, the shadows in the throne room trailing behind its master to vanish through the portal door.

The windstreams simultaneously released the trapped Elvans before dissipating into the air. As shadows receded, brilliant sunlight flooded through the cracked walls.

The portal door dissolved into thin air, leaving no trace of the turmoil that had engulfed the Elvan kingdom.

Every Elvan in the room took a few seconds to collect their thoughts before rising to their feet. .

Cidran swiftly surveyed his surroundings and was relieved to find the queen unharmed and whole.

They gazed around, stunned at the shattered throne room, all at the hands of one lone Sukran.

"*How did one Sukran wreak such havoc?*" Gildor exhaled as he strained to stand up.

"He is no ordinary Sukran," Cidran remarked while massaging his stiff shoulders. "He is more powerful than the Sukran King."

Elanor disregarded her companions while her palace guards labored to open the barricaded door.

She looked at the scroll and realized she was facing her reckoning for her betrayal so many years ago.

She doomed her heart to become the queen of the Elvans. And now, her heart had doomed her people.

She knew she would no longer even consider sending Elvans to the Mayan kingdom. Her selfish decision would soon ruin the one alliance she had with another human race.

History would remember her as the Elvan queen who destroyed the realm by forsaking her race's duty to the realm.

Only an Elvan could fulfill that duty, and she wouldn't dare to send one to the Mayan kingdom, jeopardizing the peace in the realm.

She knew that Fanadaar had set an expiration date for the realm's peace. It wouldn't take long for the turmoil to spread over the entire realm.

Elanor would be remembered as the queen who destroyed the Elvan kingdom by allowing emotions to cloud her judgment against the greater good of the realm.

After all these years, her sins finally caught up with her, an event she had always dreaded. But she never imagined it would doom the entire world.

The Elvans in the room observed their queen on her knees, bewildered by her refusal to acknowledge their questions about her well-being.

While Elanor was left with nothing but desolation, she suddenly realized that she did not need to send any Elvans to the kingdom of Mayan to fulfill her duty. There was yet someone

outside the Elvan kingdom who possessed Elvan blood.

Could her harbinger of doom become her redeemer?

She knew the Mayans would be enraged if the Elvans didn't show up in their land within a few years, but a race as strong-willed as the Mayans would try to exploit the child with Elvan's blood to accomplish the Elvan race's duty.

She pondered if Fanadaar knew of the half-bloed child, a possibility she couldn't rule out given his knowledge of ancient lore and possession of an ancient legendary Weamris blade.

She prayed to the Blessed One that Fanadaar would not also harm the innocent Mayan child.

She couldn't fathom the dangerous game played by this Sukran and wondered what he aimed to gain by thwarting the Elvans from fulfilling their duty.

What nefarious plan did Fanadaar have in store for the entire realm?

Elanor perused the scroll once more and crumbled beneath the weight of her past misdeeds.

Only one question reverberated in her mind like a hurricane.

Could the Mayan halfling save the realm from its grim fate?

And, more importantly, what nefarious plot did Fanadaar have in store for the entire realm?

Prelude

The Half-Blooded Mayan

Most often, a war is not determined by who is right—only by those left to write the history books.

*-- Jurak
(Mayan Clan Chieftain)*

Mayan Kingdom – Forty Years Later

Alena clutched her aunt's hand and asked for the umpteenth time, "*Are you sure you know the way to our city?*" Her aunt continued to chant spells as they descended the trail leading down from the mountain summit.

Alena raised her other hand, clutching a shining white round stone to light their way. "This doesn't look like the trail we used to enter this accursed mountain," she murmured.

Even though Alena held the white stone, it was her aunt, Rema, who used spells to illuminate the magic stone that had bonded with Alena.

The dense, massive trees on the edges of the trail blocked the bright morning sun that Alena had seen on the summit of the ten-thousand-foot-tall mountain, making the woodland gloomy.

Alena's hair perched up when she heard numerous creatures pursuing them in the darkness. Her aunt, the Oracle of the Mayan race, used her shamanic magic to utilize the magic light to keep the beasts at bay.

As Alena peered about in all directions, she unintentionally let the light from the magical stone reveal one of the monsters pursuing them in the woods.

Alena froze in terror at spotting the creature's monstrous visage. She nearly lost her grip on her aunt's hand, and the white light emanating from the magic stone wavered. Emboldened by the flickering of the magical light, a handful of monsters began to approach the Mayans.

However, the Oracle whispered a spell and grabbed her niece's hand, holding it tight for dear life.

The stone began to shine brightly once again, and the monsters shrieked and fled beyond the region not lit by the stone's magic.

"Dear, you need not fear these monsters," Rema said, trying to soothe her niece's anxiety. "We are close."

"Close to what? Close to death at the hands of these abominations!" Alena snarled at her aunt, knowing she was overreacting.

Undeterred by her niece's concerns, the Oracle guided them steadily through the cursed mountain with unwavering resolve. As they descended towards the mountain's base, sunlight pierced the thinning canopy, casting a triumphant glow upon their path. Yet Alena could still feel

the watchful eyes of unseen creatures lurking within the forest's shadows.

It was a palpable relief when they finally stepped onto a vast expanse of open ground, bordered by imposing walls of stone that soared a hundred feet into the sky. With a jolt of alarm, Alena spied a crimson flag fluttering above the gates, a gray wolf embroidered upon its fabric.

"*Aunty, you've led us astray!* You have taken us to the *Wolfan city!*" Alena accused, her voice tinged with dread. Her father had always warned her to avoid this place at all costs.

Rema released her grip on Alena's hand, a mischievous smile playing upon her lips. "Oh, have I lost my way, little one?"

Alena met her aunt's gaze with fierce determination. "I am not a little girl," she retorted. "I am an adult."

"Would my father have permitted me to enter this wretched mountain if I were still a child?" she hissed.

The Oracle's laughter echoed softly through the clearing, a blend of warmth and gentle mockery. "You will always be my child, even when you bear children of your own."

Before Alena could protest, the Oracle raised a hand, silencing her niece's retort. "Wrap the stone in this dark linen and conceal it within your cloak," she commanded, her tone brooking no argument. She extended a linen cloth of blackish-silver towards Alena. "Do not risk losing it during one of your petulant tantrums."

Alena glared at her aunt, but the wisdom of her words was undeniable. With a sigh, she accepted the cloth and carefully encased the stone, its radiant glow instantly extinguished by the linen. She tucked the bundle into the pocket of her cloak, a garment she rarely wore but had agreed to don for this treacherous journey beyond the safety of Galrogon city – her home.

The two women traversed the open expanse in silence, their weary limbs protesting each step. At last, they reached the colossal metal gates of Wolfan city and paused, trepidation hanging heavy in the air.

"*Wolfan warriors of the Maya race, I, the Oracle, request passage through your city,*" the Oracle's voice rang out, clear and unwavering.

A tense silence followed. Then, with a groan of metal, the gates ascended vertically, revealing a contingent of Wolfan warriors ready to receive them, their faces etched with hardened vigilance.

Alena and the Oracle entered the Wolfan city, and shortly after, the gates slammed shut behind them with an ominous finality.

"*Well...well...what do we have here?*" A sneering voice pierced the stillness, drawing their attention to the right. A hulking Mayan warrior, clad in a sleeveless green shirt and cotton slacks, pushed his way through the ranks of soldiers, his towering physique casting an imposing shadow on all the Mayans lingering around.

"Well, well...look who's greeted us with their presence here?" he drawled, dark eyes glinting with a predatory gleam. "The esteemed oracle of the Mayan race and it's half blooded princess!"

The Oracle acknowledged the hulking wolfan clan chief with a frigid tone, "*Jurak*. We are merely passing through your city."

Jurak's gaze narrowed as he approached, his movements deliberate and menacing. "Passing

through indeed..." he mused, inclining his head towards the Oracle. "Passing through from the accursed mountains?"

Alena's hand instinctively fell to the hilt of her longsword, her voice ringing with defiance. "Not one step closer, clanchief" she warned.

"Or what, Mayan Princess?" Jurak leered at Alena, his eyes gleaming with a dangerous edge.

Alena, undeterred, unsheathed her sword, its gleaming blade pointing directly at Jurak's chest. The soldiers, witnessing the tense standoff, instinctively raised their bows, metal-tipped arrows nocked and aimed at both the Oracle and the young princess.

Jurak's sneer widened, his voice laced with icy contempt. "You may be the Mayan Princess, but I am the clan chief of this city, and it would be in your best interest to lower that sword if you wish to leave this city unscathed."

Rema, ever the composed Oracle, placed a calming hand on her niece's, gently lowering the raised sword. "What do you want, Jurak?" she asked, her voice steady despite the tense situation.

"I want to know what the esteemed Oracle of the Maya race and its half-blood princess were skulking around those damned mountains," Jurak retorted, his eyes narrowing with suspicion.

"It is none of your business!" Alena snapped, her voice laced with defiance.

Jurak's gaze turned icy, his words dripping with menace. "It is my business if you are passing through my city. And I have a strong suspicion that you are carrying a little package back to Galrogon city, aren't you?"

Rema and Alena exchanged a knowing glance, their faces feigning innocence. "What package are you referring to?" Rema asked, her tone laced with feigned ignorance.

Jurak strolled forward with a predatory grace, his movements calculated and intimidating. He reached out and grabbed Rema roughly, holding her close as he pressed one of his twin knives against her throat. "I am not naive to believe that the Oracle and the half-blooded Mayan Princess would be venturing into those treacherous mountains without seeking the one thing of great value in that mountain. I suspect you were searching for the mystical Guardian stone, isn't it?"

Rema struggled to speak, her voice barely a whisper, "As long as Toraz lives, Alena will not inherit the stone." She hoped dearly that the rogue clan chief would buy in to her story.

Alena, her eyes blazing with fury, threatened the wolf clan chief. "Jurak, if my father discovers your treachery, he will torture you until you beg for death."

Jurak chuckled darkly; his voice laced with a chilling disregard. "He will never know what happened to you. You and the Oracle could have easily perished in those treacherous mountains. Your father would have no one but himself to blame for your disappearance."

His eyes turned cold, his gaze fixed on the Oracle. "And if I were to silence you and your niece and bury you deep within my city, neither your father nor his bonded beast would ever discover your remains."

Alena hissed, her voice laced with venom. "You may be able to kill us, Jurak, but I will take a few of your soldiers with me to my grave."

Jurak's lips curled into a cruel smile. "You won't, Alena. Instead, you will watch helplessly as I sever each of your aunt's fingers before you hand over the magic stone you possess."

Alena's breath caught in her throat, her eyes wide with horror. "It is not yours to possess," she gasped, her voice trembling.

Jurak's eyes gleamed with malicious intent. "It is mine if it comes within my range, and last I checked, Wolfan city belongs to me."

"But..."

With a cold, menacing voice, Jurak issued his ultimatum: "If you do not hand over the stone to me within the next five seconds, I will chop off one of your aunt's fingers before we restart the counting for the next finger." His knife inched closer to the Oracle's index finger, emphasizing his ruthless threat.

Alena's mind raced, desperately searching for a way to save her aunt and escape from this city ruled by a ruthless clan chief. She watched in anguish as her aunt struggled against Jurak's grip, her heart pounding in her chest.

Left with no other choice, Alena made a difficult decision. "Will you promise to let us leave this accursed city without harm if I hand you the Guardis stone?" she asked, her voice trembling with desperation. She knew that trusting Jurak was a gamble, but she could not bear to watch her aunt suffer.

Jurak shrugged nonchalantly. "I have no use for you or the Oracle other than to acquire the stone you possess." His eyes gleamed with avarice as he stared at the princess. "I give my word that I will allow you to pass through my city unharmed if you hand over the Guardis stone."

Alena fell silent, her gaze fixed on her aunt. Rema, with a knowing nod, gestured her niece to surrender the stone. Alena, hoping that her aunt might have foreseen the events to come, reluctantly agreed.

With a heavy heart, she lowered her sword and reached into her cloak, retrieving a piece of black linen. She tossed the stone wrapped in the black linen towards the wolf clan chief, who snatched it with unbridled excitement.

Jurak shoved the Oracle towards one of his soldiers, his attention solely focused on the glowing stone. He eagerly unwrapped the linen, revealing the radiant white stone that shone even in the bright sunlight.

A triumphant smile spread across Jurak's face as he caressed the stone, his eyes gleaming with anticipation. He sliced his palm with his knife, letting his blood drip onto the stone, initiating the bonding process with the magic stone.

Alena and the Oracle watched in disbelief at Jurak possessing knowledge on using blood to bond with the mystical Guardis stone. Soon, they witnessed a white glow enveloping Jurak, signaling his connection forging with the magical stone. Jurak reveled in the power coursing through him, and a maniacal grin spreading across his face.

"Who told you how to bond with the Guardis stone?" Alena demanded; her voice laced with disbelief.

"An old man enlightened me about these Guardis stones so many years ago!" Jurak retorted smugly, *"In fact, I even know how to use this magic stone."*

He gazed at the stone with adoration, basking in its warmth. "It appears like fortune has finally begun to favor me. Now that I possess this powerful stone, I am on my way to acquiring a Weamris sword to bond with it."

Alena's patience had worn thin. "Jurak, you promised to let us leave this city in peace," she reminded him, her voice laced with frustration.

Jurak let out a sinister chuckle. "Foolish girl. You will not be permitted to leave Wolfan city yet."

"*But you made a promise!*" Alena protested.

Jurak's lips curled into a mocking sneer. "I offered my word that I would let you pass through my city, but you never specified the timeframe when I should allow you to leave."

"*Liar!*" Alena cried out, her anger flaring.

She raised her sword, ready to strike Jurak, but Rema intervened, placing a restraining hand on her niece's arm.

"Child, everything is just the way it should be," Rema assured her niece, her voice calm and reassuring.

"Aunty, I'm not in the mood for your cryptic remarks," Alena snarled. But despite her frustration, Alena heeded her aunt's counsel and lowered her sword. She let a group of Wolfan soldiers escort her and her aunt towards the heart of Wolfan city.

Recollection about Jurak bragging about seeking a Weamris blade made her stop on her tracks. Turning to face Jurak, Alena scoffed, "I don't recall hearing about any of the Mayan clan possessing the fabled Weamris sword."

Jurak, still basking in the glory of his newfound power, replied with a wry chuckle, "It is true that none exist in our kingdom, but the Sukrans possess one."

"*Sukrans?*" Alena echoed, her eyes widening in surprise at Jurak's revelation.

"Yes, princess!" Jurak let out a hearty laugh, his eyes gleaming with malicious intent. "*I am going to war with the Sukrans.*"

Chapter 1

Magic is Might

*"Kindled by spirit,
Caroused by fire,
Roistered by wind,
Tendered by water,
Strengthened by earth,
And bound by blood..."*

*-- Evander Primus at the dawn of the Age of Magic
(First king of Sukra)*

"Concentrate harder, boy!" Garius bellowed at his struggling son, who grappled to maintain a stone elemental shield against a streak of flames threatening to engulf him.

"Father, this fire terrifies me," William whimpered, raising his hands in an attempt to maintain the stone shield from succumbing to the torrent of flames emanating from his father's outstretched palms.

William contended against the scorching blaze, seemingly eager to sear his flesh the moment he faltered in controlling his stone shield.

Even in the early hours of a delightful spring morning, perspiration gleamed on the young teenager's face, aggravated further by the raging fire pit set up adjacent to his father.

As William grappled, the inferno seemed eager and poised to consume him.

"Do not yield, boy. Strive harder to sustain your shield," Garius growled.

Yet, as William lost control over his earth elemental, the leaping flames reduced his stone shield into gravel. A scream of terror escaped William as the fire surged toward his face.

Garius sighed ruefully at his son's pitiful attempt to maintain a simple stone shield. But he pulled the fire back from scorching his son's torso in the nick of time while William sank to his knees, completely petrified by the encounter.

"I never envisioned my son would prove too fragile to wield a simple stone shield," Garius began berating his son for his lackluster display in mastering elemental magic.

Granting his son a few moments to collect himself, Garius urged him to rise.

"Will, why do you believe you faltered in maintaining the shield?" Garius tempered his irritation, posing the question to his son.

"I... lost control of my magic," gasped William, still kneeling on the ground, shaken to the core by the terrifying encounter.

"It appears you have lost more than just control over magic," Garius shook his head, observing his son quivering in fear.

William lowered his head in shame, and was met with Garius's heavy sigh.

"What is elemental magic?" Garius asked

William rose to his feet, brushing off the dirt.

"It's the magic used to manipulate the elements surrounding us."

"What are the various elements of our realm?"

"Orinn encompasses five primary elements: *earth, fire, air, water, and spirit*."

"And the secondary elements?"

"*Metal, wood, light, and shadow*."

"You've overlooked *space and time*," Garius admonished his son.

"But father, that's merely a myth. No one in our history has successfully bent space or time."

"Yes, that is a myth, but many Sukrans have faith that our race will one day evolve enough to be able to bend space. Sukrans may one day be able to teleport from one end of the kingdom to the other if the speculation by our learned scholars is to be believed."

Garius fell silent, allowing William to absorb and memorize the information.

"*So, how do you manipulate these elements?*"

"We manipulate the elements by communing with the elements."

Garius shook his head. "Wrong...we can't directly control the elements."

"You can't raise a stone shield under the ground just by commanding it in the physical realm."

"It's an onerous task to transform the elements from one form to another in the physical realm without magic."

"But it's pretty easy to transform the elements from one form to another if you can commune with the primal spirit of the element."

"*After all, the spirit is a spectral reflection of your physical self in the spirit realm*."

"You manipulate a primal spirit in the spirit realm, and the result is witnessed in the physical realm."

Garius extended his arms wide. "*Essentially, magic in our world hinges on your mastery over the spirits*."

"The various styles of magic practiced by the different races in the realm boil down to spirit magic. Each race employs a different means of controlling the primal spirits around you."

Garius grew silent to let the information sink in to his son. "Like how we all possess spirits or souls as some would call it, even the primary and secondary elements in this realm possess spirits."

"We hail them as the primal spirits or elemental spirits—the spirits that aided in creating this magical realm in the first place."

"So, you can manipulate the elements around you only by communing and controlling those elements' primal spirits." Garius continued.

"Boy, never forget that we are composed of body, mind, and spirit."

"We must train our minds to access our spirit, utilizing it as a conduit for interacting and influencing the primal spirits within our realm."

Silence enveloped the pair as Garius allowed William to absorb the information, letting it penetrate his thick head.

"So, we use our spirits as a conduit to commune with the primal spirits?" Will asked more to himself.

"Yes!" Garius replied with an heavy huff.

After a contemplative pause, Garius inquired, "What are the strengths and weaknesses of our elemental magic?"

"We can only manipulate the elements that are present near us." Will replied.

"Yes, Sukrans possess the ability to manipulate the elements surrounding us, but we lack the power to create any element, in stark contrast to the Elvans. They, with their mastery over spirits by using spells and true names, can manifest their ideas into tangible elements at will."

Garius gestured toward the fire pit containing smoldering logs. "I cannot conjure fire without a nearby source. However, Elvans, commanding a fire spirit, can unleash flames even when no fire source is in proximity."

William tried to understand the Sukran magic particularly. "So, you can transform one element into another only when that element is present, but you cannot create it?" William sought clarification.

Garius nodded. "Exactly."

"So, what if there's no nearby fire to enhance your magic?" William inquired, his curiosity piqued.

"I can generate fire from any material that possesses warmth," Garius replied, pointing towards the radiant glow of the morning sun. "I can extract the warmth from the air that has been warmed by this glorious morning sunlight."

As he spoke, Garius demonstrated his elemental mastery, drawing fire from the surrounding air. A fireball erupted in his palms, casting an eerie glow upon their faces.

The temperature around William dropped noticeably as his father siphoned the warmth from the air in their vicinity, causing a sudden chill to descend upon them. Garius, visibly fatigued from exerting his fire elemental powers, released the magic, allowing the air to regain its warmth.

"While generating fire from a nearby source of fire is undoubtedly more efficient and easier by allowing me to directly manipulate the element and amplify its strength, transforming one element into another requires significantly more effort to bring our magic into reality," Garius explained, his voice tinged with weariness.

"Our world is composed of all the elements that mix to form the reality in which we live; thus, if you are smart, you can manipulate the elements that exist around us."

William absorbed the knowledge imparted by his father, his mind buzzing with newfound understanding.

"However, a word of caution," Garius warned. "The number of primal spirits you can control simultaneously is directly proportional to the strength of your mind. The more powerful your mind, the greater the number of elements you can manipulate."

"So, I can access two primal spirits simultaneously?" William's eyes widened with anticipation.

"Indeed," Garius affirmed. "Provided you can compartmentalize your mind effectively, allowing you to connect with multiple primal spirits simultaneously."

Willaim pondered out loud. "Therefore, those with an affinity for multiple elements should cultivate the ability to compartmentalize their minds, enabling them to access all the primal spirits at the same time," William concluded, his mind racing with possibilities.

After a moment of silence, he asked the one question swirling within his mind. *"Is there a price to pay for wielding our magic?"*

"All magic exacts a toll, and the price of our elemental magic is mental fatigue," Garius explained. "The more potent the magic you cast, the faster your mind becomes exhausted, requiring a longer recovery period before you can wield magic again."

Garius pointed his hand at his son. "Therefore, exercise caution when employing magic that exceeds your mind's capacity. Just as our muscles grow stronger with regular use, so too does our mind, enhancing our ability to control magic effectively."

"So that's why older Sukrans struggle to control their magic as their mind deteriorates over time," William hypothesized, observing that the older men on the farmhold had difficulty harnessing their magic.

Garius nodded and smiled gently at his son, who might not be a total loss after all.

"But how can we strengthen our minds and spirits to amplify the potency of our magic?" William asked, eager to uncover the secrets to unlocking his full potential.

"The more you use your mind, the stronger it will become, aiding you in enhancing the potency of your magic," Garius replied. "Dare I say, you have much catching up to do if you aspire to become a powerful elementalist."

With a twinkle in his eye, Garius posed a challenge to his son, "Now, tell me, what are the strengths and weaknesses of each elemental?"

William, eager to showcase his knowledge, readily responded, "Air can empower you to *soar through the skies* by creating a windstream strong enough to lift you into the clouds. It can also amplify your hearing by fetching sounds from distances far greater than normal."

"Earth, being the sturdiest of all elements, can lend you its immense strength, enabling you to lift objects of immense weight. Fire can incinerate anything in its path, while water can heal the wounds of living creatures. Spirit allows us to communicate with one another across vast distances."

Garius shook his head. "No, water alone doesn't help in healing us. It's a combination of spirit and water magic that can aid in healing a wounded creature. You have to heal both the body and the spirit at the same time so that the injured person can recover completely."

"Water being a natural source for nourishing life, provides the much-needed energy for the body to heal itself while the healer has to urge the wounded spirit to direct its body and heal itself using the nourishing water provided to it."

"But healing has limits; you can't regenerate a severed hand. Any flesh scorched by fire can never be healed completely. After all, fire contrasts with water, and the scorched flesh resists getting fully healed despite the nourishment provided by water."

Garius stopped discussing more about the intricacies of healing. He was neither a healer nor was his son, even though William seemed interested in the art of healing.

"Where do secondary elements fit into the world?" Garius questioned.

"Those with *earth* and *fire* elements can control the *metal* element, while those with *earth* and *water* elements can manage the *wood* element," William concluded.

"Yes, the combination of *air* and *fire* elementals are used to manipulate *light* and *shadow*."

"Father, is it possible to employ the light elemental to become invisible?"

"Absolutely. They bend light to conceal themselves, even in broad daylight."

"And shadow magic?" Will inquire eagerly.

"Shadow magic is a clandestine art, primarily employed by assassins and spies," Garius explained. "In fact, most powerful Shadow elementalists are called shadow walkers if they can seamlessly leap from one shadow to another, concealing themselves amidst the darkness."

William absorbed the knowledge, his mind buzzing with newfound insights.

"Father," he inquired, his voice tinged with curiosity, "I still lack a clear understanding of spirit casting on how they can aid us in healing other humans."

"Hmm!" Garius paused, his eyes gleaming with a hint of intrigue at his son's eagerness to learn more about water and spirit magic rather than earth magic. "Since we wield our spirits to manipulate the elemental spirits around us, couldn't we also exert control over the spirits of other individuals?"

"The rules of the physical realm do not restrict spirits," Garius continued, his voice resonating with authority. "Sukrans can employ spirit casting to transmit messages to other Sukrans across the realm, regardless of distance. Additionally, spirit casting can be utilized to soothe or agitate the emotions of others, proving invaluable in interrogating and truth-seeking prisoners."

He paused again, allowing William to process the information.

"However," Garius cautioned, "while we can commune with the primal spirits of the elements through our spirits, as our bodies are composed of the same elements of nature, interacting with the spirits of other sentient beings within the realm requires a special ability."

William pondered his father's words, his mind racing with possibilities. "So, that's why we have fewer Sukrans with healing abilities," he mused. "The art of healing demands not only mastery over water casting but also the ability to commune with other sentient spirits."

Garius nodded, a hint of disappointment clouding his gaze. His son seemed more engrossed in the intricacies of magic than practicing it.

"Father," William pressed, his curiosity piqued, "if we utilize our spirits to control the elements around us, why can't we exert control over the spirits of other people?"

A scowl etched Garius's face as he faced his son's persistent queries. "Oh, boy," he retorted, his voice laced with exasperation, "we have the ability to control the spirits of others as well. Haven't you noticed the slaves in the valley, boy?"

William nodded in acknowledgment. "Yes, I have seen many of them in the valley, but not on our farmhold," he replied, his voice laced with apprehension.

"Well," Garius explained, his tone softening slightly, "our master, Adrian Veracious, views slavery as an abomination. He believes that imprisoning someone's spirit is a fate far worse than any physical punishment."

However, Garius's expression hardened as he continued, "There are those who have

committed heinous crimes, individuals who have been condemned to slavery, their spirits bound to their masters, forcing them to obey every command without question."

"And remember, there is no better prison to punish the wrongdoers than imprisoning them within their own mind where their free will is subdued by spirit magic!"

"Adrian is right in believing that there can be no worse punishment in this world than being enslaved in one's own mind!"

Turning to his son, his gaze piercing, Garius issued a stern warning. "And boy, if you don't start practicing your magic with dedication, you might end up as one of those slaves."

William's heart pounded in his chest at the thought of such a fate. He had witnessed firsthand the plight of the slaves in the valley, their lives stripped of dignity and freedom.

The slaves in their kingdom were treated as the worst of society. Of course, every townsman treated Theron like vermin.

Slaves were not even deemed as men in the eyes of their brethren.

Garius's fingers traced his chin in a contemplative gesture. "We must employ a different technique to mold you into a respectable earth caster," he declared. "Evidently, your feeble mind is not assisting your cause."

Just then, the sound of footsteps approaching the training circle interrupted their conversation. A voice called out, "Ah, Garius, what a pleasant surprise to encounter you so early in the morning!"

Garius turned to face his close friend, Sergius, who also resided on Adrian's farmhold. "Good morning, Sergius," he greeted cordially.

Sergius's gaze fell upon the young boy, William, who was perspiring profusely despite the early hour. "Ah, young William," he addressed the boy. "How are your training sessions progressing? We hold high hopes that you will emulate your father's legacy and become a powerful elemental." Sergius stepped next to William and ruffled his hair.

Before William could respond, Garius interjected with a disparaging remark about his son. "It would be a miracle if he could overcome his fear and refrain from wetting himself whenever confronted with even a minor magical fire attack," he scoffed.

Sergius echoed Garius's sentiment, adding his own query. "Boy, how do you aspire to become a soldier one day if you continue to cower in fear at the sight of a mere fireball?"

William's face flushed with a mixture of embarrassment and determination. He remained silent, his resolve to master magic burning within him.

Garius sighed, his voice heavy with disappointment. "I am beginning to wonder if Will's weakness stems from his mother's bloodline. He's as feeble in magic as his mother," he lamented. "I should have thought twice before marrying a water caster with no spirit-casting ability."

William's eyes widened in disbelief, his heart aching at his father's words. He held deep affection for his gentle and kind mother, and he couldn't bear to hear her ridiculed.

"Well, you didn't marry Lartha for her magical prowess, did you?" Sergius teased.

Garius chuckled, momentarily forgetting his frustration. "True!" he conceded. "If I had known I'd sire a son who would tremble in fear at the sight of a mere fireball, I would have..." He paused, his words trailing off.

"Oh, you're not the only one who's made such a mistake," Sergius scoffed, his voice laced with irony. "Never forget that you share the company of some elite Sukrans!"

Garius waved his hand dismissively. "True," he conceded. "I share this dubious honor with Prince Livian Primus, who also married a woman with negligible magic."

"Yes," Sergius agreed, his voice dripping with sarcasm, "it's still quite astonishing that Prince Livian dared to sire a bastard with a lady farmholder whose magical abilities pale in comparison to his own."

"He's probably still regretting that decision in the afterlife, siring a bastard with one of the maids in his phalanx," Sergius continued, his disdain for the deceased prince evident.

"No wonder Dorian Primus, the bastard son of Livian Primus, hardly possesses his father's powers," Sergius sneered.

William, his curiosity piqued, inquired about the deceased prince, who was widely revered among the Sukran populace. "Father, didn't Prince Livian Primus get married?" he asked, his voice filled with eagerness.

"No, Will," Garius replied, his tone somber. "Livian Primus was slain in battle before he could marry and produce a rightful heir to the Sukran throne."

"Instead of leaving behind a legitimate and powerful heir to continue the illustrious reign of the House of Primus," Garius lamented, "we find ourselves in a predicament where the House of Primus is on the brink of being ousted from the Sukran throne."

Turning to his friend, Garius expressed his disbelief. "Have you ever heard of a Sukran prince who lacked the ability to control all the elements?" he exclaimed, his voice laced with astonishment.

Sergius shook his head in agreement. "No," he affirmed. "And more importantly, I've heard that he can't even fly," he scoffed. "Can you imagine a man with no flying skills attempting to ascend the Sukran throne?"

"No chance that any Sukran citizen would accept to be ruled by such a weak prince."

"Despite Dorian's reputation as a competent swordsman and his proficiency in fire and earth magic," Sergius asserted, "I am certain that he would struggle to hold his own against even the weakest of noble lords, let alone formidable ones like Alectan and Maleficus."

"Indeed," Garius concurred. "This is precisely why the noble lords are maneuvering for the throne, for they perceive our bastard prince as an unworthy successor to King Valerian Primus."

"*Yet, King Primus wants his bastard grandson to ascend the throne.*" Garius replied.

Sergius shook his head in disbelief. "The noble lords may tremble before King Primus's might, but make no mistake, the bastard prince poses no threat to their power. I have heard of numerous assassination attempts against Dorian's life, all thwarted by his powerful grandfather's intervention."

"In anticipation of King Valerian Primus's descension from the throne, the nobles have begun forming factions to support their preferred candidates among the squabbling lords," Garius explained.

After a moment of silence, Garius let out an evil chuckle as a thought surfaced on his

mind. "Maybe it would be an excellent match for the bastard prince to befriend our dear Theron of Adrian-Hold."

Sergius erupted in laughter. "*A match made in heaven, indeed!*" he exclaimed. "Our master's magicless nephew and the bastard prince – a pairing of unparalleled absurdity."

"One is the first Sukran prince to lack the power to retain his rank in our society," Garius remarked, "while our beloved Theron is the first Sukran...not to possess magic at all."

"A deadly combination if there ever were one." Sergius added sarcastically.

A frown creased Sergius's forehead as a troubling thought occurred to him. "William always hangs around with that magicless freak, has he not?" he inquired.

Garius nodded in exasperation. "I cannot fathom what my son sees in that worthless piece of shit," he grumbled.

For the first time in his life, William dared to contradict his father. "*Theron is not worthless,*" he asserted with newfound courage.

"What was that, boy?" Garius roared, his voice laced with anger.

"Theron is not worthless." William reiterated with more courage to speak against his father.

"What spell has that freak cast upon you?" Garius hissed, his eyes narrowing. "Do not let any of the townsmen hear you defend that freak. They might turn their harassment upon our family as well."

Despite his father's warning, William stood firm in his defense of his friend. "But, Father, Theron is my friend," he protested.

Garius dismissed William's claims with a contemptuous snort. "No, Theron is nothing more than a wastrel who contributes nothing of value to the town," he declared.

"If Theron were not the nephew of our master Adrian and Lady Elissa," Sergius asserted, "we would have chased him out of the valley long ago."

The trio fell into an uneasy silence, William bristling in rage at his friend's humiliation. However, he wisely chose to remain silent, fearing his father's volatile temper.

"Do you think that the freak's curse might spread?" Sergius speculated. "Perhaps it explains William's struggles with mastering magic despite inheriting the magic of your powerful bloodline."

A frown settled upon Garius's face. "I pray that is not the case, for the freak's sake," he confessed. "But if that wretch has somehow stunted my son's magical abilities, I will not hesitate to end his life with my bare hands, nephew of our master or not."

Sergius sighed deeply. "Speaking of the devil," he began, his voice laced with sarcasm, "have you seen the freak today?"

"No, I have not," Garius replied with a shrug. "Perhaps the wastrel is still slumbering."

Sergius shook his head in denial. "No," he corrected, "Theron has already herded the cattle to the nearby grasslands for grazing."

"I am eagerly awaiting his return so that I can lock those cattle in the animal pens and be done with my duties for the day," Sergius declared with a hint of eagerness.

"So eager to complete your duties so early, are we?" Garius teased playfully.

"Indeed," Sergius confessed, his eyes sparkling with anticipation. "I am eagerly awaiting today's tournament and the subsequent Wintersend Festival feast in the fortress." Sergius dreamed in glee about the sumptuous feast waiting for him in the fortress tonight.

The old count, Marius Tenevis, had graciously invited every townsman to his fortress to celebrate the Wintersend Festival as like all the previous years.

"Perhaps the freak has chickened out and is hiding in the grasslands after foolishly enrolling himself in the tournament," Garius sneered.

Sergius's eyes widened in astonishment. "What! Theron is participating in the tournament?" he exclaimed incredulously "Has he lost his mind as well? *How can a magicless freak hope to compete in the tournament today?*"

Garius waved his hand dismissively, a cruel smirk playing on his lips. "On the contrary, my dear friend," he retorted, "I am eagerly anticipating the freak's participation in the tournament. I relish the thought of witnessing his humiliation before the entire town. Imagine the shame that will befall Adrian when his nephew flees away from the arena, his tail tucked between his legs."

Sergius nodded in agreement, his eyes gleaming with malicious anticipation. "Yes, Garius," he concurred, "it would be a spectacle to behold. The townspeople will revel in the freak's downfall, their laughter echoing through the fortress as he flees from the tournament in disgrace."

William, unable to bear the sight of his beloved friend being subjected to such mockery, stepped forward, his voice trembling with defiance. "Father," he interjected, his gaze unwavering, "I may not know how Theron intends to become victorious in the tournament without magic, but I can assure you he will not cower in fear or flee from his opponents."

Garius's eyes narrowed, his lips curling into a sneer. "We shall see about that, boy," he growled, his voice laced with venom. "But if you do not wish to share the freak's fate, I suggest you dedicate yourself wholeheartedly to mastering your magic."

"Remember, there is nothing more important to Sukrans than magic. After all, Magic is the very essence of our existence," Garius continued, his tone heavy with disdain, "Magic is the source of our power and the key to our survival. Without it, you are nothing more than a weakling, a pathetic excuse for a Sukran."

"And magic is the only thing that can improve your station in our society." Sergius reiterated to William.

"Yes. Magic is the primary currency of Sukra, boy. Don't you ever forget it." Garius declared.

"See you later at the festival, Garius." Sergius bid the duo farewell as he went in search of the devil who was yet to return with the cattle.

"Where the devil is Theron?" Sergius growled.

Chapter 2

The Magicless Freak

What is more essential, talent or dedication? Most would choose talent, but I will boldly choose dedication without any doubt. For talent without dedication is as worthless as a snake without poison.

I seek dedication over talent, for talent is cheap; dedication is as expensive as the gratified life it can offer.

For I need dedication more than talent in the unenviable quest I have embarked on to understand the nuances of our way of life and, more importantly, how it can be enhanced.

No man is good or bad by birth.

Only his ideologies determine him as good or evil. And If I hope to reform my kingdom, I need to change the ideologies of my brethren.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

"Footwork!" Cadmus hissed, his eyes gazing with predatory intent. He lunged forward, his sword a blur of deadly steel, aiming for Theron's torso. Simultaneously, Cadmus commanded his earth elemental to erupt from the ground beneath Theron's feet, hoping to disrupt his student's balance and leaving Theron vulnerable to attack from his long sword.

Theron, however, was no novice in swordplay. Sensing a manifestation of an earth elemental about to rise beneath his feet, he swiftly evaded its grasp, his movements as fluid as water. With several years of honed reflexes, he intercepted Cadmus's sword strike, deflecting his master's blade away from his midsection.

The ground where Theron had stood moments ago shattered, unleashing a hail of stones that rained down upon Cadmus. The skilled swordsman, reacted to this counterattack with equal swiftness, conjured a stone shield with the aid of his earth elemental, effectively protecting himself from the barrage of stones spawned by his own magic.

Theron, his eyes locked on his opponent, took a step back, his mind racing with strategies. Cadmus, the sword master who had been training him for the past eight years, was a formidable opponent, renowned for his mastery of swordsmanship besides possessing potent earth and fire magic.

Theron, an ambidextrous swordsman himself, parried Cadmus's slash towards his waist with the sword in his left hand. In the same breath, he unleashed a powerful swipe at his opponent's knees with the sword in his right hand. Cadmus, however, was equally skilled, his narrow dagger intercepting Theron's attack just as it was about to strike his target.

Theron's long, rippling white hair danced around his shoulders as his intense blue eyes darted around the glade, searching for any telltale signs of magical attacks. His broad black brows furrowed in concentration, his sharp cheekbones and slender nose adding to his air of determination. His small, open lips, set in a firm line, tasted the metallic tang of battle in the air.

Both swordsmen circled each other warily, their movements a dance of death. Cadmus, his

long blonde hair tied back with a ribbon to prevent it from becoming a distraction, held his long sword at the ready, his slanted pale gray eyes following Theron's every move like a hawk.

Save for the mark of a coward, Cadmus' sharp nose, square jaw, and tanned complexion accentuated his handsome countenance. On his left cheek, the imprint of a crown with diagonal slashes transformed his attractive features into a more menacing visage. Despite his slim appearance, Theron was certain that not a single muscle in his opponent's lithe physique remained untuned after enduring countless whippings from Cadmus in sword training over the past eight years.

Cadmus wielded a longsword that gleamed in the early morning light, heralding its triumph over the darkness of the night. They engaged in a fierce duel across the grassland beyond the alcove on the crest of a small mountain, where a herd of cattle grazed. Natural elements surrounded the alcove, including a creek that streamed nearby, its gurgling noise echoing against the rough pebbles littering the stream bed.

Theron had chosen this alcove to conceal his sword training from the prying eyes of townspeople, who rarely ventured into the mountains to herd their cattle from the Lemurian Valley, five miles away.

Circling his sword master without breaking stride, Theron keenly listened for any elemental magic assaults. As anticipated, Cadmus launched a rapid gust of wind to his right, aiming to catch Theron off guard. Focused on his surroundings, Theron sliced through the windstream with his right blade while delivering a surprise strike with the left.

A flicker of shock, followed by grudging admiration, crossed Cadmus's face. He had not expected such a swift and precise counterattack from his student, a testament to Theron's growing prowess.

The duel continued, a mesmerizing dance of swordplay as Theron skillfully switched between offense and defense, his twin blades weaving a tapestry of deadly strikes. Cadmus, despite his mastery of magic and swordsmanship, was forced to retreat cautiously, his sword and dagger interposing themselves between him and Theron's relentless onslaught.

After an hour of intense sparring, neither swordsman showed signs of fatigue. Their movements remained fluid and precise, a testament to their years of training. Cadmus's elemental magic was matched by Theron's exceptional skills and physical conditioning, honed over a decade of practice.

Theron's custom-designed unique swords were equal in size and length, with identical pommels that appeared to be composed of a combination of gleaming metals. They were a stark contrast to Cadmus's longsword, a weapon of practicality rather than ostentation.

"Not bad for a boy without magic," Cadmus taunted, hoping to unsettle Theron and force his ward into making a mistake.

Theron had received enough lashings in prior duels to compose himself and ignore the taunts from his sword master.

Cadmus was a rare common citizen who could control multiple primary and secondary elementals. And Cadmus was prodigious with fire and earth, which enabled him access to the metal element. After all, most metals are formed from fire and earth containing various mineral

ores.

"These blades seem a splendid substitute for your deficiency in elemental magic," Cadmus remarked, admiring the weapons.

Theron narrowed his eyes, sensing a shift in Cadmus's tactics. The sword master was stalling, buying time to unleash a coordinated assault of magic and swordsmanship, hoping to overwhelm his student with a single, decisive strike.

Sure enough, Cadmus summoned a torrent of pebbles from the ground, intent on bombarding Theron's right side. Simultaneously, Cadmus commanded his earth elemental, manifested as a black stone panther, to pounce on Theron from the left. To prevent Theron from retreating, Cadmus conjured a windstream barrier behind him.

Theron, however, was not caught off guard. His heightened senses had detected Cadmus's upcoming elemental assaults before they even commenced, providing him the extra time to predict Cadmus' next move alongside the magical assaults.

Theron recognized that Cadmus's magical attacks were a mere distraction, designed to keep him occupied while Cadmus lunged with his longsword, aiming for a killing blow.

Impressed with Cadmus' cold calculation on using his familiarity with Theron's reactions to surprise attacks, Theron made an inconceivable maneuver. He pivoted to the left, directly into Cadmus's swinging arc. With a swift movement of his left sword, he slashed horizontally at Cadmus's body, forcing the sword master to take a hasty step back to avoid the blade.

Theron, without pausing, continued the backswing of his left sword, severing the head of the manifested panther made of stones to his left and then slicing through the windstream barrier on his rear side.

He then dodged another of Cadmus' sword thrusts on his chest by a whisker before stepping into the sword master's arc and pointing his right blade at Cadmus's throat.

Theron's abrupt forward movement caused the plethora of small pebbles to fall harmlessly into the space he vacated, while Cadmus' earth and air elemental manifestations disintegrated into a mist after being obliterated by Theron's left sword. Cadmus watched as his elementals disintegrated before they could do their job of distracting Theron.

Cadmus was caught off guard by Theron's unexpected and brutal counterattack and discovered Theron's longsword mere inches from his throat, a stark contrast to the scenario he had envisioned. Both warriors held their positions for a minute until Cadmus raised his hand in defeat.

"*I yield!*" Cadmus sounded surprised at his defeat.

Theron retracted his sword and took a few steps back before sheathing his longswords into the scabbards fastened in a crisscross pattern to the armor on his back.

He looked up to see Cadmus looking at him with wide eyes before nodding in admiration of his ward's accomplishment. "I've never expected you to defeat me in just eight years of training and without magic to boot. Well done, lad!"

"I had a masterful instructor and superior weapons," Theron shrugged, his tone laced with nonchalance. He understood that defeating his sword master was merely the first step in his journey to becoming the most formidable swordsman he could be.

Despite the fact that his mentor was an estranged and capable guardsman for some of the wealthiest merchants in the north, Theron was aware that there were countless swordsmen within the Sukran kingdom who could easily defeat him, none more so than Erasmus Berian, the best swordsman in the kingdom..

Cadmus shook his head in astonishment. "I am still not able to comprehend on how you were able discern all of my elemental assaults without possessing any elemental magic of your own?"

Theron responded with a knowing smile. "I have always possessed the ability to sense other beings, both magical and human. I doubt it would have mattered much if you hadn't crafted these magnificent swords to compensate for my lack of magic."

Cadmus shook his head in disagreement. "Nay, Theron. The weapons are merely tools. It is your heightened senses that make you exceptionally dangerous. *Never underestimate them, lad.*"

A silence fell upon them as they contemplated how Theron had managed to defeat his sword master for the first time in the eight years since his training had commenced.

"Besides," Cadmus pointed out, gesturing towards the twin swords slung across his ward's back, "you were the one who designed the swords, even though they were forged by others."

Theron grinned at his master before approaching the cloak he had discarded before commencing the duel. He retrieved a pouch of coins from his cloak and tossed it towards Cadmus, who effortlessly snatched it out of the air with his powerful air elemental.

Cadmus' expression turned grave. "*Are you certain you wish to proceed with this plan?*"

Theron nodded resolutely. "You know why I must execute this plan. This is likely my only opportunity to gain Count Marius's endorsement for admission to the university. I may be skilled with swords, but without magic, I am nothing more than a mere babe against all the powerful elementalists."

"*Magic is not everything,*" Cadmus sighed, shaking his head to gather his thoughts.

"Do you believe Sergius will maintain his composure today? It requires someone to handle the task with utmost delicacy," Cadmus questioned.

Theron met his gaze with unwavering determination. "I have faith in Sergius' loathing for a magicless freak like me to complete his task. He needs only a gentle nudge in the right direction."

Cadmus grinned at him. "As you suggested, I have already revealed your plans to Garius under the guise of a foolish servant blabbering his master's schemes. By now, Garius must have informed Sergius about your participation in the Wintersend tournament today." Cadmus hesitated before asking, "So, you have no intention of informing your uncle and aunt about this insane plan of yours?"

Theron grimaced. "I would prefer not to notify them of this endeavor. Aunt Elissa may have some reservations about today's events. I am certain she is not thrilled about my participation in the tournament, and she would be even less pleased if she learned of my other plans for this momentous day."

Theron muttered to himself, "*Moreover, the outcome of today will have a profound impact on my life.*"

"It's a make-or-break day for my aspirations, and I am pleased to have commenced it by

defeating you after eight long years of training and gaining more confidence."

Cadmus nodded. "Very well then. I would not voluntarily inform your uncle and aunt, but if they ask, I will not lie to them since I am obligated to speak the truth to them."

"That should suffice. I will distract them long enough to make them ignore you today."

Theron contemplated the obstacles that lay ahead. The day's events would profoundly shape the rest of his life.

"When the moment arrives, Cadmus, ignite a green signal," Theron instructed, his voice filled with determination.

Cadmus nodded and rendered a legionnaire salute, which Theron reciprocated. "*Thank you, Master Cadmus.*"

Cadmus gave him a bitter grimace at the word 'master' before concealing his weapons in the knapsack and returning to his chores at their farmhold situated across the grasslands.

Theron strolled towards the creek and crouched down to drink from the pristine stream.

After swallowing several gulps of water using his palms, he observed his reflection staring back at him.

Oh, how he had transformed over the past few years!

True, his physical appearance had evolved from a scrawny boy into a medium-built young man of average countenance. Nevertheless, he was mindful that the anguish he had endured for over a decade had not diminished in the slightest.

He sighed ruefully as bittersweet memories flooded his mind.

His entire life unfolded before his eyes, a tapestry of memories woven from the threads of his past. He recalled his formative years as a tween in a border town, where his friends appeared to cherish his companionship. Yet, with the passage of time, a subtle shift occurred, and most of his companions began to distance themselves from him.

As his companions gradually unlocked their magical abilities while he remained magicless, they started to abandon him, their friendship waning like the setting sun. He was far too young to grasp the reason behind their peculiar behavior, unaware of the unspoken derision and hatred they harbored towards his magical incompetence.

In the early days of his ostracization, his aunt offered solace, assuring him that he was merely a late bloomer, destined to discover his magic in due time. He clung to this hope, buoyed by stories she regaled of men who had awakened to their magical abilities in their early teens.

His aunt regaled him with tales of legendary figures who discovered their magic only after reaching their teens, igniting a spark of hope within his soul.

He convinced himself that he was one such late bloomer, for the alternative was too horrifying to contemplate. As the days turned into weeks and the weeks into months, he lost count of the days he had been magicless, his hopes crumbling under the weight of the scorn and contempt he faced at every turn.

It didn't take long for him to comprehend the grim fate that awaited him, if the treatment he had received from his townsmen were anything to go by. He soon became an outcast, the lone figure despised by most of the Lemurian townsfolk.

In the end, *he became an anomaly*, the only Sukran in history to achieve a feat no other

Sukran had accomplished: remaining magicless even in his adolescence.

He was widely referred to as the *magicless freak*, a label that stuck like a brand, marking him as an outcast in a kingdom where magic was the currency.

And in a society where social rank was dictated by the magic one possessed, he quickly recognized that being born without magic in his kingdom was the most heinous of all sins.

A surge of grief overwhelmed Theron as his mind delved into the countless instances of humiliation he had endured even from his tween years. He wasn't merely ostracized by the immature youth who once considered him a friend; even adults treated him as a blight upon the Sukran kingdom.

The most agonizing experiences were the attempts by a few elders and friends in the valley to awaken his magic through flogging him with their powerful elemental magic. They believed that pain would be the key to unlocking his latent magic.

Soon, even the few friends who had stood by him during his early years of ridicule began to distance themselves, fearing the attention and scorn of the Lemurian townsfolk who relished in his torment.

Theron knew that without the protection of his Uncle Adrian and Aunt Elissa, two of the most influential farmholders in the valley, he would have been banished from their town.

It was his uncle's reputation as a war hero that deterred most locals from actively seeking his expulsion, but their tolerance was fragile and could easily shatter any moment. The townsmen were willing to tolerate his presence in the valley for the time being.

But Theron recalled that even though he had given up hope of ever achieving his magic, it didn't stop him from seeking to understand it. But who would teach magic to a magicless young man despised by the entire town?

He resorted to hiding, observing kids his age as they learned to harness their magic from their parents. Through these clandestine observations, he began to understand the intricacies of each elemental, yet it did little to bring him closer to accessing his own magic.

What good was it to understand magic better than anybody else if you couldn't use it?

He could barely recall a night he went to bed without fresh wounds on his body, a testament to the relentless torment he faced. Seldom did he sleep through the night without sobbing at his fate.

And yet, every night, he would foolishly convince himself that he would acquire his magic miraculously when he awakened the next morning, only to wake up to the harsh reality of his magiclessness.

Theron recalled how his early morning enthusiasm would turn sour the moment he realized he had failed yet again. He had experienced the agony of being disappointed practically every day of his life.

Disappointment was his only true companion that never deserted him, despite all his efforts to avoid it.

He was branded a failure even before his life truly began in earnest.

The relentless harassment and stark reality of being ostracized for the rest of his life as the weakest Sukran in history ignited a surge of rage and determination within him. He vowed to

prove his worth to his townsfolk, to defy their expectations and shatter their perception of him as a failure.

Even though he lacked magic, he never lacked pride and determination, a terrible mix for a child reviled by everyone. His unwavering determination and unrelenting pride had earned him more beatings than he cared to count.

But it didn't break him. *And when something heinous fails to break you, it can only make you stronger.*

Theron had accepted the bitter truth that he would never discover magic. With his path to magic forever closed, he sought other avenues to establish himself as a man worthy of respect.

Respect... A simple word for most, but it was his *heartbeat*, the driving force behind his every action. His entire life was shaped by this single word—*respect*.

Theron shook his head to dispel the early-morning spell of grief that had gripped him. As he examined his reflection in the stream, he noticed a yearning for respect in his eyes.

While gazing at his reflection, Theron continued to be haunted by the question that had plagued him for years:

Could he live with the stigma of failure his entire life? And how could he gain the respect of his kin without magic?

What is the point of living if you haven't even won the respect of your fellow citizens? How long can one endure the humiliation of being regarded as vermin?

He wasn't content with earning the respect of only his fellow townsmen; magic or not, he aspired to win the respect of the entire kingdom someday.

He gradually convinced himself that magic was not the lifeblood of their existence.

No... magic was only a tool to enrich their life.

And a fool who possessed powerful magic was still a fool.

He hoped to search for solutions to his unanswered questions elsewhere.

He had one distinguishing edge over the majority of his fellow citizens. He was substantially more intelligent than the bulk of his peers, but his tormentors consistently proved that brilliance without the ability to defend oneself usually led to greater misery.

He discovered that no one liked it when he reminded them that they were less brilliant than the magicless freak considered the weakest man in the kingdom.

No, his intelligence alone proved insufficient; he needed more than mere magic or intellect to stand resilient on his own feet against formidable elementalists.

He needed the means to negate their magic using his intelligence and resolve if he hoped to stand his ground against his powerful but ruthless brethren.

He understood that he would have to become the finest swordsman in the nation if he wanted to survive against his ruthless brethren. Unfortunately, his uncle, a celebrated war hero, was of little assistance to him in teaching him the intricacies of swordplay since Adrian depended

more on his strong magic than his weaponry to vanquish his opponents.

Uncle Adrian's magic was his primary weapon.

He had pleaded with the soldiers stationed in the neighboring fortress to teach him the fundamentals of swordplay, but to no avail; none of the guards were willing to waste their time on a magicless freak.

With no other options in the border town, he hoped for a glimmer of light to illuminate his path amid the endless darkness that engulfed his existence.

He eventually found a glimpse of hope when his uncle brought Cadmus to their farmhold.

A glimmer that had ultimately irrevocably altered him.

Initially, he was ignorant that Cadmus was the only blessing the gods had bestowed upon him. The boon that compelled him to work harder than anybody else in the history of his kingdom to overcome his weakness—magic.

And it was one hell of a weakness in a society ruled and dominated by magic.

Fortunately for him, he was a fool for believing that nothing in this world was impossible. He came up with a strategy to accomplish his goal of turning his weakness into a strength.

And when he saw the scarred blacksmith for the first time, he had no clue that Cadmus was the most crucial facet in his quest for redemption.

He didn't have any magic, but he did have Cadmus.

Theron sighed heavily as he rose to his feet and turned to look at the receding figure of the man with the coward's mark on his face.

His uncle stumbled upon Cadmus lying on the road leading to Titus city more than a decade ago. Cadmus was barely alive after being left for dead by bandits who raided his caravan and slaughtered the people he was supposed to guard.

Uncle Adrian took pity on Cadmus, who was severely punished by the bandits. The renegade bandits had not only snatched his duty to protect his masters in the caravan but had also branded the cowards' insignia on his cheeks.

In addition, his uncle was astounded to learn that Cadmus had gone insane after the tragic event.

Uncle Adrian had brought Cadmus to his farm, where his sister had been able to save Cadmus' life but not his mind or face.

Adrian lacked the ruthlessness to send a fool with a coward's mark into a horrible world that would endlessly abuse him. Therefore, he employed Cadmus as a blacksmith, who, despite losing his sanity, could cast metal in ways that no one else in the valley could match.

In the secluded valley, every townsman perceived Cadmus as a rambling fool, his metal-casting skills earning him the title of a competent blacksmith. Theron, however, had pierced through the fool's façade a decade ago. Driven by curiosity, he had spied on Cadmus, only to witness an extraordinary display of swordsmanship with an iron rod from the smithy. Theron had never seen such a stunning display of swordsmanship, not even from his war-hero uncle..

When Theron confronted Cadmus, challenging his charade, Cadmus confessed to earning the coward's mark, a consequence of fleeing his duty to protect his caravan master. To atone for the shame he had brought upon his family, he revealed to Theron that he had embraced a life of exile.

Cadmus had explained that Elissa, Theron's aunt, had eventually healed his mind, but he chose to continue playing the fool, seeking to be regarded as harmless vermin, unworthy of attention by most townsmen. The very few townsfolk who pitied Cadmus, attributed his strange behavior to his addled mind. They believed it futile to seek answers from the unfortunate man who had lost his mind, so they ceased prying into his past.

No one bothered Cadmus with the mark's tale, which he feared would force him to remember his traumatic history. Cadmus had revealed that he had concealed his recovery from everyone, even Theron's uncle, for fear that his employer would lose sympathy for him and dismiss him from his service. After all, it was no secret that Uncle Adrian despised outsiders in the community, a prejudice rooted in the tragic death of his twin sister, Theron's mother. Cadmus was determined to spare his family from the shame of harboring a coward, and so, he had exiled himself, bearing the burden of his disgraced past alone.

Theron, moved by Cadmus's explanation, pleaded the blacksmith to train him in swordmanship until Cadmus eventually relented eight years ago. Cadmus began training him clandestinely on the outskirts of the farmhold, nestled near the mountains.

Ironically, Cadmus was the only other person in town who suffered almost the same fate as Theron. In a society as vicious as the Sukrans', it was extremely perilous to be both a fool and a coward. Cadmus could relate to Theron's plight since he had endured the same scorn and persecution at the hands of the townspeople, but he was even more inspired by Theron's ambition and resolve to fight his horrific fate.

So, unlike the other townspeople who saw Theron as a wastrel, Cadmus saw Theron as an opportunity to redeem himself.

Redeem his cowardice by training a young man with nothing to lose.

Redeem his soul by training Theron into a man capable of forging his own destiny, defying Theron's bleak fate.

Despite Theron's lack of magical abilities, Cadmus committed to training him to become the finest swordsman Theron could be. Their secret training sessions took place daily, hidden from the prying eyes of the townsfolk.

Cadmus, a demanding taskmaster, subjected Theron to rigorous footwork and sword form drills without even touching a blade for the first two years. Only when Theron had mastered all sword forms did Cadmus initiate blade training six years ago.

And Theron had toiled all day to build his strength and, more critically, his speed as a swordsman. To compete against a formidable Sukran without magic, Theron recognized that he had to become faster than any other Sukran.

With time, Theron's muscles gradually toned and became lithe as his workouts started to bear fruit.

He didn't just stop at learning the sword forms from Cadmus. He enlisted the help of his

uncle to teach him the skills of a ranger to track trails through the forest as well.

Being a prodigious archer, Uncle Adrian trained Theron in archery as well.

His fellow citizens still ridiculed him, but it gave him the motivation and determination to focus all his efforts on a single thought: to become the kingdom's finest swordsman at all costs.

Theron was a natural with the sword, but without magic, he struggled to reach his full potential and was easily defeated in a duel with a metal elemental of much lesser swordplay skills, thanks to their ability to easily manipulate and shatter his blade using their metal magic.

Despite his exceptional memory and ability who never needed to be reminded of his mistakes twice, Theron's lack of metal-casting skills rendered him vulnerable, his blades no match for the elemental's magic.

Theron's opponents, wielding their metal magic, shattered his blades with ease. *A swordsman who could not safeguard his weapon was unworthy of the title of a swordsman.*

Determined to overcome this weakness, Theron began training to wield swords with both hands, ensuring that he could continue fighting even if one blade was shattered. He tirelessly trained both arms, striving for mastery of wielding swords with either hand in equal measure.

However, ambidextrous swordsmanship without metal-casting skills merely prolonged the inevitable in duels against metal elementals. It failed to grant him the decisive advantage he needed.

Powerful elemental casters, by constructing diverse elemental shields to protect their swords, rendered their weapons impervious to the manipulation and shattering powers of other metal casters.

Theron's speed, strength, and sword forms, while formidable, were insufficient to overcome the elementals' magical defenses.

With no magic to call upon, Theron realized that his predicament had but one solution: acquiring swords that cannot be manipulated by magic.

But where could he find swords that could negate magic? None of the other Sukrans had ever sought such weapons as they relied on their magic to protect their blades.

Theron, being the only Sukran born without magic, bore the unique burden of seeking these elusive swords that could not be manipulated by magic.

Theron had plunged into despair and depression, realizing that he could never truly compete with a metal-casting swordsman, even one with inferior swordsmanship, unless he possessed magic-resistant blades. His ambitions seemed unattainable, his path forward shrouded in uncertainty.

To achieve his ambitions, he needed a game changer.

In a desperate quest for answers, Theron scoured the local library, immersing himself in books on old legends concerning the secrets of forging legendary weapons crafted by legendary metalsmiths.

With no success in finding a direct solution to solve his quandary, Theron realized that he had to discover the answer by himself and sought solace in knowledge. He delved into books, meticulously studying each elemental magic, comprehending its intricacies and nuances.

Theron scoffed at the irony in his situation, a magicless Sukran immersing himself to learn

the intricacies of all the primary and secondary elemental magic. Yet, within his studies, he discerned a glimmer of hope. He theorized that the harmonious union of opposing elements, such as earth and air, metal and wood, fire and water, could yield extraordinary results of enhancing the efficacy of each element and reducing its limitations.

In such a union, the intrinsic intertwining of wood with metal, for instance, would render the weapon resistant to the manipulative powers of metal elementalists. However, such a forging technique was seldom practiced, as it demanded exceptional skill to forge a metal blade while seamlessly integrating opposing elements.

With his fate hanging in the balance, Theron implored Cadmus to forge a weapon imbued with equal proportions of wood and metal. After months of relentless effort, culminating in the creation of a small dagger, they achieved a breakthrough: a prototype of a metal weapon impervious to metal magic.

Armed with a working solution, Theron's ambitions soared. He anticipated confrontations not only with metal elementalists but also with those wielding the power of multiple elements, like Cadmus himself. To combat these formidable foes, Theron embarked on a quest to design a weapon incorporating all primary elements in equal measure.

The design of a particular sword caught his attention in an old, brittle book that had fallen from a shelf of his town's library. Even the old librarian was unaware of this book's existence until Theron brought it to his attention.

Theron's research further revealed that blood was the sole substance capable of binding all elements in equal measure. A prime example was the kings' and nobles' practice of marrying within their lineage. While most perceived it as a mere political alliance, Theron recognized the true motive: to ensure that their descendants inherited the ability to control all elements of their parents.

Thus, Theron concluded that blood served as the binding agent for the elemental fusion.

However, forging such a weapon demanded an unwavering level of trust among the participating elemental casters, a rare quality in a society rife with suspicion and power struggles. And for a people that was borderline vicious and addicted to power, it was rare to find men who trusted others so profoundly to combine their magic to forge these weapons, and therefore such techniques were seldom attempted before.

However, Theron had three trusted well-wishers who possessed mastery over various elements. With their combined magical prowess, he hoped could forge the weapon that would be the game changer.

Theron pleaded with his uncle, aunt, and Cadmus, the house blacksmith, to join forces in crafting a sword imbued with equal proportions of all elements. His aunt Elissa, his uncle Adrian, and Cadmus, driven by their unwavering love for Theron, could not deny him his only chance to compete on equal footing with the most powerful elementalists.

Cadmus, utilizing a *rare metal ore* he had retrieved from the depths of the nearby Smoky Mountains, forged the weapon by modifying the ore to bond harmoniously with all the other elements. His three trusted well-wishers labored diligently for several months to meticulously craft identical swords, perfectly suited for Theron's ambidextrous swordsmanship. They used Theron's

blood as the binding agent, fusing all the elements into a formidable weapon.

Their experiments revealed that swords imbued with the power of all elements could penetrate stone, air, water, and fire, even severing weak spots in metals.

Utilizing the same technique with the remaining ore, they crafted a dagger, a bow, and a set of arrows, completing Theron's arsenal. Glittering armor and boomerang-shaped knives made of the same technique was further added his weaponry.

Aunt Elissa coined the term '*unmetal*' for these weapons, acknowledging their unique composition, seemingly formed from a fusion of metals yet possessing properties far beyond their original forms.

Theron had dedicated years to mastering these weapons, and only now was beginning to grasp their true potential. He was attempting to procure a sword impervious to magic, but the extraordinary metal ore gathered by Cadmus amplified the unmetal sword's capabilities manifold.

He discovered that a single strike from this remarkable weapon could slice through an elementally forged stone without dulling its edge. The metal aspect of the sword severed the stone, while the stone aspect protected the blade from being dulled ever.

Theron had sought a sword resistant to be manipulated by magic; instead, he had acquired a weapon that negated magic.

Sometimes, the hard work paid one more than he dreamed. And he was thankful for the fortune which seldom blew on his life.

After enduring years of ridicule and contempt, Theron had finally obtained the means to confront formidable elemental casters. Having endured years of humiliation, ridicule, bullying, and the stigma of being labeled the realm's weakest man, he was ready to *unleash himself upon the world*.

After several years of toiling hard, he had gained warrior skills. And he had gained weapons that could not be manipulated by magic.

Now, it was time to unleash his biggest weapon of all—his intellect.

Having recently reached adulthood, Theron resolved to leave his border town behind. However, after years of scorn and mockery from his fellow townsmen, he yearned to leave with a resounding bang.

His townsmen had inadvertently helped to impart valuable lessons over the years, and he was not someone who didn't return the help rendered to him.

It was time to teach the realm a lesson it would never forget, and he would start with his border town.

Just winning the local Wintersend Tournament was not enough; he needed to teach a profound life lesson to his townsfolk - *a lesson in humanity*.

Theron cleared his mind, gathered his weapons, and followed Cadmus back to his farm. He herded the cattle grazing on the plains, returning them to the farmhold. Today marked a pivotal moment, and he had numerous preparations to make before the tournament commenced.

Despite the presence of his unmetal swords, the odds remained heavily stacked against him. A single misstep could unravel twelve years of meticulously crafted plans and preparations catastrophically.

The flawless execution of his elaborate plan was paramount to achieving his first and most significant milestone in his quest for redemption - *the university*.

Chapter 3

The Innocent Trickster

*I often wonder if I must be blatant against noble lords who put up a facade to trick me.
But alas, my hands are tied by my grandfather who prefers to let the tricksters dupe me.
After all, the king maintains that a trickster fails to fool you if you recognize his deception. My
grandfather, King Valerian Primus, prefers to lure his adversaries into underestimating him. For he does not desire
a direct confrontation with the renegade noble lords seeking for my rightful throne.
But I beg to differ.
Isn't it a very cautious and timid approach to act foolish in front of someone you suspect is attempting to
dupe you?
After many years, I feel the urge to surrender to my emotions and dare myself to face the consequences of
voicing out against the double-faced noble lords who consider me to be an idiot.
They have failed to comprehend something fundamental.
Using trickery on a trickster to persuade them to mend their ways is not trickery, but the rightful use of
intelligence.
So, if the motive behind the trickery is good, even the trickery becomes good.*

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

The cattle mooed as Theron steered them back to their corrals, nestled at the farthest extremity of his uncle's expansive farm.

Theron observed Garius, visibly irate and impatient, tutoring his son in elemental magic. Clearly, it was evident that Garius lacked the essential qualities of an effective teacher.

"Where in the world have you been, boy?" admonished Sergius as Theron readied to secure the pen gate. Theron turned to confront the portly man, who seemed to be struggling for breath after sprinting to the corral on noticing Theron's return.

"As you probably recall, Sir Sergius, I had taken the cattle to graze in the neighboring meadows," Theron replied with a nonchalant shrug.

"Boy, don't act smart with me. I know you were deliberately delaying to annoy me," Sergius hissed.

"Would I ever keep you waiting, Sir?" Theron retorted sarcastically.

"Get out of my pen, you scumbag. Unlike you, I still have a great deal of work to complete before I depart for the stronghold to attend the Wintersend Festival," Sergius ordered Theron to vacate his corral immediately.

Well, Sir, I would dearly love to leave you in peace. However, there is still a small matter of payment that you owe me for herding cattle every day for the last five years," Theron reminded him.

"What! I owe you no money, boy," Sergius exclaimed vehemently.

"Well, you do if you delegated your work for a tenth of what you receive from my uncle for the same job," Theron snapped back sharply.

Sergius glared at the freak, contemplating whether to unleash his earth magic to silence the insolent child. However, he decided against it, as he had no desire to spend this festive day listening to his master Adrian reprimand him for assaulting his nephew.

The lad was not worth the trouble of missing the Wintersend Festival over.

Sergius fumbled through his cloak pouch and retrieved two silver coins, tossing them to Theron, who caught them with a casual sweep of his palm.

Theron then nonchalantly tossed the silver coins back to Sergius, who struggled to grasp them.

"Sergius, you may have miscalculated my wages. I believe you owe me one gold coin for the past five years of service," Theron stated calmly.

"What!" bellowed Sergius. "A gold coin?"

Theron shrugged. "You agreed to pay me one silver coin per year for my services. So, for five years of work, you owe me a gold coin."

As Sergius glared at the freak with barely contained anger, Theron feigned innocence. "I trust you know that five silver coins equal one gold coin."

"Boy, I know how to count my coins," Sergius' jaw clenched with fury. "Do not dare to instruct me in the art of trading."

Sergius pondered for a moment before deciding he would not grant the freak a gold coin. Even if the freak brought the matter to Count Marius, who in this town would believe the magicless freak over a respected man like him?

"No, boy...I will not even give you a bronze dime. You ought to have appreciated my generosity when I offered you two silver coins. However, your haughty demeanor makes me not want to part with my gold coin any time soon," Sergius declared.

Sergius turned with a satisfied grin to leave the moron, content with his trickery of the fool. It was a fitting lesson for the idiot who expected him to keep his word and return the gold coin. How could the fool even imagine receiving a single gold coin for his services?

The boy must have been a fool to be so easily duped into serving him for five years without any wage.

"Do you know how much a lamb costs in the valley, Sergius?" Theron called out loudly to the man who had attempted to defraud him.

Sergius ignored the freak and continued towards his house in the heart of the farm.

"How much do twenty lambs cost?" Theron asked out loud.

Sergius slowed down and shook his head in exasperation. "Perhaps you should check with the butcher about it."

"That is precisely what I intend to do," Theron grunted with a mischievous grin. "After all, *I have sheep to exchange with the butcher.*"

Sergius stopped and turned back to examine the animal pen.

"Do not bother to count the number of cattle in the corral, Sergius. I suspect that twenty sheep are missing from your corral," Theron said with an innocent smile.

Sergius growled as he realized Theron had duped him. "*You...you dare to steal from me!*"

Theron ignored the farmhand purposefully and nonchalantly poked his ears, further provoking the enraged man.

Sergius could not tolerate being humiliated by the magicless freak. He attempted to summon his earth elemental to detain the boy so he could intimidate him into disclosing the whereabouts of the sheep he had stolen.

Theron, sensing the farmer's impending but expected foolishness, merely sighed as the two earth-cast arms rise from the ground, attempting to restrain him.

Unfazed, Theron allowed the black stone arms to clasp his shoulders. "If I were in your shoes, Sergius, I wouldn't do it," he advised without any trace of fear..

"We'll find out soon enough when you beg for my mercy," Sergius growled as he approached Theron, his rage palpable.

"Do you think this is the first time I've been held captive by magic and beaten for my lack of magical abilities?" Theron inquired, a cheeky grin playing on his lips.

Sergius was perturbed by the boy's unwavering confidence. He had expected Theron to cower in fear and plead for compassion, not exhibit such defiance.

"Trust me, Sergius, your feeble earth magic is nothing compared to the beatings I've endured at the hands of far more powerful elementalists," Theron declared with a shrug.

"I'm sure you're aware that I've suffered daily abuse from the likes of Ferris Gavlin, whom the town considers to be the second-strongest elementalist after my uncle Adrian," Theron continued.

"Therefore, you must realize that your threats and humiliation pale in comparison to those of Ferris and other notorious young men who use every opportunity to teach me a lesson for my magical incompetence," he shrugged.

"If you persist with your foolish plan to beat me and coerce me into revealing the whereabouts of the stolen sheep, you will only draw attention to yourself when you use your magic to pound me. And when my uncle and the other farmholders arrive to investigate the commotion, I will be obliged to disclose that you were the one stealing the very sheep you were supposed to protect in the first place," Theron explained with a sly grin.

Pointing his finger at himself, Theron extended his hand and continued with a mocking tone, "Being the respectable and devoted citizen that I am, I would tell them that I confronted you about your theft and advised you to change your ways, but you resorted to violence to prevent me from exposing the truth about you."

Sergius, though slightly unsettled, scoffed at the boy's accusation. "No one would believe you, freak," he snarled.

"Of course, they wouldn't. *Who would believe the freak?*" Theron agreed with a knowing nod. "They may not believe me, but they will believe their eyes when they investigate the corral for the missing cattle and verify the truth in my tale."

"And once they realize that you are missing several sheep, they cannot deny your weakness for pilfering," Theron concluded.

"*Pilfering?*" Sergius questioned, his voice laced with disbelief.

"Yes..."

"However, I did not steal the sheep, and I've never stolen anything in my life," objected Sergius. A smile played on his lips as he pondered a shrewd approach to rebut the cunning boy.

"I will demand a truth-seeking to prove my innocence," Sergius replied, contemplating an exit strategy.

"But, poor Sergius. You have committed theft in your lifetime" Theron affirmed with a grin. "After all, you've just stolen my payment for the services I've rendered over the last five years."

Sergius stared at Theron, his eyes wide with astonishment.

Theron continued to pile more misery at the portly man. "Therefore, you would be caught lying by a truth seeker when you boast that you've never stolen anything in your life."

"And unless you can deceive a truth seeker, I would consider you a bigger fool than me if you try to involve a truth seeker," he added with a final jab.

Sergius, cornered by the boy's unwavering logic, cocked his head at the freak.

"Even if you don't want a truth-seeking, I may request one to establish that you are guilty of theft," Theron threatened.

Sergius gasped in shock.

"Even if you manage to lie to a truth-seeking, which is very rare skill, you'd still be held responsible for the missing sheep," Theron pressed.

"Perhaps I will not raise a commotion by handing you the thrashing you so richly deserve and drawing attention to myself." Sergius, his pride wounded and his reputation at stake, bristled in rage before turning around and storming away.

"You appear to be an even bigger fool than I anticipated," Theron called out to the retreating farmer.

"No one would even investigate the missing sheep. And if you complain to your uncle, I will tell him that you stole the sheep and are attempting to frame me."

Sergius, unfazed by Theron's threats, merely rolled his eyes. "Who are these farmholders going to believe?" he scoffed, his voice dripping with contempt. "A gentleman like myself or a magicless vermin like you?"

Theron's lips curled into a sly smile. "Don't you know, Sergius, that my uncle is obligated to share his sheep with the fortress today as a token of his appreciation for the Wintersend celebration feast?"

Sergius froze in his tracks, his face turning pale. It was true that Adrian would expect him to collect the oldest of all sheep for the feast to be shared with the chefs of the stronghold.

With a shrug, Sergius attempted to mask his worry. "Don't fret, kid," he said, his voice laced with feigned confidence. "I have it all covered. I will give your uncle twenty of the oldest sheep to prevent him from peeking into the corral."

Theron stretched out against the corral, a smirk playing on his lips. "Your funeral then," he replied.

Sergius halted in his tracks, a frown creasing his forehead. "What do you mean, boy?" he demanded.

"If you had bothered to look at the corral, you would have noticed that the twenty missing sheep are the oldest of the flock," Theron revealed with a hint of amusement.

"Wouldn't my uncle suspect foul play if you tried to pass off young sheep as the oldest?" Theron asked with a sardonic tone, emphasizing Sergius's reckless blunder.

Sergius spun around and rushed towards the corral, his heart pounding with dread. When he discovered that the freak had indeed stolen the twenty oldest sheep he had planned to bring to the festival, his face turned ashen.

Neither did he have the time to earmark the oldest sheep in the remaining flock, nor did he have any more old sheep to sacrifice.

Sergius found himself trapped in a predicament of his own making. A gulp escaped his lips as he grasped the gravity of the situation he had unwittingly created.

"Regardless, you would be proven to be a thief who either stole his master's livestock for money or stole money for a job he never performed for his master." Theron asserted, his voice laced with a chilling certainty.

Sergius's heart pounded in his chest as the realization of his precarious situation dawned upon him.

"Don't be so naive to think that only your reputation is at stake here," Theron cautioned, his eyes gleaming with an unsettling intensity.

"What do you mean?" Sergius muttered, his voice trembling with fear.

"Our valley despises those who steal from their masters," Theron explained, his tone laced with a hint of malice. "They may even label you a thief and expel you from the community."

Sergius's mind raced as he envisioned the grim future that lay ahead. Being ostracized by his community, stripped of his livelihood, and branded a thief was a fate he could not bear.

"Who knows, you may even be sold into slavery as punishment, imprisoned in your mind through spirit magic," Theron continued, piling on the misery.

A gulp escaped Sergius's lips as he realized the depth of the hole he had dug for himself.

"However," Theron conceded with a sardonic grin, "I must confess that I have never heard of a thief branded a slave for a petty theft of a single gold coin."

He pointed his finger directly at Sergius, a mischievous glint in his eyes. "Don't worry, though. I'll convince my doting uncle to set aside his philosophies and purchase you as my slave."

"Your slave?" Sergius gasped in shock, his mind reeling from the audacity of the freak's suggestion.

"You are aware that I am regarded as the weakest man in this realm," Theron reminded him, his voice laced with sarcasm. "Imagine how you would be treated if you became the slave of the weakest man in the kingdom."

Theron paused for dramatic effect, letting his words sink in. "How far would you fall from your current social status?" Theron asked with a mocking tone.

"From a reputable farmer employed by the most esteemed farmholder in the valley to a lowly slave to serve the most reviled and weakest man in the realm."

"All because you wanted to steal a single gold coin," Theron concluded with a flourish.

The earth-cast arms that had restrained him earlier dissolved back into the ground, leaving

Theron standing unscathed, a triumphant smirk playing on his lips.

He brushed the dust off his shoulders with nonchalant ease. "Wishing you the best of luck in your future of hating your stupid self for getting yourself enslaved just to steal a young man's hard-earned money," Theron reprimanded the farmhand with a final jab before turning to depart the coral.

"Freak..." Sergius called out in anguish. He shook his head and gathered his wits about him. "Theron...Please stop..."

Theron paused in his tracks, turning back with a broad grin. "It wasn't hard to use my name, was it?" he asked gently, asserting his dominance over the defeated man.

Sergius tamed his raging fury with much difficulty, putting up his palms in a placating gesture. "I was only testing you, Theron," he lied and pretended to be nice and cordial to Theron all the while swallowing the bile that rose to his throat. "I always intended to reimburse you for your services."

Theron responded with a devilish grin. "I was certain you'd come to your senses eventually, Sir Sergius."

Sergius hissed in response to the perceived insult and ceased his act of being nice to the freak. With another tremendous effort, he reined in his anger and fiddled with his cloak, extracting two gold coins.

"Count yourself fortunate that I have decided to compensate you more than you deserve for the work you have provided over the past few years," Sergius snarled, grudgingly displaying the coins to Theron. "But first, I would require you to disclose the spot where you hid the sheep."

Theron merely shook his head, a mischievous smile playing on his lips. "No."

"No?" Sergius was taken aback but quickly recovered. He extracted three more gold coins. "I'll give you five gold coins."

Theron fiddled with his ears indifferently. "*So, is your freedom just worth five coins?*"

Sergius was even more startled than before. "Not satisfied with five gold coins, eh?" he exclaimed, his voice laced with terror. "*This is outrageous, boy.*"

Sergius cursed himself for not offering Theron the single gold coin in the first place, avoiding this whole mess. "I did not even charge five gold coins to your uncle for the same service you have rendered for me," he protested.

Theron stepped aside with boredom, turning his attention to Garius' ongoing magic class for William.

Sergius struggled to contain his fury at the freak's dismissive attitude. "I can only offer you a maximum of ten gold coins," he practically begged Theron. "I have no more to give for my mistake."

Theron let out a sigh and shook his head. "Unlike you, Sergius, I have no interest in stealing other people's hard-earned money. I simply want the single gold coin you owe me for my years of service as your herder."

Sergius blanched as if he had been slapped. However, after a time, he laughed at the boy's foolishness.

Sergius thanked god for the moron's idiocy and tucked the nine gold pieces into his cloak.

He had feared the freak would demand more than twenty gold coins for his mistake, but the boy had proven himself to be an idiot.

Sergius casually tossed a single gold coin towards Theron, but the boy easily dodged the path of the coin.

Theron crossed his arms, his gaze unwavering as Sergius's coin lay at his feet. "Sergius," he began, his voice laced with a hint of authority, "I am not begging for your money that you so arrogantly toss at me as though you are giving charity. I am demanding the coin you owe me for my years of loyal service."

"I need you to give me the coin in the same polite manner as you would with any other townsmen in this valley."

Sergius let out a frustrated growl and scooped up the fallen coin, his hand trembling slightly. This time, he placed the coin directly into Theron's outstretched palm, his eyes meeting the boy's with a mixture of anger and terror.

"Well, that's a good start to the day's business, isn't it?" Theron accepted the coin with a mischievous grin, his mind already racing ahead. This single gold coin, he believed, held the power to change the course of their kingdom's history if all worked as per his plan. He was certain that this would undoubtedly transform him, and he hoped it would also reform his townsfolk for the better.

Theron tossed the gold coin into the air and caught it once more.

Well, he was hopeful that this single coin would change the world.

Sergius, unable to tolerate the presence of the freak any longer, snapped, "Boy, where have you hidden my sheep?"

Theron ambled towards the corral and unlocked the door with a practiced hand. He blew a loud whistle that shattered the tranquility of the early morning like a thunderclap.

Within moments, twenty sheep emerged from the nearby woods and trotted into the corral, their presence filling the air with a chorus of bleats.

Sergius's eyes widened in disbelief as he realized that the sheep had been right there all along in their vicinity the entire time, hidden in plain sight. Theron merely shut the corral door, allowing the sheep to mingle with the other livestock.

"*Well, that concludes my duties for the day,*" Theron announced, rubbing his hands together to counter the chilly breeze sweeping through the farmhold. "Have a pleasant day, Sergius." Theron bid farewell to the man who was snarling at his impudence for concealing the sheep in the vicinity and making a mockery out of him.

Sergius, his face contorted with rage, attempted to block Theron's path. "You think you've had the final laugh, don't you?" he snarled, flexing his arms as he unleashed his earth elemental in the form of a massive black ox.

Theron, however, remained calm and collected, his gaze steady and unflinching. "I suppose you haven't learned today's lesson, eh?"

Sergius ignored Theron's taunts, his anger clouding his judgment. The ox lunged forward; its horns aimed directly at Theron's chest.

"So, you prefer to be branded a murderer instead of a thief," Theron retorted calmly, his

voice laced with a hint of warning.

Even as the ox sprang at him, Theron lingered lazily and still. "You may speak the truth in a truth-seeking without concern that you have not stolen from me since you have returned the money you owe me now, but you have still stolen both my uncle's money and trust since you did not provide the service for herding the cattle in the first place."

As the ox was ready to stab its enormous horns into Theron's chest, it crumbled into the sand and let Theron pass through the disintegrated dust with a malicious grin.

Sergius growled in fury, realizing that he was forced to withdraw his elemental, lest Theron demand a truth-seeking and brand him as a stealer of sheep and money from his own lord.

Sergius let out a frustrated growl, his rage tempered by fear. He had been outsmarted once again by the freak, and he knew he couldn't risk further confrontation.

Theron, his expression unreadable, turned and strutted away, leaving Sergius standing there, defeated and humiliated.

"*Boy, do you believe you have accomplished something today?*" Sergius snarled at Theron, his voice dripping with contempt.

"*Oh, I'm just getting started,*" Theron replied with a mysterious grin.

Sergius's eyes narrowed, his anger rising like a storm. "Mark my words," he hissed, his voice laced with venom, "before the day ends, I will collect that gold coin from you."

"All the best," Theron merely shrugged nonchalantly, unfazed by Sergius's threats.

With that, Theron turned and strode towards the farmhouse, where his aunt and uncle awaited him for breakfast.

He had orchestrated the first phase of his plan flawlessly, and he was confident that Sergius would take the bait. And after humiliating Sergius, Theron was certain that he can count on Sergius to retaliate today. After all, Sergius had the ear of many townsfolk, and Sergius would stop at nothing to humiliate the town's "freak."

Theron knew that he was playing a dangerous game, one that could backfire spectacularly if he faltered in the upcoming tournament. But he was determined to succeed, even if it meant putting everything on the line.

The first part of his plan was executed to precision. It was time for the next part.

"Aaargh!" Theron let out a yelp of pain, clutching his injured hand as he hurled a stream of expletives at the valrog that stomped before him with a smug smirk.

A roar of laughter erupted at his expense from behind him, and Theron spun around to find his uncle, Adrian, approaching with a wide grin.

Adrian was a towering figure, standing six feet tall with rippling muscles that spoke of a lifetime spent drawing strength from the earth. Despite his imposing size, he moved with an unexpected grace, his beard neatly trimmed to military regulations. A master of earth, water and wood elemental magic, Adrian also possessed considerable skill in metal, fire, and air. He was armed with a massive longsword and a slender dagger, both sheathed on his hips.

Theron noticed that his uncle was missing his maple wood bow that was usually slung over Adrian's shoulder. Theron glared while his uncle's gentle, pale-gray eyes twinkled at him.

"Uncle," Theron said through gritted teeth, "I tried to saddle your beast for you, but the damned beast won't let me near it."

Blood trickled from the bite marks on Theron's hand, courtesy of the valrog's sharp canine teeth.

"Boy, you should know by now that Citrus only allows me to touch him. Valrogs are fiercely possessive creatures and only allow their chosen master to handle them." Adrian grunted in a manner characteristic of most earth-casters.

"Since you were obviously late to the Wintersend Festival, I decided to expedite our departure by preparing Citrus for you." Theron pointed out that it was Adrian's mistake that he even tried to get near the beast.

Citrus, a behemoth of a creature twice Adrian's weight, resembled a giant ox with rhinoceros horns and the grace of a lion. While not as agile as warhorses, valrogs could effortlessly pull wagons and heavy loads over vast distances. Due to their immense size, a stampeding horde of valrogs was just as hazardous as a stampeding horde of warhorses. Due to the scarcity of horse trails leading up the mountains from the valley, the valrogs' powerful legs made them well-suited for pulling heavy wagons and navigating the mountainous terrain of Lemurian Valley.

Adrian turned to Theron, his expression softening. "Are you feeling anxious about your first appearance in the tournament later today?"

"No..." Theron objected. However, he eventually conceded with a heavy sigh. "Perhaps a bit anxious to begin the day as opposed to ruminating on what could go wrong for me today."

"Easy, lad. Everyone gets a case of jitters before their first attempt in the tournament. Even I was a nervous wreck back in my day. But you've been ready to compete in the tournament for at least two years." Adrian slouched as he snatched the saddle from Theron and sauntered toward the giant beast.

Citrus greeted him with affectionate nuzzles and licks of its oversized tongue.

"Easy there, boy," Adrian cooed. "Have you been naughty?"

Citrus responded with more affectionate licks.

"Theron," Adrian explained, "these magnificent creatures form deep bonds with their chosen master. The valrogs inherited a lot from their larger cousins, the galrogs."

Theron frowned, his curiosity piqued. "*Galrogs?*"

Adrian nodded. "Galrogs are colossal beasts, twice the size of valrogs, who form bonds with Mayans. They are powerful, proud creatures who are fiercely loyal to their bonded Mayans."

Theron pondered this information, recalling the tales of Mayans, the mysterious barbarians residing beyond the smoky mountains near the valley. "Uncle, I thought Mayans could form bonds with any animal, like wolves, horses, and birds."

"Yes. The Mayans are divided into several clans, and they typically form bonds with the clan's animals." Adrian stated, "I heard they move to a different clan if they form a bond with the animal of that clan."

Mayans, a nomadic and barbaric human race, resided several hundred miles away from Theron's border town. They were a notorious species renowned for their bonding magic to bond and control any living animal in the realm except humans.

Adrian, noticing Theron's contemplative mood, reassured him, "Don't fret about the tournament, lad. I'm confident you'll perform as admirably as your mother did in her tournaments."

Theron's head jerked towards Adrian, surprised by the rare mention of his mother. "Did my mother compete in the Wintersend Tournament?"

"Yes," Adrian recalled, adjusting the saddle on Citrus' back. "Felixia traveled to Titus city to compete in the Wintersend Tournament and brought honor to our family and our tiny border town."

Theron swelled with pride. Not everyone could earn an invitation to a Wintersend Tournament in a major city like Titus. One had to prove themselves in multiple trials before qualifying for the main event.

Observing his uncle's distraction, Theron seized the opportunity. "What was my mother like?" he croaked, eager to learn more about his otehr.

His aunt informed him that his mother, Felixia, had died giving birth to him, but she was hesitant to speak about her sister due to the sorrow of the memories it evoked.

Elissa and her brother, Adrian, had sacrificed their own dreams to raise him, never marrying. However, they remained reticent when reliving memories of his mother.

"Felixia was a kind and vivacious spirit who saw the best in others," Adrian began, his voice heavy with emotion. "She was my twin, and I was closer to her than to Elisa. Elissa took on the role of mother after our parents were slain in a Mayan skirmish. I don't think Elissa enjoyed her life as much as Felixia did. Caring for her younger siblings as a young lass hardened her. Elissa was only a teenager when she inherited the responsibilities of our family and this farm."

Adrian's tone turned wistful. "Felixia was the most adventurous of us, and she loved life to the fullest. She was never troubled by adversity. Being a very prodigious air caster, she used to soar over every farmhouse in the town and make fun of others."

"Felixia was the one who brought joy and laughter into our lives. No one could resist her charm, and she was always the center of attention"

Adrian continued after a moment of silence. "Her most endearing quality was her ability to see the best in everyone. She hardly mistrusted anyone in her life."

Adrian chuckled softly. "No one could be upset with such a vivacious and trustworthy girl for being naughty. She was pampered by all the neighbors of our farm."

"As we grew older, our paths diverged. I enlisted in the Titus legion and was stationed in Titus city, but we stayed connected through letters."

"She eventually convinced Elissa and embarked on a solo road trip to explore the great cities of our kingdom."

"During her early travels, she would send me letters, and I knew she was brimming with happiness as she explored our land."

Adrian fell silent, overcome with sorrow as he reminisced about his twin. "What happened next, Uncle?"

"She stopped sending me messages. Elissa later revealed that Felixa returned to the farm a changed woman. She left the valley as a girl and returned a woman who had witnessed a fair share of the horrors of the world."

"She was pregnant with you when she returned to our farm a few months before your birth."

"I should have been there when she needed me most, but I was busy waging another man's war when I sensed my twin's passing."

"Even though I was thousands of miles away, I felt her depart with a sense of contentment that you had survived," Adrian concluded solemnly, bitter memories of his dearly missed sister resurfacing. "Felixa was too young to bear a child, and despite Elissa's efforts, she perished during childbirth."

Adrian tightened the saddle straps around the valrog's torso in silence, seemingly consumed by distressing recollections of his twin.

Theron absorbed every detail about his mother. "What about my father?" Theron inquired, his face contorted with disgust and loathing at the thought of his father.

Adrian turned to Theron, grimacing in his direction. "Elissa revealed to me that Felixa fell in love with a baron during her travels in Ristan city—*Baron Dracian of the House of Lampros*."

A baron? Theron frowned.

"However," Adrian continued, his voice dripping with contempt, "I have discovered that there is no House of Lampros."

"I believe that this man, whoever he is, took advantage of Felixa's trusting nature and abandoned her when he learned of her pregnancy."

Adrian continued, "Her most endearing trait, her ability to see the best in others, unfortunately, ruined her life."

Adrian's eyes narrowed; his anger mirroring Theron's own. "For the past fifteen years, I have been searching for any information about the man who wronged your mother."

"Have you found him?" Theron asked, his voice burning with the desire for vengeance for abandoning him and his mother.

"Not yet!" Adrian shook his head. "I have heard rumors of a young noble seen with Felixa in Ristan city, but I have yet to uncover his identity."

"A noble?" Theron growled, his disdain for the nobility deepening. "Of course, it had to be one of them." Theron had loathed the Sukran nobility for many years, and this discovery only cemented his view that the power-hungry nobles were the true scourge of their kingdom. The nobles always preyed upon the innocent and the weak.

A heavy silence descended upon them, both consumed by thoughts of retribution against the man who had wronged their beloved Felixa.

Adrian observed a reflection of his rage on Theron's face as well. He was astonished by his ward's outburst of rage since he was usually adept at controlling his emotions.

Adrian placed a reassuring hand on Theron's shoulder. "Have no doubt, Theron," he

declared, his voice laced with unwavering determination. "I will uncover the identity of your father, and I am certain he will beg for mercy when I capture him."

Theron shook his head firmly, his face blazing with contempt. "I have no interest in the man who sired me," he avowed. "I despise him to the very core of my being, and will continue to despise him to the end of my days."

Adrian gently brushed Theron's hair, his eyes filled with affection and understanding. "Enough with dwelling on the past, my dear boy," he advised. "Let us not tarnish this glorious day with such somber thoughts so early in the morning."

Theron nodded gratefully at his uncle for voluntarily sharing information about his parents, even though his uncle was aware that Theron was probing for information.

"Why are you revealing this knowledge now after remaining silent all these years, Uncle?" Theron inquired.

Adrian's voice softened as he replied, "You have reached manhood, young man. It is your time to learn about your lineage. I have imparted all that I know about your parents."

"Retrieve your steed. Let us make haste towards the fortress," Adrian instructed, a hint of concern clouding his expression. "Count Marius has summoned me to his presence today."

Theron anticipated the count's inquiry, understanding that Marius would likely question Adrian's decision to remain unmarried despite Theron reaching his adulthood.

But now that Theron had reached adulthood and turned eighteen last summer, the count would compel his uncle to consider marriage.

His uncle was two years shy of his fortieth birthday, and the count may force him to marry since it was one of his uncle's foremost duties to bear children and pass along his gifts in magic. All soldiers, whether male or female, were required to bear children for the welfare of the kingdom. After all, for a warrior race, most offspring of soldiers followed the path of their parents and enrolled in the army.

The count, however, could not compel Theron's aunt, Elissa, to marry, as she was a civilian and exempt from military law. She had never enrolled in any legion and had dedicated her life to raising Theron. Besides, she just played a role of a caretaker until her brother raised a family.

Theron pondered the discriminatory law that prohibited women from inheriting their father's property if they had a brother. He recalled Marius's repeated attempts to persuade Elissa to marry, but his aunt remained steadfast in her decision, sacrificing her own aspirations to raise him.

Theron deeply appreciated his aunt and uncle's unwavering support and selfless devotion. He had always considered them his true parents, questioning if his biological parents would have showered him with the same love and affection.

"I shall bring the horse at once." He walked away from his uncle, who had gone silent, lost in contemplation.

As Theron headed towards his mount, a pleasant voice called out to him, "*Please also retrieve my steed, my dear boy.*"

Theron whirled around to find his aunt grinning at him.

Elissa was a gorgeous woman who could still put adolescent girls to shame. As the most potent water, fire, and air caster in the valley, she seemed fifteen years younger than her age of forty-five. Only her dark blue eyes, which she shared with Theron, betrayed her decades of hardship and experience. She had a delicate nose and petite lips that were currently smiling at him.

Clad in riding attire that complemented her striking blue eyes, Elissa adjusted her peplos, a square garment draped and pinned over her shoulders, leaving one side gracefully exposed. Her attire was completed by drape pants, ideal for horseback riding.

"Aunty," Theron inquired, his voice filled with anticipation, "do you intend to grace us with your presence at the Wintersend Festival celebration and tournament?"

Elissa enveloped Theron in a tight embrace, before she straightened his tangled hair. "All these years, I've resisted joining the festivities. But I couldn't miss seeing my boy participate for the first time in the tournament, could I?" She returned his smile.

Theron's smile mirrored his aunt's, but it faltered momentarily as Elissa's expression turned to one of concern upon noticing the blood staining his fingertips.

"For heaven's sake," Elissa chided her nephew, her voice laced with exasperation, "how many times in a day do you manage to injure yourself?"

With swift, practiced movements, Elissa grasped Theron's fingers and invoked her water and spirit elements to mend the wound.

"The day is just getting started." Theron replied with a playful wink.

Elissa raised a small gust of wind over Theron's fingertips. With a flick of her wrist, Elissa summoned droplets from the condensed air, allowing them to trickle onto Theron's injured fingers. Her combined mastery of water and spirit elements cleansed the blood and restored Theron's fingers to their unblemished state.

"Thank you, Aunty," Theron expressed his gratitude, examining his healed fingers with relief.

Elissa waved her hand dismissively and teased, "I trust this will be the last time you require my healing services today."

"I certainly hope so." Theron gave her an appreciative grin. "I shall fetch our steeds so we may continue with our day."

With a newfound spring in his step, Theron turned and trotted towards the stable, his heart brimming with joy at the prospect of his aunt's presence on this fateful day that held the potential to alter his life for the better or worse.

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"Elissa," Adrian murmured, his gaze fixed on Theron's retreating form, "*the boy is truly special*. I have never seen the likes of him ever."

"None could have handled this tumultuous issue of being magicless with such grace and

composure," Adrian continued, his voice filled with admiration. "Despite the relentless criticism and animosity he faces at every turn, I'm surprised he still holds his head high and moves forward."

Elissa raised an eyebrow at her brother's observation. "Why not intervene and silence his detractors?"

Adrian shook his head firmly. "Handling this on his own will give him the courage to confront bigger challenges and criticisms later in life."

His eyes met Elissa's, their gazes locked in a silent understanding. "Today marks a pivotal moment in our lives, Lissy," Adrian declared, his voice resonating with conviction. "In any case, he will discover more about himself, for better or worse, and that is why I urged you to join this tournament."

Elissa nodded in agreement, her eyes following her nephew's retreating form.

"*True, I am not sure how, but I have a feeling he has grand plans for this tournament.*" Elissa conceded, her voice tinged with apprehension, "I doubt merely winning the tournament will sate him. He seems to have been meticulously preparing for this day for several years, and it seems the tournament is merely the prelude to a larger plan."

"I'm sure I won't like what he's got in store for us today, but I didn't have the heart to stop him from doing something he appears to want to accomplish so desperately."

"Lissy," Adrian implored his sister, "swear to me that you won't let your overly protective side interfere with his desires today."

Elissa met her brother's gaze, her eyes conveying a hint of defiance. "Do you require an oath to prevent me from intervening and safeguarding my newphew?"

"Yes, indeed," Adrian affirmed, placing his large hand reassuringly on her shoulder. "I am aware of your unwavering affection for the boy. However, today is not the day for your protective instincts to take precedence. *Today is the day we let him unleash himself upon the world.*"

Elissa nodded solemnly, accepting her brother's words. "Very well, then. I pledge not to meddle with my boy's defense unless he specifically requests my assistance," she declared, her voice resolute.

Adrian nodded and smiled. "Moreover, I urged you to join us for the festival because we must be by his side on this day that may reshape not only his life but also our lives."

Chapter 4

The Ancient Lemurian Fortress

There is a thin line between confidence and arrogance...It's called humility.

Confidence smiles, Arrogance smirks.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

All of Adrian's farmhands galloped towards the fortress, the annual venue for the Wintersend Festival, a celebration for the triumphant arrival of spring over the bleak and prolonged winter. The inhabitants of the Lemurian Valley converged annually at the fortress to shepherd the winter season to its dusk.

Sir Marius Tenevis, a genial count, marshaled five thousand sentinels in the fortress at the best of times. Since assuming dominion over the border town decades past, the count had taken immense pride in hosting this festival. The fortress, an emblem of steadfast defense as the last bastion, had stood resolutely for generations, undefeated by any besieging force, safeguarding millions of farmholds stretching all the way to Titus city, five hundred leagues distant. A league in Sukran lexicon was commonly quantified as three miles.

People shared their livestock, grains, vegetables, and an assortment of farm-grown fruits in readiness for the opulent banquet to be served later in the day. The women banded together to prepare a feast surpassing the one presented the previous year.

Youths and children alike eagerly anticipated the splendid music and dance that would accompany the sumptuous feast later in the evening.

Count Marius typically presided over council assemblies to deliberate on various valley matters. Holders presented allegations against other holders to the count, abiding his rulings on such affairs.

The children assisted the men in setting up the area for the upcoming feast and spent the remainder of the time playing, squabbling, and debating about the tournament slated to be held for later in the evening.

Theron rode in the company of his uncle, aunt, and the other denizens who worked and dwelled on their farmhold. He observed Cadmus prattling incoherently to Maria, the corpulent cook at the end of the line. Maria listened to Cadmus' prattle while yearning to be elsewhere but was too courteous to rebuke him for his shortcomings. The residents of Adrian-Hold embraced Cadmus as an equal despite his guise as a fool and coward, in contrast to the residents of other farmholds who harassed Cadmus as much as they harassed him.

Cadmus gave Theron a wink before returning to pester Maria.

Theron noticed that several of his companions were casting him disdainful glares. Sergius

seemed to have worked twice as hard as promised to turn the populace against him.

Speaking of the man, Theron didn't spot Sergius in their procession. He presumed Sergius must have already departed for the stronghold to sow discord over his imminent participation in the tournament.

Theron shrugged and turned around to soak in the surroundings as they approached the stronghold, which was twelve miles from his uncle's farm. Uncle Adrian owned the valley's largest farmhold, with fifty families in his employ. The Lemurian Valley was situated at the outermost reaches of the realm on its southeastern border. It was a border town encircled by natural defensive features shielding it from incursions by the Mayan race.

The Mayans lived as barbarians in the untamed and harsh mountain ranges beyond their valley. Apart from the war that erupted in the fortress before Theron was born, there was little interaction between the two races, as the concept of trade was nonexistent in Mayan society.

They traversed past the woodland leading to the stronghold, moving through a landscape that left Theron breathless each time he beheld it. They witnessed two colossal mountain ranges descending on either side of their trail.

The mountains soared several thousands of feet above the land. One side of the slope descended into a natural ridge, rendering the mountain unscalable. Supposedly, the Lemurian river running above the Merile mountain had streamed down the other side for ages, creating such an unscalable ridge.

The massive river flowing atop the Merile mountain range was redirected by an elemental-cast dam to flow over the fields beyond the valley and into the Lemurian town.

The insurmountable ridge compelled any invading army to venture into a two-mile-wide plain nestled between the surrounding mountains. This narrow passage significantly reduced the numerical advantage of invading forces due to the narrowness of the plains.

At the end of the valley, the fortress rose, with fifty-foot-tall walls extending to the edge of the mountains on either side.

Theron's entourage traversed the plains and passed through the elemental-cast gates to enter the stronghold. Most of the soldiers stationed atop the fifty-foot ramparts gave them a fleeting glance. However, a handful of guards saluted his uncle, admiration evident on their faces.

During the war between Noble Lord Titus and the deposed lord Vatican who revolted against his neighbouring state to encroach into the Titus city, his uncle had been acclaimed as the war hero for the Titus legion. His uncle resigned from the legion after the war when he learned of his twin sister's death.

As they entered the stronghold, sounds of laughter and revelry wafted from the gathered townsfolk. The men were erecting tents and adorned the entire area with elemental-cast lights and beautiful foliage, hoping to amplify the splendor of the festive night once the sun bid farewell for the day.

Young children dashed around the tents with unbridled joy, while adolescents engaged in mock battles in preparation for the tournament.

The majority of farmholders residing within the valley had already arrived, with those on the valley's outskirts, such as his uncle's, tricking behind his entourage.

Despite the weight of the day's significance on Theron's shoulders, he couldn't help but smile at the cheerful atmosphere. His entourage trotted toward the stables, exchanging greetings with other holders who turned to greet them.

They lodged their horses, and his uncle bid them farewell before leisurely strolling toward the townhouse in the fortress' center, where the town council convened. Theron and his aunt traversed to the storage tents with the remainder of their farm's personnel to dispense the supplies earmarked for the festival feast.

After contributing to the unloading of the wagon carried by valrogs, Theron bade farewell to his aunt. He ventured towards the training grounds to locate his friends, who he believed might be lingering around the training grounds where the Wintersend Tournament scheduled for later that evening.

En route to the tournament grounds, he exchanged pleasantries with other holders and their progeny. However, as he passed by, many of his townsfolk regarded him with disdain, some going as far as attempting to belittle him with derogatory epithets, which triggered raucous laughter from his detractors.

To make matters worse, misguided teenagers, swayed and enamored by their parents' insults, endeavored to pelt him with stones. Skillfully, he evaded their projectiles and ventured deeper into the stronghold.

Yet, Theron remained undaunted by this reception, having weathered criticism throughout his life. Today, however, the hostility directed at him seemed more pronounced. Sergius must have upheld his vow, further inciting the local populace against him—a task made easier by the fact that many already despised him for being born without magic.

Theron grinned, contemplating how a simple feud could escalate the situation in his secluded border town. He hoped to control the ball he had set rolling today.

He observed a group of lads engaged in animated discourse about the tournament and how they envisioned setting it ablaze once they reached the eligible age. Anyone above sixteen could participate, and although there was no upper age limit, individuals above twenty-five seldom competed in the tournament.

Such reflections summoned numerous memories of his tween years, initially filled with promise, only to be later turned as years passed to the horrific realization that he bore no elemental magic.

Shaking his head, Theron pushed aside the melancholic thoughts before he drowned in self-pity. He was obliged to return to his uncle's side later in the day to assist in setting up tents for their farmhands, as the entire town would spend the night within the fortress, reveling until the late hours.

He spotted Schultz and Gaby engrossed in conversation near the fence of the tournament ground. Navigating through the crowd, he made his way toward his friends.

"So, all set for the evening?" Theron quipped upon joining them.

Schultz, a sandy-haired youth, nodded and pointed towards the fortress guards preparing the ground. "They are organizing five sections, each with an equal amount of elements."

Two warriors engaged in a mock battle, pitting their earth elementals against each other. A green bear elemental made of stone slammed with resounding power into with a wolf elemental made of black stone, sending the latter flying ten feet. The wolf, however, adeptly rolled upon landing and sprang back at the bear.

The bear elemental pounded its breast in victory, imitating its master's jubilant expression, and prepared to repel the wolf's assault.

"Hands down, the wolf is going to get crushed," Gaby declared.

Schultz concurred with Gaby. "Consider the size of the bear elemental. It will easily crush the wolf."

Theron shook his head. "No, the wolf is too agile for an earth elemental; it will wear down the bear."

"Not a chance," Schultz disagreed.

Theron faced his companions with a knowing smile. "I wager two silvers that the wolf wins."

Schultz agreed to the bet. "I'm in," and Gaby followed suit.

The wolf elemental lunged towards the bear elemental, who braced for impact. Just as the bear elemental raised its fist to strike, the wolf darted to the left and, with a powerful swipe of its paws, raked its claws across the bear's forehead, sending a shower of stone fragments flying.

The bear elemental, caught off guard by the wolf's agility, let out a startled roar and quickly spun around to face its nimble opponent. It snarled in frustration as it realized that the wolf had anticipated its move and was now lingering behind it.

The wolf elemental, sensing victory within its grasp, leaped onto the bear elemental's right leg and sank its teeth into the stone flesh. The bear elemental, in excruciating pain, tried to turn towards the wolf, but the wolf, with its superior agility, moved along with the bear and maintained its position and tore another chunk of stone from the bear's other leg.

The bear elemental, overwhelmed by the relentless assault, let out a final, anguished cry and collapsed face-first onto the ground. It writhed and twisted in agony as the wolf elemental pounced upon its chest, tearing away a piece of stone from its throat before nimbly dodging the bear's flailing paws.

The bear elemental, its strength waning, attempted to rise, but its efforts were in vain. As the wolf elemental continued to dismantle the stone cords that held the bear elemental's form together, the bear elemental crumbled into dust, its existence extinguished.

The soldier who had summoned the bear elemental was on his knees, unable to sustain it after losing his connection with the manifested elemental.

The second soldier was petting the wolf when he heard clapping from the crowd at the fence. He made a mock bow, and the wolf elemental imitated him with something that resembled a bow. The wolf eventually disintegrated into dust as onlookers cheered.

The victorious soldier approached his friend, who was on his knees, and helped him to his feet. As they trudged back to the barracks, animosity forgotten, they discussed the battle.

Schultz and Gaby each handed Theron two silver coins with sour expressions. Theron, his smile radiating with quiet confidence, remarked, "Raw power is not the strongest power."

Turning to Gaby, Theron asked, "So, Gaby...Schultz is participating with me today. Are you certain you will not change your mind about participating in today's tournament?"

"No way," Gaby replied flatly, his expression reflecting his lack of interest. "I have no reason to participate. The other contestants will easily overpower my weak earth elemental." He paused, his gaze turning shrewd as he met Theron's eyes. "And I don't think you should participate either."

Theron responded with a nonchalant shrug. "Well, one can only give their best shot," he remarked, his voice laced with a hint of defiance.

After a moment of hesitation, Gaby spoke with a little bit of apprehension. "Theron, you're my friend, but I can't fathom how you intend to compete against the other contestants without elemental magic..." His voice trailed off, an embarrassed look crossing his face for bringing up Theron's lack of magical ability.

Theron's gaze turned distant as he muttered under his breath, "Never underestimate a wolf."

Just as Gaby was shaking his head in disbelief, a harsh, arrogant voice erupted from behind Theron. "Bless the elementals, Freak! Have you lost your mind?"

With a disappointed grunt, Theron spun around to face his arch-nemesis from his tween years, Ferris Gavlin.

"Ferris," Theron hissed with his tone laced with equal measure of hatred as in Ferris' voice.

Ferris, with his jet-black hair, chiseled features, and well-trimmed beard, exuded an air of arrogance that was further amplified by his entourage of thuggish companions.

"Freak, or should I call you an idiot?" Ferris sneered, his words eliciting a chorus of laughter from his friends at his slur.

Theron fired back, his voice dripping with sarcasm, "Says the man who couldn't even pass for a dimwit."

Ferris's friend, Briar, let out a whistle, his eyes gleaming with malicious amusement. "Looks like someone's itching for learning another lesson," he remarked.

"Freak, after all the lessons I've imparted on you over the years on addressing your betters, how dare you still disrespect me?" Ferris snarled with a smirk..

"Superiors?" Theron quipped. "Last I checked, you were hardly a master of anything but your own stupid mind."

Ferris's face contorted into a mask of fury as he stormed towards Theron, their confrontation drawing a circle of curious onlookers.

Theron sighed. "I'm growing weary of this endless exchange of insults. There must be a reason the mighty lord of the Lemurian Valley is seeking an audience with this simpleton," he remarked with a tinge of sarcasm.

Ferris, his anger momentarily quelled, jabbed a finger into Theron's chest. "I understand you've registered for the tournament today?" he demanded, his voice laced with disdain.

"Why should my participation concern you?" Theron frowned on his gaze catching sight of Sergius lurking among the crowd, a smirk playing on his lips.

Theron realized with a sigh that Sergius had orchestrated this encounter, hoping to prod him at his most vulnerable spot—his deep-seated animosity towards Ferris Gavlin.

Ferris, his face blazing with contempt, declared, "Freak, if you dare to participate in the tournament, you'll tarnish its reputation, and I won't receive the due recognition when I win this tournament today."

"Isn't it a bit premature to boast about victory before the tournament has even begun?" Theron inquired in disbelief.

Ferris, his arrogance unwavering, replied, "Freak, who dares stand in my way? Briar is the only one with elemental casting power capable of challenging me." He gestured towards his friend Briar, who stood behind him, arms crossed, his expression a menacing scowl.

"He'll join my team, and we'll conquer this tournament in record time," Ferris declared triumphantly, high-fiving his companion.

Theron couldn't tolerate Ferris's stupidity, which appeared to have no bearing on reality. "Aye, hail your lordship, the mighty warrior who dreams of slaying others while clutching his..."

Theron braced himself for Ferris's punch, which landed squarely in his gut with all the strength Ferris could muster from his earth elemental. Theron soared a few feet through the air and landed hard on his back, blood trickling from his lips.

"*You dare...you dare to ridicule me, Freak?*" Ferris growled. "I command earth, fire, and air elementals and can instantly annihilate your pathetic existence."

"All you have control over is your bladder, more than your stupid mouth, clearly." Theron, still lying on the ground, couldn't resist engaging Ferris in a verbal duel.

Ferris, enraged by the insult, approached Theron, eager to teach the freak a lesson.

Sergius stepped between them, holding out his hands in a placating gesture. "Stop, Ferris," he said. "Don't degrade yourself by fighting this magicless creature."

Theron scowled at Sergius' attempt to dissuade them from fighting. It was uncharacteristic of the man who was hellbent on teaching him a lesson tonight.

"But the freak dared to insult me," Ferris grumbled. "It's time I teach him how to speak with his betters."

"I'm not preventing you from teaching him a lesson," Sergius replied. "Remember, you're not just any young man. It's unbecoming of the cousin of the Sukran prince to brawl with the likes of the magicless freak."

Sergius fixed Theron with a cold stare before continuing. "Besides, you are no longer children. You're adults now, and you'll be in trouble with Count Marius if you disrupt the festivities today with your immature brawl."

"What do you suggest we do to teach the freak a lesson?" Ferris protested. "I can't let him get away with humiliating me who is one of the strongest elementalists in the valley."

"You are entitled to issue him a challenge," Sergius suggested, grinning ickedly at Theron, who comprehended the trap he was being lured in.

"The freak will have no choice but to reveal his cowardice to the entire town if he declines

the challenge and demonstrates he's unworthy to compete in the tournament," Sergius continued.

"Or he'll be a fool to accept a challenge from a powerful magic caster like you, who will unrestricted by any laws during the tournament and have free rein to teach him basic manners when you confront him during the tournament," Sergius added, his grin widening.

"Once the tournament starts, the freak will have to face your prodigious magic without help from his uncle or aunt, who won't be able to come to his defense midway."

"So, let's see if he's a coward, a fool, or both?" Sergius concluded with a smirk.

"Well said, Sergius. Let's expose the freak's true colors," Ferris agreed, pleased with Sergius's clever maneuvering of Theron into a corner where he would lose either way.

"Do you accept the challenge to defeat me in this tournament, Freak?" Ferris asked with a menacing sneer.

Theron watched as Sergius smiled triumphantly, having successfully pushed him into a corner. The crowd began to mock him, believing he had no choice but to concede defeat and decline Ferris's challenge.

Sergius had sprung a well-crafted trap, but his adversaries had made one critical mistake. They underestimated his determination to win the tournament. Besides everyone assumed he would lose the tournament against Ferris despite his best efforts.

Theron sprang to his feet, spitting out the blood from his mouth. It was time to turn the tables on his detractors.

"I accept the challenge to defeat you in this tournament," Theron declared, his voice filled with defiance.

Ferris and his companions erupted in laughter. "Are you completely insane? The blacksmith fool living on your uncle's farm appears to be more intelligent than you," Ferris mocked.

Theron acknowledged the comment with a nod. "Yes, Cadmus has more wisdom than I do. But I have more brains and balls than you all put together."

Ferris's expression darkened as he approached Theron and jabbed him in the chest with his index finger. "I accept your challenge. What do you want if I lose?" he demanded.

Theron pondered for a moment. "I want you to swear on your honor that you will never hurt or bully anyone, always respect your inferiors in elemental casting, and assist those in need."

Despite Ferris's frown, Sergius appeared delighted. "You are definitely a fool. An even greater fool than I expected. What do you gain from this?"

Theron shrugged and pointed at the surrounding townspeople. "All these people will know Ferris is a dishonorable person if he breaks his pledge and harms someone. He'll lose the respect and trust of the valley's inhabitants, even if he's one of the most powerful elementalists here."

"So, Ferris stands to lose just as much in this contest as I do. If he fails this challenge, can he refrain from showing off his magic and quit harassing others?" Theron successfully reversed the trap on Ferris. "If Ferris does lose this challenge, I am sure that townsmen will find a strange in Ferris' body if he remains to be trusted as a honorable Sukran."

Ferris, realizing the gravity of the challenge, let out a menacing growl. "In exchange, what

will you do if you lose the wager, freak?"

"What do you want me to do?" Theron asked

Sergius mumbled something into Ferris' ears before he could issue his challenge.

Ferris' mouth curved into an evil smile.

"If you lose the challenge," Ferris declared, his voice dripping with venom, "*you will surrender the gold coin you unjustly stole from Sir Sergius and be exiled from this valley forever.*"

A murmur of shock rippled through the crowd, but it was quickly drowned out by the raucous laughter and jubilation of those who despised Theron. Ferris leered at Theron while Sergius looked pleased with himself.

Theron stood speechless, taken aback by Ferris's vicious animosity. He was hardly surprised by the demand to return the gold coin he had acquired from Sergius as payment for herding the cattle.

But he was surprised by the demand to be banished from the valley if he lost the tournament.

"*Why do you want me banished?*" Theron asked, his voice filled with disbelief. He was by no means a popular figure, but what had he done to garner such vitriol? *Was it his fault that he was born without magic?*

Ferris spat fire with his words in contempt. "*You are a curse on this valley, freak. You are a stain on Sukran's history.* No one in our history has been born without the ability to wield elemental magic. Your exile will protect the people of this valley from the doom you may bring upon us all one day."

Theron's anger surged with every word Ferris uttered. He took a deep breath, forcing himself to remain calm. He had never intended to spend the rest of his life in this valley.

His goal was to attend university, far from the stifling judgment of his townsmen. Losing the tournament would mean losing his dreams, his aspirations. Moreover, he couldn't bear to burden his uncle and aunt any longer. They had given him more than an orphaned boy could ever ask for.

Victory in the tournament would allow him to pursue his dreams in the capital city. This challenge, regardless of its outcome, would only strengthen his resolve to leave the valley.

With renewed determination, Theron squared his shoulders and met Ferris's gaze. "I accept your challenge," he declared, his voice firm and resolute.

"What idiocy is this, Ferris?" Gavlin bellowed at his son after arriving to inspect the growing throng at the training ground.

Ferris spun around, his eyes darting anxiously under his father's stern gaze. "Father, I assure you, I have everything under control," he stammered.

Gavlin's expression hardened as he clutched an old book hard on his hand. "I raised you

to be a better man of integrity than this, Ferris. How could you stoop so low as to devise a plan to banish an innocent man from his home?"

Ferris squared his shoulders, his voice growing firmer. "Father, I implore you not to side side that freak again. Why do you insist on forcing me to play nice with that freak?" he retorted, his resentment evident.

"This has nothing to do with Theron. I do not want your arrogance to drag you down." Gavlin snapped.

"Well, we shall discover that from today's outcome soon enough, won't we? So, until the conclusion of the tournament, I beseech you to refrain from lecturing me on treating the freak like an equal."

"Well said, Ferris. Well said, indeed." Sergius intervened to diffuse the situation, lest Galvin compel his son to withdraw from the challenge.

"Briar, let's go..." Ferris snapped at his friend and led his group away from the scene.

Gavlin clutched his old book tightly and glared at Sergius furiously for manipulating his son. Gavlin barely controlled the anger simmering beneath the surface. With a heavy sigh, he cast an apologetic glance at Theron before turning and striding towards the command center, his shoulders slumped in defeat.

Sergius turned his attention to Theron, a sly grin spreading across his face. "Didn't I warn you about the retaliation for humiliating me this morning?" he taunted as Ferris and his pals stomped away, talking loudly about the day they would watch the freak leave their town. The gathered onlookers had also dispersed.

"Where will you go if you're banished from this town, freak? Thanks to your uncle's generosity, you've lived a comfortable life here, but if you're exiled, no one would even consider respecting a magicless person as a slave, let alone a citizen of this kingdom."

"Remember that you brought this fate upon yourself by being arrogant to your betters." Sergius chastised.

"However, I eagerly await the day when the only heir to your uncle's farmhold is expelled from this town. Enjoy the remainder of the day, Theron. This might very well be your last in this place." Sergius scoffed at Theron before leaving him in the company of Schultz and Gaby.

"Are you really as daft as Ferris claims?" Schultz berated Theron.

Theron shot Schultz a look of surprise. "You don't believe in me either?"

Schultz appeared perplexed by his question. "How do you plan to defeat the most potent elemental caster in our valley without possessing even a single elemental power? I acknowledge your intellect surpasses the rest of us combined together, but the odds remain heavily stacked against you."

Theron responded with a grin. "Then I must transform into the wolf we encountered earlier. Magic is not the sole source of strength in the world," he asserted. "It is merely a tool for

enriching our lives."

The trio crossed a few townsmen who sneered derisively at Theron.

"Sergius has incited the entire populace against you," Schultz scowled.

"Indeed, Sergius has executed his role flawlessly," Theron snorted.

"*Wait!*" Gaby, sharper than Schultz, comprehended Theron's statement. "You deliberately provoked Sergius to incite the townsfolk against you?"

Theron smiled at him. "Yes. There is no point in winning the tournament if I lack the funds to pay for university. Most folks will be enticed by the idea of expelling me from this town and will not hesitate to humiliate me and strip me of all my possessions if given the chance."

"When one of my friends, Schultz, lacks faith in my chances of winning the tournament, those townsmen who only respect and value power and magic would never conceive that I could surmount the challenge with Ferris." Theron explained, "So, I've made Sergius' task of inciting the townsfolk against me a piece of cake."

Theron looked at his friends. "Granted, I didn't anticipate Ferris demanding my banishment if I fail the challenge, but regardless, I'm leaving this place to carve out a life for myself after this tournament," Theron replied.

Schultz continued to wear a frown. "I still believe your odds of winning this tournament are one in a thousand.

Gaby interrupted with enthusiasm. "Exactly what Theron needs. Well done, Theron. Ferris has not yet realized that he's been goaded into a challenge he never wanted in the first place. Nevertheless, this will all be in vain if you don't return victorious. You've significantly raised the stakes against you."

Gaby pointed his hand at the retreating forms of Ferris and his friends. "If Ferris wishes to win the challenge at any cost, he will resort to playing dirty. He would loathe losing this tournament, especially to you. He'll get rid of you from the tournament as soon as possible." Gaby stated.

"He'll attempt to get rid of me," Theron corrected. "Furthermore, if I can't handle the likes of Ferris and his bullies, what chance do I stand in a university where nearly everyone would have inherited demigod elemental magic from their lordship parents? This will be my litmus test to determine if I can deal with these bullies on my own."

Schultz nodded at Theron. "Sounds good to me. If I had the choice to pick my team, I'd choose you as my teammate."

Theron grinned at his friend. "That would be exceptionally kind of you."

The majority of the populace seemed eager to impart a lesson to him. Before departing the town permanently, Theron aimed to astonish his prejudiced townsmen by teaching them a valuable lesson.

"Will meet you guys later." Theron bid them farewell as he made his way to the section of the field where his uncle had commenced erecting tents for his farmholders.

Adrian and Theron, alongside the other farmhands of their farm, erected their tents in a contemplative silence.

After a considerable time spent setting up the tents, Adrian finally broke the silence. "*So, you've chosen to depart from this valley, regardless of the outcome of the tournament?*"

Theron met his uncle's gaze and released a long sigh. Despite numerous attempts to prepare for this conversation, he was unable to formulate a tactful approach. Eventually, he responded in a hushed tone. "It's time for me to stand on my own, Uncle. Because of me, you and Auntie have never moved forward with your lives. I am so indebted to you that I doubt I'll ever be able to repay you in my lifetime."

Adrian shook his head. "Boy, we're family, and when things get tough, we stick together. *Never let your aunt hear you say otherwise.*"

"I can't stand in the way of your life with a wife and children. The count must be pressing you to marry regardless."

Adrian waved his hands dismissively. "Nonsense. What does my marriage have to do with you? I won't marry until I find the woman of my dreams. Don't get all sentimental on me, young man."

After completing his task, Adrian turned to face Theron.

"Theron, we will not let you be exiled alone if you lose this tournament. If needed, your aunt and I will relocate with you from the valley where we've lived since birth. Don't put your aunt through that. Elissa is more attuned to our farmhold than either of us. She considers the farmhold as a part of her."

Theron began to object, but Adrian silenced him with a raised hand. "Regardless of you winning or losing, we stay united. No more discussion on this topic."

Adrian's hand rested on Theron's shoulder. "Make us proud today." He turned and headed to the town council to meet the count.

Theron felt the weight not only of his own future but also that of his uncle and aunt pressing heavily on his shoulders.

The only way they could get on with their life was when Theron started a new life at the university.

"By the Great Elementals!" Theron lamented his predicament before steeling himself. He had to succeed at any cost.

Chapter 5

The Wintersend Tournament

Oh, what an occasion is the Wintersend Tournament held yearly in the capital city, Ristan.

I am more than eager and anxious for this year's tournament, as I look forward to participating in the tournament for the first time.

But as the time dwindles toward the fateful night of the Wintersend Festival, I feel nothing but anxiety at my stupidity and brazen act of enlisting for the tournament.

Can I win the tournament with my mediocre magic?

Unlike other participants, my failure in the tournament would have ripple effects across the entire kingdom.

For many vultures circle above me to feast on me at my first misstep.

But does it matter if I win or lose in the tournament?

Isn't participation more important than winning or losing?

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

"Welcome to the eighteenth Wintersend Tournament, graciously hosted by His Excellency Count Marius Tenevis, the illustrious war hero of the Elvantis War," proclaimed the count's valet to the gathered townspeople.

The valet's resounding voice reverberated throughout the park, where the citizens were assembled in the stands constructed beyond the perimeter of the grounds. Employing his air elemental, the valet sound cast his voice and ensured that his proclamation reached every soul in attendance.

Seated atop the tallest stand, the count commanded a panoramic view of the entire arena. A multitude of spectators erupted in fervent cheers, expressing their admiration for the benevolent and esteemed count. Marius reciprocated with a beaming smile and gracious waves.

Theron noticed his uncle sitting next to the count and engaged in conversation with other fortress dignitaries. After searching the crowd for his aunt, Theron turned his gaze toward the prominent stand, only to be astonished to find the presence of Elissa seated next to the other side of the count. Clearly, she had been invited for the healing prowess she had provided to the count's soldiers over the years. His aunt was, without question, the finest healer in the valley.

He nodded at her, and she responded with a broad grin.

Observing Cadmus and Gaby positioned near the gambler tent, Theron noted the unusually large throng. The impending clash between Ferris and himself must have captivated the interest of many, transforming the challenge into the town's hot topic. Many residents appeared eager to get their long time wish fulfilled at long last, thanks largely to his stupidity to accept the challenge. Many awaited eagerly to witness him banished from their town at long last.

The valet continued his oration. "This event will scrutinize the talents, strategies, and teamwork of the participants through a simulated battle. We will divide the contenders into five teams, each tasked with defending a designated section of the grounds." He gestured towards the five sections, each adorned with the flag embroidered with the picture of a different animal—Silver horse, golden lion, black panther, white bear, and gray wolf.

The gray wolf section was on the opposite end of the count's stand, while the remaining four sections were strategically arranged across from one another on either side of the count's stand.

"Twenty-five young men will compete in this year's tournament, with each team

comprising five players and be assigned a section to defend."

"At the commencement of the game, each team shall receive a golden flower totem housed within a vase which is molded to hold only the totem. The vase will consume everything but the specifically crafted flower totem offered to each of the team."

The participants observed soldiers placing golden flower vases in each section of the ground designated for each of the five teams.

Before proceeding, the valet allowed a moment for the rules to settle. "Each team must safeguard its flower totem while endeavoring to capture the opposing team's totem. The game will unfold over one hour, concluding with the team possessing the most flowers declared as the victor."

"Members of the triumphant team at the end of the game shall have the privilege to seek a boon within Count Marius' authority to grant."

Pausing momentarily, the valet heightened his voice. "Each participant will be equipped with armor meticulously crafted by the fortress' finest blacksmiths. These armors are built to endure to assaults of any magnitude without harming the wearer. While participants are permitted to wield personal weapons, using them on any unarmored part of another participant is strictly prohibited."

"In the event of a fatal hit to the armor, the armor will freeze the wearer and render the wearer unable to continue. Non-fatal blows will induce a freeze until healed by water-casting participants, with the armor thawing upon healing."

"You can employ any tactic to secure victory and claim the coveted golden flower totem of your opponents," emphasized the valet as he elucidated the rules.

"However, let me stress once again that attacking unarmored sections of an opponent with your weapons will be considered a criminal offense and will be suitably punished by the count."

Turning to the assembled participants, the valet declared, "In the history of the game conducted in this town, there have been no fatalities, though some participants have been permanently crippled. Should anyone wish to withdraw, please step forward now."

Even though this was a formality, there had been occasional unintentional impairments. Accidental fatalities had occurred in the heat of battle during tournaments conducted in the capital.

No contestant chose to withdraw, earning applause from the audience in acknowledgment of their valor.

The valet tipped his head in recognition of their bravery. "Esteemed denizens of the realm have gathered here to witness the talents of these young men. This tradition of conducting this game dates back to the reign of Sukra's first king, Evander Primus. This ancient game assesses a contestant's combat, strategy, and teamwork skills. Let us, akin to our forebears, understand the prowess of these young men and steer them towards vocations that best serve the realm."

The townspeople erupted in thunderous applause, eagerly anticipating the tournament's commencement.

The valet turned his back to the players and pointed to a circle in the center of the ground. "As I announce your names, step into this circle and showcase your elemental prowess. This

demonstration will aid in sorting you into appropriate teams. Exhibit your most potent elemental ability, followed by others in descending order of strength."

"The circle encompasses all elements—water, stone, a fire pit, and trees—to accentuate the potency of your elemental magic."

A palpable silence enveloped the entire ground.

Unfurling a scroll, the valet began to read aloud, "Let us invite *Bardic Mantis* to demonstrate his elemental mastery."

A large, muscular young man approached the circle. Bardic was the apprentice of the town's blacksmith. He unsheathed his large arcing sword, and with a single swing, he halved an enormous stone boulder set up in the circle, showcasing exceptional metal-casting skills.

A small applause echoed from the crowd even whilst the valet guided Bardic to the metal-caster's circle.

"*Bedric Galdian!*" the valet proclaimed next.

Theron winced as the corpulent lad, Bedric, Ferris's comrade, stepped into the circle. He drew strength from his earth elemental to fortify his body and lifted the man-sized boulder. Bedric hurled the stone with tremendous effort to the far end of the expansive field. Louder cheers resounded for his impressive display of might, the valet diligently sending him to the circle of earth casters.

"*Pepwick Canticus.*"

The medium-built lad from Eric's farmstead approached the circle timidly.

Pepwick knelt and conjured ten five-foot-tall sand mounds with a strenuous groan. Each mound sparkled with a distinct mineral—silver, black coal, and gold. However, in a few seconds of raising the mounds, Pepwick lost control of his earth magic and at once, each mound disintegrated into sand, drawing boos from the audience at the poor display of earth elemental casting.

Exerting considerable effort in his next attempt, Pepwick raised a ten-foot-tall stone wall, maintaining it for a brief moment before allowing it to crumble into dust. The crowd continued to boo the lad his shoddy mastery of earth magic.

The valet was displeased by Pepwick's exhibition but directed him toward the earth casters.

"*Briar Devlan.*"

Ferris' best mate entered the circle with an air of arrogance and self-assurance. Briar struggled briefly to control his fire elemental. Eventually, he siphoned the fire from the nearby fire pit and unleashed molten fire onto the stone Bedric had hurled earlier. Even though the stone was several thousand yards away, Briar's modest air elemental drove the fire to the far end of the ground.

Briar's molten flames liquefied Bedric's stone, eliciting audible gasps and subsequent applause from the spectators.

Ferris exulted in his friend's formidable display of brute strength while Briar was directed to the fire casters' circle as its first contestant for the day.

"*Gerrick Graybeard.*"

Gerrick was a five-foot-tall, slender wood caster who confidently approached the circle.

He touched the tree in the circle, causing the branches to fall. Employing his wood elemental, Gerrick swiftly transformed them into razor-sharp arrows.

He commanded his air elemental to raise the arrows, and with a flick of his wrist, a blast of wind propelled a dozen arrows into the sky.

The arrows sped toward the far end of the fence like a rain of spears and pierced the soil upon impact.

Summoning his earth elemental and borrowing its strength, Gerrick effortlessly lifted a five-foot stone from the ground and hurled them towards the far end of the field. His combined use of air and earth elemental propelled the stone to strike the arrows at the far end of the plains.

The exhibition of several elemental prowess elicited thunderous applause and joyous roars from the crowd. Gerrick strolled back without any arrogance, despite being one of just a few valley inhabitants capable of manipulating several elementals.

The valet was uncertain of determining Gerrick's primary affinity and hesitated between the wood, earth, and air ranks. After a moment of contemplation, he placed Gerrick amongst the wood casters circle.

Theron nodded in admiration of Gerrick's immense power. Gerrick was one of the few young men in the town who treated him with respect, despite his lack of elemental abilities.

"Ferris Gavlin."

With a casual stride, Ferris entered the circle. His earth effortlessly raised twenty rocks from beneath the ground, each the size of a man, while his air elemental lifted the rocks into the air. He clenched his fist and summoned his fire elemental, unleashing molten fire upon the rocks hovering in mid-air.

Mimicking Gerrick's flicking motion, Ferris sent the burning rocks hurtling through the air. His air elemental manipulated the windstreams around each of the blazing rocks to swerve across each other, creating a spectacular display of fiery destruction.

The rocks slammed into the ground with earth-shattering force, leaving a crater and obliterating any trace of Gerrick's arrows and rocks hurled by other contestants so far. The force of the throw caused the rocks to roll and bounce over the fence, leaving a trail of dust in their wake.

Ferris basked in the deafening applause and standing ovation from the crowd. Ferris turned around and pointed his finger arrogantly at Gerrick. Ferris made an crude gesture toward Gerrick by slitting his throat with his hand. He then made his way to the air caster ranks with a triumphant wave of his hands at the crowd.

Ferris had access to four primary elementals, like Theron's uncle, and was respected more for his elemental ability than for his character. It was rare for a common citizen to possess more than one elemental power.

Theron observed the animosity between Ferris and Gerrick. It was clear that Ferris viewed Gerrick as the sole contestant who could rival his powers.

"Schultz Gomez."

"Wish me luck!" Schultz, who was standing with Theron, murmured as he left the line of contestants.

Theron encouraged Schultz as his friend strode toward the circle.

Schultz waved his hand, summoning a thin tornado that breezed slowly towards the distant target. A fireball followed, though with considerably less potency than Ferris' display of fire magic.

Schultz strained to compartmentalize his mind and summon both his air and fire magic together simultaneously to control his light elemental. After a long moments of arduous efforts, he managed to make veil himself and turn invisible.

The crowd's response was mixed, with a few claps drowned out by jeers. Ferris chuckled, mocking Schultz's meager efforts. "Your breeze is as skinny as you are," Ferris admonished.

The valet struggled to determine the primary affinity of schultz before he directed Schultz to stand in the air casters circle.

The valet summoned all the remaining contestants who showcased their elemental abilities, but none could match the prowess of Ferris and Gerrick.

Finally, the valet called out, "Theron of Adrian-Hold!"

Murmurs erupted as the crowd recognized Theron, the magicless nephew of their beloved war hero, Adrian. At once, the mob greeted him with insults, including the cruel moniker "bastard."

Several contestants joined in the taunts, but Theron ignored the derision, stepping into the circle with his head held high. He adjusted his armor, ensuring his unmetal blades were secured in their makeshift sheaths on his back.

He had to remodel the placement of his weapons over his person since the plain metal armor proisioned by the fortress for this tournament had fewer slots to house his various weapons than his unmetal armor.

Silence descended as Theron stood motionless, staring at the ground. The growing impatience of the crowd prompted the valet to urge him to display his elemental abilities.

"Boy, we don't have all day." The valet grimaced.

Theron declared, "Sir, I do not possess elemental magic."

"What?" The valet was caught off guard. "You have no elemental magic at all?"

"No!" Theron met his gaze with a firm shake of his head. The valet's eyes narrowed, suspicion evident on his face.

"Everyone with Sukran blood has command over at least one element, regardless of its strength. Are you attempting to cheat to get an unfair edge over other competitors by concealing your magical abilities?"

Theron remained resolute. "No, I am not lying."

"Young man, I don't believe you. I shall summon a spirit caster to truth-seek the veracity of your claim. If we discover that you have lied about your elemental talents, you will immediately be disqualified from the event."

Unconvinced, the valet summoned a spirit caster to verify veracity of Theron's claim. A grizzled soldier approached Theron amidst widespread jeering from the crowd.

The intensity of the throng's jeering at Theron seemed to be more louder than the applause received by Ferris, elucidating the shared hatred by almost all of the townsfolk.

The truth-seeking soldier prepared his spirit for truth-seeking. "I am ready," he announced to the valet.

Spirit casters could detect the emotions of other creatures and influence

Truth seekers used their spirit to detect guilty emotions that generally accompanied lies.

Yet, this power was rare, limited to those wielding potent water and fire elementals.

The valet questioned. "Do you possess any elemental magic?"

Theron raised his head and spoke loudly. "*The color of the sky is green.*"

Theron's voice, magnified by the air casting of the valet, boomed over the ground. The truth seeker froze in shock. The soldier stammered, turning to face the bewildered valet who was waiting for his verdict. "*I don't detect him lying with my truth-seeking.*"

"*What?*" The valet's disbelief was palpable. "He's obviously lying about the sky's color!"

The soldier nodded. "Indeed, he is lying. However, my spirit casting unable to detect his lie. Only a handful of nobles in our kingdom possess such skill to deceive a truth seeker."

The crowd collectively gasped at Theron blatantly lying successfully to the truth seeker.

The valet, surprised by the revelation, swiveled his head to study Theron.

"*I can lie to a spirit caster,*" Theron asserted, his voice ringing out, amplified by the sound casting on all participants. "I simply wished to demonstrate that I could have concealed my lack of magic from the truth seeker had I chosen to cheat."

The valet regarded Theron with disbelief. "I am being truthful when I claim I have no elemental magic."

The valet's jaw dropped wide, unable to find a response for a few seconds. "I have never heard of a Sukran without magic." the valet conceded, his voice softened. "Why would you sign up for tournament where you are clearly outmatched and steamrolled without any magic?"

"*I will take my chances,*" Theron declared, his resolve unwavering.

Ferris, unable to suppress his laughter any longer, chortled loudly. "The freak has issued a challenge to defeat me in this tournament and pledged to depart the valley if he fails," Ferris proclaimed delightfully, relishing the thought of Theron's impending exile from his beloved hometown.

The valet looked at Theron with a mixture of pity and disbelief. "Not only have you chosen to compete against individuals with far greater power, but you have chosen to challenge the most powerful one of them all! Are you right in your mind, boy?"

Theron's eyes narrowed. "As a citizen of the Sukran kingdom, I am within my rights to participate in this tournament."

The valet, shaking his head at Theron's presumed idiocy, gestured for him to stand aside from the ranks of elementalists.

"So be it then if you are interested in getting humiliated in front of the whole town." The valet shook his head again at the adamant fool before announcing the game's rules for the benefit of the participants once more.

"We have twenty-five contestants vying for victory. Each team will consist of five members, tasked with defending their golden flower totem while capturing the opposing team's. This competition will test your abilities, strategies, and teamwork to the utmost."

He continued, "Five commanders will be chosen to select the remaining members of their teams based on the abilities demonstrated by each of the contestants. Each commander may choose any individual they believe will bolster their team's strength."

The valet, his gaze sweeping over the assembled contestants, declared, "We require five commanders to lead each section, and team members should obey their leader's orders to the best of their ability. I call upon any contestants who aspire to the role of commander to step forward."

Theron, along with nine other contestants, boldly stepped forward. He understood that he needed to command a team to win this tournament. If he was relegated to play under another commander, he knew would be discarded as an undesired piece.

Hence, here lay his first challenge of the day. He had to become a team commander and choose individuals who would assist him in achieving victory, individuals who would rally behind him without dissent or ego about being led by a magicless freak.

The valet shook his head at Theron's decision to volunteer for a leadership role. "With ten vying for the role of commander," he announced, "we shall hold an archery competition to determine the five worthy leaders."

Heeding his command, soldiers planted a wooden target a half-mile from the center of the grounds. The archery target consisted of three concentric circles painted in three vibrant colors. The innermost circle, the smallest and most coveted, was painted black. Following the black circle was a green band twelve inches wide. Completing the target was the outermost red circle, twice the size of its green counterpart.

"We shall divide these ten aspiring commanders into two groups and pit the two members of each group against one another." The valet proclaimed.

"One person may fire three shots at the target while the other stands in the adjacent circle and tries to prevent the arrows from striking the target. The black circle is worth ten points, the green circle is for five points, and the red circle is two points. No one is permitted to manipulate the archery target while defending it from the archer. The archer with the most points after three attempts will be designated the group's commander."

He divided the ten aspiring commanders into pairs. Theron was paired with Balkin, a formidable air and metal caster.

The valet summoned the first pair. Gerrick and Galdrick marched up to the valet.

The valet handed Gerrick a coin. "Shuffle the coin with both hands closed. Keep the coin in either fist and present it to your competitor to identify the hand holding it."

Gerrick deftly shuffled the coin and extended both closed fists towards Galdrick. Galdrick, eyes narrowed, chose Gerrick's right hand and found the coin held within that hand. A smirk touched Galdrick's lips. "My earth elemental can easily sense the location of any metal coin extracted from the earth."

The air crackled with the amplified voices of the contestants, reaching the packed audience around the ground.

"Will you strike or shield?" the valet inquired, his gaze fixed on Galdrick.

"Shield," Galdrick decided, his voice firm.

Gerrick ambled towards the designated circle for the strikers. He looked around at the

circle which was equipped with an array of bows, arrows, and spears crafted from stone, metal, and wood. Meanwhile, Galdrick entered the adjacent circle to shield the archery target.

"Commence," the valet declared. "You have three opportunities to strike the target with your chosen weapon, earning as many points as possible for accuracy."

Gerrick, his brows furrowed in thought, selected a wooden bow and arrow. As he aimed his first shot, Galdrick grunted, summoning walls of stone from the earth just in front of the archery target, forming an impassable barrier that blocked Gerrick's view of the archery target.

Undeterred, Gerrick fired the arrow, encircling it with a condensed windstream conjured by his air elemental. He sharpened the windstream's edge as the arrow sped towards the target at a tremendous speed. The increased wind velocity assisted the arrow to penetrate past Galdrick's wall and, with a satisfying thud, the arrow pierced Galdrick's wall, plunged squarely within the black circle of the archery target.

A thunderous applause erupted from the enthralled audience.

Galdrick frowned and responded by constructing a multitude of walls, forming a formidable barricade in front of the archery target.

Gerrick, nimble-minded, fired his second arrow high into the air, guided by a windstream like the previous bout. With a flick of his wrist, he reversed the windstream surrounding the arrow, causing it to plummet towards the target. Guided by the unseen hand of wind, the arrow descended effortlessly over the towering walls, and plunged onto the black circle once more.

The audience whistled again in excitement.

Furious, Galdrick swore and redoubled his efforts, erecting numerous ten-foot walls mere inches from the target board. He ensured that Gerrick could not use his air elemental to adjust the arrow's trajectory midair by erecting barriers many feet taller than the target.

Left with limited options, Gerrick employed the same tactic as the first arrow. However, Galdrick, anticipating his move, had erected four walls immediately before the target.

Gerrick picked a metal arrow and aimed it directly at the target. He reinforced the air shield with a powerful windstream, honing its edges to razor sharpness.

With a thunderous roar, he released the arrow. It sliced through the first few walls with ease, but its momentum faltered as it struck the final wall. The windstream around the arrow soon lost its potency after plunging past three walls. With little sharpness around its edges, it barely pierced past the fourth one. However the sturdy wall deflected the arrow even as it lunge past with little momentum and struck the outermost red circle on the target board.

The crowd erupted in a frenzy of applause as the valet announced, ""

"Exchange places," The valet declared.

On the valet's order, Gerrick and Galdrick traded places. Galdrick recollected Gerrick's prodigious affinity with wood and hence, chose to pick a metal arrow over an wooden one, effectively negating Gerrick's wood magic. Galdrick drew back the bow, his earth-fueled strength allowing him to bend it to its limit.

Galdrick fired the arrow. It was a powerful shot, hurtling towards the target with unwavering determination. But just as it neared its mark, a sudden gust of wind materialized out of nowhere, sending the arrow veering off course from the target.

Frustration etched on his face, Galdrick discarded the bow and raised an iron spear. He retreated several steps towards the edge of the circle.

With a quick sprint and a powerful lunge at the last moment, he hurled the spear using the strength borrowed from his earth elemental. A gale of wind attempted to impede its path, but the spear, fueled by the earth's might, pierced through the wind stream and struck the target dead center. The force of the impact shattered the archery board to pieces.

The valet quickly ordered a replacement board to be brought forth.

Galdrick repeated his tactic with the next spear. This time, however, Gerrick, having anticipated his move, conjured a stronger windstream, effectively deflecting the spear away from the archery target.

"The victor of this group is Gerrick!" the valet announced above the roar of the crowd. He motioned for Gerrick to step apart from other contestants and then turned his attention to the next group.

The valet then beckoned the next group forward, wherein Belfit Makrant, a formidable elemental proficient in the manipulation of fire and wood, accompanied Ferris as they strolled toward the valet.

Everyone could feel the crowd brimming with excitement as their favorite contestant, Ferris, was called forth for the archery competition.

At the toss, Ferris employed his earth elemental abilities effortlessly to sense the coin nestled in Belfit's right palm. Ferris, his earth elemental aiding his perception, effortlessly identified the coin held in Belfit's right hand. Having correctly called the toss, he opted to shoot first.

Approaching the designated circle for archers, Ferris picked a stone arrow, meticulously honing its edges with his earth-casting prowess. Nocking the arrow on his own bow, he skillfully let it loose on the target. In response, Belfit unleashed molten fire in the direction of the arrow, yet Ferris promptly extinguished the flames by sucking the air around the fire with his air elemental. As a result, Ferris's arrow reached the target without encountering any hindrance and struck at the center.

The crowd erupted in applause, recognizing the brilliance of Ferris' strategy, a stark reminder that fire cannot exist without the very air it seeks to consume.

In the next bout, Belfit stubbornly attempted to erect a wall of earth before the archery board despite knowing about Ferris' prowess with earth magic. Desperate, he infused the wall with molten fire, hoping to deter Ferris. However, Ferris, with an effortless display of mastery over both earth and fire magic, effortlessly dissolved the wall and extinguished the flames. His arrow, unimpeded by Belfit's meager attempts, found its mark, striking the black circle on the archery board with unwavering precision.

With an arrogant smirk tilted towards Belfit, Ferris fired his next arrow.

However, Belfit changed his strategy and swiftly began constructing a dozen thin walls, outpacing Ferris's attempts to disintegrate them in time for his arrow's flight towards the target. Unable to demolish all the walls in time, the arrow pierced through a few of them until it barely pierced past the final wall with very little momentum.

Deflected from the center of the archery target by the last of the walls before the target,

the stone made arrow ultimately struck the green circle.

"*Twenty-five points to Ferris,*" the valet declared.

Ferris and Belfit traded positions, with Belfit's subsequent attempts to reach the target with his arrows proving futile against the formidable walls and blustery windstorms conjured by Ferris.

Joining Gerrick as the next team commander, Ferris watched as Baldrick and Crevis emerged victorious from their respective groups, solidifying their positions alongside him and Gerrick on the tournament roster as the commanders for their respective team

The valet called forth the final group, shaking his head at the seemingly foolhardy undertaking of Theron.

Theron and his adversary, Balkin, a formidable air elemental with modest fire-casting abilities, approached the valet. In the meantime, the crowd started booing on getting ahead of the game instead of wasting a useless archery bout with the magicless freak participating in it.

Realizing the mood of the crowd, the valet tried one last time to convince Theron to withdraw from the tournament, much less lead a team as a commander.

When Theron refused the offer to concede defeat, the valet shook his head at the stupidity of the magicless lad.

Amidst continual boos for conducting this round, the valet offered Theron a coin, but Theron stopped him with a raised hand. Theron reached down and scooped a handful of sand from the ground. Rising to his feet, he collected the coin with both hands filled with mounds of sand, his enigmatic behavior leaving the valet perplexed.

Theron concealed the silver coin within the sand pile, then shuffled his hands and extended both his clenched fists. Balkin attempted to detect the coin's location with his air magic, only to groan in realization as to why Theron had chosen to bury it in a sand pile.

By utilizing sand, Theron effectively prevented his opponent from detecting the coin with his air elemental, as air cannot penetrate the dense mound of sand surrounding the metal coin. Only earth casters possessed the ability to perceive what lay concealed beneath the soil.

"*Clever move, Freak,*" Balkin begrudgingly conceded. "Now I cannot detect the metal coin."

The valet, impressed by Theron's resourcefulness, remarked, "Perhaps you will not disgrace yourself or the competition after all."

Balkin chose his right hand, but Theron displayed the metal coin on his left.

"*I shall defend.*" Theron declared.

Balkin glared angrily at Theron. "What is the point, Freak? Your only option is to pray that I miss the target. My air casting will ensure you never strike any targets. My abilities are insulted by being forced to compete with you."

Several onlookers in the crowd echoed Balkin's sentiment, declaring it a waste of time to witness the inevitable humiliation of the magicless freak.

"I agree with you, Balkin." Ferris chuckled.

Theron's eyes narrowed. "Let's find out who walks the talk."

Balkin hissed once more before approaching the shooter's circle. The valet, filled with sympathy, stated, "I pity your condition, boy, but Balkin is right. Without magic, I cannot fathom how you could possibly defend against his arrows so far from the archery target."

The valet's gaze expressed empathy for what he conceived would be Theron's impending embarrassment.

"Sir," Theron replied respectfully, "elemental magic is not the strongest power in the realm. I appreciate your compassion."

With that, Theron approached the circle of defenders, unslinging the unmetal bow from his back and selecting a wooden arrow from the quiver placed within the circle. A wooden arrow with a metal tip flew quicker than one made of metal, yet the metal arrow penetrated the target more effectively.

Balkin scoffed as he saw Theron nocking an arrow in his bow. "*Are you daft, Freak?* I am the one shooting the target. You're supposed to be the one who's defending it."

A chorus of laughter and jeers erupted from the crowd, prompting the valet to shake his head in embarrassment.

"What do you expect from a fool who accepted a challenge from one of the town's most formidable elementalists?" Sergius' voice rang out, inciting further taunts directed at Theron.

Ignoring the jeers, Theron calmly stated, "I am aware of who the shooter is. Stop dawdling and get on with the game when you are ready."

Balkin, enraged by the magicless boy's defiance, resolved to teach him a lesson even before Ferris could get his opportunity later in the tournament.

Pointing his metal arrow at the target, Balkin fired it at the target. Using his air elemental, he created a massive windstream around the arrow to propel it toward the target faster.

Theron, with lightning-fast reflexes, launched his arrow after following the trajectory of Balkin's. With his arrow fired from an unmetal bow, it flew with tremendous speed and struck the tip of Balkin's arrow with such force that it deflected it away from the target.

A stunned silence descended upon the crowd as they witnessed the seemingly impossible feat of one archer intercepting another's arrow mid-flight. Even the previously skeptical valet erupted in raucous cheers.

The valet's laughter rang out as he realized that he had gravely underestimated Theron's abilities. Perhaps, the boy wasn't as deranged as everyone had assumed.

"*It must be a lucky shot.*" Balkin turned to stare in shock at Theron.

Theron shrugged his shoulders and calmly nocked another wooden arrow onto his bow.

Balkin growled and nocked a second metal arrow. Before releasing it, he erected a shield of air around it, sharpening its edges to razor-sharpness. Additionally, he utilized his light elemental abilities to bend the light around the arrow to veil them, turning it invisible with the hopes of concealing its location from the magicless frea.

With a sneer, Balkin taunted Theron, "You can only stop the arrow if you can see it. What will you do if it's veiled?"

Theron could not cast elementals, but since infancy, he possessed a unique ability to sense the presence of both magical and mundane objects in his surroundings. And over time, Cadmus had assisted him in honing his gift.

Expanding his senses, Theron sensed the precise location of the veiled arrow as it hurtled towards the target. After understanding the trajectory of Balkin's arrow, he released his arrow with

remarkable precision and penetrated the veil and deflected the invisible arrow away from the target once again..

The crowd fell silent on watching the veiled arrow suddenly appearing out of thin air and was even more astounded to find it veering off course from the archery target.

As one, the entire crowd roared with even greater fervor, witnessing an archery display unlike any they had ever seen. Despite lacking the elemental abilities of air and light that would have allowed one to detect the veiled arrow, the throng were surprised to find a magicless boy continuing to intercept veiled arrows with astonishing accuracy. The audience, baffled by the "freak's" prowess, could only marvel at his skill.

Balkin's jaw hung slack as he muttered in disbelief, "*By the Great Elements, how is this possible?*"

Glaring at Theron with a mixture of anger and frustration, he roared, "Try stopping this one!"

Anticipating the strategy that Balkin would come up next, Theron grabbed a wooden arrow and plunged it into the ground, coating it with sand. He then nocked the sand-coated arrow onto his bow.

Balkin, enraged by Theron's defiance so far, unleashed his final shot at the target. He encased the metal arrow within a swirling vortex of windstreams to as a formidable shield. He willed the air shield to be as dense as possible so that it could even stop a crashing boulder, let alone a slender wooden arrow. As before, he veiled the arrow using his light elemental and turned the arrow invisible.

Theron again detected the arrow's flight path and unleashed his sand-coated arrow. The arrow dipped in sand penetrated the air shield and disrupted the windstream. Like how the sand and earth stopped air from penetrating past the ground, the sand coated on the arrow's tip impeded Balkin's control over the windstream, causing him to lose control of his air casting momentarily. This brief lapse was enough for the windstream to become erratic, dragging the veiled arrow along with it and causing it to miss the target entirely.

The crowd went wild in disbelief and erupted in cheers, their enthusiasm resonating through the air. They had witnessed a captivating display of exceptional archery skills and unparalleled ingenuity.

The crowd was captivated by Theron's clever manipulation of seemingly opposing elements to counter Balkin's air magic. His innovative use of sand to send the wind spiraling out of control resonated with many onlookers, who were impressed by his ingenuity.

It was a well known fact that earth and sand were natural barriers against air, and the magicless freak had effectively exploited this fundamental principle of nature to neutralize Balkin's primary advantage.

The valet, overcome with excitement himself, raised his hand to silence the throng. "Young Theron has demonstrated remarkable archery skills. However, he must still strike the target to claim victory. Please switch positions."

Following the instructions, Theron and Balkin traded places, with Theron taking his position in the shooter's circle and nocking a wooden arrow from the quiver.

The crowd fell silent, their anticipation palpable.

Balkin yelled in rage, "I concede that you have some skill with the bow, but your decent performance before will be moot if you cannot hit the target."

Balkin created a massive windstorm in front of the target and fought to keep it in place by swirling the windstorm.

Balkin panted as he expended all his energy holding up a windstorm half-mile away from him. "Let's see if you can strike the target through my windstorm without magic."

Several spectators whistled in awe of the immense windstorm, far surpassing anything Ferris or Gerrick had managed. Unlike them, Theron lacked the ability to manipulate elementals and dispel the whirlwind. The crowd pondered how Theron would overcome this seemingly insurmountable obstacle without magic and strike the target.

For a full minute, Theron calmly observed the swirling vortex.

"I can keep this up all day!" Balkin yelled.

Ignoring Balkin's taunts, Theron focused on the swirling vortex, his gaze fixed on its right edge. He released his arrow toward the right-most border of the swirling windstorm, drawing jeers from the crowd who perceived it as a misfire. Undeterred, Theron swiftly nocked and launched two more arrows in rapid succession, unfazed to determine if the first arrow would get past the whirlwind and strike the target.

Three arrows were already airborne, hurtling towards the storm before even the first arrow reached the right most edge of the swirling windstream.

"Man, that was some horrible firing, if any!" Balkin squealed with delight at the arrows flying wide of the target.

But his expression changed to horror when the arrows got caught in the massive whirlwind that was rotating anti-clockwise direction, pulling the arrow at its edge along with it in a clockwise direction. The wooden arrow launched with the immense strength of the unmetal bow had enough energy to escape the grasp of the whirlwind and land dead center on the archery target. The remaining arrows followed the same trajectory and landed dead center on the target one after the other.

Theron turned without any fuss and headed toward Ferris and the other commanders.

A stunned silence descended upon the crowd, followed by a thunderous roar of applause. The spectators, who had moments ago ridiculed his supposed misfire, erupted in cheers, awestruck by the astonishing display of archery prowess.

The valet, his face beaming with excitement, had to raise his voice to be heard above the din. "*Behold our five commanders!*" he declared, gesturing towards the victorious archers. "They shall now select their teams for the competition."

CHAPTER 6

Talent meets Tenacity

I have no choice but to win the Wintersend Tournament to retain the honor of our prestigious House of Primus.

To win the tournament, whom do I need to team up with in the Wintersend Tournament in Ristan city? A talented participant or a smart one.

A talented participant might win moments in the game, but the smart one can win you the tournament.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

"Elissa," Count Marius's voice boomed, "it is an pleasure to have you join me for the tournament."

Elissa, accompanied by Adrian, entered the grandstand with a graceful air. "The honor is mine, My Lord," she responded, extending her hand to the count who gallantly kissed it.

The count gestured for Elissa to take the seat on his left, and she graciously complied and took the seat.

Adrian approached the count and saluted with a legion standard. "My Lord."

Count Marius returned the salute warmly. "Come, my boy. Take the seat on my right."

Adrian nodded and settled into the indicated seat.

Other high-ranking officers of the fortress escorted their ladies into the grandstand, which offered the finest vantage point of the entire tournament ground.

The count greeted them warmly and urged them to make themselves comfortable. A few maids entered, offering refreshments to the guests.

Marius noticed a slim, middle-aged man in a castle guard's uniform enter the stand.

"*Sir Chivalrous*, welcome to my fortress!" Marius rose from his seat to greet the commander of the valley.

Chivalrous smiled and greeted Marius with a legion salute.

Marius waved his hand dismissively. "Don't be overly formal, Chivalrous. You outrank me as the protector of this valley."

Chivalrous gazed uneasily at the illustrious count, once regarded as the greatest general of his age.

"While I may supersede you in rank, your stature surpasses mine," Chivalrous responded with charming diplomacy. "You will always be an inspiration, Sir Marius."

Following the Mayan War, Chivalrous was appointed commander of the newly constructed castle within the valley, strategically positioned to deter future Mayan incursions. He was named the guardian of the valley even before Marius was transferred to this border town as a count.

Though relegated to the role of count in this border town after Chivalrous' appointment as

the guardian of the valley, Chivalrous revered Marius's unwavering dedication to duty. Despite being asked to report to a less experienced soldier, Marius never allowed resentment to cloud his judgment, prioritizing the protection of the frontier from Mayan incursions.

The Mayan War shocked the entire kingdom with the huge price paid to end the war. The king convinced the senate to construct a new castle several miles away from the fortress in a mountainous valley better equipped to prevent Mayan assaults into Sukra.

The kingdom, still reeling from the devastating impacts of the Mayan War, found itself teetering on the precipice of heading towards an unavoidable civil war.

"Chivalrous, have you met Adrian, *my finest soldier*?" Marius inquired, indicating Adrian who rose to greet the valley's commander.

With a courteous nod and a slight smile, Chivalrous responded, "Indeed, I am acquainted with the *hero* of the Titus War."

"A pleasure to meet you again, Sir Adrian."

"The pleasure is mine, Commander," Adrian replied in kind.

"Please make yourself at home, Chivalrous." Marius gestured towards the chair beside Adrian, inviting Chivalrous to be seated. He then instructed his maids to serve refreshments to the valley commander.

Suddenly, Marius felt Elissa squirming uneasily on his left.

"Why do you appear fidgety, Elissa?" Marius inquired, his attention turning towards her.

Elissa chuckled sheepishly at her evident distress. "I am not sure if I belong among the finest of the fortress folks. Moreover, I am more anxious than usual as my nephew is competing in today's tournament."

Marius dismissed her concerns with a wave of his hand. "Nonsense. Your prompt healings are the reason many of the men under my command are still alive. Elissa, you have a remarkable ability to heal people."

Elissa lowered her head in respect and gratitude. "Thank you, My Lord."

"So, your nephew has finally overcome his shortcomings and is ready to compete?" Marius inquired.

Elissa's face paled as she whispered, "No, My Lord. He has not yet acquired any elementals."

The count's brows furrowed in surprise. "Yet he chose to compete against more powerful young men today?"

Adrian, sensing Elissa's discomfort, intervened to steer the conversation in a different direction. "My Lord, did I hear Centurion Barican right who was mentioning unusual activity near the Smoky Mountains?"

The count turned and regarded him with a leveled look. He glanced around the grandstand, observing the engaged conversations among the guests. Even Chivalrous was engrossed in a conversation with the fortress sergeant.

With a subtle gesture, Marius utilized his air elemental to create a private sound veil encompassing Adrian, Elissa, and himself to prevent anyone from eavesdropping them. Adrian raised an eyebrow, intrigued by the unexpected security measure taken by the Count.

"Indeed," Count Marius confirmed, his voice laced with intrigue. "We've received numerous reports, all painting the same unsettling picture: a bizarre creature roaming the Smoky Mountains, elusive and cunning enough to escape every attempt at capture. I've personally verified these claims with several trustworthy individuals, leaving little room for doubt."

Adrian's curiosity piqued. "A strange creature, you say? One never before documented in our history?"

A faint smile played on Marius's lips as he observed Adrian's furrowed brow. "Not entirely," he revealed, his voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "There's only been one other recorded sighting in our kingdom's history..." His voice trailed off, leaving Adrian hanging, anticipation building in the air. "We have confirmed sightings of a unicorn in the Smoky Mountains, close to the Mayan border."

Elissa, momentarily disengaged from the official discourse between the count and her brother, gasped at the mention of a unicorn. "A unicorn?" she echoed in disbelief.

"Indeed, my dear," the count acknowledged with a nod, his gaze shifting to Adrian's wide-eyed expression. "I gather from your expression that you understand the significance of the unicorn's arrival at this moment. And I presume you are aware of how unicorns have been revered throughout our history?"

Adrian, still lost in thought, nodded absentmindedly. "Something about the unicorn being the one who taught the Sukrans about elemental magic," he mumbled.

Marius nodded in agreement. "According to historical accounts, the unicorn aided our Sukran ancestors in their defense against the terror that drove them from their original homeland."

"And no unicorn has been sighted in living memory," Marius added, his voice solemn. "Given the unicorn's importance in our history, I am duty-bound as a royal servant of the crown to investigate this further."

"I tried dispatching numerous squads of skilled warriors adept in various elemental magic to seek the unicorn, but the majestic creature always seems to sense their presence and evade capture. It appears to be too elusive to observe firsthand, almost as if it's toying with these soldiers."

Marius stared at Adrian, his gaze unwavering. "I am too old to embark on such a wild goose chase, but as my most trusted and best soldier in my employ, I would like to entrust you with this mission of seeking out the unicorn after the Wintersend Festival."

Adrian contemplated for a moment before giving a curt nod. "I will do my best to track it down. I shall begin the day after tomorrow."

"Thank you for your service, Adrian," Marius said with a warm smile.

Marius shifted his attention to Elissa, who appeared paler than usual. "Are you alright, Elissa?"

Elissa tried to stifle the emotional maelstrom that erupted within her upon hearing about the unicorn. She offered the old count a forced smile and a nod. "Do you find the timing of the unicorn's arrival to be more than just a curious coincidence, given the current political climate?"

Marius gave her a knowing nod. "Indeed, I do. The appearance of the unicorn at this critical juncture portends significant change for Sukra."

"Since Prince Livian's demise at the hands of the Mayans, the lords have begun vying for the throne, with no clear successor in sight. King Primus has managed to maintain order for the oment, but I fear civil war may soon engulf our kingdom."

"Then I pray for Sukra's sake that Prince Dorian can convince the noble lords of his legitimacy and claim the throne," Elissa replied.

"It's all odds for Dorian to prove his mettle, for even the weakest of all noble lords possess far greater magical prowess than him." Marius shrugged.

Before Elissa could respond, the count's valet, Camvus Stanlake, interrupted their conversation. "My Lord, shall we commence the tournament?"

"Yes, Camvus, anytime you're ready."

The valet nodded and descended to the ground, where he rallied the other soldiers assisting him in organizing the competition. They arranged the participants in a single line. The valet announced the beginning of the tournament and spoke of its history.

He then invited each participant to showcase their abilities. As numerous young men demonstrated their impressive elemental prowess, the count was particularly impressed by Ferris' performance.

Turning to Adrian, Marius remarked, "This youngster, Ferris, possesses immense potential, but he seems a tad arrogant."

Adrian chuckled softly. "Most powerful young elementalists are, my Lord. But their arrogance often fades as they are exposed to the harsh realities of the world beyond the sheltered existence they were accustomed to in this valley."

"True. This youngster has much too much potential to be wasted by arrogance."

"Theron of Adrian-Hold!"

Theron calmly waited in the circle for a minute. The valet began questioning him and summoned a truth-seeker to conduct a truth-seeking test.

Elissa's heart ached at the jeers and catcalls hurled at her nephew by his detractors. The most hurtful, however, was the accusation of him being a bastard.

"Oh my God! I had no idea he endured such prejudice from his fellow townsmen," she murmured.

Adrian, sensing her distress, replied, "He has faced far worse."

Tears welled up in Elissa's eyes as she witnessed the harsh treatment of her nephew for something that was not his fault.

Count Marius's gaze softened as he observed the dersion hurled at Theron, "I feel sorry for the young man. In a society's structure that is founded upon elemental magic, he will be regarded less than a slave until he overcomes his limitations. It pains me to see decent people suffer, yet I doubt anyone in Sukra would even respect him as a human being."

Adrian countered, "Elemental power is not the sole measure of an individual's worth, My Lord."

Witnessing Theron lying blatantly to the truth-seeker, Count Marius sat upright and appeared enthusiastic. "Never before have I witnessed an ordinary citizen lie to a truth-seeker. Even most noble lords lack such ability."

At the apex of Sukran society resided the noble lords, individuals who wielded immense elemental magic and governed their own states. Only the king and his royal lineage stood above them, exercising dominion over the entire noble class.

Throughout the annals of memory, a self-serving ethos permeated the ranks of the Sukran nobility, with only a select few exceptions. Even Lord Titus, known for his placid demeanor and lack of ambition, displayed scant regard for the welfare of his subjects in the Lemurian Valley.

Infact, during his reign as the valley's ruler, Noble Lord Titus had never deigned to grace the border town with his presence. Power in Sukra held little to no regard for its subjects, and the populace had become accustomed to the disdainful gazes of their lords.

If the noble lords were corrupt, the king himself was a viper in human skin. Marius still felt the sting of betrayal as he recalled the darkest day of his life, the day his best friend, King Valerian Primus, had backstabbed him in the most callous manner imaginable.

"He's a clever one, that boy." Elissa's voice managed to pull him from the abyss of despair he felt for the common folk under his kingdom's yoke. "By ten, Theron was already devising ways to lie to a spirit caster like me, even learning to mask his emotions at times." A mischievous glint sparkled in her eyes as she spoke of proudly of Theron's wit. "I had to stay one step ahead just to keep him out of trouble."

The count's eyes widened in fascination upon learning of Theron's ability to outwit the valley's most formidable water and spirit elemental. "Intriguing...indeed, immensely intriguing," he murmured.

Elissa sensed Ferris' deep distaste for her nephew when she overheard him laughing and making fun of Theron.

"The freak has challenged me to defeat me in this tournament," Ferris declared boastfully, "and agreed to leave the valley should he fail to defeat me today."

"Oh, my dear." Elissa's voice shook with terror. "What has he gotten himself into this time?"

The count let out a long whistle. "These are insurmountable odds for your nephew," he remarked, "I cannot fathom how he could possibly overcome Ferris' prodigious magic."

Noticing the silence from Adrian, Elissa spun around in her seat, her gaze sharp as she hissed at Adrian. "You knew about this stupid challenge!"

Adrian responded with a solemn nod. "The news reached me through those with keen interest in the matter. And such fervor has gripped the populace over this challenge between Theron and Ferris that they have gathered in droves to witness it."

Indeed, a palpable excitement throbbed through the community as they thronged around the ground, eagerly anticipating the challenge between Theron and Ferris.

Elissa could feel the crowd eagerly awaiting her nephew to be defeated and banished from the valley

"Why did you not intervene and put a stop to this madness?" Elissa snapped at her brother

"Lissy," Adrian stated gently, "have some faith in the lad. You cannot shield him from every peril. He can only learn and grow through experience. Besides, he is an adult now, capable of making his own choices, and he must bear the consequences, whatever they may be."

Tears welled up in Elissa's eyes as she whispered, "Do you think...could he win?"

Adrian's response was measured. "While I see no apparent path for him to overcome the most powerful participant of the bunch, I trust that he wouldn't have gotten himself into this mess without a plan."

Count Marius interjected, his head shaking emphatically. "I fear your nephew stands no chance against Ferris in this challenge."

"My lord," Adrian replied with a shrug. "One should never discount an underdog in a fight!"

A knowing smile played on Marius' lips as he hoped to bait his best soldier into an emotionally driven wager. "Forgive my bluntness, but I believe your nephew hardly qualifies as an underdog in this scenario. After all, to be considered an underdog requires one to have a glimmer of hope for victory, however faint. I see none such in your nephew's case." He gestured towards Theron. "I would be delighted to be proven wrong, but I fail to discern any realistic path for him to overcome Ferris and claim this tournament."

Adrian's eyes narrowed. "I wager ten gold on my boy's victory," he declared.

"Ten gold it is," Marius accepted the wager with a smug grin, hoping to use this opportunity to instill a valuable lesson in his most trusted soldier: to temper emotion with reason and never let the heart to rule one's mind.

As the valet completed the commander's selection for each squad, the count's eyes widened in admiration. "Adrian," he exclaimed, "your nephew possesses remarkable talent with a bow. I daresay he might even rival your own skills!"

Adrian exuded admiration for his ward's performance. "He's always been skilled with a bow. However, I doubt he could match my archery abilities augmented by my elemental magic."

Despite this disparity, Adrian conceded with a smile, "He is a natural with a bow."

As murmurs and catcalls subsided following the archery competition, the valet summoned the five commanders.

He arranged the young men based on their final scores in the archery competition, with Theron leading the pack with three hits, followed by Ferris and Gerrick with two each. Baldrick and Crevis brought up the rear in terms of points accumulated.

"There will be four rounds," the valet announced, "and each commander may choose one participant for each round. They may select any style of caster they feel would assist them in winning the tournament."

Count Marius murmured to Adrian, "Your nephew has an excellent chance of securing the best elemental casters among the remaining twenty. This may even tip the scales in his favor when he faces Ferris in the challenge."

"Let's begin with Theron of Adrian-Hold," the valet declared, gesturing for Theron to start selecting the first member of his team.

"I choose Pepwick Canticus," Theron announced.

Theron's selection of Pepwick as his first teammate was met with a cacophony of unimpressed murmurs and catcalls from the spectators. Pepwick's lackluster demonstration of his abilities had failed to convince the crowd of his worth, many in the crowd deeming Pepwick unworthy of being the chosen as first member in the team when more powerful contestants were available for selection.

Even Pepwick, after his lackluster performance, was surprised to be chosen as the first member of a team. He had braced himself to be one of the last picks, expecting his hodgepodge performance to deter potential commanders until the last round.

The valet seemed surprised by the selection. "Are you sure, boy? Do you realize you have the option to choose any participant? You have a golden opportunity to select the finest of the remaining twenty men. It could aid you greatly in your fight with Ferris and increase your chances of winning the challenge."

Ferris, bristling with dissent, attempted to interrupt the valet's offer of guidance to Theron. However, Theron, resolute in his decision, declined the assistance. "While I appreciate your counsel, Sir Camvus, I firmly believe that Pepwick will be an integral member of my team and instrumental in securing our victory in this tournament."

Shaking his head in slight disbelief, the valet signaled for Pepwick to join Theron.

Count Marius shook his head, unimpressed by Theron's selection. "Perhaps he doesn't want team members who are more powerful than him."

Adrian offered a rueful smile. "Even Pepwick is more powerful than Theron in elemental casting. But I, too, fail to understand the rationale behind this choice."

"Briar Delvan," Ferris declared, selecting his best friend, who joined him with a smile.

"Belfit Makrant," Gerrick followed, choosing the archery contestant that Ferris had defeated. Belfit headed over to Gerrick and offered a curt grin at Ferris, his expression suggesting that he would have his revenge against Ferris for trouncing him in the archery competition.

Baldrick, an earth caster, selected Balkin, the air caster defeated by Theron. Theron disregarded Balkin's menacing gesture toward him.

Crevis picked a fire caster. "Marin Luthas."

The valet signaled to Theron to begin the second round of selections.

"Schultz Gomez," Theron announced, choosing his friend with weak air and fire casting abilities.

Once again, the crowd erupted in jeers and boos, baffled by Theron's choice to include another mediocre caster on his team when he had the chance to pick the best of all the fire casting contestants.

Schultz smiled warmly at Theron, and they bumped fists in a friendly gesture. The valet

shook his head in disapproval at the magicless boy's seemingly foolish choice.

Ferris couldn't help but contain himself from laughing out aloud. "Freak, your poor choices have only served to demonstrate your stupidity."

Ferris then smirked and announced, "I choose Veritan Balward, the fire caster."

Gerrick picked Nemus Klewick, a formidable fire caster renowned for his ability to conceal himself under a veil. Baldrick chose Melvin Balatics, a fire-based caster, while Crevis selected Goylin, a decent metal caster with meager fire casting abilities.

Theron declared, "I select Kelvin Nemaris," choosing the finest swordsman of the lot, despite his minimal metal-casting skills. While Kelvin's swordsmanship was superior to many, Kelvin's lack of advanced metal-casting abilities made him less desirable than other metal casters.

Ferris responded by selecting Neville Navartus, a strong metal caster with moderate earth and fire casting abilities. Gerrick, Balkin, and Crevis followed suit, choosing metal casters for their teams.

Only four water casters and one mediocre earth caster remained unselected for the last round. Crevis grumbled in frustration, *"I won't be able to choose a water caster since they will all be picked by the time I make my selection."*

Ferris chuckled at Crevis' predicament. "You deserve it for scoring the least points among all of us commanders."

The valet instructed Theron to pick his final teammate.

"Belarian Veradin," Theron declared, *choosing the earth caster over the water casters.*

The valet shook his head in disbelief, perplexed by Theron's choices. Theron could have chosen the water caster with the most potent healing abilities, but once again, the odd young man had defied logic and conventional wisdom.

Many in the crowd jeered at Theron's selection, none more vociferous than Sergius. "If there is one team that desperately needs water elementals to heal their injured, it is your team, freak! And yet, you haven't chosen a single one, leaving your teammates to fall like dominoes when injuries inevitably strike"

Ferris laughed more and yelled with glee. "I knew you were a fool, Freak! But I never imagined you would be a crow-begotten fool. Your foolish decisions have paved the way for me to claim the most powerful water caster of them all. I choose Gerad Gatter!"

The remaining commanders swiftly picked the remaining water casters, leaving Theron's squad as the only one with an unconventional composition.

Unlike the others, Theron's ragtag group comprised two mediocre earth casters, a single air caster, a single metal caster, and himself, a commander without any elemental magic. In stark contrast, every other team boasted at least one caster for each element.

The valet instructed the teams to choose their designated sections from the five available options.

Theron opted for the gray wolf section opposite the grandstand, which offered an unobstructed view of the other four sections.

Aiming to impress Count Marius with his talent in the tournament, Ferris selected the bear section that was located in close proximity to the grandstand and farthest from Theron's section to

his right. Gerrick, seeking a strategic middle ground, chose the silver horse section nestled between Ferris' and Theron's. Baldrick opted for the black panther section opposite the bear section, while Crevis claimed the remaining silver horse section opposite Gerrick.

Theron began meticulously evaluating the relative strengths and weaknesses of each team. Ferris' white bear team boasted the most powerful fire, earth, metal, and water casters, along with Ferris himself, a formidable elemental caster proficient in air, wood, light, earth, and possessing strong metal and fire-casting abilities.

Gerrick's golden lion squad, while lacking the sheer power of Ferris' team, offered a balanced combination of air, earth, fire, water, and metal elementals, further bolstered by Gerrick's exceptional air and wood casting abilities.

Baldrick's crew, however, lacked diversity, relying heavily on two metal casters and one each of fire, water, and earth. Notably, they lacked any air-based caster, a potentially significant disadvantage.

Crevis' squad, unfortunately, stood as the weakest of the four opponents. Comprised primarily of a few sturdy casters, their strategy relied heavily on Crevis' fire magic supported by a single, powerful earth caster. While they possessed an average assortment of water, air, and metal casters, it seemed unlikely to be enough to compete against the stronger teams.

With a booming voice, the valet declared, "Each team may now enter their designated sections and begin formulating their strategy. The game will commence in fifteen minutes!"

"*Ready to part with your gold yet, Adrian?*" Count Marius smirked, his amusement evident.

"The match hasn't even begun," Adrian countered, refusing to be drawn into Marius' taunting.

Count Marius chuckled at Adrian's expense. "Your nephew chose the weakest team imaginable, despite having the opportunity to select the best."

Adrian's eyes narrowed, his gaze thoughtful. "While I confess I cannot fathom the logic behind his choices, I know the boy well enough to understand there must be a reason behind his unorthodox team selection."

Count Marius let out a booming laugh. "Hope for the best, then, Adrian. We shall soon see who has the last laugh."

"This plan... it makes no sense," Belarian, the earth caster, paced within their grey wolf section, his voice laced with apprehension. "It seems like a waste of effort. Are you certain you wish to proceed with this plan?"

Theron met his gaze steadily. "We will be targeted first by all the other teams. To survive, we must utilize our elemental abilities creatively. We may lack the raw power of the other teams,

but we possess subtleties that they lack."

Kevin, the metal caster, raised an eyebrow. "Do you truly believe the other teams will be so easily swayed by this... insane plan?"

Theron nodded, his confidence unwavering. "It depends on how well we execute it."

Pepwick, the earth caster, voiced his concern. "With this strategy, we will spend most of our time defending rather than attacking. How do we then expect to win the flower totems from the other teams?"

Belarian echoed Pepwick's sentiment. "Indeed. We will be unable to defeat other teams and claim their golden flowers with our defensive approach."

"Leave that part to me," Theron reassured his teammates, but they remain skeptical.

He summarized the plan once more. "As we gather more flowers, everyone will swarm to us. Once we obtain the golden flowers from the other teams, our defense must be the best."

He assigned roles to each member of his team. "Schultz and Belarian, your roles are the most crucial to this plan. You will be exempt from defending the walls, focusing your energy elsewhere. Kevin, Pepwick, and I will hold the initial line of defense."

Kevin and Pepwick nodded, acknowledging their assigned roles and responsibility.

Theron continued, outlining the specific tasks for each participant. "As soon as the game begins, Belarian, you will be responsible for reinforcing the front wall, while Schultz will provide air cover. Pepwick, your primary focus will be guarding the golden flower totem. Additionally, you must use the water from the pool within our section to saturate the land surrounding our walls."

Theron offered a fleeting glance at the resources setup in each section to augment the contestants' magic.

Trumpets rang forth, heralding the start of the tournament.

"*Begin!*" the valet roared.

Each team sprang into action, hastily erecting their defenses. Ferris, utilizing his formidable earth magic, pulled stones from the ground and fashioned them into a formidable thirty-foot-tall, four-foot-thick wall surrounding his section. The spectators erupted in applause as they witnessed the white bear team's impressive display of earth magic mastery.

Gerrick's golden lion squad constructed a twenty-foot wall, adorned with menacing spikes of sharpened wooden spears sticking from the walls. Baldrick and Galvin's crews managed to raise ten-foot walls each.

In contrast, the wolf team struggled to construct even a five-foot wall. Belarian, their earth caster, appeared exhausted and panting already from the effort required to construct a meager structure more akin to a fence than a formidable wall. The spectators jeered and mocked their lackluster effort of the grey wolf team.

Undeterred by the united scorn from the townsmen, Pepwick, using his earth elemental, constructed pathways from the pool, allowing the water to surround the entire wolf section and sodden the ground in front of their walls. But the crude pathways he created managed to barely sodden the ground with the water.

When the wolf team failed to sodden the ground surrounding their section effectively, the spectators started catcalling the wolf team. While the idea of forcing any attacking team to tread

slowly on the sodden ground was clever, the execution of their strategy left much to be desired.

Given the limited water supply within the pools of each team's section, no other team attempted to waste their resources. The sodden ground around the wolf section would scarcely deter their foes from charging the walls. It might only slow them down.

Furthermore, this tactic did not account for opponents who might choose to assault from the air instead of charging on the ground.

The audience frowned at the strategy employed by the Wolf team to squander their water resource. Perhaps they were willing to squander their precious water on this dubious plan because they lacked a water caster to heal their wounded. And after their dubious strategy, the Wolf team had no more water to even use for healing, wasting all the water in the pool setup in their section.

Kelvin leaped over the wall and drew his sword from its sheath. "Let's see whether you're right." He nodded to Theron, who stood poised with his bow behind the makeshift barrier.

Theron surveyed the make-shift arena, meticulously assessing the defenses of his opponents. He noticed most of the teams stationed their earth and water casters within the walls, while the remaining members positioned themselves outside. A tense silence descended upon the arena as each team exchanged glances with the other teams.

"Anytime now," Theron said, as an uneasy silence covered the ground, similar to the calm one usually experienced before the storm.

"Are you ready, Pepwick?" Theron inquired, his voice betraying a hint of nervousness. Pepwick met his gaze with a resolute nod.

All teams, with the exception of the Black Panthers, charged towards the wolf section, eager to claim the flower totem from the team they perceived as the weakest opponent of all.

"*Bloody Elementals!* You were right, Theron!" Kelvin exclaimed.

Theron nodded. "Kelvin, as the game progresses, we'll need you on defense. So, don't get killed and eliminated from the game on the first assault itself."

Pepwick interjected, his voice laced with concern. "But we lack both water and a water caster to heal him if he sustains injuries."

Theron remained calm, a determined glint in his eyes. "If he receives a crippling blow, it will be my responsibility to bring him back into the game."

"How can you..." Pepwick's voice faltered as the approaching horde of opponents drew closer, their numbers overwhelming.

Kelvin grunted, a hint of doubt creeping into his voice. "Foolish of me to join this plan. *One against fifteen...* is hardly a fair fight."

"*Life is never a fair fight,*" Theron replied, a steely look in his eye.

Count Marius let out a despondent sigh. "The weak always suffer. The strong see the weakest as easy pickings, prey upon them, and strip them of everything they desire."

He was greeted by tense silence from both Adrian and Elissa.

"I pity the wolf team!" Marius gestured towards the teams converging upon Theron's wolf team, each eager to acquire an additional flower with minimal effort and get ahead of other powerful opponents in the tally of the flower count.

"*Oh my goodness!* They will be *obliterated!*" exclaimed Elissa, witnessing the combined assault of other teams on the wolf team.

The sergeant seated in front of them chimed in, "My Lady, they will be shattered to dust. Even the most powerful elementalists cannot withstand such a multitude of foes simultaneously."

Marius nodded grimly. "Indeed, though it pains me to say it, it seems Adrian will be parting with his gold much sooner than anticipated."

Adrian remained silent, intently observing the wolf team's response to the surprise allied onslaught from all the other teams.

The wolf team's metal caster fearlessly charged the advancing swarm of formidable casters. He engaged the earth casters on the front line, who attempted to overwhelm him with brute force. Kevin dodged a punch from one earth caster and delivered a lethal blow to the chest of another belonging to Crevis' team.

The earth caster crumpled to the ground, his armor frozen and rendering him immobile.

Crevis roared in anguish at the sight of his teammate getting eliminated in the first battle against the weaklings. Consumed by rage, he drew power from the earth and swung his hand at Kelvin's chest.

Kelvin spotted the incoming punch from Crevis, but instead of dodging, he twisted his body to the side and received a bone-jarring blow to his shoulder that sent him crashing against the wall. Kelvin's armor froze as he fell, the impact debilitating him. He would be unable to participate in the game until healed by a water caster. But his squad lacked a water caster who could heal him and bring him back into the game.

"Theron," he muttered, "I will kill you if this game does not go as planned..."

"*Pepwick, give me the flower totem!*" Theron yelled, terrified of the swarm of incoming opponents. All the gathered townspeople heard his voice as each participant's voice was sound cast to enrich the experience for the spectators.

Pepwick promptly retrieved the golden flower totem and presented it to Theron, who swiftly fastened it to an arrow using a thin rope. He aimed for the farthest point on the ground beyond the swarm of incoming opponents.

He fired the arrow against the walls of the golden lion team. The opponents storming toward the wolf team's wall were taken aback by Theron's cowardly deed of tossing away his golden flower totem to protect his hide.

The crowd jeered at the "cowardly" act of the magicless freak.

Ferris halted and glanced at Theron even as the other contestants retreated to the walls of Gerrick's golden lion team.

"*Coward!*" Ferris snarled at his foe before turning and soaring toward the other players, who had taken the lead.

Gerrick, outpacing his competitors, reached the arrow first. With a masterful display of air magic, he plucked the flower from the ground and tossed it over his team's wall, where it landed

within their defenses.

The arrow thudded to the ground within the Golden Lion team's fortified perimeter. Gerrick's team's water and earth casters, perched atop the wall, momentarily cast their gaze upon the precious golden flower totem before refocusing their efforts on aiding their teammates in safeguarding their fortune from the relentless attacks of their adversaries.

Gerrick landed scant feet from his team's fortified walls, turning to defend them from the very individuals with whom he had forged a fleeting alliance to assault the Wolf team. As his teammates joined him, a smile bloomed across his face. It seemed the Lucky Maiden had smiled at him today by bestowing upon him an additional flower as a gift borne from the cowardice of the magicless freak.

Crevis sent his metal caster to guard his silver horse section before venturing alone to assist Ferris' team in acquiring two golden flowers from Gerrick's squad. He knew he was no match for a formidable opponent like Gerrick, so he hoped to ally himself with Ferris and help him secure victory.

Crevis decided to worry about Ferris after Gerrick was defeated; after all, it was the norm for any alliance in a battle to be fickle in nature. Enemies became friends, and friends became enemies in an instant.

Meanwhile, Ferris launched a fierce assault against the lion team, utilizing his formidable air, fire, and earth elementals in hopes of capturing both Theron's and Gerrick's flowers and securing an unassailable lead in the count of flowers possessed by a team. He basked in the unwitting assistance rendered to him by the magicless freak to claim victory by defeating only one opponent in the game and win the tournament.

"*It's genius!*" exclaimed the count, leaping to his feet and applauding. "I never saw that coming!" Truth be told, Marius had not expected the wolf team to survive the assault.

The centurion seated in front of him scoffed. "*My Lord, that's cowardice, not genius.* Theron surrendered the flower he was entrusted to protect. No true soldier abandons his duty!"

Elissa stepped in before the count could respond. "No, it's brilliant because Theron saved his team from annihilation while pitting his two strongest opponents against each other."

Adrian picked up where Elissa left off., "With this tactic, Theron retains his ability to participate in the game and reclaim his team's flower from the victor of the two strongest opponents."

Marius burst out laughing, gazing at Elissa and Adrian. "Now I understand where the boy gets his cleverness from."

Sergius, standing amongst the crowd near the gambler tents, jeered alongside the others. Despite Theron's earlier prowess with the bow, his cowardly act had solidified his position as the

least favored to win.

"Did I not tell you?" Sergius sneered, reveling in Theron's lackluster performance so far. "The magicless freak is not only stupid, but a coward as well!"

"A coward will always be a coward, even when surrounded by strong men. However, the foolish magicless freak has surrounded himself with weaklings," sneered Sergius, echoing the growing disdain in the crowd for Theron's cowardice to put up even a decent fight.

Belan, another Lemurian townsman, chimed in, "What else can we expect from the freak but cowardice?"

Cadmus, ever vigilant, observed the unfolding events and recognized the mob's shifting perception of Theron after throwing his team's golden flower in cowardice. He had been keeping a close watch on Sergius, whose vitriol towards Theron had been festering since the tournament began.

With a swift movement, Cadmus drew a bag from his cloak and, transforming himself into an excited fool, dashed towards the gamblers' tent. On his way, he collided with Sergius, sending the toxic farmhand sprawling to the ground.

"Fool!" Sergius snarled, struggling to his feet. "What's wrong with you? You've ruined my clothes!" He lunged menacingly at Cadmus.

But Cadmus, still clutching the bag to his chest, babbled nonsense and made exaggerated gestures. Soon, a crowd had gathered around them, drawn by the commotion. Sergius noticed the coin sack in Cadmus' hand. A tiny smirk slithered from his lips as he realized the task assigned to the blacksmith fool.

"Fool, where did you steal so many coins?" Sergius roared, lunging to grab the coin the bag.

Cadmus clutched the bag close to his chest, mumbling, "*Cadmus...no...steal...Theron...gave...gamble...*"

Sergius burst into laughter, joined by the others. "So, the coward was prepared to gamble his wealth! *Has he fixed the tournament with opposing teams?*"

This accusation drew gasps and murmurs from the gathered crowd.

"*No...Theron...betting...on...himself...*" Cadmus croaked out.

Sergius bellowed with laughter. "The coward couldn't even last a minute in the game and threw away his flower to save his skin. Does he honestly believe he has even a chance of winning?"

The crowd murmured in agreement, further solidifying their negative perception of Theron's prospects.

"How much is he betting on himself?" Sergius grasped Cadmus tightly, preventing the blacksmith fool from leaving.

Feigning struggle initially, Cadmus eventually relented. "*Two...thousand...gold...coins,*" he stuttered.

At once, Sergius snatched the coin sack from Cadmus's grasp. With a flick of his wrist, he untied the drawstring and peered inside, his eyes gleaming with delight.

The sight that greeted him was a treasure trove of gold coins, their surfaces catching the

evening sun and reflecting its light in a dazzling display. Sergius whistled softly, mesmerized by the sheer wealth contained within the sack.

He reached in and was about to retrieve one of the coins, when Cadmus fueled by a surge of defiance, slammed into him and wrestled the sack of coins back. The sudden scuffle caused one of the golden treasures to slip free, tumbling to the ground at Sergius's feet.

Intrigued, Sergius bent down and picked it up, examining it closely. It bore an uncanny resemblance to the very coin he had handed to Theron earlier that day.

With a swift hand, Cadmus snatched the coin from Sergius's grasp and tucked it back into the sack, tightening its drawstring with a decisive tug. He tightly clutched the bag close to his chest, as if it were a priceless treasure that he was tasked to be guarded from thieves.

"Coward, I'm curious where Theron acquired so many gold coins," Sergius asked, a wicked plan forming on his mind.

Belan approached Sergius and peered at the bag greedily. "Adrian must have lent the money to the magicless freak. These are probably the same coins Lord Titus awarded Adrian for his bravery during the Titus war in addition to be proclaimed as the war hero."

"Yes," Sergius sneered, his plan solidifying. He would exact his revenge on Theron for the earlier insult and reclaim his coin. And if he could take all of Adrian's wealth in the process, all the better. Perhaps it was time to teach Adrian a lesson for treating him the same as the other dimwitted farmhands.

"This...is....master's...." Cadmus stuttered once more and clutched the sack tighter, his grip a desperate attempt to shield its contents from Sergius's avaricious gaze. However Sergius inferred Cadmus' action as an affront to his honor.

"*We are not thieves, you fool,*" Sergius hissed at the foolish blacksmith. "I wouldn't steal from you or your naive master."

People surrounding Sergius nodded in agreement.

Cadmus, shooting Sergius a venomous look, headed into the gamblers' tent to place a wager on Theron winning the tournament.

Sergius watched him go, an evil plan surfacing in his mind. He would have his revenge on the freak for duping him earlier in the day. And with the help of the townsfolk, he would ensure that the freak was banished from the valley after stripping Theron of every penny in his possession.

"Fool, I would never steal hard-earned money," Sergius retorted at Cadmus' receding form. "But I can earn it by betting against Theron. The coins will come back to me anyway." he declared.

Cadmus returned from the gambler tent empty-handed, and when he passed Sergius, the old farmhand scoffed at him.

"Theron is foolish enough to force you to wager on his behalf, and you are even more foolish for revealing the amount he is wagering," Sergius mocked. "I shall sleep soundly tonight after acquiring some easy money."

Sergius turned to the others, a sly glint in his eyes. "What are we waiting for, friends? There is easy money to be made." Sergius rubbed his hands in glee as he approached the gamblers'

tent.

Sergius' words hung heavy in the air, igniting a spark of greed in the hearts of those around him. They envisioned easy riches, a chance to earn easy money by betting against against the town's freak.

Buoyed by the lackluster performance of Theron so far, it wasn't long before the first of the numerous townsfolk ventured into the gambler's tent, their pockets laden with coins and their hearts heavy with the desire to wager against Theron and strip the magicless freak of all his coins.

Sergius's lips stretched into a triumphant smirk as a single, vindictive thought consumed his mind. With the aid of his fellow townsfolk, he would not only secure his revenge upon Theron, but also deprive the magicless freak of all his possessions and banish him out of the town.

Theron and his squad watched passively from behind their walls as the fierce battle unfolded at the walls of the golden lion squad led by Gerrick.

Pepwick glanced at Kelvin lying motionless near their wall. "I guess it's time to move on to the next phase of the plan."

Theron frowned. "Yes, we must act immediately, but..." He trailed off, but when he spotted a green light ascend into the sky from the stands near the gambler's tent, a smile widened across his face.

"Let's begin!" Theron exclaimed to his comrades.

Theron slung his bow on his back, leaped over his team's wall, and charged towards the silver horse team. The metal caster tasked by Crevis of the silver horse team to secure his team's wall charged towards Theron, blade raised, aiming to defeat the "magicless freak" with a single blow.

The metal caster frowned as he saw Theron rushing towards him without even drawing his sword. He shook his head at the apparent foolishness of the magicless boy.

Theron, aware of the puzzled thoughts swirling within the charging metal caster's mind, saw his opponent's blade swing vertically towards his chest. He dodged the swing at the last moment, letting the blade pass harmlessly by his side. With all the force gathered during the charge, Theron swirled to his side and struck the armored chest of the imbalanced metal caster with his elbow.

Taking a fatal hit to his armored chest, the metal caster sank to the ground as his armor glowed red, signifying his elimination from the tournament. Theron didn't waste any time and continued advancing against the horse team's wall.

The earth caster atop the horse team's wall began raising several stone spears along Theron's path of assault. But Theron utilized his unique ability to sense elementals to learn about the locations where the spears were about to raise from the ground and he effortlessly evaded the spears. The earth caster was astonished to see Theron overcome all his defensive spears.

"Pepwick! Now!" Theron yelled as he neared the silver horse's team walls.

Pepwick crouched on the ground outside their flimsy five-foot wall and commanded his

earth elemental to raise a series of slender, cylinder-shaped stone towers in front of Theron, each one a foot taller than the last.

Theron used the towers like a stairway to gain altitude above the ground by leaping from one tower to the next. The earth caster safeguarding the horse team's wall attempted to dismantle the stone towers, but Pepwick, despite possessing inferior ability in earth magic, was quicker. Pepwick raised stone towers faster than the other team's earth caster could destroy them.

As Theron ascended the final towers near the wall, he drew a small metal dagger from his side belt and hurled it at the earth caster perched above the walls, not to inflict harm but to divert his attention.

Theron leaped atop the final stone tower, five feet from the horse team's wall, and utilized his speed and the tower's height to launch himself at the earth caster.

The earth magician was busy attempting to evade the dagger thrown at him by the freak and only managed to notice Theron's leaping at him at the last moment.

Before even the earth caster could yelp in surprise, Theron slammed into the earth caster's chest and knocked him off the top of the ten-foot wall. The earth caster landed on his back, his armor absorbing most of the impact but still leaving him winded and unconscious. The red-glowing armor signaled his elimination from the game.

Theron landed with his knee against the earth caster's stomach to cushion the shock of his fall, rolled onto the ground, and rose to his feet.

The water caster waiting within the horse team's wall stepped down to the ground from the top of the wall, his mouth wide, trying to save his friend from the freak. But realized he was too late and his earth caster teammate was eliminated from the game. "How did you accomplish this feat without magic?"

Theron unsheathed his blade and aimed it at the throat of the water caster, who raised his hands in surrender. Theron hissed, "Don't make me hurt you."

Fear gripped the water caster. "Take the golden flower," he stammered. "I will not stop you."

Theron grinned. "I did not come here for the golden flower alone. Please take the flower out of your vase."

Still perplexed by the weird request, the water caster complied. He pulled out the golden flower from the vase and handed it to Theron, who placed it in the empty scabbard tied to his back. He then retrieved his discarded dagger from the ground, the very weapon he had moments ago flung at the earth caster.

Theron instructed the water caster to approach the wall. The water caster threw Theron a confused expression. "These walls don't have any doors."

Theron yelled for his teammate to hear, "Pepwick, please open a door."

As if on cue, a section of the wall crumbled into dust, leaving a five-foot gap in the wall. Theron gestured for the water caster to step through.

On the other side, a grinning Pepwick awaited them. "You know what to do," Theron said to his teammate.

Pepwick nodded, and ventured into the silver horse's section. He returned after a minute

carrying a huge stone vase filled with water collected from the pool setup in the Silver horse's section. The audience realized that Pepwick had used his earth magic to create a stone vase.

Pepwick summoned a three-foot earth cast hand which collected the vase filled with water. Pepwick unsheathed his sword with the other hand, and pointed it at the frightened water caster. "*Don't dally here, mate. Let's go!*" he snarled, escorting the captive back to the Wolf team's section. The three-foot earth cast hand trailed behind him, all the while hoisting a stone vase filled with water.

The spectators erupted in cheers and astonishment at the sudden display of prowess from the so-called "cowardly" team.

Crevis, bewildered by the unexpected reaction of the crowd, turned to check on his team. He let out a cry of shock and despair as he saw a gaping five-foot hole in his team's walls. Through the opening, he noticed Pepwick stepping out of his team's section and started escorting his captured water-caster teammate back to the Wolf team's section at swordpoint. To his further horror, Crevis found his remaining teammates lying unconscious on the ground, their armor glowing red, signifying their elimination.

Infuriated by the sight, Crevis glared at the smirking Theron. With a bellowing roar, Crevis charged at the magicless boy. Unfazed, Theron stood his ground and drew a small, round disc tied to one of his scabbards, a temporary place to house his weapons with very few slots provided in the customized armor provided by the fortress soldiers for the tournament.

Theron slipped his forearm inside the straps attached to the disc and tapped its center with the flat part of his sword.

The circular disc instantly unfurled and expanded into a five-foot rectangular shield crafted from the same unmetal as his swords. The astonished crowd murmured in amazement at this unexpected display of metal manipulation, transforming a small disc into a full-fledged shield, albeit a slender one.

Theron seemed to sense the question forming in everyone's mind: *Where did the magicless boy acquire such a remarkable shield?*

Crevis, consumed by fury at Theron's smug demeanor, stopped fifty yards away. "Do you think your puny shield can withstand my molten fire?" he roared, channeling the fire energy he had absorbed from the multitude of fire pits set up in his vicinity. He clenched his fists furiously and siphoned every single drop of fire from all the nearby pit. He unleashed a wave of molten fire towards Theron.

Theron calmly knelt on one knee and thrust his shield forward, sliding to the ground and taking cover behind the unmetal shield.***

Elissa sprang from her seat, a gasp escaping her lips as she witnessed the inferno engulfing Theron.

"*Adrian!*" she cried, her voice laced with desperation, "He is going to be roasted alive by so much of fire!"

Adrian, his face taut with conflict, remained seated. He knew interfering to save his

nephew would disqualify Theron. "Lissy," he urged, his voice firm, "have faith in the boy!"

Elissa, heedless of his plea, moved to summon her air elemental to shield her nephew. But Adrian sprang up and stopped her.

"Remember your oath," he reminded her, his voice tinged with a hint of exasperation. "You swore not to aid Theron until he seeks your assistance."

"But--"

"Lissy, have trust in the boy!"

Tears streamed down Elissa's face as she watched the flames engulf her boy. She bit her lips, struggling to control her protective instincts to not intervene. A collective gasp swept through the crowd as they witnessed the horrifying scene. But just as hope seemed lost, the flames subsided, revealing Theron rising to his feet unharmed by the molten fear.

Count Marius was perplexed. "He deflected the molten flames with that... that shield? *How is this possible?* The shield should have been melted by the molten flame."

Elissa, overcome with relief, finally allowed herself to exude a breath she hadn't realized she was holding. Her nephew was safe. Safe for the moment at least!

Crevis' jaw dropped in disbelief as he saw Theron remaining unscathed from the inferno.

With a flourish, Theron rose to his feet and tapped the center of his shield with his sword. In a mesmerizing display, the shield contracted into a small circular disk that fit neatly in his hand.

"How could a mere metal shield extinguish my raging inferno?" Crevis stammered, his voice trembling with disbelief and fury.

Theron shrugged nonchalantly, a smirk playing on his lips. "Mere? This shield is far from it." He secured the unmetal disc between the scabbards on his back and drew the other sheathed sword in a swift motion.

A moment of silence hung heavy in the air before Theron continued, his voice laced with a hint of pride. "My arsenal of weapons and this exceptional shield are the product of years of tireless research, arduous labor, and the invaluable assistance of kind-hearted friends who, surprisingly, still reside in this town known for its avarice."

Theron knew he was profoundly indebted to his master, the skilled master-craftsman who forged such exceptional weapons. He was certain that without Cadmus's aid, his arsenal would be far less formidable. Indeed, even a master craftsman like Cadmus had poured countless hours into perfecting the shield that could fold and unfold at will. Cadmus used his extraordinary metal-casting skills to fold the unmetal into a circular disc that could unfold into a full-fledged legion shield, capable of repelling not only mundane weapons but also magic.

This unmetal was no ordinary metal. It was a rare ore, when blended with equal parts of all the primary elements, rendered the forged weapon impervious to any of those elements.

Noticing Theron charging towards him, Crevis desperately attempted to conjure more flames. However, he had exhausted the entire fire pits near his vicinity in their first encounter itself. He berated himself for letting his rage rule over his mind and consume all the fire from the

nearby fire pits, leaving him none to fall upon now. With the evening sunlights's warmth as his only source of fire, he managed to muster only weak, pathetic fireballs which he hurled at the charging Theron.

Theron effortlessly evaded these feeble fireballs and continued to advance on Crevis.

Realizing he needed more time to build a powerful stream of fire from the air warmed by the evening sunlight, Crevis drew his blade, preparing to engage Theron in a desperate duel.

As they neared each other, Theron sheathed one of his swords, drawing applause from the crowd. The crowd applauded Theron for choosing to fight on equal footing with Crevis, who wielded only one blade and possessed no shield to protect himself.

Crevis, his frustration boiling over at the freak granting him a leeway, swung his sword clumsily at Theron. But Theron, with lightning-fast reflexes, swayed out of the swing and moved in for the kill. With a swift thrust, Theron smashed the pommel of his sword into Crevis' armor with sufficient power to qualify as a fatal blow.

Crevis crumpled to the ground, his armor turning red, signifying his elimination from the tournament.

Theron, his gaze surveying the battlefield, spotted Pepwick dragging the water caster towards their wall.

"Pepwick!" he called out, "make sure our prisoner heals Kelvin immediately!"

Pepwick grinned and nodded eagerly, his sword held firmly against the water caster's throat while he escorted the healer to the limp form of their team's metal casting swordsman - Kelvin.

"Heal him!" Pepwick commanded, pointing at Kelvin who lay still on the ground. Though unharmed, Kelvin's armor had tightened after sustaining an incapacitating blow, immobilizing him. The armor was specifically designed to be used for the tournament, letting itself to be healed by water casters in the same way they healed people.

Pepwick grabbed the vase of water from his earth-cast hand and offered it to the water caster. "Use this vase of water to heal him," he instructed.

Taking the vase, the water caster began spraying the water on Kelvin's armor. Though unfamiliar with healing an armor before, he hesitantly drew upon his combined water and spirit elemental magic. Initially, he struggled, having never attempted to heal armor before. After a moment of struggle, he grasped the concept of the armor mimicking a human torso and, within seconds, managed to restore its functionality with his healing magic.

After his lengthy confinement, Kelvin rose to his feet, flexing his muscles in relief.

Pepwick, using his earth elemental, created a small doorway in their wall and urged the water caster inside. Once the prisoner was secured, Pepwick sealed the entrance, leaving the water caster trapped within.

Theron plunged his blade into the ground and retrieved the golden flower from the scabbard on his back. With practiced ease, he tied the flower to an arrow using a piece of rope from his pocket and drew his unmetal bow. With a powerful twang, he sent the arrow flying towards the ground in front of Kelvin's feet.

As soon as the arrow thudded into the ground in front of his feet, Kelvin retrieved the

arrow and gave Theron a sharp salute. Theron nodded with a wide grin. "Protect the flower," he said, his voice filled with a sense of purpose.

Count Marius erupted in laughter. "Now I understand why Theron chose not to pick a water caster on his team. Why waste a slot in your team for a water caster when you can capture one from your opponent and use them to heal your teammates? This frees up a slot for another caster with a different elemental ability, increasing your chances of victory."

"Indeed," Adrian agreed, his face beaming with pride,. "The boy has set a precedent that will change the way water casters are utilized in this game forever."

Theron watched the fierce battle between Ferris and Gerrick's teams. One member from each side had already been eliminated. Ferris' metal caster lay motionless beneath Gerrick's feet, who was now engaging Ferris in a duel between the game's two strongest contestants. Meanwhile, Briar, Ferris' best friend, hurled fireballs from afar, targeting the earth caster of Gerrick's team who stood atop their defensive wall.

Both teams were too involved in the battle to realize that one of their opponents had been defeated.

As the two strongest teams locked horns in a fierce clash and remained preoccupied with each other, Theron's gaze darted towards the lone outlier - the Black Panthers.

The black panthers preferred to observe and wait, while allowing the other teams to wear themselves down in battle. Their objective, it seemed clear, was to strike the final blow against the last, weary team standing, securing victory through strategic timing and minimal effort.

Theron, however, had other plans. He surged forward, charging directly towards the fortified section of the Panthers. Noticing Theron's charge towards their section, Balkin sprang from the ten-foot-tall wall alongside his two metal caster teammates and assumed guard positions on the ground. Above them, perched upon the wall, stood Balkin's water and earth caster teammates.

As Theron neared within a hundred feet of their wall, he unslung his bow and selected two white-feathered wooden arrows with blunt tips. He nocked both arrows simultaneously, each arrow held between two of his fingers at a distinct angle and drew the bowstring with practiced ease. "Pepwick!" he boomed.

Pepwick began constructing a series of stone towers, this time several hundred feet ahead of the Panthers' wall. Theron, with agile leaps, scaled the stone towers, using them as stairway to reach a higher altitude.

With a final push with his feet to gather strength for his leap, Theron launched himself towards into the air. He angled his bow slightly to the right and fired both the nocked arrows. The two arrows flew at different targets with tremendous speed, each aiming for one of the two

unsuspecting opponents perched atop the panther team's wall.

The arrows flew with such speed and precision that the unsuspecting water and earth casters perched atop the wall barely saw them coming.

The blunt tips of the arrows struck with force, knocking the casters over the edge. Their armor glowed red as they plummeted to the ground. Balkin, unaware of Theron's motives, roared in fury at the loss of two of his teammates.

Theron landed gracefully on the ground, his armored knee absorbing the impact.

The crowd erupted in a thunderous applause and whistles as they witnessed Theron's incredible feat of archery. Never had they seen such skill, such precision in launching two arrows simultaneously.

Elissa whistled in awe of her nephew. "Oh my gosh, I didn't even know that firing two arrows in a single shot was possible!"

Count Marius, equally enthralled, hooted and clapped his hands with delight. "Neither did I!" he exclaimed, thoroughly enjoying the unexpected tactics employed by the weakest team of the tournament.

Theron slung his bow over his back and drew his twin unmetal swords as he raced towards the panthers' section. As he neared Balkin and his remaining metal-wielding teammates, he slowed to a confident trot.

"Coward, you'll plead for your mother by the time I'm done with you today!" Balkin howled.

Theron stopped and offered a mischievous grin. "Who is the coward here, Balkin? I have accomplished more than you have since the game began. You have done nothing so far in the game except to cower behind your team's wall like a frightened child!"

With a roar, Balkin stormed forward at Theron, followed by his metal caster companions. They encircled Theron and began to pace around in a circle to make the freak anxious to battle three swordsmen at the same time.

"You made a mistake of coming here alone, freak. You should have brought the rest of your team to make this lopsided duel even a little bit fair against competent swordsmen like us!" Balkin hissed.

Theron looked around at the trio with a shrug. Their false bravado to project the aura of competent swordsmen were betrayed by their footwork which appeared clumsy to a man who had been honing his swordforms for almost a decade.

Theron, having trained extensively with a seasoned soldier like Cadmus, found their footwork amateurish.

"Fellows, it's you whom I believe needs more backup. So, why don't you request aid from

the crowd for a dozen more of your admirers to come to your aid and make this a fair duel!"

Three swordsmen, clad in metal, hissed in retort and circled Theron like predators. Their blades gleamed in the sunlight, a silent promise of violence.

The metal caster to his left, impatience boiling over, broke rank and lunged at Theron with a thrust of his sword. Theron, with effortless grace, sidestepped the attack and surged past, deflecting a strike from the second swordsman with a flick of his right-hand blade.

Balkin, circling like a predator behind Theron, saw his opportunity when Theron seemed busy in defending against his two metal casters. He sneaked behind Theron and swung his sword in a horizontal arc to deliver a fatal blow at Theron's back, hoping to exploit the distraction from his metal casters to eliminate the freak from the game.

But Theron, sensing the attack, bent at the waist, the sword whistling harmlessly over his head. He wasted no time, delivering a powerful back-kick to Balkin's stomach, sending the panther's team leader sprawling to the ground.

The first swordsman, still off balance from his missed attack, stumbled past Theron. With a swift kick to the ass, Theron sent the first metal caster sprawling onto the second swordsman, creating a tangled heap of metal and frustration.

While the two metal caster contestants of the Panther's team were busy trying to disentangle themselves, Theron turned his attention to Balkin, who was just rising to his feet.

"Alone now, are we?" Theron smirked, unleashing a flurry of attacks with his twin blades at the isolated panther's commander.

Balkin, overwhelmed by the swiftness and precision of Theron's strikes, yelped and barely managed to defend himself. Sensing his struggle, Theron sheathed one of his swords. "Perhaps two swords are too much for your skills?" he taunted.

The crowd roared with jeers at Balkin for needing a favor from the magicless freak to safeguard himself, and Balkin's face contorted in a mix of anger and shame. But he had no time to dwell on it, barely managing to parry against Theron's single sword.

In fact, he decided against summoning his earth elemental to defend himself, realizing that it would be too dangerous to slow himself while using his earth magic against a swift swordsman like Theron.

Theron feinted and double-feinted, his masterful swordsmanship leaving Balkin completely outmatched. The Panther's commander could only manage weak parries against the relentless assault of the master swordsman.

Balkin, driven by fear, leaned back to avoid a strike, foolishly leaving his sword exposed. In a swift moment, Theron pulled out of the feint, and with a full-body turn for momentum, swung his unmetal blade, cleaving Balkin's sword in two.

Balkin stared in shock at his broken weapon, then looked up just in time to see Theron's sword inches from his chest. He closed his eyes, expecting the blow.

Balkin closed his eyes in fear and defeat, but felt no sword striking his armor.

But the blow never came.

Balkin opened his eyes to see Theron grinning mischievously at him, the sword held back a mere inch from his armor. "The duel has only just begun," Theron said. "And it wouldn't be

honorable to take down a commander before his army is defeated, would it?" Theron retraced his sword and stepped back a couple of steps.

Even as Balkin gaped, he saw his two metal casters disentangle themselves and charge towards Theron's back. One veered off to join him, but the other lunged forward with a sword thrust aimed at Theron's back.

Sensing the attack from behind, Theron swayed to the side, letting the sword pass harmlessly over his shoulder. However, the momentum carried the metal caster forward, his weapon now aimed straight at the chest of the weaponless Balkin.

Balkin, his heart leaping into his throat, watched in horror as his teammate's sword arced through the air, aimed for a fatal blow. Unintentionally, his teammate was about to eliminate him from the game with their own weapon. But Theron, with lightning speed, intervened and grasped the caster's wrist with a firm grip, stopping the blade inches from Balkin's chest.

Balkin, his eyes snapping open, saw the blade hanging mere inches away, his astonishment growing as he realized Theron had once again spared him from elimination.

"Your team's commander should be defeated by my hands, not yours!" Theron chided, pushing the stunned swordsman back towards Balkin.

The three metal warriors stared at Theron in disbelief, their confidence shaken by his effortless display of skill.

Balkin finally found his voice, holding up his broken sword. "How did you know where it was weak?" he stammered.

"Balkin," Theron replied with a shrug, "you know only how to wield a sword, but I know how to forge one. Years spent in the smithy taught me to discern the weakness of a blade by the sound it makes when it clashes against mine."

Suddenly, a stern voice cut through the crowd's hushed awe. "Stop fooling around!"

Theron recognized his swordmaster's stern voice and sighed. "Playtime's over, boys," he declared and retrieved his sheathed left sword as well.

Before Balkin could even summon his earth elemental or his teammates could react, Theron launched into a breathtaking dance. His blades, flashing in the sunlight, effortlessly parried every attack. He moved with the grace of a predator, his swords singing a harmonious but deadly song.

His hands a blur, Theron eliminated the two metal casters within seconds. The first, on his left, was struck with the pommel of his sword, sent flying back with a red-hot glow enveloping his armor before he hit the ground.

Desperately, Balkin sent his stone elemental to smash into Theron.

Theron dodged away from Balkin's earth elemental, a hulking leopard made of yellow stone, which he sensed charging from behind. With one fluid motion, he intercepted the remaining metal caster's attack and slammed the pommel of his other sword into his chest, freezing his armor and eliminating him from the game.

Theron's focus turned to Balkin and his earth elemental, a hulking yellow leopard. Balkin directed the creature towards Theron, the leopard lunging at Theron's head. Theron, light on his

feet, effortlessly leaped out of its path, his movements almost defying gravity. As the elemental passed, he hoisted his sword over his head and with a swift downward swing, severed the leopard's head clean off.

With its head severed, the elemental lost control, disintegrating into dust. Balkin, stunned, instinctively grabbed one of his fallen team members' swords. He stared at Theron in a mix of astonishment and despair as Theron stepped forward, parried Balkin's feeble strike, then with a decisive move, slammed the flat portion of his second sword against Balkin's chest. The armor flared red, and Balkin fell, immobile.

Theron turned his attention to the remaining opponents. Ferris and Gerrick were still locked in combat, but the rest of Gerrick's team had fallen to Briar's prowess with fire magic. With a determined stride, Theron marched towards Balkin's panther section, his sights set on the golden flower totem.

As he neared the walls, Pepwick opened a door into the black panther team's lair. Theron entered, retrieved the golden flower, then exited to the roars and applause of the spectators. He had returned victorious, his skill and grace unmatched even while confronting three metal casters at the same time.

He returned to his team's section and handed over the golden flower totem to Pepwick amidst surprised whoops and applause from the spectators who had completely underestimated the wolf team as the weakest ever to participate in the history of the game.

Elissa sighed with relief, her heart pounding after watching Theron effortlessly defeat three metal casters simultaneously. "That boy will give me a heart attack one of these days," she muttered.

Count Marius chuckled, impressed. "Outstanding swordsmanship indeed. He barely broke a sweat against those three. It almost seemed like he was playing with them."

He turned to Adrian. "Did you train your nephew in swordplay?"

Adrian shook his head. "He's a natural. I taught him the basics when he was young, but he's surpassed me by far."

The Count pondered Adrian's statement, his eyes never leaving Theron and tried to answer the enigmatic puzzle the boy posed himself to be. "Given the boy's ingenuity, it wouldn't surprise me if he's learned a trick or two on his own."

The trio watched the game from the grandstand as Theron rejoined his friends and handed the golden flower to Pepwick, who promptly deposited it within their team's wall. Kelvin winked at Theron. "Everything is going according to plan," he said.

Theron grinned back. "Indeed. Now, we wait."

His gaze shifted to the ongoing battle between Ferris and Gerrick, a fierce clash between two skilled warriors.

Meanwhile, Count Marius noticed something peculiar. "Only three members of the Wolf

team have actively participated so far. What of the other two?"

While Adrian frowned at the statement from Marius, he watched Ferris finally defeating Gerrick after a long and arduous battle.

Ferris triumphantly marched towards the lion's den. Unlike Pepwick, who opened a door, Ferris smashed the wall to pieces in a show of dominance before claiming the golden flower. He also bent to the ground and picked up the Wolf team's flower totem that Gerrick had thrown inside the wolf team's wall earlier.

Exiting from the lion team's rubble with two golden flowers in hand, Ferris surveyed the field. His eyes widened in shock as he realized the other two teams had been defeated, their walls breached with open doors in the walls.

Ferris spun around, his gaze falling on Theron and his team watching silently. "How did this happen?" he demanded, his voice echoing across the field. He had been so focused on Gerrick that he hadn't noticed the fate of the other teams.

"Coward!" he accused, turning to address Theron directly. "Did you sneak up on the other two teams while they were battling each other and stabbed the winner to steal their flowers? How else could you have defeated them?"

Theron and his teammates remained silent, their faces impassive.

Ferris, despite his accusations, couldn't help but feel a flicker of doubt. It didn't explain the scattered positions of the defeated players. If Theron had indeed backstabbed the victor of these two teams, wouldn't the members of these two teams be lying next to each other.

Ferris shook his head, clearing his thoughts. "Regardless, Coward, we have three flowers to your two. To win, you will need to overcome our superior defenses."

Theron smiled briefly at Ferris. "*Is that so?*"

Ferris rolled his eyes at the "stupid" boy who couldn't even count the number of flowers he owned. "Idiot!" he muttered.

Turning on his heel, Ferris sprinted towards his team's wall, entering and heading straight for their flower vase. Briar followed close behind.

"*Freak, the challenge is over. Prepare to be expelled from this valley!*" Ferris yelled back, relishing his apparent victory.

Marius turned to Adrian, a frown on his face. "I hate to accept it, but Ferris is right. Ferris has more flowers, and their defenses are formidable. I can't see how Theron could possibly win with such unskilled and weaker teammates."

Adrian watched Ferris place the flowers in the vase. A sudden grin spread across his face. "Ferris' defenses are indeed formidable," he conceded, "but what use are defenses if you are the one forced to attack?"

Marius furrowed his brow, confused. "Ferris has three flowers to Theron's two. Why would Ferris need to attack Theron when he already has the maximum number?"

Adrian's grin widened as he pointed at Ferris.

Ferris placed the two flowers in the vase housing his team's golden flower, increasing his tally to three. Ferris triumphantly hoisted the vase, displaying his three golden flowers to the cheering crowd. Loud cheers arose from the crowd, acknowledging his cunning strategy of defeating only one team to gain an unassailable lead of three flowers.

While Ferris was reveling from the cheers, the cheers were abruptly replaced by gasps when one of the flowers in the vase burst into flames, dissolving into ash. Ferris lowered the vase with a frown, his face taking a moment to contort in realization. He remembered the valet's words – the vase only accepted the original flower totems.

As the revelation dawned on him, Ferris spun around with murderous fury to confront a grinning Theron.

"The challenge is far from over," Theron declared, his eyes gleaming. "It's just begun."

"Ah, a duplicate flower!" The Count slapped his thighs, roaring with excitement. "I didn't see that coming! Brilliant indeed!"

"Lord, I am not getting what just happened!" The sergeant in front of him stammered incomprehensively at the sudden change of emotions on Ferris' face.

"Theron used his earth-caster to create a duplicate golden flower, using it to trigger a fight between his strongest opponents. He then capitalized on their distraction to nab flowers from weaker teams. He's now at three flowers, including his own, which he never discarded. It was always with him and he never sacrificed his duty of protecting his flower!"

"What! Theron never discarded his duty?" The sergeant asked dubiously, wondering on how he let a young lad fool him into believing that Theron was a coward to safeguard his duty.

"Yes! Don't be too disgruntled by your mistake. I believe every onlooker here is guilty of the same mistake!" Marius added. "Including myself!"

Marius rubbed his cheek, "But can Theron hold off his stronger enemies with their flimsy defenses?"

Adrian pondered the same question, scrutinizing the wolf team's walls. "Tricking Ferris with a duplicate flower was one thing," he murmured, "but stalling him with their weak defenses...that's another story."

As the crowd realized what transpired, cheers erupted for Theron. They had all been fooled by the "coward" they had underestimated. The "freak" had outsmarted almost all his opponents, acquiring more flowers than the remaining team with minimal effort and losses.

"It doesn't matter! We'll crush your flimsy defenses and take back the remaining flowers!" Ferris roared at Theron, his fury matched by the cheers erupting for Theron.

"Attack as one!" he bellowed at his team.

Exhausted from their battle with their strongest opponents, Ferris and his comrades surged towards the wolf section, their elemental casting abilities far exceeding those of Theron's team.

Theron looked at Kelvin and Pepwick. "Can you defend our walls and handle Briar and the water caster, who must be worn out by now from fighting their strongest opponent?"

Both nodded and rushed back to stand next to their walls, preparing to confront their charging adversaries.

"Briar, now!" Ferris yelled, slowing to a jog as they neared Theron's team. Briar used his light elemental to vanish, skirting away from Theron and approaching Pepwick and Kelvin, who were startled by Briar turning invisible suddenly.

They searched around for Briar, who was stealthily approaching them.

"Take the flowers from their vase," Ferris bellowed at his air caster who was soaring forty feet above the ground in a violent windstream created by his air elemental.

The air caster nodded and sped towards the wolf team's walls.

Theron stood still, allowing the air caster to pass unimpeded. The air caster scoffed at the wolf team's passivity and their shoddy five-foot wall. He couldn't believe their arrogance in thinking such a wall could stop him. He slowed down, preparing to land near the vase.

Suddenly, the air caster slammed headfirst against an unseen object, crashing to the ground unconscious.

The air shimmered near the slumped air caster as a veil dissolved, revealing a forty-foot stone wall next to the half cooked five-foot shoddy stone wall.

As the massive stone wall materialized, the crowd gasped in collective shock. They had all been fooled into believing the five-foot wall was the wolf team's only defense.

Everyone, even the Count, exclaimed in surprise and admiration at the unexpected wall's appearance. They discovered Belarian and Schultz, the last two members of the wolf team, kneeling on the ground within the forty foot walls, clearly exhausted from maintaining the wall and the light cast veil around it.

"Send in the healers immediately." The Count yelled for healers, but Theron had Pepwick release the imprisoned healer from Crevis' team. The healer knelt beside the unconscious air caster and used water from the vase carried by Pepwick earlier to heal the slumped air caster.

Ferris' disbelief was palpable as he and his water caster teammate sputtered to a halt. "How did you maintain a veil over those walls without anyone sensing the light casting?" Ferris asked.

Theron smiled faintly. "Schultz may not be as powerful a fire caster as Briar, but he's more skilled in subtle casting, which doesn't require a blazing inferno. And by the way, it wasn't a veil in any traditional sense that was used to conceal the real walls. It was, in fact, the opposite of a veil created by light casters to turn invisible."

Theron elaborated with a hint of pride in his teammates' achievements. "But in this case, Schultz simply captured the light over the shoddy walls and projected them onto the real walls and vice versa, fooling everyone in plain sight by switching the location of the two walls. It wasn't a normal veil for your light casters to sense behind our fake walls," Theron explained, a hint of pride in his voice.

Ferris recoiled, a cocktail of incredulity and rage churning in his gut as a chilling thought wormed its way into his mind. The prospect of dispatching Theron's team like flies, a mere formality, was dissolving with alarming rapidity. He dismissed the traitorous notion with a snort.

How could this ragtag bunch of misfits possibly pose a threat to his powerful team even though they have been reduced to three members?

He had his Water Caster, the third-best contestant in Briar, at his side, and himself, the most powerful of all contestants. Surely, such a disparity in strength was insurmountable for Theron and his team.

But he decided to be more smart in the way he went about things. This was not the time to bull his way to victory. It was time to be vigilant enough to not let Theron trick him with more traps. Maybe, it was his time to trap the wolf team.

Ferris decided to lure Theron into his trap by distracting the freak and buy more time for his teammates to dispatch their opponents. Besides, Theron seemed to be gloating after landing few surprising blows. *It was time to goad the gloating freak to trip on his own leg.*

Ferris feigned a gasp to prod Theron's ego. "Your team doesn't have powerful casters to maintain such a complex light casting over two walls for so long."

Theron answered slowly, shaking his head. "Elemental power is not strength, Ferris. Magic is a tool, just like any other you use to get a job done."

Belarian, Theron's earth caster, retrieved the golden vase with three flowers and ferried it to the safety of the forty-foot-tall walls. Schultz, drained from maintaining the unique veil shrouding the two walls, had finally surrendered to exhaustion and sank to his knees within the wolf teams' forty-foot walls.

"Hmm!" Ferris' brow furrowed in concentration as he channeled his light elemental, meticulously tracking the movements of his friend, Briar. Under the cloak of an expertly crafted light-cast veil to turn himself invisible to human gaze, Briar crept closer and closer to Pepwick and Kelvin, undetected.

Any moment now! Ferris' lips curled into a smirk as he observed Theron distracted from the

plight of his two teammates who were struggling to locate the invisible Briar.

The moment of Theron's reckoning was imminent! Ferris pondered to himself and smirked at Theron who suddenly frowned at the change of Ferris' demeanor.

"Ah...Freak, you thought you alone possessed the ability to trick others?" Ferris smirked mischievously, noticing Theron finally comprehending Ferris' plan to distract him.

Theron met Ferris' gaze with a furrowed brow, wondering how Ferris planned to trick him.

"Freak, you have allowed yourself to be duped now. I may have been unaware that the walls were concealed, and its location switched by the foolish Schultz. But, for the last few minutes, I was merely attempting to distract you, so Briar could approach within striking distance of your two teammates standing near your walls."

"Kevlin and Pepwick have no light elementals to discern Briar's whereabouts, and the invisible Briar has crept closer to them now that he can knock them out at any moment. Schultz is too exhausted after maintaining such a complex light casting to detect Briar's light veil and reveal Briar's current location to your teammates."

Kevlin lowered his head in shame, recognizing the truth in Ferris' words. Pepwick frantically searched his vicinity for Briar, his anxiety growing with each passing moment.

Meanwhile, Briar, cloaked in his light elemental's veil, tiptoed across the sodden ground towards Pepwick, who was spinning in circles, oblivious to the danger approaching.

A wide smirk suddenly bloomed on Theron's face as he sensed the locations of all three Sukrans near his team's walls. He felt Briar's presence tiptoeing near Pepwick, while Kelvin looked down in apparent submission.

"Ferris," Theron inquired, his voice heavy with amusement, "why do you presume we lack the means to locate Briar without light elemental magic?" The question hung heavy in the air, instantly altering the atmosphere around the ground.

Ferris realized with terror that Theron had sensed the trap. "Briar, stop!" Ferris' shrill scream reverberated across the ground. But he was too late.

Suddenly, a loud clang of steel against armor shattered the silence, followed by a yelp of surprise from Briar. Briar lost control of his light elemental and flared into view of all the gathered Sukrans.

Ferris watched in disbelief as Briar sank to the ground, his armor frozen and glowing crimson after Kevlin had struck an invisible Briar across his armored chest, eliminating the light caster from the game.

Ferris was confused as Kevlin sheathed his weapon with a broad grin, while Pepwick turned to scowl at Kelvin furiously. "Kelvin, what took you so long? Do you know how terrible it is to play bait?"

Theron looked at the disbelief in Ferris' face. "Ferris, it was you who was tricked!"

Ferris' face failed to regain color from the unexpected shock. He gasped incomprehensively, "How was Kevlin able to detect Briar's location without the capacity to cast light elemental?"

"Briar may be smart enough to veil himself with his light elemental and turn invisible, but

he lacks the earth-casting talent to prevent his boots from leaving footprints on the sodden ground," Theron explained with a confident grin.

Ferris finally understood. "You sprayed the ground in front of your walls with water so that an invisible adversary's boot would leave prints on the sodden ground?"

"Yes," Theron confirmed. "Kevlin was watching the ground for Briar's tracks, and as soon as he spotted them, he dispatched Briar from the game."

Ferris was astonished by Theron's simple yet effective strategy to track any incoming, veiled foes.

"You don't need magic to do everything. Nature supplies us with the same means as magic to accomplish tasks. Magic can be *swift* and *pristine*, but nature is always *precise*," Theron emphasized.

The crowd gasped in realization. They had been tricked into believing that the wolf team had watered the ground in front of the walls to slow down any charging opponents. In fact, the water had been strategically placed to locate veiled adversaries approaching their walls on ground by watching for footprints on the sodden ground.

Consumed by rage, Ferris roared, "I am going to kill you, vermin!" Ferris summoned his earth elemental to raise a twenty-foot earth cast stone hand that started sweeping away the sodden ground leaving no water or moisture on the sand to help the wolf team to track their opponent's charge.

"An excellent casting, but don't you think that it is a tad bit too late?" Theron taunted his biggest tormentor.

Irked by the mockery, Ferris lost himself to rage and threw caution to the wind and lunged at Theron.

A few yards before reaching Theron, he slipped under a light-cast veil, disappearing from sight.

"Did you forget, Freak, that Briar is not the only one who can veil himself? And I have removed the sodden ground around you now, so how will you protect yourself against me without any magic to detect me?"

Ferris surged towards Theron in a zigzag pattern, aiming to mask his approach and deceive Theron from sensing his exact location.

Theron stood on the balls of his feet, eyes narrowed, both swords drawn. Though he lacked magical prowess, Theron possessed a keen sense of awareness of his surroundings. He delved into his senses, listening intently. He could feel the approaching presence to his left, the swish of a blade.

Theron narrowly dodged a blow aimed at his neck by diving to the ground, then rolled to his feet, listening intently. He relied on his senses, his inability to cast magic compensated by an exceptional awareness of his surroundings.

And it was time to put to use the only thing unique to him – *Sensing both magical and mundane presences near him.*

As he focused hard, he even started feeling the path of the sword swings. When he sensed the tip of Ferris' blade sweeping towards his throat, Theron leaned back, the blade missing by a

hair's breadth.

Before Ferris could recover, Theron struck with the flat of his blade, connecting with Ferris' shoulder blade.

Ferris screamed, his light veil flickering and dissolving. He stumbled, trying to regain his balance, but Theron's powerful kick to Ferris' ass sent him sprawling face-first into the dirt.

The crowd watched the duel turning dirty as both men started discarding the game's rule to not use their weapon against an unarmored part of the opponent's torso.

But the crowd can feel the tension in the air as both men relented the control of their mind to rage of punishing their most hated adversary!

Meanwhile, Theron decided against capitalizing on his advantage, giving Ferris time to regain his footing. Anticipating an attack while he was sprawled on the ground, Ferris flailed his sword wildly behind him as he regained his footing, drawing jeers from the crowd at his fear.

Theron could find it in Ferris's stunned gaze that it was the first time in his life that the Lemurian townsmen jeered Ferris. For a man who was always reveled and pampered by the townsmen for his magical might, Theron knew it would be the biggest blow that Ferris could receive on the day.

Scowling, he spat at Theron, "*You're done, freak.*" Theron remained silent and awaited Ferris' next move. Ferris, angered by the taunts and fueled by his desire to obliterate Theron, drew excessive power from the earth, seeking its aid to overpower Theron with a single blow. However, this surge of power hampered his agility and hindered his footwork, a common mistake committed by most earth casters who traded agility for brute strength.

Ferris lunged at Theron with a primal roar, fueled by the fury and strength borrowed from his earth elemental. He swung his blade at Theron with reckless abandon, the air crackling with raw elemental energy.

Theron knew that stopping such a powerful attack without metal or earth magic would destroy a regular sword. However, he was curious to test his unmetal blade against the mighty blow of an extraordinary earth caster.

Theron met the blow head-on, his unmetal blade ringing as it clashed against Ferris' sword backed by the strength borrowed from his earth magic. Unlike any other metal blade, Theron's unmetal sword absorbed the impact, the air and water within its core swirling and dissipating the force of the blow.

Ferris, surprised by the resilience of the seemingly weak blade, faltered for a moment. Theron grabbed the opportunity, punching Ferris square in the nose with the hilt of his other sword. The blow sent Ferris reeling back, and he lost his footing, crashing to the ground.

Ferris crawled backward, blood streaming from his nose. He stared at Theron in disbelief, his arrogance shattered by the unexpected turn of events.

Theron stepped back and waited for Ferris to regain his footing. Ferris rose to his feet, spitting blood, utterly shocked that Theron's blade had remained intact after his powerful blow.

"How could your blade remain intact?" Ferris stammered, clutching his bloodied nose. "Without any metal magic to protect your sword, my blade backed by the strength I drew from the earth should have cut through your sword like butter."

"How many questions do you wish to have addressed today?" Theron replied with a taunting grin, further infuriating Ferris.

Fueled by rage, Ferris unleashed his earth elemental to crush Theron. A black tiger materialized on Theron's right.

Theron, sensing the elemental rising to his right, retreated with lightning speed, his twin swords glinting in the sunlight. As the earth elemental lunged at the space he had just occupied, Theron swung both blades in a devastating arc, bisecting the tiger into three parts that dissolved into dust, causing Ferris to lose control of his earth magic for the moment.

Ferris, his eyes gleaming with fury, charged towards Theron with a wild swing aimed for the belly. But Theron, sidestepped the sword swing with ease and delivered a swift counterpunch to Ferris' nose with the hilt of his blade, sending Ferris sprawling to the ground once more.

Ferris cried in agony as he plummeted to the ground and dropped his sword to catch his broken nose.

Instead of immediately delivering the finishing blow, Theron stepped back and surveyed Ferris, whose face was now a mask of bloody mess. Ferris' eyes flickered with fear and uncertainty for the first time on his chances to vanquish his most hated foe.

Theron turned to check on his teammates, Kelvin and Pepwick, who stood over the unconscious body of Ferris' water caster, and busily watched the fierce duel between Ferris and their commander.

"Retrieve the flowers from Ferris' team's section," he commanded, his voice tinged with icy calm.

Theron sheathed his swords and faced Ferris, who rose to his feet with a snarl, clutching his broken nose. Theron met his foe's gaze with a contemptuous grin. "Let the contest be fair," he said, his voice dripping with sarcasm. "I wouldn't use my sword on a helpless man."

Theron saw a flicker of fear in Ferris' eyes, quickly replaced by a surge of fury at the insult.

Ferris looked once at his long sword lying at his feet, but he decided against picking it and using it against a weaponless foe and prove to the townsmen that he could defeat Theron only if the freak surrendered his weapons in the duel.

No! He will defeat the freak with just his prodigious magic!

Ignoring the pain on his bloody nose, Ferris lunged towards Theron, commanding his air elemental to reduce weight of his body and enhance his speed in the air. He transformed into a whirlwind of rage and hoped his enhanced speed would vanquish his foe when his brute strength couldn't.

As he approached Theron, Ferris attempted to slam his fist into Theron's chest and end the challenge. Theron, who was used to dueling Cadmus employing similar air magic to quicken himself, was not surprised by Ferris' tactic. Years of practice helped Theron to move quick enough like a blur without magic. He swayed to his left and watched the punch sail harmlessly over his ear. As Ferris's flailing arm sailed past his ear, Theron grabbed the flailing arm that had missed slamming him by a mere inch and stretched it outwards. Theron then punched back at the armored part of Ferris' right shoulder.

The armor around Ferris' right shoulder froze at once, rendering his right arm immobile.

Adding to his distress, the frozen armor constrained his right arm, compelling it to remain outstretched to the right.

Theron disengaged and stepped a couple of steps back, wearing a grin as he demeaned his tormentor before the local townsmen, who had practically revered Ferris for his magical prowess and turned their face aside against all of Ferris' bullying and harassment.

Enraged and despondent about his inability to use his right hand, Ferris looked at his sword once more.

With no other option, he bent down to pick his sword with his left hand. He turned to gaze at the triumphant and condescending look from Theron.

"Don't you worry, I will not go back on my word and use my weapons to dispatch a one handed fool armed with a sword that he doesn't know how to use!"

Ferris ignored the catcalls from the townsmen who didn't appreciate his decision to use a sword to attack an unarmed opponent who had surrendered his weapons as a favor to Ferris and make the duel fair in the first place.

Ferris flung the sword with his left hand at Theron in desperation, only to have it met with a similar fate when Theron swayed once more and struck the armor behind his left shoulder. Ferris dropped his left sword at once as soon as the armor on his left shoulder froze as well. The young Ferris was now trapped, both his hands frozen in mid-air.

Ferris cut a sorry figure in front of his townsmen, both his arms immobilized and outstretched.

With both hands outstretched in front of him and no way to move them, Ferris harnessed the last vestiges of strength from his earth elemental, hunched to his waist and charged headlong into Theron.

But Theron, anticipating the only available counterattack from his opponent, evaded the bizarre charge effortlessly.

With a swift kick, Theron slammed at the armor over Ferris' hip, freezing the armor at Ferris' hip and locking Ferris in a hunched position. Ferris wailed in despair, his pride shattered at being made to remain in a half hunched position.

The once deafening roar of the crowd, which had fueled Ferris's every step throughout the competition, abruptly died down. A chilling silence descended upon the arena as they witnessed the downfall of their once-revered champion. Theron, the underdog who had defied all odds, walked towards Ferris, his every step echoing in the stillness.

Ferris raised his head apprehensively at the young lad he had bullied all his life.

Theron walked in front of Ferris and tapped him on the cheek, a chilling reminder of the years of humiliation Ferris had inflicted upon him in a similar fashion.

Theron, fueled by years of pent-up anger and a desire for justice, forcefully lowered Ferris's head to face the ground. He then slammed his palms on the armor behind Ferris's neck, effectively freezing the armor behind the neck and locking Ferris in a position of forced submission.

Try as he may, Ferris failed to lift his head upwards and was forced to gaze at Theron's feet.

Theron leaned his head closer to Ferris' ears.

"Do you hear the rapid whirring of my mind, Ferris?" Theron inquired, his voice laced with anger and vengeance. "It races at breakneck speed, reliving the countless instances of similar humiliation you inflicted upon me for failing to access my magic."

Ferris, enraged and powerless, could only struggle in vain against the constraints of the armor. He was unable to even lift his head to meet Theron's eyes, forced to gaze down at the ground in utter defeat.

Ferris wailed in dismay and disbelief at the humiliation he was receiving at the hands of the magicless freak.

"How does it feel, Ferris," Theron spat, his voice dripping with scorn, "to be forced to look at another man's feet instead of his face as an equal?" Theron had no mood to spare his tormentor who had subjected him to the same humiliation over the years: being forced to gaze at Ferris' feet.

A part of Theron's conscience questioned his actions, urging him not to let anger cloud his judgment. However, the deafening silence from the gathered onlookers, a stark contrast to the once-booming cheers for Ferris, tasted like nectar to a hungry man which fueled his contempt and rage to overrule his conscience.

Theron raised a palm to his ear and leaned close to Ferris's mouth, his voice low and menacing. "Did you say something, loser?" Theron mocked, his words dripping with sarcasm using the same word 'loser' that Ferris most often referred to him by. "I thought I just heard one of your taunts, the ones that have haunted me for years."

"So, where has the taunting disappeared?" Theron chided as he tapped Ferris' cheeks softly. His eyes blazed with triumph as he witnessed the silence that followed. The arrogant taunts that had once plagued him were now silenced, replaced by the whimpers of a defeated man.

Theron's eyes narrowed as he surveyed the defeated Ferris. A smirk played on his lips as he recalled one of the past taunts from Ferris that affected him the most.

"Do you recall, Ferris," he spoke, his voice laced with icy amusement, "how you took every opportunity to mock me, claiming the very name 'Theron' should be redefined as loser in our tongue?"

He scoffed, the sound holding a hint of vengeance, as he surveyed his opponent's hunched form. "But I believe you have just grasped the error of your ways, don't you? In our dictionary, it is not Theron that means loser. I just proved that it is Ferris that means loser in our dictionary!" Ferris, defeated and broken, didn't wish to hear any more of Theron's taunting. He managed a single word. "Finish it."

Theron raised a palm to his ear, a cruel smile playing on his lips. "So, you concede your defeat in the challenge?"

Ferris rumbled with rage, but his body remained frozen, unable to defy the power of the armor. He could only gaze at Theron's feet, his pride shattered.

The excruciating pain in his armored shoulders and back prevented Ferris from focusing his mind, rendering him unable to summon his magic and put up a decent fight.

"Finish it!" Ferris roared; his voice laced with desperation.

Theron, his authority undeniable, silenced Ferris with a gesture. "You are not in a position to demand anything, Ferris. If you do not renounce your arrogant conduct, I will leave you to remain in this position until the game concludes after the stipulated duration of one hour."

Ferris's rage intensified, but the armor held him captive. He knew that any further defiance would only prolong his misery. But he couldn't bring himself to plead with the man he had considered vermin.

"You know," Theron continued, his voice laced with a chilling calmness, "if you continue to show defiance and give me a chance, I would dearly love to humiliate you in front of these folks who once adored you for your magic skills."

Ferris hissed at Theron and continued to show defiance. "Finish the game, freak!"

"Not until you speak the magic word," Theron said with a mischievous grin.

Ferris frowned, his mind racing. "Magic word?" he asked after a moment of contemplation.

Theron shrugged nonchalantly. "Yes, a single word in our language that can perform extraordinary magic on its own. Only the most honorable of men understand its true value. I wouldn't expect you to grasp the magic behind it, but I'd at least hope a revered elemental caster like yourself, who can compartmentalize his mind to access multiple elements simultaneously, would possess the ingenuity to guess the magic word."

Ferris recognized the word, but his pride prevented him from speaking it.

Theron sighed. "Alright then. Let me leave you to enjoy your defiance and pride for the rest of the game in this same hunched position." He turned to walk towards his teammates, who stood a few yards away, holding a vase filled with all the five golden flower totems.

Panic surged through Ferris. He wasn't sure he could endure the humiliation of remaining hunched for the entire game until it concluded.

A tense silence descended upon the arena as Ferris locked eyes to his feet. Finally, after an agonizing moment, Ferris broke his pride and defiance.

His pride eventually gave way after a long, agonizing silence. "Please, Theron, finish the game," he pleaded.

Theron stopped on his tracks and turned, a grin spreading across his face. "Not difficult, was it?"

Theron walked up to the hunched form of his tormentor in chief. "Ok then, let the history books not mention that I was not compassionate to my foes." He bent over Ferris' stooped body and poked his finger into the armored chest with enough force to qualify as a killing blow.

Ferris closed his eyes in humiliation on being forced to plead for finishing the game even as a crimson light engulfed his entire armor, signifying the end of the game.

A protracted moment of silence ensued, only to be succeeded by a smattering of cheers that swiftly escalated into a resounding standing ovation.

The crowd erupted in thunderous applause for the Wolf team. This was a game that would be etched in history, and once the word about this game spread around the country, the strategies employed in this game would change the way the sport was played in the future across the kingdom.

And many could still hardly believe that the man at the historical transformations of the game was the magicless freak whom they had been deriding all these years.

Theron, however, remained unfazed by the cheers, but let himself bask in the pleasure of finding the joy and jubilations pasted across his teammates' faces as they hugged him in disbelief on winning the tournament.

However, he knew that his day had just begun. He had the impression that things were about to get much more difficult, and he knew he had to be ready for the challenges ahead.

He searched the crowd for Cadmus, finally spotting his swordmaster sporting a wide grin at his ward's accomplishment so far and giving him a thumbs-up. Theron nodded in acknowledgment with a wide smile, a silent message exchanged between them - Cadmus had succeeded in executing his role successfully.

Theron then motioned for the captured water caster to heal Ferris's armor and release the poor man from his misery. The water caster freed Ferris from his armor and healed his broken nose.

Theron's teammates joined him in celebrating their victory.

Ferris, humbled and defeated, sat crouched on the ground, his arrogance shattered. Theron walked towards his longtime tormentor.

Ferris looked at Theron with the fear of an animal ready to be butchered. Theron grinned at the defeated expression on his adversary's face and motioned for Schultz to use his magic to sound cast his voice across the entire arena.

Theron remained silent for a long few seconds. He stood tall, the victor not just of the game, but of a battle for equality and justice. He cast a piercing gaze at the crowd, his eyes gleaming with a newfound wisdom.

Finally, he lowered his head to look down at Ferris. "How do you feel to have the crap beaten out of you?" Theron inquired, his eyebrows raised.

Ferris's face darkened as anger flooded him. "You are here to gloat about your unexpected victory?"

Theron chuckled, the sound echoing off the entire ground. "So, gloating is acceptable when you win, but not when you lose? Are you trying to preach about human values now?"

Theron shook his head. "It is wrong, Ferris, to cast aside your values and principles when you are in a favorable position of power and only adopt them when it suits your needs."

"You dare advise me?" Ferris hissed, a flicker of defiance remaining in his voice.

"Why shouldn't I?" Theron replied calmly. "In what way are you superior to me?"

Ferris spat out venomously, "You are a weakling with no magic and completely useless to our society."

Theron raised an eyebrow, unfazed by the insult. "Are you such a devoted citizen who had taken it upon himself to rid our kingdom of its weeds? Can you tell me which lord bestowed upon

you this unenviable duty?"

As Ferris remained silent, Theron asked yet again. "Or, you may merely be a bully who hides behind your false passion for this kingdom?" Theron pointed out

Ferris stammered, unable to answer. He knew Theron was right, his words cutting deep into the heart of his self-righteousness. "I was trying to spare the kingdom from being disgraced by your presence!" Ferris managed to hiss back

"Me a *disgrace*!" Theron's voice hardened. "And what do you think of yourself now, Ferris? Defeated by a worthless nobody. Should you not exile yourself to save the kingdom from such a disgrace?"

Ferris fidgeted anxiously, speechless as Theron twisted his words.

"I know you boast of being blood kin to the Sukran prince himself, Dorian Primus," Theron said, fixing Ferris with a piercing gaze. "Is this Prince truly worthy of ruling the kingdom?"

Ferris was glad at Theron switching the subject and gave a proud nod. "Without a doubt! He is far superior to the other squabbling noble lords."

"But isn't the scholar prince considered meek and greatly lacking in magical prowess compared to those noble lords?" Theron countered. "In fact, there are rumors abound in the kingdom that the noble lords considers it's a disgrace to our proud kingdom to have a crown prince so weak and meek!"

No! Dorian is not a disgrace to the kingdom." Ferris retorted. "Dorian possesses a heart of gold, making him the sole candidate worthy of the Sukran throne."

"You boast of your cousin for his benevolent heart," Theron continued, his tone sardonic. "Yet he possesses less magic than many noble lords. But you believe he is fit to rule the kingdom, while on the other hand, you also believe that someone like me, with no magic at all, deserves nothing but scorn."

Ferris frowned, the hypocrisy of his own actions staring back at him. He had always prided himself on being fair and just, yet he had treated Theron with nothing but cruelty.

"After all, the difference between my magical skill to that of our townsmen seems pretty similar to the gulf separating Prince Dorian from the rest of the noble lords, isn't it?"

"Do you not see the double standard, Ferris?" Theron pressed. "You support your cousin for his gentle and kind heart, and are prepared to ignore his shortcomings in magic, because of his noble lineage. Yet you wouldn't extend the same courtesy to me and instead you judge me harshly for the very shortcoming that was not my fault in the first place."

Ferris frowned at hearing Theron's words, which rang true. "I never compared your predicament to that of my cousin."

Theron shook his head. "No one does. This is a classic example of how most of you treat your lords differently than you do your inferiors."

Theron's voice rose, echoing through the stunned ground. "If powerful magic is the sole measure of worth, why are so many people dissatisfied with the oppressive rule of the noble lords? Doesn't your logic imply that they raise taxes for the kingdom's benefits, not to their own benefit? Why do the commoners rebel against their lords then? As a loyal citizen, aren't you all obligated to obey whatever your noble lords ask of you, regardless of how unfair it may seem?"

A hush fell over the crowd as Theron's words resonated through their hearts.

"*This mindset suggests that we do not respect our noble lords, but rather fear them due to their magical might,*" Theron declared.

"Most of you are cowards, lacking the courage to oppose the unjust actions of your superiors while simultaneously having no qualms in demeaning the actions of a man inferior to you in power."

Theron turned to address the gathered onlookers. "Why are you all being hypocrites, complaining about oppression from your noble lords while you yourselves are oppressing those less gifted in magic than you?"

"Until you treat everyone equally," Theron concluded, his voice ringing out with newfound conviction, "you have no right to complain about the demeaning treatment you receive from your lords."

"What you give is always what you get," Theron declared, his gaze unwavering from the gathered crowd. "That's the one undeniable truth of life."

He swung around, his words directed at Ferris, whose face was etched with shame. "True friends aren't those who bask in your power, but those who stand beside you when it's darkest. Most of your companions and admirers only stick around for the glory and protection your offer, but they will be quick to vanish when you can't offer them what they desire."

Theron paused, his gaze sweeping across the silent crowd. "I'm not gloating. I've been there in your situation myself, countless times."

He looked back at Ferris, his voice hardening. "Earn respect, not hostility. Help someone in their hour of need, and decent folks will return the favor when you are in need."

Silence settled over the ground.

"Do you know why I chose a team that most considered the weakest?" Theron asked, tilting his chin towards a distraught Ferris. Ferris shook his head.

"I wanted to teach everyone gathered here that magic is not true power. It's a tool, nothing more. Magic alone doesn't win battles. It is the mind that wields this tool, the heart that guides it to victory."

Theron's voice boomed. "A fool with strong magic is still a fool."

He turned to the gathered townsfolk, pointing at his chest. "True power resides within one's heart."

His gaze held theirs. "You can defeat a man with strong magic, but you can never vanquish a man with a true heart. You may kill him, but you can never defeat him."

"We defeated seemingly strongest opponents with nothing but our ingenious minds and the courage of our heart. *It is time we judged each other by the strength of our character, not the strength of our magic.*"

Theron understood that it would take more than a game to transform his town's citizens, despite many people seeming to comprehend the truth in his statements. They were too steeped in this anarchy that they would find it difficult to transform overnight.

After all, Theron thought about the adage—No one would attempt to transform into a good man unless he realizes that he is a bad man in the first place.

Why no

ld someone look for a solution when they don't even recognize the problem in the first place?

Besides, he had other motives for choosing the seemingly weakest team, which he didn't want to disclose yet. But he knew that he would have to reveal the reason sometime later in the evening.

Theron expelled a massive sigh. "What am I doing here, wasting my time and yours with words that would fall on deaf ears?"

As he regarded an emotionally distraught Ferris, he narrowed his gaze.

"As the loser of the challenge, if you want to retain any semblance of honor in this town, you'll start helping those in need and stop bullying. It's time you started using your remarkable elemental skills for good deeds, not waste your prodigious magic just to intimidate helpless folks.

Will you abide by the terms we agreed upon before the challenge?"

Ferris's jaw clenched, then he slowly nodded. "I accept the terms!"

Theron's gaze remained unwavering. "Break your word, hurt others, and these people will see you as nothing but a dishonorable man. A man without honor is a rabid beast, fit only to be put down."

Chapter 7

Passing the Baton

Give me a thousand finest warriors, and I will win my enemy kingdom in a war. But give me a single, smart spy, and I will win the same enemy kingdom without even waging war.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

"Not bad, Gwen," the voice remarked, wavering slightly. "Not at all bad. Had I not known you, I would have ignored you as a waitress."

Gwen, a gorgeous blonde intentionally made up to appear tanned and blemished by continuous use of the salves from the Brump tree, turned towards the hovering spirit of her mentor, Sylvius.

"Sylvius," she chastised, "don't be arrogant like your other lomer friends. This outfit should aid me to infiltrate the command tent of this illegal phalanx easily."

Sylvius's spirit resembled its caster, who possessed prominent cheekbones, a robust torso, and multiple scars crisscrossing his face, lending him an air of both beauty and masculinity. Though composed of wavering air, the spirit's figure was substantial enough to mimic Sylvius's features with remarkable accuracy.

The spirit of the lomer was anchored to the coin placed a few feet on the ground in front of Gwen. These specially crafted coins allowed casters to imprint their spirit selves onto them, enabling their spirit to leave their body and travel across vast distances. When placed on the ground, the coin tugged the spirit of its proprietor to a meeting with the person requesting their attendance.

Unlike physical beings, spirits were unbound by the laws and limitations of the physical realm. While it could take days or months to travel physically from one part of the kingdom to another, traversing the spirit realm was instantaneous, allowing the caster to manifest a replica of their spirit near the imprinted coin. The imprinted coin acted as the tether to let the spirit not wander off in the spirit realm aimlessly.

However, the ability to create and utilize these spirit coins was a rare talent, reserved for elite Sukrans who possessed the powerful combination of spirit, fire, and earth magic. Sukrans who lacked this ability relied on birds to carry messages across the realm.

Gwen offered a wide grin to her tutor, who returned the gesture with his characteristic smug face. His face, with its accentuated features and sharp eyes, held an air of both wisdom and experience.

Sylvius, in turn, gazed upon his student, the only one he had tutored during his years as a lomer to the king. Lomers were the renowned spies of the king and other powerful noble lords,

tasked with carrying out missions and gathering information for their masters. They played a prominent role in the constant power struggles between noble lords vying for a higher position over other noble lords in the Sukran hierarchy.

Unbeknownst to the king, a rogue noble lord had begun assembling an unauthorized Phalanx. Under normal circumstances, each noble lord was only permitted to maintain three phalanxes unless commanded by the king to raise additional forces.

However, with Sukra facing its first true threat in eons and the House of Primus appearing uncertain in its grasp of the throne, several noble lords had begun disregarding the law in pursuit of their own ambitions to ascend the throne.

The history of Sukra was rife with examples of friendships turning sour and enemies becoming allies. The king relied heavily on his vassals to gain insight into the motives and actions of both his allies and adversaries.

Having gathered her thoughts, Gwen addressed her mentor's spirit. "I've been observing the command tent for several days," she explained, outlining her plan. "The waitress taking food in and out is the only way to sneak into the tent undetected."

"So long as you obtain the password before attempting to enter the command tent," Sylvius remarked.

"Obtaining the password is easy," Gwen assured him, adjusting her maid's apron. "But sneaking into the command tent... that's a different beast altogether."

Sylvius gazed at her confidant and chirpy self and decided to verify her ward's recon. "Are you certain their wind riders did not spot you when you spied on them?" Sylvius asked, skimming reports to assess the number of air casters patrolling the sky.

"That's child's play," Gwen scoffed, perfecting her disguise. "They had many wind riders, but my wind elemental is too subtle for them to detect my presence. Besides, I was miles above them, concealed by a light-cast veil."

Sylvius raised an eyebrow. "You far-casted two miles from the camp and gathered all this information?"

Gwen turned and pouted. "I can easily cast four miles away."

A tense silence followed, broken by Gwen's question, "So, how do I look?"

Sylvius examined her critically. "Too many pimples and tan lines for a twenty-year-old girl."

Gwen rolled her eyes. "Not everyone is as observant as you. The guards stationed on the command tent will only remember a beautiful waitress, not this pimply, ugly face."

"If I try to infiltrate with my real gorgeous face, they'll recognize me instantly as a new waitress and may even arrest me," she explained. "Brump tree salve tans and causes boils, making me Unsightly. With the correct password, the guards will dismiss me from their minds readily."

She grumbled to Sylvius, her mentor and father figure, "I'll have to use water casting to heal these boils after this mission, you know."

Sylvius grinned. "Had you focused on water casting at the university, you wouldn't have to ruin your beautiful face for the sake of a mission."

"I may not be the best water caster, but I'm one of the best fliers in the land," Gwen said,

adding after a pause, "except for maybe the nobles."

She smirked. "And my light-cast veil is far superior to yours."

Sylvius shook his head in exasperation. "At least you're not nervous about your first unsupervised mission. Remember, you must pass this exam to become a full-fledged lomer."

A tense silence ensued.

"Sylvius..." Gwen bit her lip. "Could I become a lomer with half your skill and commitment?"

Sylvius regarded her thoughtfully. Gwen, you are my sole student in all my years of service, a rose among thorns that you normarly find in the university. I have trained you with all my heart, even when I had been hard on you on occasion."

"However, life is the greatest teacher. Remember that always." A hint of regret flickered in his voice.

Gwen steeled herself. "The next time we meet, it will be as colleagues."

Sylvius smiled sadly. "I look forward to that day, lass."

Gwen scowled at his gloomy disposition. "Thank you for mentoring me and teaching a plain girl what it means to serve the kingdom and its lord."

Sylvius's voice turned cynical. "My lass, never forget the order in which you serve."

Gwen scowled again, then forced a cheerful tone. "Speaking of the king, Prince Dorian has requested to take me as his date to the Wintersend Festival."

Thinking about her boyfriend, she blushed. Despite Sylvius's warnings to avoid a relationship with the savant prince, she couldn't resist Dorian's pure heart, a stark contrast to the filthy minds of other nobles.

Dorian seemed to be the only person with a true desire to make the kingdom a better place. She smiled, picturing him diligently studying to become a worthy king. It was no surprise that most common people often dubbed him the scholar prince. Dorian was consistently found engrossed in his books, tirelessly seeking answers to some of life's most profound questions that had perplexed other scholars.

She couldn't wait to see him again, this time as a full-fledged lomer. She knew she could be a valuable asset to him during these turbulent times, especially since so many other nobles sought his downfall.

Gwen was convinced that Dorian was the best hope for their nation, and she was determined to support him in any way she could.

When was the last time a Sukran prince aspiring to the throne viewed every Sukran citizen as an equal?

Dorian was the sole obstacle preventing the noble lords from ascending to the throne, as the king was too elderly to father a child again.

Sylvius watched, a sigh escaping his lips, as his blushing ward daydreamed about her lover she met at the university. "Novice?" His stern voice cut through the air, "Focus on the mission! Your future pursuits can wait."

"You will continue to remain as a novice if you allow your mind to wander during such a crucial mission." Sylvius warned her.

Gwen remained silent on listening to her mentor's lecture before nodding sheepishly.

"Do you have the tracking stone?" Sylvius inquired, his voice softening slightly.

"Yes, I have it in my possession!"

"If you are captured, they will confiscate all your belongings before interrogation," Sylvius cautioned. "Make sure to keep your tracking stone on your person where your enemies might not consider confiscating it!"

"Yes, it's hidden within the clasp of my hairband." The possibility of being captured on her first mission terrified her.

Apart from the tracking stone, she possessed an ingenious invention – the *Obilisque*. Crafted by a talented classmate, this marvel utilized light and air magic to capture surrounding events along with the sound and preserve them within its complex architecture that could be reviewed later in a pool of water. The only downside of this marvelous invention was that it could be used only by a person possessing air and light elemental magic to start and stop recording.

As a contingency, she had borrowed the stone in case she couldn't find evidence of the noble lord commanding the illegal phalanx. Based on her reconnaissance of the unlawful legion, she deduced that the rogue lord in question must be one of the most powerful figures in the realm to assemble such a massive illicit army.

Sylvius's brow furrowed. "*What is your backup plan?*" he asked.

"If you haven't heard from me within a day, use the tracking stone. But I pray it doesn't come to that." Gwen replied.

"Gwen, be cautious. Flee at the first sign of trouble. Remember, lomers are not heroes. We work in the shadows, our accomplishments shrouded in secrecy. After all, if our identity as spies is revealed, we are rendered worthless to our profession." Sylvius's voice held a hint of sadness as he was about to send his ward, the girl he had nurtured like a daughter for a decade, into the lion's den. "Don't play the hero today, be the smart Gwen I've trained for the past decade. I want you back, safe and sound."

Sylvius stayed silent, observing the restless and anxious daughter. Despite his desire to join her on this perilous mission, one that posed a threat even to the most seasoned of lomers, his professional mindset overrode his protective instincts. Recognizing Gwen's considerable talent, he believed she was fully capable of handling the challenging mission on her own. He understood that facing such danger was essential for her to gain confidence in her own abilities.

"*All the best, Novice. Make me proud!*"

From her vantage point two miles in the sky above the phalanx camp, Gwen surveyed the scene below. A light-cast veil masked her presence, rendering her invisible to any air sentries posted by the phalanx. Below, air sentries, braving the brisk spring winds, vigilantly scrutinized the skies for any telltale signs of an approaching air caster.

Their reliance on light-cast veils for invisibility proved their undoing. Their windstreams, unlike hers, lacked subtlety and could be easily detected by a skilled air caste, revealing their positions despite being invisible to human gaze.

The airborne sentries were strategically stationed, forming a vigilant network around the camp. Apart from the air sentries diligently patrolling the skies to detect any potential intruders, earth sentries, skilled in earth magic, were positioned on the ground. Concealed by a subtly cast veil of light, they conducted patrols along the camp's perimeter, watchful for any approaching threats.

Gwen was surprised by the number of air and earth sentries employed by this phalanx force, clearly elucidating their possession of a massive number of soldiers at their disposal. Judging by the sprawling array of tents arranged within the camp, her estimate would lean toward no fewer than fifty thousand soldiers being enlisted in the phalanx.

In Sukra, a phalanx constituted a moderate-sized military force, accommodating a range of thirty to fifty thousand soldiers. It comprised diverse units, including infantry, archers, healers, wind riders, and cavalry, with each soldier harnessing the requisite magical abilities associated with their respective forces.

Every noble lord had the privilege of maintaining three phalanx to oversee the governance of their state. However, in times of war against other kingdoms, they were obligated to cede command of their phalanxes to the Sukran king.

However, the owner of this unauthorized phalanx must have raised this army, unmistakably endeavoring to stage a coup for the throne. It was now her responsibility to gather evidence about the rogue noble lord and ensure he faced justice.

She felt a shudder at the weight of responsibility pressing down on her shoulders. She was aware that her mentor must have persuaded the crown to entrust her with this mission. She had no doubt that the crown would have preferred a more seasoned lomer for the task of infiltrating the phalanx camp and gather evidence against the rebellious noble lord.

Now, it was her moment to demonstrate her mentor's judgment was correct in selecting her for this pivotal mission that could sway the fate of the kingdom.

With a deep sigh and a surge of determination, she snapped herself out of her contemplative thoughts.

"Remember your training, play the part of the waitress flawlessly, and make your exit with the evidence," she reminded herself to unravel the knot of tension and fear that had taken hold of her heart.

Dusk had fallen, cloaking the camp in shadows, creating an ideal environment for Gwen's reconnaissance.

Reducing her windstream to a gentle bubble around her body, she navigated the airspace between two air sentries, confident that even the sharpest sentry would fail to detect her. Her descent, a testament to her mastery of flight, required minimal wind manipulation. While other air casters relied on powerful windstreams to soar, she utilized few deft maneuvers and the natural air currents to fall gracefully, leaving no telltale trace or the air magic that the air sentries was searching around them.

The sentries often made the mistake of only searching for powerful windstreams that helped one to fly. But most of them overlooked the simple solution of falling through the sky, which didn't demand a larger windstream as needed for flying across the skies.

After skillfully eluding the air sentries, she soared towards the designated spot within the phalanx camp – the maid's tent. Summoning a gentle windstream to slow her descent, she landed discreetly in a shadowed area near the maid's tent, concealed by the cover of darkness. This secluded spot was one of the many in the camp, intermittently lit by fire lamps set up across different sections.

Concealed beneath a veil, she sought out a vantage point with an unobstructed view of the command tent. As with all phalanx camps, this one adhered to a standardized layout, positioning the command tent at its core.

Stealthily navigating her way toward the first row of healer tents, she positioned herself behind the shadows near a dim section behind the healers' tent. Nestled in the darkness, her gaze remained fixed on the entrance of the command tent.

The command tent buzzed with activity, its silhouette revealing the movements of men and women engaged in discussions or moving about the space. Two sentries armed with spears guarded its entrance.

After spending a quarter of an hour in her current location, she shifted to the next concealed spot a few hundred yards away. This precaution, though appearing overly cautious, served her well. In the world of covert operations, it was always prudent to err on the side of caution.

Her paranoia, though seemingly excessive, served her well. It was always better to err on the side of caution.

After relocating half a dozen times and enduring a couple of hours filled with boredom, she observed the activity within the command tent gradually diminishing to a trickle. Two guards remained vigilant, and only a handful of officers filed in and out of the tent occasionally. With a sigh, she came to the realization that her infiltration would have to be postponed until the officers departed for the night.

Attempting to alleviate the boredom, she made an effort to eavesdrop on the meeting by employing her air magic to carry the sound from the command tent to her concealed location. However, her efforts were thwarted as she sensed the presence of a private sound veil enveloping the entire command tent. This veil effectively barred anyone, including the two sentries and herself, from eavesdropping on the conversations within the command tent.

She had hoped to wait for the commander to step out and have dinner with his men before attempting to break into the command tent. However, it became evident soon that the commander of this illegal phalanx had no intention of joining his men for dinner. Recognizing the commander's preference for being served dinner within the command tent, she understood the futility of lingering too close and risking capture. With a sigh, she made the decision to retreat back toward the maids' tent for the time being.

She landed in the shadows next to the cleaners' tent and heard laughter from within. She had a direct view of the command tent and the guards while waiting for one of the maids to deliver dinner to the officers in the command tent.

A short while later, a slender waitress, her gait marked by a limp, emerged from the maids' tent, carrying a tray of food. Laughter echoed from within as she spoke, "You girls behave

yourselves while I deliver dinner to the commander." A teasing remark followed, "Better not let the commander's wife catch you ogling the chiseled body of our esteemed commander!"

"Lady Korinna can't stop me from feasting on her husband in my mind!" the maid with the food tray smirked at a friend through the tent flaps and proceeded towards the command tent.

"Finally!" Gwen rolled her eyes at the maid departing for the commander's dinner. She swiftly cast a private veil around the maid's ears.

The maid suddenly halted and turned around with a frown. "Who's there?" she called out anxiously, scanning for an unseen threat. After a moment of silence, she dismissed it, thinking she might have imagined the sound, unaware of the subtle tendril of a sound veil encircling her ears.

Gwen aimed to use the sound veil around the maid's ears to eavesdrop on those conversing with her inside the command tent. Observing the maid's progress toward the sentries, Gwen invoked her sound veil to catch the ambient sounds around the maid. One of the guards intercepted her.

"Password, Neesa!" Gwen heard the gruff voice of the guard, despite lingering a thousand yards away from the command tent.

Exasperated, the maid sighed. "Bearus, must I repeat the password after uttering it numerous times today to enter the tent?" she asked.

"Phalanx laws!" Bearus, the guard, replied with a shrug.

With a deep sigh, the maid uttered a single word, "Tartus," and the guard to her left acknowledged it, granting her access to the tent.

Gwen felt a wave of disgust as the other guard leered at the departing maid. "Hey! She's like a sister to me!" Bearus protested against the crude look from his comrade.

"All the more reason!" the other guard cackled lewdly. Disgusted by his behavior, Gwen switched her attention to a pile of scrolls being scuffled aside within the tent.

"Ah! Neesa. Thank goodness you have brought my dinner just as I was beginning to starve." Another gruff voice, undoubtedly belonging to the commander, boomed from within the tent.

"It's my duty to keep you well-fed, commander!" Neesa replied politely.

"Right you are... I believe you are doing the most important job than mine - I am sure it is no easy task of feeding this ravenous bunch who call themselves soldiers in this camp" The commander joked, followed by the unmistakable sounds of meat being devoured with gusto.

Neesa maintained her polite silence before inquiring, "Do you need anything else, commander?"

"Nothing for the moment. Thank you, Neesa!" The commander dismissed the maid, and the crackling of scrolls being moved around filled the air once more.

Gwen watched as Neesa exited from the tent, empty-handed. One of the sentries' gaze followed Neesa's limping form back towards the maids' quarters.

"Vile men!" Disgusted by the crude behavior she had witnessed, Gwen retreated further into the shadows near the maids' tent.

Gwen absentmindedly watched Neesa return to her tent.

A sudden peal of laughter shattered the night's quietude. Gwen sprung to her feet, startled,

and scrutinized her surroundings for anyone who had chanced upon her. Only after a moment did realization dawn upon her – she had forgotten to remove the sound veil from Neesa's ears!

Gwen realized to her dismay that she had failed to remove the sound veil around Neesa's ear.

"Neesa, clearly you seemed to have ogled at the commander, did you not?" a woman's voice drifted over, eliciting a sigh and an eye roll from Gwen.

Gwen knew she was trapped. Removing the sound veil now might risk alerting other maids with air magic. Stuck listening to their endless and unabashed chatter about men, Gwen settled onto the ground with a sigh of resignation.

Do women, be it noble lady or lowly maid, only ever talk about men? Can't they discuss anything more substantial? Gwen scowled, settling onto the ground to endure the next few hours of tedious conversation.

While she found their conversations tedious, she couldn't deny a sense of satisfaction. The first step of her mission was complete - *Acquiring password to the command tent*. Now, she would bide her time, waiting for the opportune moment to breach the command tent with the password she had learnt from Neesa.

Hours crawled by, filled with the incessant chatter of the maids. Despite the tedium, Gwen held firm to her objective. The password was hers, and soon, the secrets within the command tent would be hers as well soon.

Everything was proceeding as planned.

Gwen had spent the past few hours perched beside the maids' tent, eavesdropping on the gossiping maidservants. A sudden, excited murmur rippled through the group, punctuated by giggling, before one girl proclaimed excitedly, "Lord Maleficus has ordered his legion officers to arrange a banquet in celebration of his imminent victory in the upcoming campaign. The cooks have been instructed to prepare a festive meal for tomorrow."

What! Noble Lord Maleficus is the true owner of this illegal phalanx? Gwen sat up straight.

Could she have fortuitously stumbled upon the true owner of this phalanx? She was certain that most citizens wouldn't be surprised by Maleficus going against the law. There was no noble lord more infamous for his power-hungry and erratic behavior than Maleficus, who never hesitated to display his disdain for Dorian, even in public.

However, Gwen realized that overhearing a maid's gossip would not be sufficient to convict Noble Lord Maleficus. She needed concrete evidence, particularly with his distinctive signet marking, to make a compelling case against Maleficus.

No wonder none of the soldiers wore armor signifying their allegiance to Lord Maleficus. The rogue lord might have been insane, but he was cunning enough to command his men to keep his allegiance a secret.

Gwen grunted at the extreme precautions taken by the noble lord who owned this unlawful legion to conceal his identity. Gwen hoped that she could obtain proof within the command tent.

A groan echoed from another maid. "It appears we'll be working day and night tomorrow, then."

"But at least there will be better food tomorrow night, wouldn't you say?" another young woman remarked shyly, eliciting a wave of blushes from the other maids at the prospect of the upcoming celebration.

"*Better food!*" Another maid scoffed. "You play with the food! I'll play with the company I manage to get tomorrow night!" She remarked unabashedly.

Gwen scoffed at the girls swooning over men, yet a flicker of recognition sparked within her. *Had she not swooned over Dorian as well?* And surely, men swooned over women far more often. At the very least, she had noticed Dorian had swooned over her often.

"Alright, ladies, wind down for the day and get some rest. Tomorrow will be a busy one. I'll clean up the command tent and wind up for the night as well." Neesa huffed,

Neesa exited from the cleaners' tent, heading towards the command tent for cleaning duty.

Gwen, swift as a shadow, moved ahead of the maid to her pre-selected ambush point, concealing herself beneath a light-cast veil and awaited the maid's approach.

With practiced precision, Gwen waited for the maid to pass her hiding spot before leaping into action, delivering a well-aimed punch to the nape of Neesa's neck.

Gwen grabbed the maid before she could fall unconscious and dragged her into the shade of a nearby tent. There, she swiftly bound the maid's wrists and knees, gagging her to prevent any noise that might draw attention upon her awakening.

She peeked towards the command tent which seemed to be vacant with the night setting in properly now. With the maid secured, Gwen donned the maid's grey cloak and approached the command tent under the cover of darkness. As she drew closer, she noticed a change in the guard detail. New guards stood watch, their voices engaged in animated conversation.

Adopting a casual demeanor, she approached them and spoke the password 'Tartarus', maintaining the facade of normalcy.

With a curt nod, the lead guard gestured for her to enter before returning to his conversation with his comrade.

Gwen slipped inside, only to find the tent eerily silent and empty. Fear gnawed at her and her heart beat anxiously, but she quickly regained her composure. Maintaining the facade of a dutiful maid, she gathered the trays, her movements deliberate and controlled. As she walked toward the center of the tent, curiosity tugged at her. She reached for the parchments scattered across the command table, her fingers itching to unravel the secrets they held.

A gasp escaped her lips as she discovered a letter bearing the unmistakable signature of Lord Ravesian, his signet dagger leaving an indelible mark on the seal. Her heart hammered in her chest as she snatched the document, a fallen soldier from the battlefield of secrets with a quick sweep of her hands.

As she browsed through the contents of the scroll, her blood ran cold. It contained explicit instructions from Ravesian, detailing the launch of their campaign at the border.

Her mind raced. *Border?* Which border? *East or southwest?* The question gnawed at her, but she had no time for contemplation. Crumbling the letter, she tucked it into her pocket, her mind

racing.

Well! My job is done here. It is up to the king to worry about Lord Ravesian!

Then, as she turned to gather the plates, a stray but chilling thought struck her.

Lord Ravesian was widely regarded as the most noble of all lords, yet here she was, with evidence suggesting his involvement with an illegal phalanx. Moreover, the maids had spoken of Lord Maleficus leading the phalanx, yet this letter undeniably implicated Lord Ravesian as the owner of this phalanx.

What is she missing? And more importantly, was she being misled to accuse a good man like Lord Ravesian? The two pieces of information from two different sources were countering each other.

Or could it be that both Lord Maleficus and Lord Ravesian had colluded to form this phalanx?

A shiver ran down her spine at the thought of two powerful lords uniting to overthrow her master, the Sukran king.

Once again, she placed the plates on the table, turning back to peruse the other documents.

She was searching for further evidence when a sharp blow landed on her head, plunging her into darkness even before she could fall unconscious to the ground.

The throbbing in Gwen's head intensified as she struggled to open her eyes, the bright sunlight piercing through her eyelids.

Although the agony made it difficult for her to open her eyes, she could sense the warm sunlight filtering through her closed eyelids.

She lay face-down on the hard floor, her hands bound behind her back. Groaning in pain, she tried to move her legs, only to discover they were also tied.

Groaning in pain, Gwen strained to hear the voices around her. As she stirred, a bored female voice inquired, "My Lord, may I wake her?" The woman's tone clearly conveyed a desire to be elsewhere.

A gruff response echoed through the tent, "Here, here, my darling. Where would all the fun be if there is no foreplay to an interrogation? I savor the wait as much as I enjoy torturing these fools."

Gwen's stomach constricted at the man's chilling words, foreboding the torment that awaited her.

"Ha!" The gruff voice boomed again, "It seems the girl is awaking on her own."

Rough hands hoisted her up, dragging her towards their leader. Blinking in the harsh sunlight which seemed to have reached its zenith, Gwen glimpsed a man with a grizzled face and stern expression. His attire, steel armor and a massive longsword strapped to his back, spoke of a warrior's life. Beside him stood a beautiful woman, clad in a flowing pink peplos, her eyes filled with disdain as they met Gwen's. Two guards, their crossbows trained on her chest, stood at the tent's edge.

Gwen quickly realized she was still clad in her shirt and pants, but her cloak and cleverly

concealed knives were stripped from her person. She was bound and imprisoned in the heart of the illegal phalanx's camp - the command tent.

Steeling her nerves, she lifted her head to meet the gaze of the man in steel armor, a massive longsword strapped to his back. He was fiddling with a knife, a cruel smirk playing on his lips.

"Someone finds themselves in a rather precarious situation," the warrior declared with a twisted smile.

Gwen knew Sylvius wouldn't be expecting her return until sunset. *Could she endure another six hours at the mercy of these men?* She trembled at the horrifying thought but refocused her attention on the huge man.

"My Lord," she stammered, fear widening her eyes, "I do not understand why I am bound like a prisoner. I am but a simple maid."

"*A simple maid, eh?*" The man chuckled, his gaze sharp. "A maid who happens to be carrying a dozen knives in her person?"

His voice hardened. "Girl, let us dispense with this charade and get down to business, shall we?"

Gwen met his gaze with a defiant smirk. "Surely, you can't blame a girl for trying, can you?"

The man's lips twitched in a brief smile. He studied her intently. "Your predicament will only worsen with your imprudent tongue." He signaled to a guard, who marched forward and struck Gwen across the face. She cried out, falling back onto her back. The guard roughly yanked her back to her knees and retreated a few steps.

"Do we understand, Lomer?" The big soldier's gaze bore into Gwen, emphasizing the final word. .

Gwen understood she couldn't lie her way out of this. The beautiful woman beside the big warrior was clearly a truth-seeker, invited here to this interrogation to discern truth from falsehood.

Sucking in a sharp breath, Gwen met the soldier's gaze. "I am not yet a Lomer," she accepted, her voice barely a whisper. "Perhaps not ever."

Erasmus chuckled, a cruel sound that sent shivers down Gwen's spine. "Has the old king gone senile, sending children to spy on his enemies?"

His laughter died down, and he turned back to her. "What is your name, girl?"

Should she reveal her true identity? Gwen hesitated, weighing the options. In the end, she decided there was no harm in exposing herself to these traitors. She was virtually a nobody, after all. Revealing her true name might, at the very least, save her from further beatings if the truth-seeker detected any lies.

"Gwendolyn. And to whom do I owe the pleasure of entertaining, Your Majesty?" she asked, bowing sarcastically.

Erasmus's smile widened. "You definitely are entertaining me, girl. I am Erasmus Berian."

Gwen's blood ran cold. Erasmus was a legend, the kingdom's most feared swordsman, a man whose skill with a blade was unmatched.

"Where have I heard the name...Gwendolyn..." He muttered to himself before he strode towards the command table, flipping through a pile of scrolls. He selected a thick one and leafed through it swiftly. "Gwendolyn...Gwendolyn..." He sought any mention of the girl's name in the scroll

His eyes widened in surprise as he stopped at the name Gwendolyn at the top of the scroll.

"*Bless the Great One!*" he exclaimed. "Lady Luck smiles upon us today." He turned to his wife, a broad grin etched on his face.

"Who is she, My Lord?" the beautiful truth-seeker inquired, her voice laced with curiosity.

Erasmus's gaze fell back on Gwen with a sneer. "We have the pleasure of hosting the prince's girlfriend herself," he declared, his voice dripping with amusement, "and a wannabe Sukran Queen."

Gasps filled the tent, followed by delighted grins.

Gwen's face drained of color. The situation had taken a drastic turn for the worse.

Erasmus leaned in closer to her face, his voice a low menacing growl. "Boys, we have the prince's schedule now."

"*No. Never will I betray Dorian,*" Gwen stiffened, her voice unwavering despite the fear gnawing at her.

"Oh, you will soon betray your boyfriend!" Erasmus gestured to a guard, a cruel smile playing on his lips. The guard stepped forward; his fist clenched. Panicked, Gwen tried to summon her wind elemental and shield her from the impending punch, but to her horror, her elemental refused to answer her. The guard flexed his wrists and punched her face without hesitation.

Her elemental had deserted her when she needed it the most.

Disoriented and in shock, Gwen couldn't even muster her muddled mind to think clearly and summon her magic again. As she doubled over in pain, another blow landed on her stomach. The guard hauled her up to her knees by her hair.

Erasmus's voice cut through her haze. "Stupid girl," he sneered, "you've been poisoned to prevent you from summoning your elementals."

Gwen's heart sank. But then, a spark of hope flickered. Her hairband, with the tracking stone and the Obilisque, was still clasped to her hair and yet to be confiscated. She quickly suppressed her emotions, fearing the water caster might detect her flicker of hope.

Bracing herself, she endured the pain, ignoring the blows that rained down on her. Blood trickled down her chin as she screamed in agony. Finally, Erasmus called a halt to the brutal torture.

"Look here, lomer! It will be a lot easier for you if you talk," he said, his voice dripping with sarcasm. "We have plenty of time to break you and inflict unimaginable pain before you die. You will reach the afterlife one way or another if you continue to show defiance."

He leaned closer, his voice dripping with malice. "Do you think you can save your beloved? We have spies and assassins tracking his every move."

"Even as we speak, Dorian has invited Lord Ravesian to negotiate an alliance," Erasmus sneered, his contempt evident at a Sukran prince stooping low enough to barter an alliance with a

noble lord and secure more support for his ascension to the Sukran throne.

"Dorian is a blight upon those to have worn the title of Sukran crown prince. He will be eliminated soon enough," he added ominously. "It is only a matter of time. It is up to you, Gwen, whether you choose to suffer the same fate or join our side."

Gwen's mind raced, ignoring the absurd offer of betraying her beloved Dorian. But only one thought circled her mind. *How had she been captured?* Her plan had been flawless.

She shook her head. This is no time to be remorseful. She remembered old Malin's words from the university: "Any problem can be viewed as an opportunity if viewed from the proper perspective."

Perhaps she should heed the counsel of one of the esteemed lecturers from the university. However, the challenge lay in figuring out how to transform this distressing discovery of her identity as Dorian's lover by these scoundrels into a positive outcome.

She steeled herself. Erasmus's discovery that she was the prince's girlfriend was a double-edged sword. He wouldn't risk killing her until he obtained the information he craved from her. As long as she resisted and stalled the interrogation, she could survive without the fear of being murdered by these thugs. If she can buy time for her mentor, she was hopeful that Sylvius would arrive to rescue her from these vermins.

She gave Erasmus a warm grin with puffy lips. "By the Great One, you can all rot in hell," she spat out, defying him even in the face of torture.

Her defiance earned her more beatings before she finally succumbed to unconsciousness.

Gwen awoke with a jolt, the truth seeker looming over her and placing a hand on her chest. She found herself submerged in a water tub.

This woman was a healer?

"Gwen, Gwen," Erasmus chided her. "We shall heal you each time you lose consciousness. My wife will only heal you enough to keep you from succumbing to unconsciousness."

The soldiers dragged her from the tub and dumped her on the floor roughly. She gasped, the pain shooting through her limbs. They had cut the cords that bound her hands and legs to prevent her from writhing during the water casting inside the water tub.

She could hardly feel her hands and legs, much less defend herself with them.

She remained barely conscious throughout the evening while she was tortured. She was repeatedly healed and tormented, causing her captors to grow increasingly agitated, yet she remained silent and tight-lipped about Dorian.

She desperately prayed for Sylvius to come to her aid.

"*Speak up, girl!*" Erasmus snarled, his anger boiling over. "Where did you plan to meet the prince in the capital for the Wintersend Festival? *Speak now!*"

"My Lord," the water caster, Korinna, intervened, placing a restraining hand on Erasmus's arm. "We can't keep mending her forever. The energy required to heal comes from her own body, and she is at her limit. Torture her any further, and she will die, taking the precious information

you seek to her grave."

Erasmus glared at Gwen, his eyes filled with rage. He took a deep breath, regaining control of his emotions.

"You're correct, Korinna. Indeed, she is a strong girl. She has resisted for one long day."

"Yes!" The woman conceded. "This one is strong-hearted!"

Erasmus gazed intently at Gwen. "Well, girl. We'll break you in a day or two. And all of this will be for naught."

Erasmus turned to the guards. "Tie her up and post guards outside the tent." He barked the order before storming out of the tent, leaving Gwen bound and alone.

The guards duly secured her wrists and legs, yet Gwen hardly registered the act as she slumped into the ground with disbelieving ears and heart-wrenching anguish—a suffering more excruciating than the physical assault she had endured throughout the day.

Chapter 8

A Lesson in Humility

Never underestimate any man, for he will never underestimate you. In fact, the deadliest adversary you face is not the man you underestimate but your own arrogance.

Make way for the biggest humiliation when you underestimate your adversary's intellect while overestimating your intelligence in arrogance, for arrogance is the downfall of all.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

Elissa swelled with pride watching her nephew Theron finally receive the respect and recognition he deserved after years of abuse and ridicule.

Count Marius grinned as he handed Adrian ten gold coins. "This is the only wager I've ever been happy to lose. This was one of the most remarkable Wintersend Tournaments I've ever witnessed, and I've seen lords and even Prince Livian himself compete in the capital."

Adrian beamed as he collected the coins. "The boy has never let me down."

The valet approached the count. "Shall we begin the honoring ceremony, My Lord?"

"Yes, Camvus. Let's get started when you're ready."

Camvus nodded and ascended the dais, addressing the excited crowd still buzzing about the unorthodox tactics used by the tournament winners. "I want to express my gratitude to Sir Marius for organizing this fantastic Wintersend Tournament. Without wasting any more time, let me invite him to the podium to award the victors." Camvus bowed and exited the dais as Count Marius took his place.

Using his air elemental, the count broadcast his voice to reach the entire crowd.

"Today, we witnessed a historical, game-changing performance by the young men of our valley. I commend the bravery and talent displayed by every participant. It fills me with hope that our realm, and especially our border town, will be in good hands when the old works like me retire."

The count's quip was met with laughter. Despite his nearly seventy years, he was as fit as a soldier half his age. He wasn't hailed as the best general of their generation for nothing. King Primus himself had declared Marius a war hero few decades ago.

"I would now like to invite each of the victors to the podium to receive a boon that I can grant within my authority as count of this border town and former general of the Crown phalanxes."

Kelvin, the metal caster teammate of Theron, approached the podium and bowed before the count. "My entire life, I've envisioned myself practicing with the elite of the fortress. I'd like to

be enlisted into your fortress to train alongside those fine soldiers."

The count smiled and nodded. "Your request, young metal caster, shall be granted." The crowd erupted in applause as Kelvin bowed his gratitude before returning to his cheering teammates.

Belarian followed the meta caster and bowed to Marius. "My Lord, I am a farmer and would like my farm to be exempt from all taxes for a year."

"Your request is granted, young earth caster," the count replied with another nod.

The crowd continued to applaud as Schultz and Pepwick received the same boon to be exempted from taxes for a year.

Finally, Theron ascended the stage, greeted by deafening cheers and a standing ovation. He bowed to the count and then to the entire audience before turning back to face the count.

The count smiled warmly at him. "I was truly impressed with your strategy and decision-making throughout the game. Your tactics have the potential to revolutionize the way the game is played in the future. But more importantly, I am incredibly impressed with the way you demonstrated the flaws in our power-based culture and how a humans' willpower can surpass any power."

The count peered at the gathered townspeople. "You may have even sown seeds of doubt about our way of life within some of our townsmen, which is an even greater accomplishment than winning this tournament."

"Thank you, My Lord," Theron bowed.

"Ask me for any boon within my power to bestow, and it is yours."

The crowd fell silent, eagerly anticipating the request from the day's hero. They had learned one thing today: never expect the expected from this extraordinary young man.

Theron's eyes narrowed. "My Lord, I request that you use your authority as the count of this border town and former war hero of the realm to recommend me as a *potential cadet to the university at the capital*."

Murmurs rippled through the crowd. The university was the kingdom's premier institution of learning, only accepting the most brilliant students. To be enrolled, one had to either be a spectacular elemental caster or extravagantly wealthy, neither of which applied to Theron.

The university was every young man and woman's dream, a gateway to a life of luxury. Its graduates were highly sought after and welcomed into key roles across the kingdom. However, each year, only the offspring of prominent lords and influential people were granted admission.

The count studied Theron intently for a full minute. "Are you aware that your request is *seldom granted*?"

Theron nodded. "Indeed, My Lord. However, there are precedents that it has been granted on occasion," he added, emphasizing the last few words.

The count continued to scrutinize Theron. "Why do you wish to attend the university? Do you desire the power and influence that comes with learning alongside the children of prominent lords?"

"*Nay, My Lord*," Theron replied in a soft voice, a gentle shake of his head accompanying the words. "Respect, as an equal, is all I crave. Power holds no allure for me, but curiosity gnaws at

me on why I am the sole Sukran bereft of magic, unable to cast even a single elemental at my will."

The Count's gaze softened with contrition as he met Theron's. "I sympathize for your plight, young man. In fact, your tactical acumen impresses me greatly, making me even to yearn for you to gain magic, so that you may serve the realm with even greater prowess."

Hope flared inside Theron's heart.

"However," the count sighed, his voice heavy with regret, "your dearth of elemental magic casts an ominous shade upon your application. I doubt even the discerning eyes of the enrollment councilors will see past your lack of magical prowess to discover the exceptional mind that resides within you." The count's words were like a hammer blow, shattering the young man's hopes and dreams, leaving Theron with the suffocating sensation that fate was determined to deny him his rightful place. Years of earnest effort and tireless pursuit felt like dust blowing away in the wind, leaving Theron with a profound sense of despair.

"Even with my endorsement as a war hero and a former general," he added, "the university doors may remain firmly shut for your application, despite your stellar performance today."

Theron felt the world crumble around him, threatening to swallow him whole. Yet, he held fast to his composure, unwilling to squander this singular opportunity to reclaim the respect he craved.

"Then, My Lord," he inquired, his voice resolute, "what kind of recommendation would truly hold weight with the enrolment councilors?"

"There are precedents," the Count grumbled. "I can replicate them by sending you on a quest no other elemental caster has ever completed. If you succeed, the university councilors may be persuaded to consider your application seriously."

A shaft of hope pierced through the darkness that had begun to engulf Theron. "My lord, If you can set me on a quest no other caster has accomplished," he declared with unwavering conviction, "I will devote every fiber of my being to its completion."

Marius, his gaze filled with concern, tried to dissuade Theron from venturing down this perilous path of redemption. "Even if you succeed in your quest, I fear you wouldn't be able to afford the university's exorbitant tuition. Without a sponsor, I'm afraid your dream will remain just that – a dream."

Adrian, who had been standing behind the Count, stepped forward. "My Lord, I am willing to sell my farmhold to sponsor Theron's enrollment into the university."

The Count began to protest Adrian's offer, but Theron intervened. "Uncle, I will not allow you and Auntie to sacrifice your life's work for the sake of my aspirations. I have already secured the necessary funds."

The Count spun around, his jaw slack with astonishment. Theron whistled, and to his command, five heavy bags of gold coins flew from within the crowd, landing with a thud at his feet.

"Each bag contains a thousand gold coins," Theron announced, "which I trust will be sufficient to cover my studies at the university."

The Count's jaw dropped. "How did you acquire such wealth?" He squinted, a terrible

suspicion dawning upon him. "Did you steal these coins?"

"Not at all, My Lord," Theron chuckled. "You asked me to secure a single sponsor, but instead, I have secured the support of the entire valley. Their generosity will see me through my studies at the university." He smiled warmly at the Count, his arms outstretched in a gesture of gratitude.

The revelation hung in the air, silencing the crowd.

The Count, still grappling with the revelation, furrowed his brow and asked, "What do you mean by the valley sponsoring your studies?"

Theron, gesturing towards the gambler's tent, explained, "Many of my townsmen believe that raw elemental power can triumph over anything standing on its path. They share Ferris' opinion that my lack of magic has cursed our valley."

A tense silence descended upon the crowd as Theron continued, "Many anticipated my exile after losing to Ferris. Thus, when they learned I was wagering all my coins on winning this tournament, they bet against me."

"They aimed to punish me for besmirching their valley with my presence, stripping me of all my possessions before driving me out as penance."

A sardonic chuckle escaped Theron's lips. "The irony is, they desired my departure, and I too wish to leave this town. So, in a sense, they are funding my university education."

Count Marius couldn't help but chuckle along. "So, that's why you bowed to the crowd earlier?"

"Indeed, my lord. They are unintentionally sponsoring my university aspirations."

Marius regarded Theron for a moment, then inquired, "Young man, how did you convince the townsfolk to wager five thousand gold coins against you? I have known most of them for more than a decade, and I am certain many are thrifty individuals who hesitate to part with their coins for anything less than substantial."

"I did not influence them directly. Sir Sergius, who resides on our farmhold, played an instrumental role in swaying the townsfolk to gamble against me."

Gasps rippled through the crowd as they all turned as one towards Sergius, disbelief etched on their faces.

"I enraged Sergius by teaching him a lesson in the morning on humane values. Sergius was beyond enraged at being instructed a lesson by a magicless freak, so he sought to exact revenge on me and sate his ego."

"While I only manipulated Sergius, his magnanimity – or lack thereof – led him to manipulate the townsfolk against me. Their existing prejudice towards me as a magicless individual must have made Sergius' task effortless. Sergius didn't stop just there. He even persuaded Ferris to challenge me and forced me to accept exile as the penalty for losing the challenge to the most powerful contestant in the tournament today."

"Sergius mistook a sack of brass coins for gold and used it to convince the townsfolk to wager against me. In his zeal to destroy me, he misled the greedy townsfolk into betting against my chances, inadvertently aiding me in acquiring five thousand gold coins."

"I exploited Sergius' desire to disgrace and rob me before banishing me. He was so

consumed by his hatred that he never considered his actions could inadvertently aid me."

Marius's curiosity was piqued and regarded Theron for some time. "How much did you wager on your own victory?"

"One gold coin, Your Majesty. Just one coin that Sergius paid for helping him around in our farmhold." Theron smiled at the Count. "Most of the townsfolk wagered five thousand gold coins to win my single coin."

"Five thousand against a single coin?" Marius was awestruck at the young lad manipulating an entire town with such ease.

"It is simple to persuade individuals deluded by anger or greed. And to my good fortune, I live in a town full of people who despised me and were eager to steal my monetary possessions. However, I think they learned a valuable lesson—that arrogance and greed are not the ideal companions and can lead to inevitable downfall."

"Hmm! I am beginning to comprehend a few of your unconventional strategies now." Marius wagged his finger at Theron. "You deliberately chose a seemingly weak team to further entice your critics, didn't you? You were aware that our townsmen would underestimate your squad, believing it had no chance of winning with such a weak team, thereby goading their greed to gamble their hard earned money with more assurance than would have been possible with a strong team." Marius deduced, finally grasping the rationale behind Theron's peculiar team selection.

"Each of my teammates was formidable in their own way, My Lord," Theron clarified. "But our townsfolk underestimated them because they lacked Ferris' raw elemental power. I aimed to show them that magic is not a power, but a tool."

"And any tool is only as powerful as the user's mind. A powerful fool is still a fool."

Theron directed his gaze at the crowd. "I wanted to plant a seed within their minds, hoping it would lead them to introspect on their conduct so far and realize that mind and willpower are more important than a tool like magic."

"A man with powerful magic can build you a house in a blink of an eye," he explained, "but a man driven by passion and determination, even with limited magic, can craft a dream home that will bring you enduring joy. *It is not the magic that matters, but the heart that wields it.*"

He raised his voice, his words echoing through the silent air, "Therefore, let us not judge individuals based solely on their magical abilities, but on the passion and strength that reside within their hearts."

A profound silence descended upon the crowd, their minds grappling with the wisdom Theron had imparted. They had witnessed firsthand how a young man, underestimated and ostracized for his lack of magic, had triumphed through strategic thinking, unwavering determination, and the unflinching courage of his heart.

Marius watched with admiration as the young man before him achieved his goals and, in doing so, taught his narrow-minded neighbors a valuable lesson about broadening their perspectives.

Sergius stood frozen, absolutely overwhelmed by a mixture of shock and shame. The revelation that he, in his arrogance and anger, had played into Theron's hands was a bitter pill to swallow. He looked around at the faces of the townsfolk, their expressions filled with a mixture of disappointment and anger at leading them to be fooled by magicless freak.

It hurt to be fooled by a fool. It made the crowd realize that they had been a bigger fool than the magicless freak. And they blamed Sergius for the debacle.

Sergius understood that he had irrevocably lost the trust and ears of many townsfolk. It would be better to depart the stronghold so he wouldn't have to face the enraged locals any time soon.

"*Never underestimate anyone indeed,*" Marius declared. "You've taught us a valuable lesson. I assume you even managed to orchestrate your challenge with Ferris through Sergius to pique the crowd's interest and gamble their coins against your odds?"

Theron responded with a delicate smile, "My Lord, I never asked Ferris to challenge me. Gaby, my friend, spilled the information to Sergius that Ferris would be angered by my participation in the tournament. Sergius must have provoked Ferris to fight me, believing I would be terrified to face Ferris in the tournament."

The count was amused. "Poor Ferris had no idea he was being influenced." The count rubbed his cheek. "But why him?"

"Ferris is regarded by everyone here as the role model of how a citizen should serve the realm with powerful magic," Theron said. "My aim was to impart a lesson to the townspeople, and who better to employ as an exemplar for this lesson than the man acknowledged as one of the most potent casters in the valley?"

"I needed to shake them from their entrenched prejudices," he explained, his voice calm and composed, "I needed to take down their idol, their inspiration, and impart a lesson that would resonate throughout the valley that no power, not even the most potent magic, can stand against the unwavering willpower of a human!"

"Besides, Ferris, on the other hand, is an incredibly powerful elemental caster spending his entire life in arrogance without learning the harsh realities of life beyond the valley. Like most other townsmen, he needs to understand that he'll be treated the same way he treats others."

The count nodded, impressed. "Well said, young man. I am surprised by the number of objectives you intended to achieve by winning the tournament. I was hailed as a war hero by the kingdom's most prominent lords and brightest citizens. However, I feel you can even surpass my achievements if you obtain your military training."

The count offered Theron a position in his phalanxes, where he still held influence. Theron, however, declined politely.

"Without magic, I'm certain the military will discard me just like the university," Theron explained. "I need your recommendation to attain my magic by researching with the brightest minds at the university, which also houses the world's largest library."

The count sighed deeply. "You are very tenacious, boy. This goal may cost you your life. Is

your ambition to enroll in the university more important than life itself?"

"No, Your Grace. Ambitions are never more important than life" Theron responded solemnly. "But respect is paramount in my books. I believe the right to be treated equally with a basic respect reserved for a fellow human is more vital than life itself. I am prepared to risk my life to earn the respect I so dearly crave."

Elissa tried to intervene, but Marius stopped her. "He's an adult, Elissa. We cannot decide for him. We can only empathize with his plight, but none here could ever comprehend his suffering."

The count faced Theron with a serious expression. "I admire your accomplishments, truly. But you had a great deal of assistance from your teammates to win this tournament. This quest, you must undertake alone if you are to prove your mettle to the enrolment councilors in the university. I cannot send you alone on a dangerous quest unless I am convinced you can handle its perils."

Hope rekindled inside Theron. "My Lord, how do I demonstrate that I am qualified for this quest?"

The count gave him a sharp look. "By accepting the challenge to beat five of my best warriors in this fortress."

Theron hesitated, frowning in contemplation. He was unsure of his ability to duel trained soldiers, let alone the best in the fortress. But he had nothing to lose, as his ambition of attending university would be shattered if he declined the challenge from Marius.

Just as Theron was about to accept, the count stopped him with a raised hand.

"These warriors are better trained and experienced than the young lads you fought in the tournament," the count explained. "These duels are fought with real swords and armor. There have been unintentional fatalities in the past during such duels."

He looked at the young man with pity before delivering the final blow.

"Moreover, your uncle stands top among my finest soldiers. Despite being a farmholder, he continues to serve me faithfully. So, ponder well if you wish to engage in a duel with the man who relinquished his knighthood and marriage to nurture you into the remarkable young man you've grown into."

The notion of a father-son duel cast a chilling silence across the fortress grounds. Theron, stunned by the unexpected turn of events, grappled with the decision to accept the challenge and potentially endanger his uncle, who had sacrificed so much for him.

Adrian, discerning Theron's thoughts, stepped forward and locked eyes with him. "Boy, don't fret about harming me."

With a lump in his throat, he added, "I wholeheartedly wish for your victory to fulfill your dream of enrolling in the university. But my honor will not let me surrender without a fight. Even though I desire your success, I will fight tooth and nail to defeat you."

A few moments of silence ensued as Theron closed his eyes, contemplating his predicament. He realized that his uncle could only be harmed if he acted recklessly. There was a way to ensure Adrian's safety during the duel. Theron steeled his resolve, determined to choose death over causing irreparable harm to his uncle.

Following Cadmus's guidance to center his mind, he composed his emotions and opened his eyes to face the count with unwavering determination.

"I accept the challenge!"

Chapter 9

The Challenge

Success is not final, failure is not fatal: It is the perseverance to continue that counts. Most often, a bend in the road is not the end of the road for those who persevere till the last step.

And, It's always too soon to quit, for you fail only when you stop trying.

I will persevere until my last breath to reform Sukra. All I need is a catalyst to usher in the change.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

The air crackled with anticipation as Count Marius rallied his finest warriors for the impending challenge. He had commanded the grounds be prepared for the upcoming duels with meticulous attention to detail, ensuring a spectacle worthy of the occasion.

Elissa approached the tent where Theron was preparing for the imminent duels. A wave of dread washed over her, momentarily causing her to stumble. The day had been a whirlwind of emotions for her. Initially, she was devastated when she learned of Theron's daring wager: exile if he lost the tournament. As she witnessed him effortlessly defeat his opponents with skill and cunning, a surge of pride and elation coursed through her veins. Yet, a new worry gnawed at her heart - the dangers that awaited him during the challenge itself, and beyond, should he return victorious.

Aware of Count Marius' reputation for never exaggerating the gravity of any challenge, Elissa apprehended that the impending quest would be exceptionally perilous. Hence, a nagging doubt persisted: should she wish for Theron's victory in both Marius' challenge and subsequently in the quest, knowing it would lead him away to the university, away from her protection, and into the clutches of the power-hungry elite?

She possessed the ability to influence events atleast within this border town to protect her nephew. However, in the capital, where the worst of the populace dwelled primarily, she fretted over whether Theron would be able to fend for himself without the aid of magic.

No! Not anymore! She resolved to place her trust in her nephew and allow him to explore the world. Just as she hadn't hindered Theron's mother from exploring the kingdom and experiencing the best years of her life beyond the confines of the border town. Although Felixa was never quite the same upon returning from her hiatus, Elissa acknowledged that her sister had savored the finest moments of her life outside the valley, even though it eventually exposed her to the harsh realities beyond this border town.

"Don't expect others to be content living here just because you are content here in this valley," Elissa reminded herself.

So, if she was not going to prevent Theron from leaving the valley, she might as well

endeavor to enhance his prospects of victory in any way she could assist him.

Steeling herself and keeping her emotions in check, she entered the tent to find Theron and Cadmus engaged in final preparations, where the master was offering instructions and wisdom to his ward before his most important duel.

Upon seeing Elissa, Theron greeted her with a dazzling smile, "Hope I haven't aged you a year today, Aunty?"

She chuckled at his buoyant demeanor despite the impending challenge, which bespoke volumes of his adeptness at controlling his emotions. Despite his outward cheerfulness, she could discern that he was a bundle of nerves, well aware that he faced an uphill battle just to stay in the fight for pursuing his dream to enroll in the university.

Choosing to play along, she feigned shock and exclaimed, "*A year?* You have aged me by a decade at least!"

Theron's grin became even wider. Elissa continued gazing at her boy with adoration. "I am proud of your accomplishments today."

Theron continued with his task of adorning his unmetal armor while nodding gleefully at her praise. "Several factors played in my favor to help me win the tournament."

Elissa shook her head. "I was more pleased to see you demonstrate the importance of respecting others regardless of their skills and rank."

Theron's smile deepened, agreeing with her assessment of his true accomplishment of the day. His aunt was always astute enough to recognize the crucial details that others would overlook.

Turning to Cadmus, Elissa inquired, "What do you think of his chances in these upcoming duels, Cadmus?"

Cadmus, with a shrug, responded, "He's yet to be truly tested so far. His greatest challenge will not be outwitting his opponents in swordplay, but rather adapting to the ever-changing dynamics of a duel. He's trained only with a small group of opponents so far, slowly learning their strengths and weaknesses through repeated practice. Today, however, he must quickly assess each opponent's strengths and weaknesses and formulate effective countermeasures."

"Considering his inexperience in duels with different opponents, I'd say he has an equal chance of winning as he does of losing." Cadmus continued, his gaze fixed on Elissa. "But my greatest concern is that his emotions might cloud his judgment and get the best of him when he faces Sir Adrian."

Elissa thanked Cadmus for his candid assessment, then turned back to Theron. His exceptional emotional control made it impossible for her to decipher his thoughts. Even before he reached adolescence, his ingenuity in concealing his emotions had amazed and sometimes frustrated her. He had learned early on that she could detect his lies with her powerful spirit elemental magic, and thus began a playful game of deception to deceive her with falsehoods during many of his mischievous pranks. Through trial and error, he had honed his ability to mask the truth from her prying eyes. With the start of his training under Cadmus, however, this veil of secrecy had become an impenetrable wall.

Elissa studied her nephew for a moment, "I suppose I should have had this conversation much earlier."

"What is the most important thing in a person's life?" she posed a thought-provoking question.

Theron pondered for a moment, "The most important thing is not glory, but the respect one earns from others."

Elissa raised an eyebrow, "What would you do with the respect people shower you with? It does little more than help you keep your head held higher. But does it truly bring happiness to your soul?"

She shook her head, her gaze unwavering, "No, Theron. I know the wounds left by years of abuse and criticism fuel your desire for respect, for acceptance as an equal by your brethren."

"But don't you think that actions undertaken to earn respect seem more of a selfish pursuit?" Elissa questioned, her words hanging heavy in the air.

Theron stared at his aunt, contemplating her profound question before she continued, "The most important thing in life is to love and be loved. With love, you can weather any storm life throws your way. But all the respect in the world won't shield you from the hardships that might be thrown at you by life."

She looked at her contemplating nephew. "I'm not discouraging you from giving your all to win this challenge and achieve your goals," Elissa continued, her voice laced with warmth and understanding. "But I don't want you to believe that losing this challenge is the end of the world."

Theron was deeply moved by his aunt's wisdom. *Could his aunt be right that he might be seeking respect for all the wrong reasons?*

"Am I guessing right that you are still on the fence, unable to decide if I am right or if you are right?" Elissa asked.

Theron chuckled at himself, his aunt managing to read his thoughts despite his vigorous control of his emotions.

"But Aunty," Theron protested. "I would never be able to attain my magic if I don't win this challenge, the subsequent quest and get enrolled in the university!"

"So what?" Elissa shrugged. "Are you desiring magic or respect in your life?"

Theron frowned for a moment. "How can I earn respect in a society based on magic if I don't even have an ounce of magic?"

Elissa sighed. "You may earn magic if you manage to enroll into the university or not. But I am sure that you would not earn true respect even if you manage to earn your magic!"

Theron was stunned. "Aunt, why do you say so?"

Wisdom filled her voice as she challenged his assumptions, "Do you truly believe that attending university and acquiring elemental magic will grant you the respect you crave and solve all your problems?"

"Won't I be treated equally like all other Sukrans?" Theron frowned.

"No," Elissa shook her head gently. "Even after mastering magic, you will face difficulties, just of a different nature!"

She paused, allowing her words to sink in. "We all know that the Sukran king is the most powerful magic caster in this kingdom. But is the king good because he possesses the strongest magic, wields the most power, and commands the respect of his subjects?"

Theron's brow furrowed in consideration. "No, auntie. It is a person's actions that define their character, good or evil. Not power or influence"

"Precisely" Elissa's eyes sparkled with wisdom. "Imagine, Theron," she began, "a mighty king uses his immense magic to protect several individuals from numerous raiders who were comparatively weaker than the king. Now, imagine a common citizen who risks his own life to save just one person from men far more powerful than himself."

A flicker of intrigue lit up Theron's eyes, his gaze fixed on his aunt, eager to hear her wisdom unfold.

With a gentle smile playing upon her lips, Elissa posed the question, her voice laced with a subtle challenge, "Whose actions stir a greater admiration within your heart?"

Theron paused, mulling over the question, before speaking with a conviction born of deep reflection. "The common man," he declared, his voice resolute.

Elissa's smile widened, a silent approval radiating from her eyes. "And why is that, my dear boy?" she inquired, her voice laced with a gentle curiosity.

"While the king, secure in his immense power, protected many more than the common man, the king did so knowing he could weather any storm these raiders might unleash," Theron explained "He faced no true risk, no genuine sacrifice, but was just adhering to his duty to safeguard his subjects."

"The common man, however," he continued, his voice filled with newfound understanding, "risked everything to save one life, even though he was fully aware that his adversaries, far stronger than he, could easily vanquish him."

"It is because he was willing to risk himself for another, to lay down his own life for a stranger's, that the common man deserves more respect and praise," he concluded, his voice ringing with conviction.

Elissa's smile blossomed, revealing a profound pride in her eyes. "Indeed, dear Theron," she said, her voice filled with warmth. "Do you see now that *it is not magic* that earns you respect but it is *your actions* that earns true respect?"

"With or without magic, respect is earned through the courage of your heart and the nobility of your deeds," Elissa declared, pointing her palm to Theron's heart.

Theron nodded, a newfound understanding glimmering in his eyes. He smiled at his aunt, a beacon of wisdom and guidance, who had a knack for helping him grasp the fundamental truths of life with such ease.

Instead of being a selfless man who performed every action without expecting anything in return, she drew attention to his selfish need to do any deed with the sole intention of earning respect.

His aunt was right as usual!

Doing good deeds just to earn respect itself was not a good deed and he knew for certain that no bad deed ever garnered respect amongst his brethren.

Consequently, he resolved never to pursue respect in exchange for a good deed, understanding that even expecting a return from a virtuous act diminishes its inherent goodness.

Sensing the conviction and understanding in Theron's gaze, Elissa reached out and

affectionately caressed his hair, her voice rising with encouragement. "So go forth, my dear boy," she said, her eyes blazing with pride, "and conquer the challenge that awaits you. Go with the blessings of your family and the respect you have earned today."

"Go out there with a peaceful mind that you will do your best to attain your goals without any concern about the outcome of these duels and lay down the burden on your shoulders so that your family may bear it for you for as long as necessary."

Anticipation crackled through the air. The upcoming duels were unlike any witnessed before in the history of the Wintersend Festival in the Lemurian Valley. The impressive performance of the magicless boy in the tournament had earned him at least grudging support of the townspeople, who backed him now to at least give the seasoned soldiers a fair fight.

Additionally, they eagerly awaited the battle between Adrian, their favorite fellow townsman who brought glory to the valley by getting awarded as a war hero, and the young man Adrian had raised as a son. This duel promised to be a spectacle, a clash between a skilled warrior and his student who had proven that elemental magic was not strength itself, but a tool to achieve one's goals.

The ground had been meticulously reconstructed for the duel. A half-mile circle, its perimeter marked by vibrant elemental symbols, stood at its center, ready to serve as the stage for the upcoming duels. Towering across the grounds stood fire elemental lamps, their flames fueled by sunlight absorbed during the day and unleashed under the command of skilled fire casters. These lamps bathed the entire area in a breathtaking golden hue that contrasted beautifully with the approaching dusk.

Theron arrived at the fortress grounds ahead of the count and his champions, seeking to familiarize himself with his surroundings. He wore his own armor, its unmetal construction gleaming under the light of the elemental lamps. He left his bow and quivers of arrows in his tent, anticipating that these duels would be more physical. His round shield was discreetly embedded within his unmetal armor at his midriff.

In this challenge, duelists were free to utilize any weapon or magic at their disposal to secure victory. The only restriction was that they could not leave the designated half-mile circle, or they would be disqualified.

As Count Marius and his champions entered the circle, Theron focused his thoughts and emotions. His aunt's wise counsel had lifted the burden from his shoulders, and he felt at peace, content with the knowledge that he had done his best to achieve his goal. He resolved not to obsess over the outcome of the challenge but rather to appreciate the occasion and the attention it had brought him.

An unexpected realization struck him: "Living life and all of its experiences were more wonderful than simply surviving whatever was thrown at us."

With anticipation buzzing in the air, Count Marius raised his hand to quell the crowd, "Theron of Adrian-Hold has challenged for a chance to enroll at the university. In my almost two

decades as the count of Lemurian Valley, this marks the first instance of a prospective cadet vying for a place at the university."

"I hope Theron continues to surprise us and overcome the odds in this challenge. I hope he will continue to outperform his opponents, as he has all day today."

Turning to Theron, the count addressed him. "I accept your challenge. I have assembled five of my finest warriors within the fortress today. If you can defeat them all, I will set you on a quest that can aid you to become a university cadet. However, you will not be healed between duels until you have either won all five duels or lost in any of them. Let the first duel begin, with Malefick Barius as your first opponent."

A tall, medium-sized man clad in legion armor and wielding a legion shield and longsword strolled into the circle. He began flexing his muscles to get ready for the duel.

Drawing upon Cadmus's teachings, Theron carefully assessed his opponent's strengths and weaknesses. The count hadn't specified Malefick's elemental magic, but through years of enduring harassment and ridicule from his townspeople, Theron educated himself to discern his opponent's magic by the way they carried themselves. And most often, their demeanor always revealed their magic affinity.

Malefick's square jaw, steely gaze, and ease of movement within his armor suggested he was a metal caster who had modified the edges of his armor to complement his movement and swordforms.

Cadmus had prepared Theron for every conceivable scenario, and Theron had also rehearsed against a shielded opponent. He began to formulate the tactics he should employ in each duel. As he wanted to maintain his stamina to outlast all five bouts, he understood the key was to prevent unnecessarily prolonging any single duel. Theron was also mindful of the fact that his endurance would hold little significance if he were to falter in the initial encounter.

So, he chose the middle ground. He decided to draw out the fight until he identified Malefick's strengths and weaknesses before going on the offensive.

Both fighters approached the count, who stood in the center of the circle.

"Weapons," the count asked Theron. One by one, Theron handed him his swords, daggers, knives, and shield. The count inspected them for poison and returned them after his inspection. He then requested Malefick's weapons and inspected them as well.

"The duel will commence as soon as I leave the circle," the count declared.

Both warriors nodded, their eyes locked in a tense stare. Theron drew both his swords as Malefick prepared his shield and longsword.

His opponent smirked at him. "Think you can last five minutes with me, boy?" Malefick snarled.

"Let's find out who lasts longer," Theron replied, a hint of apprehension in his voice. He had trained all his life against one swordsman, Cadmus, who employed diverse techniques in their duels. But this was his first duel with a trained soldier apart from Cadmus.

As the count exited the circle, he yelled, "Begin!"

Malefick launched the first attack in an attempt to catch the inexperienced lad off guard, but Theron was prepared. He effortlessly defended himself against the blows, refraining from

attacking the metal caster for the time being.

Theron quickly tried to discern the strengths and limitations of Malefick's swordsmanship. Theron made weak thrusts with his left blade to test the metal caster's defense and duly Malefick parried the thrusts with his shield.

The metal caster left evident openings intentionally to lure Theron in, but Theron was too well-trained to fall for such obvious traps. Malefick scowled, frustrated that Theron wasn't succumbing to his bait like most inexperienced swordsmen.

After several exchanges, Theron noticed a pattern. Malefick planted his left leg to provide himself with more strength to defend with a shield. This was a fundamental mistake for any skilled swordsman, as proper balance required a swordsman to distribute his weight evenly over both legs and standing on the balls of the feet to gain the ability to turn swiftly in any direction at a moment's notice.

Deciding to exploit the discerned mistake in his opponent's technique, Theron parried a stab from Malefick with his left sword and quickly feinted a blow to Malefick's right shoulder with his other sword. Malefick fell for the ploy, leaning forward with his right leg and extending his shield in an attempt to block the incoming strike. However, to Malefick's surprise, Theron abruptly withdrew from the feint at the last moment and whirled around towards Malefick's exposed back. Before Malefick could react, Theron struck Malefick in the nape of the neck with the pommel of his sword, rendering him unconscious.

Theron returned to his starting position within the circle. The spectators, stunned by the unexpected and swift conclusion of the duel, erupted in a thunderous applause for Theron's effortless victory over a skilled and seasoned soldier.

A healer examined Malefick and, noticing that he was still unconscious, requested that he be taken to the infirmary. Count Marius then entered the circle.

"That was a brief duel," he remarked, a smile on his face. "This gives me hope for the remaining duels. Let's see if Gorgus Avatan can fare any better against our young champion."

A towering figure, easily the largest man Theron had ever seen, lumbered into the circle. He wielded a massive ax and carried a shield as large as his chest.

The count inspected Gorgus' weapons before leaving the circle. "Begin!" he declared.

Gorgus, an earth caster of immense size and power, charged towards Theron with the ferocity of a bear. His massive ax swung with the force of a falling boulder, and his shield, as large as a chest plate, seemed impenetrable.

Theron, aware of his own limitations in brute strength, opted for agility and swiftness. He danced around the lumbering giant, dodging blows and slipping past defenses with the grace of a windblown leaf.

Theron opted to use his nimble footwork to wear out the earth caster rather than opting for a headlong defense or assault.

One attack, however, caught Theron off guard. Gorgus, anticipating his opponent's agility, launched a two-pronged attack: a ferocious swing of his ax to the right and a shield thrust to the left, aiming to trap Theron in a deadly pincer if the boy tried to sway out once more.

Theron was almost caught off guard by Gorgus' plan and barely managed to evade the

shield, his heart pounding in his chest. It was clear that he needed a new strategy. His primary objective became clear: disarm the earth caster's most lethal weapon, his shield.

Both men continued to circle one another and their dance continued, but Theron grew offensive in this bout. Theron began probing and feinting with both his swords, forcing Gorgus to defend with both ax and shield.

Gorgus, reeling from the sudden ferocity of the onslaught, raised his shield to deflect Theron's relentless jabs. Each bite of the twin blades probed for weakness within the stout shield, and Theron's nimble footwork kept the pressure relentless. Finally, with a swift but precise swing, Theron's unmetal sword met its mark, cleaving Gorgus' shield in two.

Fury contorted Gorgus' face. He roared, tossing aside the splintered shield, and charged, his axe a dark thunderhead aimed at the boy. But Theron, a whisper ahead of the attack, had already withdrawn, leaving the giant to bellow into the empty space.

Desperate, Gorgus summoned his earth elemental, a hulking behemoth of gray granite with bear-like features, to flank him. He swung his axe at Theron's left while the elemental lunged for the right, hoping to trap the nimble lad in a deadly vise.

Theron, however, danced through the storm. He swayed like smoke to miss the axe, then pirouetted past the elemental, leaving it to slam harmlessly into the ground he just vacated. With a predator's grace, Theron circled behind Gorgus, his blade a blur that found its mark on the giant's hamstring.

He made certain that he only sliced through the tendon muscles and did not cause irreversible injury.

Gorgus stumbled, the axe falling from his grasp while red hot agony searing through his leg. Theron, who appeared to be always a step ahead in this duel so far, retreated out of reach of the huge earth caster.

Gorgus spun, expecting another attack, but saw only the infuriating smirk of the boy waiting yards away. He roared at the insult and picked up his axe before charging at the lad despite the throbbing pain, but his wounded leg buckled beneath him, sending him crashing to the earth.

He scrambled up, one leg dragging, and leaned heavily on his axe, a primal snarl ripping from his throat.

Gorgus dispatched his bear-like manifestation made of gray granite stone to crush Theron from behind.

The bear circled Theron from behind. As Theron turned to pursue the elemental, it charged at him but suddenly stopped a few feet away. Theron instinctively backed away from the elemental, unwittingly stepping within range of Gorgus' fury.

The giant, fueled by hate and desperation, lunged forward on his uninjured left leg, his ax arcing down in a deathly arc. Theron sensed the danger from behind and dove to the ground just as the blade hissed past his head. He scrambled to his feet, but it was too late. The stone behemoth of an elemental, with a silent roar, slammed into him, its granite bulk sending him flying through the air to crash on his back, battered and bruised, ten feet away.

The bear elemental lunged again and attempted to crush Theron with its weight. But he flipped on impact, landing light as a feather and springing back to his feet. He dodged the

elemental's maul by a hair's breadth.

He regained his balance and laughed out loud. "Excellent strategy, Sir Gorgus."

Theron inspected his unmetal armor for damage, as it had absorbed most of the force from the stone elemental. Despite the unmetal armor absorbing the elemental's brunt, Theron knew a bruise bloomed on his chest. Undeterred, he watched the elemental prowl, sensing its next lumbering charge. This time, he decided he wouldn't wait.

Theron darted at the elemental's legs, the creature responding with a headbutt aimed at his skull. Anticipating the maneuver, Theron danced away, his blade flashing as he severed one of the beasts' leg. The elemental roared, toppling onto its remaining limbs. Before it could rise, Theron's sword danced again, severing the stone head.

The elemental disintegrated into dust as Gorgus roared in frustration at losing control of his most potent elemental. The majority of countryfolk used their manifested elementals as a means to control their magic. The loss of the manifestation caused them to lose control of their elementals. It then took a substantial minutes for their elemental to re-manifest.

However, the nobles did not typically manifest an elemental since it would be an easy target for their opponents to prevent them from unleashing their strong magic. Therefore, they trained their minds to focus on and control their elementals with their mind and spirit rather than manifested elementals.

Gorgus, limping and desperate, hoped to stretch this duel just long enough to re-manifest his earth elemental.

Theron, on the brink of attacking Gorgus and finish the duel, halted on noticing a sudden darkness enveloping his opponent. And soon the shadows continued to grow before it cocooned him in its embrace as well.

"*Shadow magic!*" Theron exclaimed in surprise, realizing Gorgus' strategy.

Gorgus, utilizing the shadows cast by the trees, created a swirling ball of darkness around him and Theron, rendering the center of the dueling ground pitch black.

As silence crept over the ground, the crowd attempted to peer through the shadows surrounding the two duelists. Only those with shadow magic could see the two duelists through the darkness.

Theron, lacking light magic, found it challenging to locate his opponent in the utter blackness of the shadows.

Theron felt a grudging admiration for Gorgus' cunning. This was no longer a clash of steel, but a chilling game of hide-and-seek.

Theron scoured the area for any sign of an assault from the gigantic earth caster. Gorgus could still see him as if he were standing in broad daylight through his shadows. But Theron was pushed into a corner, unaware of the true location of his opponent.

Theron, using his unique sensing talent, detected Gorgus creeping silently a hundred yards ahead.

It was time for him to become the hunter against his wounded opponent.

As Theron began to advance gently towards his foe, he sensed Gorgus' presence suddenly vanish in front of him.

Silence pressed down, a heavy weight against their straining ears. Theron sensed, rather than saw, Gorgus materialize behind him, ax glinting in the fading light. Theron dove at the last second, a blur of desperation, rolling across the dirt, the wind of the ax whooshing past his ear. He scrambled to his feet, but Gorgus was gone again, swallowed by the shadows.

"*Shadow walker!*" Gasps rippled through the crowd. The crowd marveled at Gorgus' shadow walking, a rare ability even amongst shadow magic casters.

Theron realized that Gorgus possessed a rare ability to use shadows to travel between two places covered in shadows. This unusual skill was not common among shadow magic casters, but it was not unheard of either.

Numerous scholars claimed that shadow walking demonstrated the basis of space magic, in which one might travel between two distant places. However, unlike mythical space magic, a shadow walker could only travel via shadows that were connected. Therefore, they were constrained in their ability to travel huge distances, but they were useful for sneaking around in their immediate vicinity.

Theron knew that Gorgus' abilities tipped the contest in his opponent's favor because the earth caster's injuries no longer hampered him.

The hunter had turned into prey!

Theron skillfully swayed out of an impending strike by sensing Gorgus' presence on his right at the very last moment. He retaliated with a swift swing of his own blade, aimed at Gorgus' presumed abdomen. But the air was empty – Gorgus, a wraith in the shadows, had vanished.

Then, a blur of movement, and the ax was bearing down on Theron's back. Theron barely managed to contort his body, the ax finding only his armored shoulder and sending him sprawling five feet to the ground. Theron scrambled to his feet, his hand instinctively checking the unmetal armor that had saved his arm.

The cat-and-mouse game continued, Theron a blur of desperate dodges against Gorgus' surprise attacks. The shadow caster, a predator stalking its prey, steadily herded Theron towards the edge of the circle, his movements observed by the grim faces of the shadow casters in the crowd.

Gorgus, intrigued by the lad's resilience to evade him without light magic, aimed to wear him down, a whirlwind of shifting shadows presaging the final blow to end the duel.

The crowd, their faces etched with pity for the young man lost in the darkness, relied on the whispered commentary of the shadow casters to understand the unfolding drama within the cocoon of shadows. Some muttered darkly, "Perhaps the boy is wrong. Nothing could defeat the power of magic, not even the strong will and passion displayed by the boy so far."

Theron, acutely aware of his precarious position, felt himself inching closer to the duelers' circle's edge.

A lull fell over the duel, Gorgus pausing to replenish the energy spent weaving his shadowy veil.

A cold wind whispered against Theron's back, a subtle clue that sent a spark of hope igniting in his chest. He was close to the far end of the circle, where the elements lay dormant, waiting to be harnessed by the duelists. With a surge of determination, Theron began to move, his

steps silent in the darkness, towards the memory of a fire pit nestled adjacent to a waterpool and a tree.

He inched ever closer to the fire pit hoping the flames would dispel the shadows surrounding him and preventing Gorgus from using shadow magic to dominate the duel.

But his senses suddenly screamed a warning. Gorgus, a phantom in the darkness, materialized before him. Theron, caught off guard, couldn't react in time. The ax, a brutal pendulum, slammed into his armored chest, sending him flying across the dueling circle to land near the water pool.

Gorgus, a triumphant sneer twisting his lips, turned towards the fire pit. With a savage swing of his axe, Gorgus smashed the fire pit into splinters, extinguishing the flames in a shower of sparks.

"The fire pit is demolished, boy," he snarled, a triumphant smile twisting his lips. "You can't hope to dispel my shadows with fire." Gorgus hissed at the young man who had almost made him doubt his prospects of winning the duel after wounding his leg and dispatching the manifestation of his earth elemental. He smirked that it was always useful to be a master at contrasting elementals as no one could foresee how each of their elementals could aid them in a situation.

Theron groaned, his body protesting the latest blow. Yet, he rose again, his unmetal armor a silent guardian which had saved him yet again. Gorgus vanished from the shattered fire pit, leaving Theron spinning in a desperate dance, searching for the shadow walker's next move. His senses, attuned to the ebb and flow of magic, screamed a warning the moment Gorgus reappeared behind him. But the shadow caster, a viper in the dark, was too fast. He was upon Theron before the young man could react, the shadow walker's sudden materializing out of thin air at the last moment neutralized Theron's only advantage in the duels against other magic casters – the ability to sense presences. Theron hardly got time to mount a defense after sensing the presence of his adversary only at the last moment.

Theron had only the time to duck beneath the ax-swing, but had no chance to turn aggressive against his wily opponent who vanished yet again.

Lost for any ingenious idea, Theron whirled around in circles apprehensively for the next attack while he sought a way to follow Gorgus' movements before the shadow walker appeared nearby.

Many in the audience could sense the young man straining to defend himself against the power of a shadow walker who had surrounded Theron with a web of dark magic.

Theron, trapped in a vortex of shadows, his mind racing for a solution, felt Gorgus appear behind him. But this time, Theron did the unthinkable. Instead of his usual evasive maneuver, he knelt, his body a blur of controlled movement. As Gorgus' ax arced down, Theron's foot lashed out behind him, a whipcrack in the darkness.

The ax missed his head by a hair's breadth, and with a powerful kick, Theron sent Gorgus sprawling into the water pool in surprise.

Gorgus scrambled out of the pool like a startled frog, vanishing into the shadows like a wisp of smoke, fearing Theron would dive in to the pool and neutralize his edge. But Theron,

surprisingly, didn't pursue. Instead, he sheathed his left blade, and drew a circular disc from its slot on his unmetal armor. Theron tapped the round disc that extended into a glorious shield.

Across the circle, a thoroughly soaked Gorgus materialized, sputtering and shaking himself off like a dog emerging from a lake. He flexed his legs, sending droplets of water flying from his waterlogged trousers. It was time to finish this young upstart. He lunged towards Theron, reappearing to Theron's left, but to his utter bewilderment, Theron had turned already to face him.

Theron lifted his shield which met the blow of Gorgus's axe with a resounding clang, sparks flying as metal sang against metal. Gorgus reeled back, stunned. Not only had Theron anticipated the location where he would appear, but this seemingly small shield had effortlessly deflected his powerful blow. The clash echoed through the arena, and Gorgus caught a glimpse of a hint of a smirk playing on Theron's lips.

Sensing danger, Gorgus mentally urged his shadow elemental to flee, but a searing blow from Theron's pommel connected squarely with his cheek.

Gorgus cried out, his vision momentarily swimming whilst the shadows whisked him away to the opposite end of the dueling circle. He stood there, panting, his hand instinctively going to his throbbing cheek.

"Must have been a lucky shot," Gorgus muttered, spitting blood onto the ground. He wouldn't give up that easily. With renewed determination, he decided to strike from behind the lad. He phased into the shadows, aiming to materialize right behind Theron, but just as he began to solidify behind his adversary, Theron whipped around, his movements impossibly swift.

Gorgus was caught off guard, Theron's shield once again connecting with his face with a sickening crack. Staggering back, Gorgus stumbled and fell, his breath knocked out of him. He scrambled to his feet, his mind reeling.

This wasn't possible. How could this magicless fool anticipate his every move? Fear gnawed at him as he commanded his shadow to whisk him away once more.

He reappeared a safe distance away, but the tide had turned. Agony lanced through his wounded thigh, his blood staining the sand crimson. Panic clawed at his throat.

He ripped a piece of his wet trousers and wrapped it around the gash, trying to staunch the flow of blood. He had to end this duel before darkness claimed him.

He glared at Theron, who stood motionless, observing him like a predator sizing up its prey.

It's time to confound the boy! Gorgus decided.

In a desperate gamble, Gorgus darted through the shadows, weaving a frantic path around Theron to confound his opponent before materializing a few feet to Theron's left.

The axe swung down, aimed at Theron's head, but the young man sidestepped with unbelievable grace just as Gorgus materialized. In a blur of motion, Theron lunged forward, his shield smashing into Gorgus's wrist with bone-jarring force.

The axe clattered to the ground with Gorgus screaming in pain.

Theron circled his prey, a predator stalking its wounded quarry. With a chilling precision, he slashed through the undamaged hamstring of Gorgus's unwounded left leg. The shadow walker crumpled to the ground, both his wounded legs buckling beneath him.

He tried to summon his shadow once more, but Theron's blade glinted menacingly at his throat. "Don't!" Theron commanded, his voice laced with steel.

Gorgus choked in apprehension on noticing the steel in his opponent's gaze. His shadow elemental wouldn't reach him in time. Gorgus raised his hand in defeat, his bravado crumbling. He couldn't believe he had been bested by a man without light magic to chase away his shadows.

"*I yield*," the shadow caster muttered, the bitterness of his defeat heavy on his tongue.

"Dispel your shadows, shadow walker," instructed Theron his adversary.

The crowd gasped as the shadows receded, revealing Theron standing triumphant over the vanquished Gorgus. A stunned silence hung in the air, broken only by the crackling fire and the chirping of crickets. Then, a thunderous roar erupted from the stands, the cheers echoing through the night.

Theron had accomplished the unthinkable. He had defeated a shadow walker without using any magic, leaving the crowd buzzing with questions and the defeated Gorgus with a newfound respect for his unconventional ingenuity.

"*How did he* defeat a shadow caster without light magic to dispel the shadows" Most people questioned the magicless freak's accomplishment of this inconceivable feat.

Theron lowered his blade, and Gorgus, still reeling from the shock of his defeat, looked up at Theron with a mixture of curiosity and grudging admiration. "How did you predict where I would apparate near you?" he croaked.

Theron shrugged, a hint of a proud smile playing on his lips. "I didn't predict the location where you apparated. I heard you before you apparated near me."

Heard me! Gorgus frowned. "Even though you appeared to be able to discern my whereabouts without light magic, I would wager my entire fortune that in the initial part of the duel, you were late in discovering where I would materialize from the shadows to pounce on you."

Theron agreed, "True, in the initial part of the duel, I couldn't pinpoint you until the very last moment of your shadowy leaps."

"*Then how did you best me?*" Gorgus frowned.

Theron winked, a sly smile playing on his lips. "I didn't predict your movements, Sir Gorgus. *I listened to them.*"

Gorgus frowned deeply. "*Listened?* I don't recall making any sound as I moved through the shadows."

Theron pointed to Gorgus' damp trousers. "You made no noise, but your wet trousers did."

"*Wet trousers?*"

"Precisely," Theron continued. "The telltale squelch of wet garments in motion betrays even the stealthiest movement. And I simply opted to listen for those squelching sounds to determine the location where you would apparate."

Gorgus protested, his voice laced with disbelief. "But surely the sound wouldn't reach you before I materialized beside you."

Theron shook his head. "You have forgotten one thing, Sir Gorgus. *Only light travels faster than sound.*"

"True, but my shadows are born from light, ain't it?" Gorgus defended, still grappling with how his wet attire had cost him the duel.

"Shadows are not light; they are the exact opposite. They represent the absence of light."

He smirked as healers and soldiers arrived to assist the fallen Gorgus. "Therefore, shadows can't move as fast as light or sound. The squelch of your damp trousers reached me long before you began to apparate near me."

The crowd buzzed with astonishment. Theron had once again used the laws of nature to triumph over a powerful caster.

Gorgus grumbled, bitterness lacing his voice. "So, you shoved me in the water on purpose? Had I not been hasty in my eagerness to defeat you, I could have thwarted your plan and avoided defeat."

"There were other ways to render your shadow magic useless without the use of wet trousers." Theron shrugged as the fortress guards hauled the captivated shadow walker out of the dueling circle.

"Why did you choose this wet trousers method?" Gorgus pressed as he let himself be hauled away from the dueling circle.

Theron met his gaze. "Because I didn't want to permanently harm a skilled opponent like you, just to win a mere duel."

Gorgus stared at the young man, surprised by the underlying confidence beneath his casual demeanor. It wasn't arrogance, but an unshakeable belief in his abilities.

Gorgus bowed his head as earth casters carried him away. "This was a worthy duel indeed, Theron. Should we meet again, I vow to be better prepared for your ingenious tactics."

Theron acknowledged the shadow walker who had pushed him to his limits. "I would be honored to face you again, Sir Gorgus."

Gorgus was soon carried away from the dueling circle.

Silence descended upon the ground as the soldiers of the fortress rebuilt the firepit and other elements to complement the duelists.

Theron mustered his strength as he observed the magnificence of the stronghold, which was illuminated by countless fire lamps on this beautiful night.

The count entered the circle once the preparations for the next duel were complete. "Outstanding performance, young man!" he boomed. "Defeating a shadow walker without light magic is no small feat. Three more to go!"

"You have conquered metal, earth, and shadow. Now, let's see how you fare against the other elementals."

"*Let's welcome Larus Gavius!*" Marius called out to his soldier.

A lean figure clad in legion armor jogged into the circle, armed with a slender sword and dagger. The count inspected his weapons and declared them free of poison before shouting, "Begin!"

Larus knelt beside the pool of water and conjured four identical copies of himself. His mastery of water and light magic made the illusions indistinguishable from the real him.

Each copy mimicked the caster's practice swings, indistinguishable from their originator.

Theron tried his best to follow the original Larus, but the water caster had other ideas to confound Theron.

Suddenly, a wave of water erupted from the pool, engulfing the five figures and obscuring Theron's view.

He scowled, trying to track the original Larus as the figures behind the water curtain shifted and rearranged themselves.

The crowd applauded loudly at the remarkable mix of water and fire casting exhibition, as they were unable to differentiate the real Larus from the illusions.

Theron lost track of the original Larus and drew his blades from their sheaths with a grimace.

The water ball slithered back to the pool, revealing five identical Larus standing side by side.

All five Larus' charged Theron and encircled him. Each Larus smirked sinisterly at his apprehension and circled him.

Theron tried his best to differentiate the original from the illusions to no avail. The prowling figures ceased. To his left, a Larus rushed at him.

Theron instinctively twisted to the left to intercept the impending blow but stumbled as his blade sliced through Larus' weapon and body as if they were made of paper. The illusion reshaped itself into the figure of Larus.

"Illusion." Theron understood, to his dismay, that the cunning light caster had set him up to make him look elsewhere from his actual location. Before Theron could regain his balance, he sensed a presence approaching from behind and stabbing him in the back. Theron swerved awkwardly in an attempt to deflect the thrust. In the nick of time, his longsword deflected the strike as a loud clash of metal on metal rang out.

Theron recognized he was gazing at the original light caster after noticing the sneer on his opponent's face.

Before he could strike his sword and separate the light caster from his illusions, another presence approached him from the right, and his instincts compelled him to spin around once again to face the new foe.

Midway through his action, he realized he had made a mistake by exposing himself to the original Larus. The real Larus struck him in the thighs.

Theron dropped to his knees and let the unmetal armor around his back deflect the sword thrust since he had no time to defend his unarmored thighs.

Sparks flew when the unmetal armor absorbed the brunt of the sword strike.

Theron rolled to the side to escape being stabbed in the head by Larus' dagger held in his left hand.

Theron hoped to climb to his feet while tracking the original Larus, but the shrewd light caster was mindful of his plans.

Larus lunged at Theron, kicking him hard in the chest. Larus flung Theron onto his back, causing him to crash through an illusion that stood behind him.

Theron experienced a chilling sensation as he flew through the illusion, which transformed

into Larus as soon as he went through it.

As soon as he hit the ground, Theron rolled onto his shoulder and rose with both swords at the ready.

Theron narrowed his eyes as each Larus switched positions to prevent him from determining the precise location of the light caster. They again encircled him. Theron muttered as he lost track of the light-caster yet again. He sought to sense whether each Larus felt identical. He could discern a slight difference in how he perceived one Larus compared to the other four.

"The presence of the original Larus feels more substantial than the water-cast illusions." Theron thought. He chose to disregard the illusions and focus solely on the more powerful presence of the real Larus. Larus and his illusions employed the same tactic of encircling him to confuse him with simultaneous strikes from all sides. However, Theron was riveted by the strongest presence.

Theron decided to put his assumptions to the test to make sure the trickster wasn't fooling him into thinking one illusion was more solid than the others.

As soon as Theron noticed the more substantial presence behind him, he spun around and charged at it with a loud growl.

The original Larus widened his eyes in shock at Theron's abrupt howl and retreated from Theron's quick, vicious assault. All of the other Larus' reacted similarly to the stronger presence, but a second later. Clearly, Larus was so astonished by Theron's unexpected charge that he lost concentration, causing them to mimic the original Larus.

Theron didn't let the original escape this time as he began stabbing and pushing his vicious swords toward the light caster, who battled to prevent them from reaching their target.

Theron spotted a gap in Larus' sword form and used the pommel of his blade to strike the light caster on the wrist.

Larus dropped his sword out of shock and agony but summoned one of his illusions to clobber Theron in the back.

Theron sensed the assault coming from behind him and instinctively turned to defend himself against his new assailant before realizing he had turned his back on his actual opponent.

Anticipating the real Larus to exploit the opening to stab him from behind his back, Theron flung himself towards the illusion stabbing it's sword at his chest.

Larus watched in disbelief as his dagger missed the young man's neck by a hair's breadth. However, the illusion's blade found its mark, plunging into Theron's stomach with a chilling sensation.

"Noooooooo!" Elissa wailed in anguish, eliciting gasps and startled exclamations from the stunned crowd. With a frantic leap, Theron evaded the remaining illusions and landed nimbly on his feet.

Spinning around, he faced a bewildered Larus and his startled illusions. Larus stooped to retrieve his sword, his face etched with disbelief that Theron had distinguished him from the illusions.

As the crowd grasped that it was only an illusion that had stabbed Theron and the boy remained unharmed, a wave of enthusiastic cheers erupted.

Theron grinned at the stunned trickster and his illusions.

Theron clenched his teeth as he realized that his ability to respond instinctively to an opponent's thrust was proving to be a significant disadvantage in this particular duel.

He had almost overcome Larus, but his ingrained reflexes hampered his efforts to finish the duel.

After years of training to rely on his instincts, he was unsure if he could control his instincts any better than in his last attempt.

Instead of suppressing instinct, Theron contemplated alternative strategies. A thought sparked a grin on his face.

Trick the trickster. Yes, it could suppress his impulses long enough for him to finish the duel.

The irony of the solution amused Theron.

As the five Larus figures shifted positions to confuse him once more, Theron focused on the stronger presence - the real Larus. Mirroring previous tactics, the five figures charged and surrounded him.

Seizing the initiative, Theron struck before Larus and his illusions could react. On his right, he sensed the stronger presence of the true Larus.

Feinting a stab towards the illusion on his left, Theron remained acutely aware of the original Larus behind him. Predictably, the original Larus tried to use his distraction and lunged for a swift blow to Theron's back.

Theron withdrew from the feigned attack midway and spun around, deflecting the strike from Larus. With a swift kick, he sent the startled, slender water caster flying five feet back.

The realization that he had been outsmarted dawned on Larus's face as he landed with a thud. Groggily rising, he spotted Theron charging towards him through the fading illusions, a wide smile plastered on the young man's face.

With a ferocious grin, Theron pursued the trickster, who vanished into thin air by creating a veil using his light magic.

Larus dispelled his illusions realizing that Theron had learned to distinguish between him and his illusions, rendering them ineffective.

Larus climbed to his feet and discreetly began to retreat under a veil of invisibility, but was still discovered by Theron who used his sensing ability and charged at the precise location of the invisible water caster.

How is the young man tracking me without magic? Larus frowned, struggling to maintain his distance from the young man.

Reaching Larus, Theron unleashed a flurry of sword strikes, forcing Larus on the defensive to use his sword to fend off against Theron's ambidextrous sword thrusts.

The spectators watched in awe as sparks flew and chimes echoed from Theron's blade clashing with the invisible Larus's weapon.

Larus was wilting under the aggressive young man about to breach his defenses. In desperation, Larus summoned a ball of water from the water pool at the circle's edge to fly at the young man. Theron swayed away from the water ball, but Larus took advantage of Theron's

preoccupation to drop to the ground and escape his grasp.

Theron dodged the water projectile, but Larus seized the opportunity to drop to the ground and slip out of Theron's grasp.

"By the Great Elementals!" Theron scowled. Frustrated by Larus' escape at the last second, Theron grumbled and chased Larus but hesitated when he observed water flowing toward the ground around him. The Water began to saturate the soil within the dueling circle.

A tense silence descended as Theron concentrated on locating the unseen light caster, who was clearly preparing to exploit his water magic.

Once the water from the pool had completely covered the ground surrounding Theron, Larus summoned his water elemental to draw the remaining water from the other unused pool set up for Theron's benefit. More water continued to coat the ground within the dueling circle.

Theron surveyed the scene - two feet of water pooling around his ankles, and the water trapped within the dueling circle by Larus's will.

Larus prevented the water from flowing beyond the circle. The water surrounding Theron gurgled, kept in place by the water caster's will.

A sinister grin spread across the trickster's face as he successfully enclosed Theron in a trap. Larus clenched his palm, summoning his weaker fire elemental.

Fire erupted around Theron as Larus extracted all the heat from the water flowing on the ground near him. As Larus extracted all the heat from the surrounding water, a surge of frost transformed the liquid into a thick sheet of ice. Theron leaped a foot into the air just in time to avoid becoming trapped within the icy layer.

Landing on the frozen surface instead of water, his feet slipped beneath him, sending his ass crashing onto the ice. Grumbling, he gingerly climbed back onto his feet.

The audience gasped in awe at Larus's impressive display of magic, transforming the dueling circle into a treacherous and slippery rink.

Scowling, Theron tested the frozen surface with a cautious step. His leather sandals offered little traction, and he slipped again.

Despite repeated attempts to regain his footing, the icy surface proved too treacherous to even stand up on his feet.

Finally, after several failed attempts, Theron plunged his blade into the ice and used it as a makeshift crutch to rise slowly to his feet. He scowled at Larus, who had undeniably turned the tide of the duel.

"*It's my turn to make you dance,*" Larus hissed at the young man struggling to maintain his balance on the treacherous ice.

"Turned the tide?" Theron asked apprehensively.

"Yes! I've flipped the tables on you, young man. I have neutralized your sword forms, which makes you a superiorly skilled swordsman." Larus smirked proudly after delivering the first significant blow on the young man since the duel began.

Theron, precariously balanced on the treacherous ice, leaned heavily on his planted blade with a scowl.

Larus, seemingly defying the laws of physics, darted onto the ice and skated effortlessly in

his leather sandals. He used his fire magic to melt a small patch of ice beneath his feet, creating a puddle of water that his water elemental kept him balanced on.

Larus glided towards Theron, playfully thrust his sword at Theron.

Theron attempted to step back and block the blow, but his clumsy footing on thin ice betrayed him, sending him sprawling back onto the ice.

Without wasting a moment, Theron used his hands to slide himself a few yards away from the advancing Larus, who chuckled triumphantly. Larus made no move to pursue, allowing Theron to regain his footing with the aid of the two unmetal swords.

"Not much of a swordsman now, are you?" Larus taunted, pointing his blade at his struggling opponent.

Ignoring the jibe, Theron gingerly inched forward, using both swords for support. He shuffled towards Larus with baby steps, closing the distance between them until he stood five feet away.

Theron swung his right sword at his opponent, but his sword met only air as Larus effortlessly used his magic to glide back on the slick surface and away from the path of the sword swing. Thrown off balance on missing his target, Theron stumbled forward on thin ice, his attempt to regain his footing proving futile as he fell on his face once more.

Furious, Theron scrambled to his feet with the help of his swords, the missed opportunity gnawing at him.

"What use is your fancy swordplay if you can't even walk without tripping over your own feet?" Larus jeered, skating several hundred yards away from Theron. He then used his fire magic to refreeze the small puddle of water he had created, effectively cutting off Theron utilizing the water puddle to pursue him.

"*Ouch!* Can't even reach me, can you?" Larus desired to make it challenging for Theron even to approach him on the ice. "Magic has its own perks, young man!"

Theron narrowed his brows at the water caster who turned arrogant on learning that he held all the trump cards in the duel at the moment. But he was lost for ideas on how he could flip the tables on the water caster once more.

Even the assembled crowd couldn't deny the validity of Larus' words.

Larus, sensing the crowd's favor shifting towards him, raised a triumphant finger towards Theron. "Remember how you used water to overcome Gorgus' shadow magic in our last duel? Well, this time, water has ensnared you and brought you to your knees," Larus declared with a smirk.

Theron, unfazed by Larus's taunt, sheathed both his swords and retrieved his shield from its slot on the armor. He tapped it to expand into a circular and slender shield.

Larus sneered at the shield. "That puny shield won't be of any help against me," Larus scoffed, scrutinizing the unassuming object. His laughter echoed across the ground.

"Sir Larus," Theron began, his voice steady, "this shield will serve a unique purpose in this duel."

He surprised everyone by dropping the unmetal shield onto the ground and placing his left leg on it. He knelt to secure the straps around his left foot before rising slowly. With both swords

drawn, he tested his balance.

"During this duel," Theron declared, planting his blades firmly in the ice, "I intend to utilize my slender shield as a sled to navigate the treacherous ice. While my feet may falter on this frozen terrain, you seem to have forgotten the advantage a flat metal surface offers for gliding over ice."

Theron plunged his swords into the ice and used them to propel himself forward, all the while raising his right leg above the ice. He slid forward on his left foot, secured to the shield, while maintaining balance by lifting his right leg behind him in the air.

After struggling for a few seconds to slide on one leg secured to a flat unmetal shield, he soon mastered the technique. Theron used his swords to propel himself swiftly towards Larus who was stunned by his opponent managing to find a way to counter his plan.

When Theron was five feet away from the water caster, he swung his right sword horizontally, but Larus, aided by his magic, regained composure, and glided nimbly to his left just in time to miss the sword swing.

"Whoops!" Larus chuckled, watching Theron's blade miss him by a hair's breadth.

Theron continued to slide towards the far end of the field.

"Your makeshift sled," Larus jeered, pointing out Theron's lack of maneuverability, "offers no control over direction. You can only slide forward, while I have the freedom to move in any direction."

He jeered at Theron's clumsy attempts to stop his makeshift sled, which showed no signs of slowing down as it hurtled towards the edge of the dueling circle.

"Boy, you can't even stop your improvised sled!" Larus taunted as his opponent struggled to halt the sled hurtling towards the waiting embrace of the fire pit set up on the edge of the dueler's circle.

As Theron neared the icy edge, he braced himself and quickly dropped onto his backside to avoid tumbling into the fire pit. Using his momentum, he slid on the ice, allowing his shield, strapped to his left foot, to crash straight into the fire pit. The impact sent burning logs flying in all directions, leaving a trail of flickering embers behind.

A wave of laughter rippled through the audience at Theron's shoddy attempt to slide on ice without magic whilst the frigid wind extinguished most of the scattered logs.

"I couldn't possibly insult you any more than you have humiliated yourself." Larus remarked, shaking his head in mock sympathy.

Enraged, Theron scrambled to his feet and snarled at Larus. He scooped up the still-smoldering logs with his bare hands and hurled them towards the water caster.

Larus dodged the flaming projectiles, which landed harmlessly on the frozen ground, their embers quickly snuffed out by the cold of the icy ground.

"A truly pathetic attempt, even for a magicless weakling like yourself," Larus ridiculed the young man, his voice dripping with condescension.

Theron, his face contorted in anger, cautiously stepped back onto the ice using the shield strapped to his left foot. He used his sword to push the slender shield towards Larus in a headlong tumble, but Larus was dexterous enough to effortlessly evade his opponent.

Larus snickered as he watched Theron struggling to stop his makeshift sled once more. "Oh, oh...Not again, boy!" Larus derided.

With no recourse to halt his speeding sled, Theron threw himself down, allowing the unmetal shield strapped to his left foot to collide with the fire pit setup in his section of the dueling circle. Though the unmetal shield remained unscathed from the inferno, the wooden logs within the pit scattered haphazardly around him.

Theron scrambled to his feet and inspected his legs, a wave of relief washing over him as he realized with gratitude that the unmetal shield had yet again shielded him from the fiery pit's wrath.

"Have you lost your mind, young man? Do you wish to humiliate yourself further?" Larus inquired, shaking his head in disapproval of the young man's foolish strategy. "You're behaving like a buffoon now that your sword forms have been neutralized." Larus pointed his blade toward Theron, who responded with a snarl.

"Are you a thick headed fool to not yet realize that the shield can only travel in straight lines, but my magic permits me to go in any direction."

Larus was soon joined by a few catcalls from Theron's detractors.

"I cannot fathom what compelled you to accept Sir Marius' challenge to duel five of his finest warriors without wielding magic," Larus continued, his voice laced with disdain. "But be assured, you have made a mockery of yourself in this duel."

"It's high time you face reality, boy," Larus hissed. "It's time you disabuse yourself of the notion that sheer human will trumps magic."

Fueled by a surge of indignation, Theron roared and flung smoldering logs towards Larus standing at the opposite end of the dueling circle. The wooden projectiles landed harmlessly several feet ahead of the water caster, their embers quickly extinguished by the unforgiving ice.

"Ah, you've even demolished the last remaining fire pit," Larus remarked disdainfully, aiming his blade at Theron. "Perhaps using the fire in the pit to melt the icy ground and create a level playing field would have proven a more effective strategy than your childish antics of flinging wooden logs at me."

Ignoring Larus' scorn, Theron glared at the water caster before stepping gingerly onto the ice. He then proceeded to slide towards him on his makeshift sled, using his swords as levers to propel himself forward.

"This challenge is becoming tedious and boring for me," Larus muttered, readying himself to confront the approaching young man. "*Let's conclude this duel.*"

When the young man reached a few yards in front of him, Larus watched as Theron swung his right sword in a horizontal arc aimed at his midsection. Larus easily parried the blow with his own blade. Larus then saw Theron thrust the other sword forward, prompting Larus to glide to the right to avoid the lunge.

Larus shrieked as his feet failed him, and he slipped to his knees on to the ground. But his terror intensified as he saw Theron's left blade hurtling towards his head.

Completely out of balance at the unexpected slip, Larus cried out in sheer terror on realizing that he was in no position to stop the sword thrust lunging at his face. However, Theron,

in a display of unexpected mercy, pulled back his blade back at the last possible moment.

Theron sped past the kneeling water caster and headed towards the edge of the dueler's circle yet again. But this time, he plunged his left sword firmly into the ice. Using it as a pivot, he skillfully spun his sled back towards Larus in a swift spin.

As soon as he sped towards the water caster once more, Theron used both swords to slow his momentum, coming to a standstill a few yards away from the kneeling water caster.

Larus, utterly shaken by his brush with death, struggled to gather himself and rise. But his efforts were in vain, as his feet once again conspired against him, sending him sprawling on the ice.

"Ouch!" Theron mimicked Larus' earlier taunt, a hint of amusement dancing in his eyes.

Larus, his face contorted in rage, mirrored Theron's strategy, using his own sword as leverage to stand upright.

The spectators watched with a mixture of bewilderment and concern as Larus, who moments ago had moved with graceful ease on the ice thanks to his magic, but now grappled clumsily to maintain his balance on the on the icy ground he created in the first place.

"No more grand words, water caster?" Theron taunted with a smirk. Larus glared back, his eyes burning with hatred. "Fate seems to have a funny sense of humor, wouldn't you agree, Sir Larus?"

"You're finished, boy," Larus growled, stepping towards his opponent with a renewed sense of determination. "I'm done toying with you."

His defiance was short-lived, however, as Larus found himself once again sprawled on the frozen ground.

"Brought down to the ground, are we?" Theron inquired, amusement dancing in his eyes.

Larus stared at Theron, astonished by the newfound confidence emanating from the magicless freak.

"What kind of *dark magic* is this?" Larus rasped, struggling to regain his footing.

Theron dismissed the water caster with a wave of his hand. "This is not magic, water caster. It's logic."

Larus glared at Theron, his opponent's newfound confidence a stark contrast to his earlier demeanor. "Logic?" Larus spat.

Theron nodded. "Don't you find it peculiar, Sir Larus, that your graceful movements on this frozen surface have suddenly become so...clumsy?"

Larus stared at him blankly, unable to comprehend Theron's words. Theron shook his head, a hint of disappointment flickering in his eyes.

"You boast of being one of the most powerful magic casters in the fortress," Theron taunted, "yet here you are, struggling to walk on ice. Perhaps your skills are not as impressive as you claim them to be."

Larus muttered under his breath, his anger simmering. He lunged towards Theron, only to be betrayed by the treacherous ice once again.

Theron shook his head mockingly, his gaze unwavering from the sprawled opponent. "Explain to me, Sir Larus, how you managed to move so effortlessly on this ice earlier?"

"I... used magic," Larus answered grudgingly.

"And how, exactly, did you use this magic?" Theron pressed.

Larus gritted his teeth. "I utilized fire magic to melt the ice beneath my feet, creating a small pool of water. Then, I used water magic to glide across the water without losing my balance."

Sudden realization dawned on Larus, his eyes widening in understanding on the reason why the icy ground turned treacherous to him.

"*Fire magic!*" Larus whispered, a note of dread creeping into his voice at his stupid mistake.

Even the audience started murmuring amongst themselves in confusion at the sudden struggle from the water caster to control the icy ground he created in the first place.

Theron aimed his sword at the water caster, "Precisely, Sir Larus. While you dawdled your time foolishly and were mocking my lack of magical prowess, I strategically destroyed the very tool that allowed you to navigate this ice with such ease."

Theron pointed his sword at the destroyed fire pits. "*I demolished the fire pits,*" Theron continued, his voice laced with a hint of proud satisfaction, "to prevent you from retaining a fire source to refuel your fire elemental and melting the ice beneath your feet once again."

"Remember, your water magic holds no sway over ice. It is no longer water, but a solid form beyond your water elemental's control."

"Without fire, you cannot transform the ice back into water, rendering your water magic useless for graceful movement on this frozen ground." Theron pointed his blade towards the shattered remains of the fire pit. "Sukrans, as you know, cannot create elements, only transform them from one form to another using their magic."

"By destroying the fire pit, I eliminated your only supply of fire in the vicinity to control your fire elemental." Theron continued.

"I have leveled the playing field, water caster," Theron declared, his voice brimming with conviction. "Water and fire are the only two fundamental elements not abundantly present in all places on this world."

"And you, Sir Larus, were foolish to use all the water around us to create this icy terrain. Now, devoid of access to both water and fire sources in your vicinity, you are rendered magicless like me for the remainder of this duel."

A collective gasp rippled through the crowd as they grasped the young man's strategy.

Theron addressed Larus directly, his voice laced with a hint of triumph. "Sir Larus, you stand here stripped of your most potent weapon – your magic."

He let out a short, humorless laugh. "Who is the fool now, water caster?" he challenged, his words aimed not just at Larus but at the entire assembly who had witnessed the seemingly invincible magic user brought low by a magicless boy.

The water caster, outmaneuvered by a young man half his age, had unwittingly exposed the fallacy of magic being invincible against strong will. Theron, seizing the opportunity, aimed to dismantle the deeply ingrained belief of his people: magic was the most powerful power in the world.

Theron continued, his voice firm and unwavering. "It's high time you understood, Sir

Larus, that magic is merely a tool – a means to enhance our lives. You embody my very point: a powerful fool with powerful magic remains, at heart, a fool."

He cast a final, scathing glance at Larus, who remained sprawled on the ice. "I have my makeshift sled to help me navigate this frozen terrain," Theron declared, his voice dripping with ridicule and sarcasm. "But do you, Sir Larus, have anything to assist you on this ice trap you've unwittingly created for yourself?"

Larus protested, "I can still harness fire from the light around us using my light magic."

"Yes, I am certain you can conjure fire from light with your tremendous light magic, but unfortunately for you, night has fallen, and there is no sunlight to turn the light's warmth into fire."

"You're left with nothing but the cool moonlight, devoid of the sun's warmth necessary for creating fire. Moonlight simply pales in comparison to the Sunlight for creating fires, don't you agree?."

"But –" Larus sputtered as he looked around to seek another source of fire in his vicinity. His gaze fell upon the numerous fire lamps placed across the ground to illuminate the vicinity.

Theron followed Larus' gaze onto the fire lamp stones set around them in the vicinity. A wide smile rose on his lips. "I hope you are not thinking of siphoning the fire trapped within the fire lamp stone. After all, I am sure you don't have earth magic to destroy the quartz stone and release the fire contained within the stone!"

Larus realized the futility of using the fire lamps as a fire source.

Without waiting for a response, Theron used his makeshift sled to swiftly glide towards Larus. The water caster, rendered immobile on the slick surface, could only raise his sword and dagger in a futile attempt to block the impending attack.

Theron feigned a thrust towards Larus' left shoulder with his right blade. As Larus fell for the deception, Theron swiftly retracted the attack.

Letting Larus' blade pass harmlessly beside him, Theron lunged with his left sword, aiming for the water caster's chest. While Larus managed to deflect the sword thrust with his dagger, he was caught off guard by Theron's next move.

Theron delivered a powerful blow to Larus' face with the pommel of his other sword. The impact sent Larus reeling back in agony, his grip loosening on his weapons as they clattered to the ground.

Recoiling in pain, Larus dropped his weapons and fell to his knees, hands pressed against his bleeding face.

Theron used his left sword as a pivot to turn towards the kneeling water caster.

With both blades slowing his sled to a halt, Theron pointed the tip of his sword towards Larus' throat.

"Do you yield, water caster?" Theron demanded in a menacing tone.

A long, agonizing minute passed before Larus finally acknowledged his defeat. A collective gasp rippled through the crowd as Larus raised his arms in surrender. He couldn't defend himself without the magic he'd foolishly discarded with his stupid plan.

"Yes, I yield," Larus conceded, his voice laced with fear for the young man he had insulted

a few minutes before.

Theron pulled his blade from the water caster's throat amidst the crowd's loud exclamations and shrieks of astonishment at the unexpected turn of events. The "magicless freak," once again, had triumphed over one of the valley's finest soldiers, relying solely on the laws of nature and cold logic.

Utilizing his makeshift sled, Theron slowly returned to his starting position.

Larus attempted to stand and leave the circle but fell again. His weapons lay out of reach, dropped earlier when he stumbled back, clutching his face.

Struggling to stand without his weapons, Larus found himself unable to exit the dueling circle.

Count Marius observed Larus' struggle and called out, "Larus, hold tight! Our men will build a fire pit so the fire casters can melt the frozen ground and help you leave the circle."

Larus bowed in gratitude to his count, who clearly understood his fear of further humiliation from the gathered onlookers.

Soldiers began constructing a fire pit, but Theron noticed Larus squirming under the townspeople's jeers, mocking him for losing his advantage and falling to a "magicless freak."

Empathizing with the water caster, Theron called out to the soldiers setting up the fire pit, "Soldiers, I will release Sir Larus from this frozen ground rap!" He then glided his sled towards the right edge of the circle, where iron poles hosted fire lamps at its roof, illuminating the arena on this beautiful spring night.

Marius watched closely as Theron sheathed both his blades and leaped a few feet into the air. He reached out with his right hand, grabbing the fire lamp stone from the top of the iron pole stand.

Theron dropped to the ground on his sled and balanced himself on the frozen ground. He marveled at the sight of the unique quartz stones known as fire lamps, each one a repository of molten fire ensnared within its crystalline lattice. These precious crystals maintained their fiery essence through a delicate balance: the relentless supply of air coursing through the myriad pores on the surface of the quartz stone, assisting in sustaining the flames against extinction.

A harmonious interplay of elemental forces—earth casting its embrace around fire, while air breathed life into its flames—ensured the perpetual dance of fire within the confines of the quartz fire lamp.

The fire lamp stood as a testament to the boundless potential of Elemental magic, showcasing the awe-inspiring synergy achievable when all primal magics worked in perfect harmony.

Using his left sword, Theron dug a small hole in the ice. Theron stepped off the sled and knelt on the frozen ground. He carefully placed the fire lamp stone within the small hole he dug within the frozen ground.

Theron lifted his shield from the ground with his right hand and swung the unmetal shield with immense force at the hole, shattering the surrounding ice and striking the fire lamp stone held within it.

Unmetal held a power unmatched by stone or metal, and the fire lamp stone was no

exception. The fire lamp stone shattered into pieces, releasing the molten fire held captive within.

The fire, blocked from ascending by the unmetal barrier, shot sideways, melting the ice into water as it spread. The huge reservoir of fire contained within the fire stone unleashed its fury on the ice as it spread rapidly, melting the frozen ground into water.

While the soldiers continued their work, the crowd watched in awe as Theron seemingly manipulated the frozen ground with a fire lamp, showcasing his remarkable intelligence once again.

Larus observed the ice transforming into water and turned towards Theron with a puzzled expression.

"Young Theron, my deepest gratitude for preserving my dignity despite my earlier insults targeted at you," Larus said, showing genuine appreciation despite his humiliation by the crowd.

Theron shrugged. "These insults are nothing new. Besides, you did nothing others in this town haven't done before."

Larus nodded gratefully at the young man for forgiving him.

"Theron, if you possessed the knowledge to thaw this frozen ground with the fire lamps, why did you not attempt it sooner when you were clearly struggling to maintain your footing on this frozen ground?" Larus inquired, a hint of curiosity in his voice. "Why did you even tried to destroy the fire pits in the first place when you had a better plan to convert the ice into water and regain your strength of swordforms back into the duel?"

"Sir Larus, I did not wish to transform the frozen ground into water, which would have allowed you to bombard me with water magic. Dare I claim that water magic is your greatest strength, and I would have been a fool to oppose your decision to forego your greatest strength in the duel?" Theron grinned.

Larus smiled, acknowledging his oversight. "Logic," he mused, "seems to be a force as potent as magic itself."

"I believe so," Theron nodded, pleased to have planted the seeds of change in his opponent's mind, even if the townspeople were slow to grasp his perspective.

Larus bowed respectfully to Theron. "While the crowd's sentiment remains uncertain, you have taught me a valuable lesson that will immensely assist me in bettering myself."

"Theron, your instruction has touched me deeply, both in heart and mind," Larus remarked thoughtfully.

Glancing at the soldier who had acknowledged his mistake, Theron reflected on his decision to save the water caster's dignity, despite the crowd's disdain. It was a reminder of the profound transformation a simple act of mercy could effect upon a person, as wise sages often proclaimed.

Mercy has always been the most powerful catalyst to transform a person for the better!

"I relished our duel, Sir Larus. It was an honor!" Theron returned the bow graciously.

Larus waved dismissively. "No, young Theron, the honor was mine. I shall be cheering you on for the remainder of the challenge."

A collective gasp swept through the crowd as the formidable soldier humbled himself before the boy who had bested him with such ingenuity.

Larus retrieved his sword and dagger and exited the dueler's circle, his head held high. He knew he had not been defeated by an inferior opponent, but by one who was every bit as enigmatic as anyone he had ever dueled with.

As Larus departed to a resounding ovation from the spectators cheering for Theron triumphing over yet another formidable soldier in their valley, the earth-casting warriors began their task of extracting water from the ground and replacing it with dry sand to prepare for the next duel.

As the earth-casting warriors set about restoring the arena for the next duel, Count Marius entered, fixing his gaze on Theron before shaking his head in disbelief.

"Theron, I could not bear to witness a young man get impaled in the name of just a duel. Yet you continue to astound us all with your resourcefulness," Count Marius remarked, his admiration evident.

"My lord, one can only strive to do their best." Theron replied.

A flicker of concern crossed Count Marius' face.

"I admire your resolve, Theron, but I fear you might push yourself too far at some point in this challenge." Marius nodded, a hint of worry lingering in his eyes.

With a wave of his hand, the count summoned the next duelist: "*Let us welcome Gabius Matis to the circle!*"

A figure of average stature clad in legion armor stepped forward, a longsword, a small dagger, and a longbow with a full quiver strapped across his back. Theron instantly recognized his next opponent: the esteemed *lieutenant of the Flamer Knights*, Gabius. Despite lacking a wood elemental, Gabius was renowned as one of the valley's most skilled archers.

What have I done! A pang of regret pierced Theron as he realized his folly in not bringing his own bow, naively assuming no opponent would wield one at close quarters in the duel. Theron knew the rules wouldn't allow him to request for his bow to be returned to him now, and he chastised his strategic oversight which threatened to turn the tide against him and even could potentially lead to his downfall.

Surveying his opponent armed with a long-range weapon, Theron understood that his choice to forsake his bow in favor of increased mobility in the duels had indeed backfired significantly.

The crowd picked up on his despair, many even urging Count Marius to provide Theron with a bow.

The count carefully inspected Gabius' weapons for any traces of poison, his gaze then turning to the crowd's fervent pleas for Theron to be provided with a bow to make the contest even.

The boy is handy with the sword as he demonstrated earlier! Some townsmen called out to the count.

With a raised hand, the count silenced the clamor. "While Theron has displayed remarkable talent and dueled valiantly thus far, he did not deem it fit to bring a bow to the challenge. It is only fair to expect that he faces his opponents without undue disadvantage. However, the rules forbid him from leaving the circle, which would lead to his disqualification.

Nevertheless, he may fashion a bow using the elements present within the dueler's circle."

Raising an eyebrow, the count turned his attention to Theron. "Theron of Adrian-Hold, would you like more time to craft a bow and arrows from the wood elements setup within the dueler's circle?"

Theron grimaced and shook his head. "I lack the elemental magic necessary to fashion a decent bow from the wooden logs setup in the during circle.."

The count shrugged, understanding the precarious position Theron found himself in. "Given the clear disparity in weaponry, would you like to forfeit the challenge, Theron? After all, your opponent holds a long-range weapon while you do not."

His jaw set firm, Theron shook his head once more. "No, sir. I will face my opponent with nothing but my weapons on my person."

A wince escaped the count's lips, anticipating the unwavering defiance in Theron's eyes. "As you wish, young man. You have overcome formidable obstacles today. While I admire your tenacity, I confess I am uncertain how you will contend with an opponent who can attack you from afar with arrows while you lack the means for a long-ranged counterattack. This may very well be your final duel."

"I will take my chances, sir!" Theron replied resolutely.

The count shook his head, certain that this was the final round of the challenge. The youngster who had demonstrated such remarkable skill and strategy did not deserve to lose his trial without a fair chance to fight an opponent attacking from far away.

Theron's brow furrowed, his mind grappling with the challenge before him. Gabius, the leader of the fortress' fire casters, was also well known for his prowess in archery, skills that even surpassed the wood casters who were widely considered the best archers in the land.

Theron realized that his best course of action clearly was to close the distance and prevent Gabius from using his bow effectively. If Gabius managed to unleash his arrows, Theron realized he would have no other options but to dodge and deflect the inevitable barrage of arrows while simultaneously closing the gap with his opponent to engage in close combat.

A worst plan if there was any! But he was not spoiled for choices either.

With his left hand, Theron unfurled his shield and prepared to guard himself. His right hand tightened around his sword hilt, a steely resolve settling in his eyes as the duel grew tricky even before it commenced. He stood on his balls of the feet and waited for the booming declaration of duel's commencement from Marius.

"Begin!" The count shouted as soon as he exited the dueler's circle.

Theron charged at Gabius, hoping to catch his opponent off guard. However, the seasoned knight anticipated this tactic from Theron. Gabius realized that Theron's only hope to win this duel was to engage in close combat. With a wide smirk, Gabius unleashed a torrent of molten fire, forcing Theron to stop and kneel, using his shield to deflect the flames.

Suddenly a stone arrow pierced through the raging inferno and wounded his unarmored right biceps as he repelled the flames using his unmetal shield.

A searing pain lanced through his right arm from the arrow piercing his unarmored biceps, but he gritted his teeth and held his shield steady, lest he was burnt by the molten flames.

Another arrow grazed his hip, the armor thankfully absorbing the impact. Gritting his teeth, Theron focused all his attention on sensing the location of anymore incoming projectiles.

He felt an arrow hurtling towards his right arm and tilted his body to his left just in time to avoid it. But he sensed another arrow descending toward his left hand. Theron swayed his body to the right yet again to avoid the second arrow but kept his shield extended in front of him to intercept the raging fire slamming into his shield.

As the arrow passed through, it scraped against the armor around his hip.

Theron continued to deftly evade incoming arrows, his focus unwavering as he eagerly awaited for Gabius to cease his relentless barrage of fire, confident that the fire caster wouldn't intend to deplete the fire source from nearby fire pits entirely in the first bout itself.

As soon as the stream of fire subsided at long last, Theron wasted no time and surged forward, determined to close the gap with his elusive opponent. But his charge faltered abruptly on finding no trace of Gabius in front of him.

"*Where has the fire caster vanished?*" Theron muttered to himself, his senses straining to detect any sign of his opponent. Realization dawned as he understood that Gabius must have employed his light magic to veil himself from view. Despite his efforts, Theron struggled to sense the fire caster's presence anywhere in his vicinity.

Meanwhile, the crowd buzzed with excitement and confusion, their voices rising as they too attempted to locate the knight who had vanished behind a veil cast using light-cast magic.

Squinting in frustration, Theron strained his senses, finally detecting Gabius hovering hundreds of feet above the ground, concealed by a light-cast veil.

A stream of curses sprang from Theron's lips as he realized his opponent possessed another powerful magic to complement his fire magic and archery skills. "By the Great Elementals," he muttered, "he's an air caster as well." A disembodied voice, just chilling and laced with a hint of regret, echoed around the arena. "*Boy, I take no pleasure in harming an unarmed opponent, especially one so young.*"

Theron raised his head to gaze at the invisible location of the knight hovering several hundred feet in the air.

"But my honor compels me to seek victory by any means necessary. If necessary, I would even resort to ending your life to prevent you from winning this duel," Gabius continued in a frigid tone. "So, I offer you one chance to withdraw from this duel voluntarily."

If his earlier plan was the worst, he knew he had no realistic plan now to defeat his opponent who had the ability to use his arrow from a long range.

But his passionate heart failed to accept the reasoning of his mind and decided against surrendering in the duel.

Theron shook his head firmly. "No, Sir Gabius. I will not forfeit the duel!"

"Use your wits, boy," the knight persisted. "Your defeat in this duel is not a question. It's just an eventuality. After all, you are a sitting duck, and without any magic to shield yourself, you're bound to miss blocking some of my arrows with your shield. I am impressed by your archery skills exhibited in the tournament earlier. It would be a shame to see such talent squandered in this pointless struggle."

Theron shouted to be heard by the knight, "Thank you, Sir Knight, for expressing your concern for me. If you are so perturbed in dueling a boy with unfair advantage, why don't you face me at close range with your swords instead of hiding in the skies under a veil?"

"Nice try, young man." Gabius let out a short, humorless laugh. "But I will not be swayed by your eloquent words."

Theron's lips curved into a wry smile. "You cannot fault me for attempting, can you?"

Gabius roared with laughter. "If you could effortlessly best even metal casters, your swordsmanship surely surpasses mine. Yet, my advantage lies in my mastery of fire and air, which I shall employ to claim victory in this duel." His voice hardened. "Therefore, I provide you one final opportunity to withdraw from this duel."

Theron dipped his head in a respectful bow. "Your offer is much appreciated, Sir Knight, but I must respectfully decline."

"*So be it!*" Gabius' voice crackled with frustration. A stone arrow, invisible to most, materialized from the veil and whistled towards Theron's back.

Years of rigorous training under Cadmus came to Theron's aid. He didn't rely solely on his eyes; his senses, honed to a razor's edge, picked up the faint tremor in the air, the telltale sign of an approaching projectile. With a swift, practiced motion, he spun and swung his blade, severing the arrow in mid-flight.

Gabius swiftly released two more stone arrows aimed at Theron's shoulder blades. Reacting with agility, Theron evaded the first shot and intercepted the second with his unmetal shield.

"*Dodge this if you can,*" Gabius snarled, his voice dripping with anger. Circling around Theron, he unleashed another pair of arrows aimed at Theron's right shoulder and back.

Recognizing the imminent threat, Theron spun on his heel, deftly slicing through the trajectory of the first arrow with his sword. In a seamless motion, he raised his shield to intercept the second arrow, effectively thwarting both projectiles.

As Gabius swooped past Theron, he let loose a stream of arrows, unleashing them from various angles. Theron, ever vigilant, sensed the onslaught and deftly twirled his shield in elegant patterns, intercepting or evading the arrows.

The spectators marveled at the fluidity of Theron's movements, applauding the nimbleness displayed by the young swordsman. They had never witnessed such skill in swordplay, especially the ability to sense and thwart stone arrows, which were designed to evade detection by a metal caster like their metallic counterparts.

But he was not a metal caster and was limited by their limitations.

Their surprise at Theron's prowess had waned throughout the day, but this display of swordsmanship was truly extraordinary.

Gabius, frustrated, narrowed the distance and accelerated his assault, unleashing a volley of over twenty arrows from various angles.

Undeterred, Theron employed his shield to a mesmerizing effect, deflecting the arrows aimed at his vitals while gracefully evading the other arrows.

Soaring overhead, Gabius roared in exasperation, "How long can you maintain this

strategy? Inevitably, you are going to tire soon and one of my arrows will find its mark!"

Theron, with a swift movement, sheathed his sword and drew a diminutive, two-inch, unmetal knife from his belt. Grabbing this opportunity of his opponent relinquishing his sword, Gabius unleashed another barrage of arrows at the now seemingly defenseless Theron who had abandoned his sword. Amidst the frantic dance of dodging and deflecting with his unmetal shield, Theron focused his senses to discern the location of the invisible knight circling above.

With pinpoint accuracy, Theron sensed the knight's location as another arrow was launched towards his torso. He deflected the arrow with his shield and, in a swift leap, hurled his tiny knife towards the unseen archer releasing another arrow at him.

The unmetal knife sped true, catching Gabius off guard by his opponent's sudden aggressive counter. Though Gabius attempted to dodge at the last moment, the knife scratched past his hip armor as it whizzed past. Theron then drew a second blade, this one resembling a four-inch boomerang. His armor held a total of five such unmetal knives strategically positioned on various spots of his armor.

A chuckle escaped Gabius' lips. "You missed, boy!" he declared, lifting his veil to reveal his apparent lack of injury. Theron, however, met Gabius with a mischievous smirk.

"Did I?" he countered; his tone laced with playful defiance.

"Your puny knife caused me no harm, young man. " Gabius scoffed. "Do you at least get now that you are limited by the weapons on your person?"

Theron's response was curt. "My objective was not to injure you, but to sever your ability to fire arrows at me."

"What are you babbling about?" Gabius' face contorted in confusion. Mid-sentence, he halted, his gaze falling upon his severed bowstring. "Despite me being invisible, how did you sense my bow and its string from down there?" he demanded.

"I just used common sense!" Theron offered a knowing smile. "I employed my senses to detect and track the source from whence you released your arrows, pinpointing the bowstring's location."

Kneeling, Theron plunged his boomerang knife into the ground. Upon retrieving it, he noted the dirt clinging to the blade.

"You no longer possess a bow and did not find it necessary to bring a shield to the duel. Therefore, it is my turn to repay the favor," Theron stated with a smile.

"What favor do you speak of? Even without my bow, I hold the clear advantage," Gabius frowned. "As long as I maintain this combat at a distance, your short-range weapons cannot aid you in defeating me from a far-off distance."

Theron shrugged. "If you concede defeat, I will allow you to depart this duel unscathed."

Gabius' expression twisted into a snarl. "Yield to a magicless opponent like you? Never! You've merely eliminated my archery skills from this duel. I have no intention of descending, and I can still rain fireballs upon you while you lack the means to retaliate from afar." He glared at the young man, then in a fit of frustration, flung his discarded bow onto the ground.

Gabius recognized Theron's strategy when he observed his young opponent holding a peculiar knife.

"What is your endgame here, boy? Futilely hurling all your bizarre blades at me from such a distance? How many knives could you possibly possess on your person?" he mocked. "Your supply of knives will eventually dwindle, leaving you defenseless against my aerial assault. This is the power of air magic, boy. I can attack from afar, while you can only cower behind your shield."

Theron offered the air caster an unfazed shrug. "I repaid the kindness you kindly extended to me before. Now it's my turn to make you dance."

With a swift throw, he launched the boomerang knife to the right of the hovering knight.

Gabius cast a disdainful glance at the peculiar U-shaped knife that was flung a few feet to his right. "A woefully inaccurate throw. Maybe, your skill rests only with a bow." Gabius smirked, mocking Theron's apparent miss. But his amusement swiftly evaporated as the knife executed an unexpected pirouette in mid-air, abruptly altering its course and hurtling towards him. The knight, caught off guard, attempted a desperate maneuver to evade the projectile, but the weird looking knife stung past his left forearm with a resounding thud. The impact not only inflicted a cut, but also sent a spray of dirt flying from its edges, momentarily disrupting the flow of Gabius' wind magic.

The mud-covered knife then completed its remarkable trajectory, tracing a graceful arc back to its owner's grasp, which Theron instinctively grasped around with two of his fingers carefully. The sand's interference with the air elemental caused Gabius to lose control of his air magic. A shriek tore from the air caster's lips when his windstream, now a raging tempest, tossed him around as it spiraled out of control.

With a herculean effort, Gabius wrestled back control of his turbulent air magic. He whipped it around Theron in a furious fit of rage and, seizing the opportunity, launched a searing fireball towards his young opponent.

Theron rolled away from the incoming fireball while scraping his boomerang knife into the sand. He stood up as he noticed that the knight was flying around him quicker, trying to make it more difficult for Theron to set him up for a knife throw.

"*Is that... a boomerang knife?*" boomed a bewildered Marius from beyond the dueling circle. He vaguely recalled tales of boomerangs used in ancient times, but they were considered to be notoriously difficult to control which had led to their eventual abandonment in favor of bows and crossbows. The art of wielding the boomerang knives had seemingly been lost to the sands of time. But now in this borderlands, Marius witnessed this young man revive the technique with an astounding degree of accuracy.

Unlike the traditional boomerangs, however, Theron's weapon was a mere four inches in length. *Was this a unique adaptation of the ancient design?* Marius pondered.

A hint of admiration flickered across Theron's face as he hefted the boomerang knife, the product of years of meticulous practice. "Sir Gabius," he declared, his voice ringing clear, "one can exhaust a quiver of arrows, but this blade... this blade will always return to its rightful owner." With a practiced flick of his wrist, he once again launched the knife in a wide arc, sending it on a path that skirted past the airborne knight.

Once more, he flung the knife in an arc wide of the flying knight.

Gabius eyed the spinning knife warily, his gaze tracking its erratic trajectory in a desperate

attempt to anticipate its path. Despite his evasive maneuvers, the knife sliced through the air caster's right leg, drawing a crimson bloom upon his flesh. Once again, the encrusted muck on the knife's edge wreaked havoc, causing Gabius' windstream to spiral wildly out of control.

The loss of control translated into a precarious descent. With a herculean effort, Gabius wrestled back dominion over his air magic. As he circled the young man, he began zipping up and down to throw Theron off his scent. He then launched a searing fireball towards his young opponent.

Theron, drawing upon prior experience, employed a practiced roll to evade the fiery projectile. As he rose to his feet, he waited to comprehend Gabius' erratic flight pattern, the air caster weaving and dipping in a frantic attempt to disrupt his aim. Theron waited silently, allowing the knight's flight path to solidify in his mind before hurling three of his boomerang knives in rapid succession, each one dipped in the omnipresent sand.

The first knife struck true, finding its mark on the knight's right knee. A guttural groan escaped Gabius' lips as he fought to regain control of his air elemental and stabilize his flight. However, before he could restore control of his flight, a barrage of knife wounds erupted on his left leg and arm from the subsequent boomerang knives. Each knife, coated in sand, proved devastatingly effective by lodging the knife into the cut on his muscles and letting the sand clinging to the knife completely disrupt his windstream.

The sheer volume of sand ingested by the wind elemental overwhelmed Gabius' air elemental. Gabius lost control of his flight entirely, plummeting towards the earth below. He barely managed to slow its descent with the last vestiges of control that he regained of his air magic, but still smashed onto the ground with more force than he would have preferred.

The jarring impact on landing on his knees sent a jolt of searing pain through his body.

He instantly surrounded himself with a fire shield to prevent Theron from exploiting his brief moment of vulnerability.

He checked his leg, the one that had borne the brunt of the landing, for any fractures. A sigh of relief escaped his lips as he realized the last-ditch maneuver with his unruly air elemental had slowed his descent enough to prevent serious injury and escape with just bruises. He removed the knives lodged onto his body and tossed them to the ground with a yelp. He knew he had no time to spend on staunching the loss of blood.

Dissipating the fire shield, he rose to his feet gingerly and met Theron's gaze, the young man waiting impassively a few yards away with no obvious intention of taking advantage of his vulnerable moment.

"*Good skills with the knife,*" Gabius conceded, a grudging respect coloring his voice.

Theron responded with a curt nod. "The first weapon I learned to wield was a knife," he explained simply.

Gabius, his curiosity piqued, looked down to peer at the weird knife. "What is the nature of this blade? I've never encountered a knife that pirouettes through the air in such a manner," he inquired.

"This knife is a modernized version of a boomerang knife, a weapon employed by our ancestors before abandoning it due to its unforgiving difficulty to master its accuracy. I unearthed

the design within the dusty confines of a book in our library and tweaked it to suit my skillset," Theron explained.

The exhausted knight hoisted his sword. It seemed the boy had successfully maneuvered him into a close-ranged confrontation. "Then let us conclude this duel one way or the other," he declared, his voice laced with a hint of grim determination.

Theron braced himself for the impending onslaught of molten flames. He drew out his unmetal sword in preparation.

Expecting the boy to use his shield to defend himself from his fire magic, Gabius unleashed a torrent of fire, slowly pushing the flames in a wide arc towards Theron and attempted to scorch Theron from all directions.

Theron, encircled by the inferno, realized his previous tactic of using his shield to deflect the fire would not suffice on encountering fire rushing at him from all directions. His shield was only capable of deflecting flames from one direction.

A surge of exhilaration coursed through him as a potential solution materialized in his mind. As the ring of fire tightened its grip and rushed at him, he crouched low, angling his shield towards the front to create a barrier against the flames approaching from the front.

The molten flames in front of him diverted as the unmetal shield remained steadfast against it.

He charged forward, his form stooped low to the ground and the shield held out in front. This strategy effectively shielded him from the flames in front of him as he darted out of the fiery circle before the flames from other directions could engulf him.

He yelled in fear even as he sprinted to his front, all the while feeling the scorching heat of the flames he managed to evade by a whisker to his side and back.

After sprinting few yards in a stooped position, he stepped away from the ring of fire with a disbelieving look that his crazy mind had saved him yet again.

"It was so close!" He smiled triumphantly at the knight's stunned expression. Fueled by a surge of exhilaration and the thrill of a physical duel against one of the valley's most renowned knights, Theron charged towards Gabius.

The exhausted knight, lacking the strength to unleash another volley of molten fire, resorted to raining down fireballs the size of a man's head upon Theron.

Theron dodged the incoming fireballs by ducking, swaying, or batting them with his shield. He charged without breaking his stride at the knight and swung at Gabius after he closed the distance between them.

The knight hastily raised his sword to deflect Theron's blow, but Theron used the shield to smash the knight in the face.

As the knight stumbled from the terrible blow to his face, Theron used the flat of his sword to smash at Gabius' wrist.

A howl of anguish ripped from the knight's lips as he dropped his sword, the other hand clutching his now-broken wrist. Retreating with a hobbled gait, Gabius summoned his fire elemental manifestation, a blazing crimson creature in the form of a ferocious tiger, to interpose itself between him and Theron.

Undaunted, Theron charged forward, feigning a stab with his right sword towards the manifestation. The fiery tiger, deceived by the maneuver, lunged forward with its scorching maw agape, attempting to engulf Theron's hand.

Theron withdrew his hand just in time before slamming his shield into the manifestation's head. The creature recoiled in agony, momentarily blocked by a slender shield.

Grabbing this golden opportunity, Theron launched a decisive vertical swing with his sword, effectively severing the manifestation's head from its fiery body. The headless creature sputtered and convulsed, spewing molten flames before disintegrating into wisps of embers that drifted harmlessly into the night air.

Gabius, utterly astonished by the sight of the young man who had just vanquished his fire elemental with nothing but a seemingly ordinary blade and a slender shield, stared in disbelief. However, the brief respite afforded by the manifestation allowed Gabius to regain a semblance of control over his air elemental after rubbing the sand clinging near his wounds on legs and arms.

With a surge of renewed desperation, Gabius summoned a powerful gust of wind, hoping to propel himself back into the air and escape Theron's grasp.

Theron, perceiving the shift in the air currents around his opponent, swiftly deduced Gabius's intention – to retreat back to the safety of the skies. Reacting with lightning speed, Theron surged forward in a desperate attempt to close the distance before Gabius could ascend into the skies.

In a final, desperate maneuver, Theron hurled his sword at Gabius who recoiled in terror and tried to sway out of the path of the sword. But Gabius lost crucial moments which Theron utilized to leap towards the knight who was about to lift himself into the sky. Theron slammed his shield into Gabius's face with all his might. The knight, overwhelmed by the sudden blow and the searing pain that erupted across his face, lost control of his windstream and plummeted towards the ground.

Theron, his heart pounding with a mixture of adrenaline and trepidation, materialized at Gabius's side just as the knight hit the ground with a sickening thud. The force of the impact sent Gabius sprawling onto his knees, clutching his face in agony. The air elemental, deprived of its master's control, dissipated harmlessly into the night air.

Theron unsheathed his other sword and thrust the tip of his blade into the neck of the warrior. "*Do you yield, Sir Gabius?*"

The knight, his voice mingled with pain, could only manage a guttural groan as he raised his hands in a gesture of surrender.

Theron remained silent for a long time before he nodded and stepped back from Gabius, glad on triumphing over a renowned knight whom he had to struggle with every bit of his fiber to get into a close-range duel.

He stepped past the kneeling form of his opponent and ventured to pick his sword that he had hurled to distract Gabius earlier. He picked his other sword and sheathed both his swords. He then retreated back to his designated position within the circle. Only then did he allow himself to relax, the cheers of the crowd finally registering in his ears.

The crowd erupted into fervent cheers, their enthusiasm unbridled as they hailed the

remarkable resourcefulness displayed by the young lad. Theron's triumph over a renowned archer and knight, achieved without possessing any long-range weapons of his own, elicited admiration and awe from all who witnessed it.

But Theron hardly paid heed to the cheers. In fact, he was too lost to himself that he didn't even notice that the knight was bowing to his receding back. His mind was too focused on restraining his plethora of emotions over the person he had to confront next.

Exhausted but resolute, Gabius exited the circle, leaving the fortress soldiers to meticulously reset the elements for the final duel.

Anticipation crackled through the throng as Count Marius entered the dueling circle. All eyes were fixed on the impending clash – a tantalizing encounter between the man who had raised Theron and the boy once they had dismissed as the realm's weakest man.

Most of the throng were initially skeptical if Theron would even survive long enough to face Adrian, but their apprehension were laid to rest by the freak. In fact, they had been left awestruck by Theron's display of prowess with various, even unorthodox, weapons. They marveled at his strategic brilliance that vanquished foes superior in strength and experience.

If the crowd had been previously just cheering and encouraging the youngster to give his best to overcome daunting challenges in pursuit of his dream, they were now rooting for him to win against the man who had reared him like a son.

As Count Marius joined the circle, he nodded to Theron and sound cast his voice. "This young man has demonstrated remarkable resilience and determination in overcoming the overwhelming obstacles piled against him and has reached the last step of this unexpected challenge."

Marius continued, his voice tinged with a hint of surprise, "In all honesty, I never envisioned young Theron surpassing even one of my most accomplished warriors. Yet, he has repeatedly defied expectations today. While I sincerely hope for Theron's continued success, I find it difficult to imagine him defeating the valley's most formidable soldier, a decorated war hero no less."

"Not only will Theron face his final obstacle to accomplishing his dream, but also face the man who raised him as his son. It is my duty to inform this assembled gathering that Theron will now have to confront the very man who relinquished the honor of knighthood and instead chose to raise his nephew."

A heavy silence descended upon the crowd as Count Marius's words painted a poignant picture. "I cannot even begin to imagine the turmoil you must be experiencing, Theron," he said, his voice softening. "The prospect of facing someone who may feel more like a father than an uncle must be agonizing. And I know your uncle, Adrian, will be utterly heartbroken to stand in the way of your lifelong ambition. Having known him for over a decade, I can assure you he will fight with everything he has, even though he is aware that this duel may break his soul."

Count Marius's voice dropped to a whisper as the crowd held its breath, completely engrossed. "I truly pity you both, entangled in this predicament that is beyond either of your control. But regardless of the outcome," he concluded, his voice firming up, "I commend you, Theron, for the remarkable skill and tenacity you've displayed in pursuit of your dream."

Theron bowed respectfully to the Count, his gaze then shifting towards his uncle who had just entered the arena clad in gleaming steel armor. He noticed his aunt venturing to greet his brother before he stepped onto the dueling circle.

A silent exchange passed between Adrian and Elissa who placed a comforting hand on her brother's shoulder, murmuring something inaudible. Theron offered a curt nod in response, the weight of the situation settling heavily upon him.

Theron spotted Aunt Elissa placing her hand on her brother's shoulder and muttered something.

"I will try my best, Lissy, but I can't make any promises." Adrian replied solemnly.

Theron spotted a single tear welling up in his aunt's beautiful eyes as she offered a curt nod of agreement. She hugged her brother and wished him luck for the duel, her heart clearly caught up in choosing between her brother and her nephew. Turning towards him, she caught him staring with a painful glance.

Swallowing back the fear and apprehension in her voice, she offered him the familiar, reassuring smile that never failed to soothe his anxieties and made him feel safe and content over the years. "It will all be alright," she mouthed silently.

The crowd erupted into a thunderous ovation on spotting their war hero, Adrian, striding confidently into the dueling circle.

Theron responded to his aunt with a small, apologetic nod. "Forgive me for putting you through this," he mouthed back. He turned to watch his uncle entering the dueling circle and stride towards Marius, but all the while Adrian's gaze beaming at him with every step.

The count boomed, extending an inviting arm towards his uncle. "We welcome Sir Adrian Veracious, victor of the legendary Wintersend Tournament held two decades ago in Titus city, and a decorated hero of the Titus War!"

The crowd erupted in a wave of cheers for their beloved townsman who had brought them glory by showcasing his prowess in the Titus war. Adrian acknowledged the adulation with a raised hand.

The count continued, his voice carrying across the arena, "Young Theron, do you still wish to continue to participate in this challenge against your kin?"

Theron met his uncle's gaze, a flicker of guilt and shame momentarily clouding his eyes. "I must," he said, his voice low. "Uncle please forgive me for dragging you and aunty into this situation."

A smattering of applause rippled through the crowd for his display of stoicism. His uncle offered a warm smile. "Boy..." Adrian began, then shook his head with a chuckle, "After all you have accomplished today, you should no longer be called a boy. I am immensely proud of the man you've become."

Theron offered a grateful nod and a flicker of a smile. "Raised by two exceptional people, how could I go wrong?"

His uncle playfully swatted the air. "We did nothing out of the norm other than taking care of our own family." His expression turned serious, and he raised his voice for all to hear. "While I dearly wish for your to win this duel and accomplish your dreams, my honor compels me to fight

at my best and prohibits me from conceding victory to you. I will use every ounce of my strength to defeat you, even though I do not wish to stand in your way of acquiring your rightful magical power."

Theron met his uncle's gaze, his face etched with solemn determination. "I wouldn't have it any other way. This duel, I believe, will be the crucible that reveals if I am worthy of enrolling into the university."

His voice hardened with resolve. "Uncle, I too, will fight with all my might to defeat you."

The count approached, his eyes flitting between the two figures. He inspected his uncle's weapon - a legion sword, a testament to his past glories. Confident in his elemental magic - air, earth, wood, and metal - Adrian had opted to forgo a shield and trust his prodigious magic to steer him to victory in the duel.

After a cursory inspection for enchantments and poisons later, the count returned the weapons and stepped back from the circle. "Commence!" he declared.

Chapter 10

An Exhibition of Passion

Being grateful or pursuing your aspirations?

What is important? Being grateful to those you owe or tenaciously pursuing your goal?

For Fate is a fickle beast that dangles the carrot in front of most men, forcing them to choose between their ambitions and their desire to be grateful to someone who has helped them immensely.

I am aware that I should be grateful for the life my grandfather has given me since he spends every waking second trying to safeguard me from a nation determined to slay me and stop me from ascending the throne.

But oftentimes, I feel as if I'm being held back from pursuing my dreams, for my grandfather stands in my way like an overprotective hand that squeezes you mistakenly while attempting to save you.

So, is it wrong for me to go against my grandfather, the only man who is ensuring my survival?

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

Theron unsheathed his twin swords whilst his uncle channeled his magic, conjuring a shield made out of both his air and earth elemental shield over his left hand. Adrian, the very man who'd aided in forging Theron's unmetal swords, had woven this unusual shield after understanding the benefits of mixing opposing elements. The shield, a volatile fusion of opposing elements – air and earth – offered far greater resilience than a standard legion shield.

Theron surged forward, only to falter as Adrian willed Tempest, his earth elemental manifestation, to erupt from the ground. The colossal, granite-hued elemental, resembling a monstrous wolf, pounced upon him with chilling indifference.

Theron lurched to his side, narrowly avoiding the elemental's ferocious leap. Tempest was a five-foot-wide, gray-stone elemental that resembled an overgrown wolf and was roughly half the size of Adrian. Guilt gnawed at Theron – *how could he raise his blade against the entity that had protected him for so long?*

So, unlike the prior duels, he refrained himself from dispatching the earth elemental.

As the colossal elemental leaped past him, he lunged towards his uncle, his unmetal swords singing through the air. The first blade clanged ineffectually against his uncle's shield, while the second deflected a counter-blow of his uncle's Phalanx sword.

Tempest, with surprising agility, adjusted its trajectory and pounced towards Theron's back. Reacting with lightning reflexes, he dodged and sidestepped the attack. Recognizing the danger his own creation posed, Adrian dissolved Tempest back into the sand, preventing it from smashing into its owner after missing its target.

Capitalizing on Theron's momentary lapse in footwork, Adrian swung his blade with ferocious intent at his nephew's torso. Reacting instinctively, Theron parried the blow with his left sword before leaping back to regain his footing.

The two duelists circled each other, a tense dance of anticipation filling the audience.

Theron feinted a strike at his uncle's left arm, a mere flicker of movement. Adrian, caught off guard, raised his shield to deflect the nonexistent attack, leaving himself open. Adrian thrust his sword hastily at Theron, who intercepted his uncle's counter-blow with his right blade. Noticing Adrian stumbling a little to stop his feint, Theron exploited this momentary lapse and spun in a full circle. Theron used the momentum of his spin to deliver a powerful, one-handed swing of his other sword at the center of his uncle's elemental shield.

The force behind the blow, amplified by Theron's whirling motion, shattered the shield into two. Adrian, stunned by the unexpected display of strength from his nephew, stumbled backwards in surprise and dropped the shattered shield to the ground.

Theron pressed his advantage, closing the distance and aiming a blow at his off-balance uncle. But Adrian, borrowing the strength from his earth elemental, recovered swiftly and deflected the attack with his own blade. Undeterred, Adrian reforged a shield from air and earth magic before slamming it into Theron's chest.

Theron, surprised by the swift reconstruction of the shield, attempted to dodge the shield, but the blow landed squarely, knocking the wind out of him. As he sailed through the air, disoriented, he sensed Tempest pounce from his left flank. Lacking the balance to evade, he braced himself for the impact, curling himself into a ball to lessen the blow.

Tempest smashed onto the curled form of the boy without any apprehension of harming the boy it had protected all these years.

Though Theron's armor absorbed most of the force, the elemental's attack sent a jolt of pain through his body. He landed with a heavy thud, rolling over to absorb the shock before scrambling back to his feet. Tempest, relentless in its assault, launched itself once more at Theron.

Knowing he wouldn't have time to regain his footing completely to evade the mammoth elemental, Theron gambled on a daring maneuver. He leaned back sharply on his knees, lowering his head to narrowly avoid the elemental's powerful leap. The elemental's claws swiped past his face by a hair's breadth.

With a graceful kick of his legs, Theron sprang upwards to his feet and turned to face his adversary. He knew he had to deal with Tempest before confronting his uncle. He spat out blood and watched Tempest circle him menacingly, letting out a thunderous growl before bounding towards him. Just as he swerved away from the elemental's attack, he felt the earth tremble beneath his feet – Adrian was charging towards him from his flanks. Anticipating Theron to dodge Tempest once again, Adrian launched himself into the air with the help of his earth and air magic towards his ward in a surprise attack.

Adrian landed close to Theron with a leap driven by earth and air elementals even as Theron tumbled down and attempted to escape his uncle's grasp. Adrian flung his shield toward Theron's back, knocking his nephew down and sent him hurtling in the air from the power of his throw. Tempest leaped at Theron, but he altered his fall into a roll and skipped past the relentless wolf elemental just in time.

The shield that had struck Theron moments ago dissipated to sand, only to be replaced by another in Adrian's hand.

He rose to his feet once more and faced his uncle with a newfound respect. A tense silence

descended upon the crowd, many witnessing for the first time the awe-inspiring and fierce exhibition of Adrian's power and coordination with his manifested elemental.

The crowd, previously a cacophony of cheers and jeers, fell into a stunned silence. Many had heard tales of Adrian's prowess, but witnessing it firsthand was a revelation. The tales about Adrian's prowess wasn't mere hearsay anymore; They watched a brutal ballet of magic and steel which seemed more like a storm that had arrived to battle.

Within a few minutes, Adrian had thrashed the youngster who had defeated the rest of the fortress' finest soldiers. *Clearly, Adrian was not a decorated soldier by chance.*

And they were shell-shocked to find a father figure pounding the crap out of the young man he'd raised as his own son. Any lingering skepticism regarding Adrian taking it easy on the boy he had raised with so much affection dissipated entirely.

They understood that Adrian is not someone who would cast his duty aside. In this particular duel, Adrian was a soldier of the fortress and not a father to the one he was duelling.

Theron scrutinized his armor, grateful that it had absorbed the majority of the blows. Thankfully, it remained in decent condition. Though he was certain he bore bruises beneath, he remained unscathed and capable of continuing the duel without impediment. Nevertheless, he pondered whether his armor could endure further onslaughts without shattering.

His uncle flexed his shoulders. "I apologize, Theron. My honor prohibits me from holding back in this duel."

Theron spat blood out of his mouth and smiled at his uncle. "Thanks for warming me up, Uncle. This duel appears to be rather challenging."

"That's the spirit, lad. That's the spirit." Adrian burst out laughing.

Instead of waiting for Theron to make a move, Adrian charged at Theron alongside Tempest. Theron realized that swerving from the elemental's path was ineffective when his uncle reading him like an open book and was ready for his counter-maneuvers already. His uncle lived by the instructions he had shared with Theron while counseling him about war and life.

"Always evaluate the opponent's response to a situation before initiating an attack."

His uncle knew too much about him, but he was unaware that Cadmus had taught him swordsmanship, which was superior to Adrian's swordsmanship by a mile.

It's time to be to be unpredictable! Theron murmured to himself.

Instead of defending against two formidable assailants like a conventional soldier, he did something that his uncle did not anticipate. He charged his uncle and the leaping manifested wolf instead.

Theron lowered his swords and dropped to the ground on his knees and leaning his body to the ground, missing the leaping elemental. He rose to his feet and feinted with his sword at his uncle's knees.

Adrian was taken aback by his nephew's offensive maneuver and hurriedly sought to defend his feint. But Theron pulled out of the feint and vaulted out of his uncle's defensive maneuver.

Theron did not retaliate as Adrian charged past him. Adrian leaped forward several feet to avoid Theron's expected backswing on his back, which never arrived.

Adrian abruptly changed direction mid-air as he tumbled backward and slashed his sword at his nephew, whom he believed would be hoping to use his stumble.

He was shocked that Theron had not used his disadvantage. As Adrian collided with his wolf manifestation, it morphed into a cushion. It was a fantastic casting effort by his uncle.

Theron did not follow his uncle in such an evident charge which even a simple soldier could have expected. *"In a battle, you should never fight in the manner your opponent expects you to."* Cadmus had pounded that lesson into him with several bruises whenever he sought to exploit his sword master's missteps during training.

Adrian stepped out of the cushion, and the manifestation reverted to its wolf form.

Theron did not wait for the elemental to launch its assault. Instead, he charged and aggressively swung his sword at his uncle, who raised his blade to block him. Theron's decisive blow, bolstered by his charge, splintered a piece of his uncle's blade, despite his uncle's metal casting the weapon to be strong.

Theron stepped past his uncle to his left as he observed the wolf elemental attempting to rush him from Adrian's right. His uncle utilized metal casting to sharpen his metal sword, and he used his Earth magic to smooth the blade and conceal the chip with a light veil.

He looked across at Theron with a frown, who had taken a step to his left. He snarled, "Tempest, go!" The elemental attempted to sidestep Adrian's right leg to charge Theron.

Adrian swung his sword at Theron. Theron, however, easily intercepted the swing with his own and sidestepped around his uncle's left side and placing Adrian, who had also rotated, between himself and Tempest once more.

The elemental hissed and attempted to alter direction, but Theron stepped to his right after intercepting his uncle's swipe and again placed his uncle between himself and Tempest.

When his uncle realized his ploy, he roared and dissolved his elemental. He attempted to summon his elemental next to Theron. But Theron raced at his uncle and swung his sword at Adrian, sensing the presence of the elemental trying to materialize behind him. His uncle parried his powerful swing without drawing power from the earth as it would slow him down and open him to Theron's strike.

Adrian halted Theron's blade with his strong muscles, metal-casting ability, and speed borrowed from his weak air elemental. Adrian retreated a few paces to keep Theron at arm's length and prevent him from approaching too closely.

Keeping one ear open for any advances from the wolf elemental that was materializing behind his back, Theron made a feint with his other blade, but Adrian slammed his shield to deflect the thrust. Theron abruptly abandoned the feint and smoothly spun before moving around Adrian. His uncle turned to face him and hissed, recognizing that Theron had once again placed him between the materialized wolf elemental and Theron.

Hmm! Adrian huffed as he realized that his plan was not working. He had planned to knock the youngster unconscious without touching him, but Theron was so determined that he was forced to face the boy in head-on combat.

Adrian drew strength from the ground and summoned his air elemental for speed before charging Theron with an air and earth shield.

Theron had been anticipating a head-on combat with his uncle for a while now. He was glad when the moment arrived and blocked his uncle's tremendous blow with the sword in his right hand, while thrusting his left hand at his uncle's shield. He retreated slowly while deflecting his uncle's blows and thrust often with his second sword to prevent his uncle from using his shield as an offensive weapon.

Adrian was moving rapidly with the assistance of his air elemental, but Theron matched him blow for blow. His uncle seemed to be looking for a weakness, and Theron purposefully provided a one little opening. Adrian had no idea what Theron was up to. Theron had so far been repeatedly slashing at his uncle's sword at the same spot, chipping it even further and weakening it even more with each swing.

Adrian advanced to capitalize on the opportunity and attempted to strike Theron with his sword's pommel. As Adrian fell into his trap and held his sword aloft vertically to the ground, Theron stepped back and used a full swing of his blade to cleave his uncle's sword in half.

Adrian gaped at Theron, disbelief morphing into dawning comprehension – he'd been tricked by his nephew into a headlong combat. The trap had sprung, and his sword lay in shattered ruin at his feet while his hand held onto the hilt of the shattered sword. In a desperate bid for reprieve, Adrian flung the hilt at Theron's head. The young man nimbly sidestepped the sword hilt and retreated a few paces.

Adrian, in turn, withdrew a few feet, employing his earth magic to shape a crude yet formidable stone axe. He summoned Tempest to stand in front of him and guard him while he sharpened the ax with his earth and air magic.

A grim understanding settled upon Adrian – Theron's blades would cleave through his hastily forged stone axe like brittle lace. The lad's assault had been calculated, aimed not at Adrian's flesh but at stripping Adrian of his sole defense against the unyielding onslaught of the unmetal blades.

Spectators were enraptured by the fluid dance between two masters of the blade, culminating in the shattering of Adrian's sword by Theron's skillful strike. Cheers erupted from the crowd, witnessing the apprentice poised to surpass the master who had nurtured him like a son.

Stepping back, Theron sheathed his swords, prompting a narrowed gaze from Adrian. "*Why sheathe your swords, Theron?*" Adrian queried, suspicion lacing his tone.

"Uncle, all this while, I aimed only for your weapon. My intent was never to harm you. With your sword shattered, mine serves no purpose in this duel anymore." With a decisive flourish, Theron ripped off the sheaths that held his twin blades and tossed it away, letting his two swords clatter to the ground.

Bewilderment clouded Adrian's features. "How can you hope to defeat me without a weapon?"

Theron shrugged, his arms spread wide in a gesture of helplessness. "How can I raise my hand against the man who has devoted his entire life to my well-being? My dream of attending the university is not worth pursuing if it requires harming you to attain it."

A collective gasp rippled through the crowd as the weight of Theron's actions settled upon

them. Theron was relinquishing his only advantage, his weapons, against the most powerful caster in the valley.

Adrian's jaw dropped open, astonishment momentarily stunning him before he regained his composure. "By the Great One! Theron!" he roared, his voice thick with disbelief. He softened his tone abruptly, a hint of desperation creeping in. "How in the bloody hells do you expect to win without even laying a hand on me? You don't even have magic for a ranged attack!"

Theron shrugged his shoulders in reply.

"Are you seriously considering conceding defeat after overcoming all these obstacles, now that I'm the one at a disadvantage without a sword to defend against your weapons?" Adrian's voice crackled with a mix of anger and frustration directed at his nephew.

Theron shook his head resolutely. "Uncle, I refuse to concede defeat. I simply refuse to resort to arms. I will still strive my best to defeat you, but I will do so without ever raising a hand against you."

Gasps rippled through the onlookers as the lad relinquished his weapons, refusing to take up arms against the valley's most formidable soldier.

Adrian's voice softened. "You don't have to do this, Theron. We did not ask for this trial. This situation was thrust upon us. I wouldn't mind losing to you, or you raising your weapons against me."

A gentle smile graced Theron's lips. "Uncle, your honor compels you to fight the boy you reared without conceding your victory. Likewise, my honor dictates that my dreams are not worth pursuing if it requires me to raise my hands against a man I regard as more than a father."

A hush fell over the gathering as the realization dawned – the young man was prepared to abandon his lifelong dream rather than strike the one who had nurtured him. After all the scorn that the magicless boy had endured all these years, he was relinquishing his only advantage at the very last hurdle.

Adrian, rendered speechless, turned to his sister Elissa, who stood outside the dueling circle. "Lissa!" he bellowed, desperation lacing his voice. "Tell the lad not to do this!"

Theron turned to face his aunt as she attempted to dissuade him from his foolish sacrifice. Elissa used her air elemental to cast her sweet, appealing voice to Theron.

"Adrian is not vulnerable despite lacking a weapon. He is a war hero, for crying out loud! Even with your swords, it is not certain that you will surpass Adrian. No one, least of all us, would judge you for raising your hands and weapons in this duel against your uncle."

Her plea continued. "Besides, you lack the magic to face Adrian without weapons. Everyone gathered here understands the hardships you've endured your whole life and how diligently you have trained to overcome the hurdles you confronted today. Please, fight your uncle without discarding the advantage you have earned fairly."

Theron smiled and answered in a calm, steady tone. Theron reiterated Elissa's earlier words in the participant's tent before he left to participate in this accursed challenge: "*The most important thing in a person's life is not to earn the glory or respect he receives from others; it is to love and be loved.*"

"How can I love myself or even have a modicum of self-respect if I raise my hand against the man who sacrificed his knighthood, his marriage, his entire life to raise me?" A steely glint entered his eyes. "I'd sooner abandon my dreams of university than defeat Uncle without laying a

hand on him."

Theron sensed his aunt's emotions—her joy, her pride, her concern—more acutely than anyone else.

"To love and family, now and always!" he declared, his proclamation echoing through the stunned crowd.

Count Marius and the assembled crowd stood speechless, utterly captivated by Theron's unwavering moral conduct.

Theron turned to gaze back at his distressed uncle who plead with Theron once more. "It was already painful for me to demolish the dreams you had fought so hard to achieve. Now I cannot bear the thought that I must defeat the boy I reared, who is so obstinate he refuses to defend himself against me." Adrian wailed.

"Please do not subject me to this torment." Adrian implored his nephew.

Theron shook his head. "No, Uncle. I resolved not to raise my hands against you even before accepting the challenge. I never intended to put you in harm's way with my weapons or hands. Nonetheless, I shall endeavor to defeat you without raising my hands to defend or attack you."

With a fleeting smile, Theron darted towards Adrian, unarmed. The war hero stiffened with hesitation. Adrian howled at his misfortune for placing him in such a predicament.

Theron's gamble was a desperate one. His only chance rested on incapacitating Adrian down, but without a weapon, and more importantly, without a single touch. If there was anything impossible in this world, Theron knew that this duel was one.

The crowd buzzed with confusion. How could this young man, wielding no weapon and refusing to defend himself, hope to vanquish a powerful magic caster?

How could a duel be won without either offense or defense?

Theron's path to even reach Adrian was fraught with peril. He had to evade not just the earth elemental's wrath, but also his uncle's shield and axe. He'd held back from dispatching the wolf elemental with his own blade out of concern for Tempest, who had protected him for so many years. Today, he had decided not to raise his hands against both his uncle and the elemental.

Despite all the odds stacked against him in this duel now, he did possess one advantage – His swordsmanship. Years of relentless training under Cadmus had honed his swordsmanship even without a blade in the formative years of his training.

Cadmus had taught him that a sword did not make a man the finest swordsman; rather, it was the mastery of superior sword forms. A sword, Cadmus had ingrained in him, was merely an extension of his body; the body itself was a sharp weapon.

Theron had always thrived on challenges, and he believed this duel was the ultimate test to determine if he was qualified to enroll into the university. Armed only with his wit, he faced Adrian and the formidable magic at his uncle's disposal.

He knew he was nimble enough to maneuver past his uncle's sword, shield, and elemental.

However, he would soon discover if he possessed the agility to maneuver his uncle's axe and elementals simultaneously.

As Theron surged forward towards Adrian, the earth caster's axe cleaved through the air

towards Theron's midsection. With calculated precision, Theron momentarily halted his advance, allowing the deadly arc of the axe to pass harmlessly by before swiftly sidestepping his uncle's subsequent left-handed strike with the elemental shield.

Having deftly evaded both of his uncle's assaults, Theron pressed on, determined to close the distance between them. Yet, his momentum was abruptly halted as he found himself compelled to evade the menacing backswing of Adrian's axe.

He stepped back on the balls of his feet, just missing the ax. He turned toward the wolf elemental, which he sensed to be charging him from his left. He rolled backward to avoid colliding with the leaping wolf elemental.

Theron quickly rose to his feet when he saw his uncle charging him.

In the heat of battle, he instinctively attempted to punch the approaching presence but hesitated, pausing his arms mid-swing upon remembering his opponent's identity. Theron resisted his impulse with great difficulty to defend himself against a rushing attacker.

With a wince, Theron lowered his arms and let his uncle's axe slam into his midsection, hurling him ten feet back. Blood erupted from his mouth, though his unmetal armor held, albeit looking dented from the tremendous blow of Adrian's axe.

He pushed himself up, muscles screaming in protest before he managed a bloody smile aimed at his crestfallen uncle. "That was exhilarating," Theron rasped.

"Theron, please don't continue with this stupidity," Adrian pleaded, his voice thick with despair. Adrian hoped that the powerful blow of his axe would make Theron fear his axe enough to relent and pick up his weapons.

Theron smiled at his uncle and spat blood from his mouth. "Not a chance, uncle!" Theron decided to draw out his sword forms for a longer duration before getting within his uncle's reach. He charged again.

Adrian again dispatched his elemental against Theron. Instead of rushing at him as in previous encounters, the elemental attempted to crush his legs.

Theron countered with a masterful triple feint, confusing the elemental. He danced around the creature, its frustrated swipes missing him by a hair.

He staggered away from his uncle's ax thrust at his stomach, whirling around and darting around his uncle's right side. He made sure his uncle couldn't use the shield in his left hand, which was the most lethal weapon in this combat because it was more difficult to evade the shield than the comparatively slim ax.

He continued to weave through Adrian's attacks, prioritizing evading the shield – its broad surface far more dangerous than the swift axe. He slipped behind Adrian, who continued to flail the shield, oblivious to his nephew's precise location.

As Theron finally glimpsed the opening he had been patiently awaiting, he swiftly retrieved a knife from his armor, his heart pounding with anticipation as he closed the distance between himself and his uncle. Yet, before Theron could execute his intended maneuver, Adrian tapped into his air casting to quicken his movements and spun around with surprising speed, the backswing of his axe connecting with Theron's shoulder.

A sickening crack echoed through the air as bones near his biceps cracked. The force of

the blow sent Theron sprawling, his body rolling across the ground from the powerful blow.

The crowd groaned when Theron came within an inch of Adrian's neck with an incredible display of sword-dance, dodging his uncle's tremendous thrusts and punches without even raising a hand to even defend himself.

Theron coughed, struggling to his feet. Agony flared in his left shoulder, indicating the fractured bone beneath the dented armor. He realized that even his unmetal armor wouldn't withstand many more blows.

The armor could only resist so many more blows before it began to weaken.

"*Theron!*" his aunt's cry pierced the air. Despite the pain, he turned towards her kneeling on the ground and feigned a smile at her aunt. He discovered tears streaming freely from her stunning blue eyes. She was on her knees, terrified of the anguish she had sensed her boy was in.

"I'm alright," he croaked, the lie heavy on his tongue.

"No, you're not," Adrian countered, his own voice thick with emotion. "Let's stop this. Concede your defeat."

Theron met his uncle's tear-filled gaze. "Never," he rasped, a defiant glint in his eyes. "This duel..." he wheezed, a ghost of a smile playing on his lips, "is just shaping up to be quite the duel."

He knew he could no longer use his left hand in this duel.

Theron rushed at his uncle unarmed and battered, his body contorted with pain. He moved with whatever agility he could muster from his anguished form, evading blows for a fleeting moment before succumbing once more to the inevitable strike that sent him crashing back to the ground.

He rose again, only to be smashed down to the ground once more.

And again...

And again...

After enduring several brutal assaults from Adrian's axe and shield, blood seeped from Theron's torso and face like a trickle of spring water. Yet, he seemed perpetually unable to close the distance to his uncle before being felled again.

Victory appeared agonizingly out of reach.

Theron, bloodied and battered, picked up a small pebble from the ground with his right hand as he rose once more. His left arm hung limp, broken, while a myriad of wounds adorned his torso and visage.

"*Give up, boy!*" Adrian pleaded in despair.

"*No!*" Theron spat out blood, his determination unyielding. He centered his thoughts, suppressing the agony in his body by diverting his mind to the very thing he yearned for each day - the day when he would wield his magic and be regarded as an equal.

The image of being treated as an equal provided a welcome distraction from the excruciating pain coursing through his body. Not one inch of his body was spared from pain.

Even his armor were dented at several places, causing several wounds and bruises beneath the armor.

Once more, he charged at his uncle, pushing himself to ignore the pain. Adrian roared at the stubborn boy, who seemed oblivious to the fact that he had been bested the moment he had

relinquished his weapons. Determined to bring an end to this accursed duel, Adrian decided to knock his nephew unconscious with a single blow.

Theron surged forward in a desperate gamble. Just as he neared his uncle, his legs buckled. With a grunt, he skidded, scraping past Adrian's left flank, then lurched backward as the glint of Adrian's axe swept above him. He comprehended the predictable arc of Adrian's next form of attack - a shield bash aimed squarely at his face. In a last-ditch effort, Theron flicked the smooth pebble he'd palmed earlier, sending it skittering towards Adrian's left foot.

In a split second, Theron leaped to his feet to miss the swipe of Adrian's shield that smashed into the spot he just vacated. Without giving time for his uncle to regain his balance, Theron feigned a lunge towards Adrian's torso.

Adrian, instinctively stepped back, stumbled over the pebble flicked earlier by Theron, causing him to lose his balance and crash to the ground.

A surprised yelp escaped Adrian's lips as his ankle buckled, sending him sprawling to the ground with a thud. His grip loosened on his weapons, and the wind whooshed from his stomach as he impacted the earth.

Scrambling for purchase, Adrian looked up to find Theron looming over him, a glint of steel cold in his hand. Realization dawned on Adrian's face. The boy held the upper hand now. One touch of the knife to his throat, and he knew he had no option but to concede his defeat.

The crowd erupted, a chorus of voices urging Theron on. The unthinkable was within reach. Time itself seemed to stretch, the spectators hanging on every agonizing second of this dramatic climax.

But before Theron could deliver the final blow, a blur of grey fur intervened. Tempest, the earth elemental, intervened with a ferocious pounce, knocking Theron clear of his uncle. Pain flared in Theron's hip as he was hurled through the air. He contorted his body to land on his back and avoid further damage to his injured shoulder. Despite the ferocious impact of his armor, it survived the collision of the elemental, but the throbbing in his hip intensified.

"Abhhhh!" A collective groan of disappointment rippled through the crowd. Victory was snatched away at the very last moment.

Theron lay sprawled, surrendering to the wave of pain that washed all over him.

Meanwhile, Adrian scrambled to his feet. With a surge of disbelief, he unleashed his earth magic, brushing the area of any remaining treacherous pebbles. He couldn't believe such a trivial object had almost cost him the duel.

Whispers of astonishment rippled through the crowd. Theron, using only a single pebble, had disarmed and nearly defeated his formidable uncle.

Tense silence descended upon the clearing. Everyone held their breath, waiting to see if Theron possessed the strength to rise and continue the fight.

A minute stretched into an eternity as Theron lay unmoving, locked in an internal battle.

The pain threatened to overwhelm Theron, urging surrender, but his warrior's heart burned bright, urging him to rise once more and resume the duel.

Would Theron rise? Could he possibly muster the strength to continue the unenviable duel?

Suddenly, heavy clouds choked the fortress, unleashing a torrent of rain that lashed the

stronghold. The gathered folks scrambled for cover, raising shields of air, earth, or water conjured by their elementals. The downpour, unexpected for a season nearing spring, sent a shiver of apprehension through the crowd.

For Theron, the icy rain was a cruel blessing. The bite of the cold momentarily dulled the throbbing agony, allowing his defiant heart to overpower the pleas of his battered mind. With a groan that rivaled the storm's fury, he rose, one arm hanging limp at his side.

Adrian, witnessing Theron's unwavering spirit, crumpled under the weight of shame. His voice, thick with anguish, broke the tense silence. "Theron, why? Why torment yourself further? You have lost this duel the moment you relinquished your weapons!"

Theron, his face contorted in pain, could only manage a weak shrug and a ghost of a smile. The effort of speaking was excruciating.

Adrian, his voice ragged with desperation, pressed on. "The pain you endure... surely the university isn't worth such a sacrifice! Yield, Theron, I beg you!"

A rasping cough wracked Theron's body before he croaked out, "This pain...it's a mere whisper compared to the ache in my heart, the scorn I've endured from our own townsfolk." Exhaustion painted his voice with despair. "Do you know how many nights I've wept, yearning for even a single elemental to answer my call so that I can be treated like an equal instead of being considered a vermin?"

He continued, his voice gaining strength despite the blood trickling from his lips. "I have much to prove. I won't surrender without a fight!" Another cough forced him to pause.

Adrian, his eyes filled with a storm of conflicting emotions, gestured with his axe towards Theron's abandoned weapons. "Then at least pick up your swords! Fight me without conceding your advantage atleast!"

Theron shook his head weakly. "I will not raise a hand against you, Uncle."

Despair etched itself onto Adrian's face. "But how can one subdue his opponent without weapons or magic?"

Theron's reply, delivered in a weary rasp that echoed the howling wind, sent shivers down Adrian and Elissa's body - "Then I will fight until my last breath."

Adrian's anguished cry pierced the air as he broke down, wailing as he inflicted pain on the boy he raised as his own son. He whirled around towards the gathered townsfolk, his voice echoing across the rain-slicked courtyard. "You! You are all to be blamed for this lad's stupid conviction!"

"*Isn't this what we've condemned in the weak* - the lack of courage to face those with superior magic?" he boomed. "Haven't we persecuted them, branding them useless to our society for lacking the power we possess?"

His voice cracked. "We mocked their lack of powerful magic in the weak, yet they've shown themselves far more human than us, holding no grudge for our bullying."

Adrian's trembling finger pointed at Theron. "This boy, deemed the weakest among us, has he not proven his worth? Doesn't his courage and strength surpass that of any of you?"

A stunned silence descended upon the crowd as Adrian spat in disgust. Shame began to creep into the faces of some onlookers. The image of a father inflicting pain on his son was a stark

reminder of their culpability. Heads hung low as they recognized their role in Theron's suffering. They had readily accepted the narrative of Theron's uselessness without any magic, fueling and encouraging the flames of bullies like Ferris to ridicule Theron at every opportunity.

"*You are wasting your time on deaf ears, Uncle,*" Theron rasped, his voice firm despite his ragged breaths. "The fault lies not with them, but with our society. Sukrans have built a Social hierarchy on magical might, not the goodness of one's heart. These people are not evil, but products of a system that worships raw power above all

He continued, his voice gaining strength. "Our society has established a hierarchy in which only those with greater magical power may advance in rank. Consequently, these people began to place greater importance on the magical prowess possessed by a citizen."

He elaborated, his tone impassioned. "Our noble lords were meant to be protectors, yet they've maintained power by oppressing the less fortunate. Even Evander Primus, our first king, failed to foresee this. He should have predicted how the hunger for power would turn Sukrans against each other in their quest for power, dominance and social status."

The crowd listened in uneasy silence, grappling with the implications of Theron's words. His indictment of their society's shortcomings left them introspective, contemplating the gradual erosion of humanity within their race.

Could the boy be correct?

Theron's gaze fell upon the silent slaves huddled at the edge of the crowd. A bitter laugh escaped him. "We've sunk so low as a race to enslave our own kin. We mock the Mayans as barbarians for their supposedly primitive ways, yet what would they think of us, who chain our own people's mind and spirit?"

A murmur rippled through the crowd. Shame flickered across some faces.

He scoffed at the Sukran populace. "They might liken us to ravenous, rabies-infected beasts that deserve to be put down."

Theron's voice dripped with sarcasm. "The king and nobility, who should've opposed this barbarity when it began, brushed it aside as a minor issue when compared to their thirst for power. They have been consumed by their petty squabbles for the throne. They were too concerned with their own welfare to worry about the persecution of their fellow Sukrans."

He continued, his tone laced with anger. "These so-called leaders embraced spirit-binding magic as a tool to enslave others and compel the slaves to carry out their bidding without fear of reprisal. Even if a slave were caught committing a heinous act at their master's command, the slaves would be unable to defy their master's orders and reveal their master's identity, thereby providing impunity to the slaves' masters from any repercussion of their heinous crimes."

Adrian, resigned, attempted to justify the practice. "Slavery was meant to deter individuals from committing heinous crimes."

"Slavery," Theron declared, "is the most heinous of all crimes, a horror we decry even from gods. Yet, we've embraced Slavery as punishment!"

"Is it not naive," Theron challenged, "to believe that one can prevent crime by codifying the most egregious of all crimes into law and punishing minor transgressions with the most heinous of crimes: slavery?"

The silence that followed his question was palpable, as the town's inhabitants grappled with the weight of his words.

"And yet, we whine about our noble lords mistreating us and abusing their position," Theron continued, his words laced with accusation, "even though most of you favor slavery just because you can afford it"

He turned to Adrian, his voice low and intense. "Uncle, do you know what is worse: being magicless in a land of magic, or enslaved by your own brethren?"

"To be enslaved by your countrymen is a punishment that should never be meted out to even the most heinous criminals."

"No one," Theron emphasized, his voice ringing with conviction, "has the right to strip another of their freedom."

"Freedom is an inalienable right, not a privilege!"

Adrian interrupted Theron's impassioned speech. "I acknowledge that our society as a whole is descending into savagery. But what can commoners like us do when our legitimate rulers refuse to prioritize the abolition of slavery?"

Theron jabbed a finger towards his Uncle. "This mindset," he declared, "allows power-hungry rulers to dismiss common citizens, believing they can quell any uprising with their unmatched god-like magic. People remain apathetic until these issues directly affect them, leaving no unified voice against the corrupt and power-hungry lords who neglect their duty to protect their brethren."

Adrian shook his head in frustration. "As you've said, the lords corrupted by their pursuit of power are too formidable for us to challenge."

Theron threw back his head and laughed, a harsh, humorless sound. "Haven't I proven today that elemental might isn't the most potent power in the world? Despite being deemed the weakest man in Sukra, I've shown that strength of human will and wisdom can overcome any magic."

"If you feel corrupt rulers are too powerful for common folks, then the disparity between the strength of those I confronted today and my magicless might is similar. Many people in this town regarded me as the weakest man in Sukra, but I have proven that elemental strength is no match for a person's willpower and wisdom."

"Forget me! If you still believe that magic can't be triumphed by anything else, I ask you all to remember the Mayans, considered widely as barbarians, who slaughtered our most powerful heir with nothing but primitive animal bonding magic! If those barbarians could topple a scion of the house of Primus with mere brute force, can't we Sukrans, with far greater magic coursing through our veins, overthrow our corrupt leaders?"

His voice dropped, tinged with sadness. "When I discovered I was magicless and was destined to endure a lifetime of ridicule as the weakest individual in the entire realm, I made a solemn vow to do something unprecedented in our realm's history."

"I have vowed to do the impossible and impart a lesson to our people by achieving what most Sukrans deem impossible even with the aid of the most powerful magic in the realm."

Theron's gaze hardened. "My goal to enroll in university is not just to gain my magic and

be treated as an equal. Magic is merely a fringe benefit of attending the university. Obtaining magic or not, my true purpose of aspiring to join the university is to glean insights into the inner workings of the upper echelons of society from those attending the university, and ultimately utilize that knowledge to shatter this oppressive social hierarchy and liberate those who have long been marginalized and oppressed under its weight."

A sudden, primal certainty washed over Theron - lightning was about to strike him. He was not sure how he was certain about the lightning strike, but what shocked him more was that he was not frightened about the impending strike.

Theron unsheathed his unmetal dagger from its scabbard at his right hip and raised it high above his head.

A crack of thunder split the sky, and a bolt of lightning shot down like a screaming arrow, slamming right into Theron's dagger! A radiant white light engulfed him, forming a swirling cocoon of energy.

"*Theron!*" Elissa's cry of horror echoed as she attempted to rush to her nephew's aid, though a part of her mind realized it was futile and she would be too late to save her nephew before the lightning charred him. But she was stopped by Marius who tried to prevent her from embracing the fate of the unfortunate boy.

Adrian sprinted towards his nephew, only to be repelled by the formidable tendrils of pure energy enveloping Theron.

The crowd, transformed into stunned statues, could only gasp and watch as Theron became a vortex of white light, the very air buzzing with raw power.

An eternity stretched into a handful of tense seconds before the light surrounding Theron began to recede into the night air. Slowly, the white cocoon faded, revealing Theron standing upright, the unmetal dagger still clutched tightly in his hand and held aloft above his head.

A collective sigh of relief washed over the crowd. Relief and disbelief flickered across Elissa, Adrian, and the townsfolk's faces as they watched Theron appear unscathed. He might have been the most reviled figure in their valley, but not on this day. Not after Theron had won them over with his display of pure heart and soul, combined with an indomitable will to never surrender.

Whispers of "miracle" started to ripple through the throng, a testament to the young man's lucky reprieve. After all, a lightning strike like the one they just witnessed could have vaporized even the most powerful noble lords.

The lightning's energy pulsed visibly along the length of the dagger, like a captured mini-storm. With a surge of determination etched on his face, Theron knelt and plunged the weapon into the earth with all his might.

Raising his head to meet his uncle's gaze, Theron proclaimed in a voice filled with fierce resolve, "*I swear to break the chains of slavery and dismantle this unjust hierarchy based on power and magic!*"

"A new order built on fairness and compassion will rise, or I will perish trying!"

A shockwave erupted from the dagger, a wave of energy that rippled outwards in widening circles, engulfing the entire fortress.

As the wave swept past the onlookers, the ground beneath their feet trembled, sending shivers down their spines. Some in the grandstand scrambled to hold onto their seats to avoid being thrown off balance.

Theron's words echoed in their ears, resonating deep within their souls. As the ground gradually stabilized, Theron sheathed his unmetal dagger, feeling unexpectedly invigorated by the lightning.

Adrian was astonished by his protege's declaration of a lofty aspiration, which was made even more dramatic by the lightning bolt that added further weight to his proclamation.

Adrian could find the gathered crowd grow shell-shocked at Theron's proclamation. Not soon after, Adrian was even more surprised when a few section of the crowd started chanting his nephew's name.

Those who, like Theron, had suffered oppression at the hands of their peers, applauded the audacity of one lad willing to confront their oppressors in such a dramatic manner. A silent yearning arose among some for Theron to transform their kingdom into a paradise.

"*Oh, my dear!*" Elissa gasped, taken aback. She hadn't realized the depth of Theron's desire to reshape the destinies of thousands who shared his plight of being oppressed by more powerful citizens.

Standing next to Elissa, Count Marius paled as he sensed a surge of excitement and optimism among the crowd, particularly the slaves gathered to witness the duel.

After a moment, Marius found his voice and exclaimed to Elissa, "This young man is truly remarkable. I had no inkling that our society had sunk as low as the lad described. I sincerely pray he achieves his lofty ambition."

Watching alongside the slaves, Cadmus beamed with pride. "By the great one!" he said, shaking his head to collect himself. "After many years, I dare to feel a glimmer of hope that our realm may yet be saved."

Cadmus shook his head again, striving to suppress the emotions welling up inside him. With a stoic expression, he raised his head and watched his student with a mix of emotions – pride, trepidation, and a touch of fear.

"Theron, I am certain that you will break this world, whether for better or worse, but break it you will," he murmured.

Theron tiredly sheathed the unmetal dagger that had miraculously saved him from the lightning bolt.

"Uncle," he said, his voice thick with emotion, "Do you now understand why I refused to raise my hands against you in this duel?"

Adrian nodded with tears streaming down his face.

"If I raised a hand against you, the man who sacrificed everything for me, just to achieve the magic and power denied to me, I'd be no better than the power-hungry lords I despise," Theron started to growl at the thought of those noble lords he despised to his core. "I'd rather die than become one of them."

A heavy silence descended upon the fortress grounds.

"Let's finish this duel," Theron said, his gaze resolute.

Despite the throbbing pain, a surge of hatred towards the oppressive lords and bullies from his bordertown fueled Theron with renewed strength. And the lightning bolt seemed to have revitalized him for one last effort for the night.

Theron recognized this might be his final chance to win since he feared he would be unable to stand if he was struck again. It was time to implement his fallback option. His entire lifetime of ridicule and scorn swept past behind his eyes as he charged at his uncle. The years of contempt had infuriated him so much that he used his rage to ignore the pain flooding his body.

It's time to confound his uncle.

"*For a united and free Sukra!*" he roared, charging at Adrian.

Theron recognized his strategy was simple: keep his uncle disoriented by making Adrian move in opposite directions. It was his final opportunity to disorient his uncle, who was relying on his earth and air casting to endure the duel.

And he had only one option to execute his strategy – the Shadow play!

Adrian sent his elemental at Theron before following close on the heels of Tempest, expecting Theron to swerve out of the elemental's course. Adrian was determined to knock his nephew with one blow and finish this accursed duel as soon as Theron swayed out of the path of Tempest.

But Theron surprised everyone. With a burst of agility, he leaped onto the elemental's back, using its momentum to propel himself over his uncle's head. Landing behind Adrian in a blur of motion, he rolled and spun to face his uncle's exposed back.

Adrian, stunned by Theron's maneuver, desperately employed his earth magic to raise a stone wall for protection behind him even whilst he started whirling around to meet his nephew.

Theron, sensing the rising wall, didn't hesitate. He leaped onto it as the shield raised to five feet, then flung himself over his uncle's head once more, maintaining his position behind Adrian like a relentless shadow.

It became a cat-and-mouse game with Theron playing shadow to his uncle using his nimble swordforms.

Adrian spun again, just in time to see Theron sail over the wall and land behind him once more. With a growl, Adrian barked. "*Tempest! Attack!*"

The elemental turned and charged towards Theron.

Meanwhile Adrian desperately swung his ax wildly at his back to catch his nephew by surprise and buy him a little time for Tempest to finish Theron.

Theron retreated from the whistling axe, narrowly avoiding a blow to his midriff. As soon as the axe swept past by, Theron trailed behind the axe along with the whirling motion of Adrian and stuck towards the back of his uncle like a shadow once more.

Off-balance and disoriented on his axe meeting only thin air, Adrian growled in anger at his nephew's tactic of clinging to him like a shadow.

Growing dazed out of turning around in opposite directions repeatedly, Adrian extended his shield to his side and whirled around, hoping to catch Theron by surprise and stop his nephew from slipping to his back yet again. But Theron feinted left, then pivoted right, swirling past Adrian's right shoulder to retake his position behind Adrian.

With a primal howl of realization, Adrian understood that Theron had once again maneuvered behind him. Reacting swiftly, Adrian stepped forward to create distance from his shadow-like-nephew and swung his ax backward, fueled by the earth's strength, aiming to incapacitate Theron and halt his nephew's advance. He didn't pause to locate his nephew accurately, instead relying on instinct and brute force to prevent Theron from closing in on him.

Theron felt time freeze and slow to a crawl. He sensed Tempest leaping towards his back while his uncle's axe hurtled towards his face. *Yes!* A surge of triumph shot through him – his gamble was about to pay off!

With a swift decision, Theron dropped to his knees, allowing the lethal swing of his uncle's axe to narrowly miss his head by a hair's breadth. The earth-cast weapon, bolstered by the strength borrowed from the ground, found its mark, but not on Theron.

The earth-empowered axe, meant for Theron, found its mark instead – on the lunging Tempest. Tempest wailed and disintegrated with a resounding and cracking sound upon receiving a vicious blow from its own master.

Adrian howled in agony as his earth-forged ax and shield disintegrated into dust as soon as his powerful blow landed on his manifested elemental. He collapsed to his knees in anguish, gripping his head, as he felt agony sear through his entire being like a bolt of lightning when his own axe summoned by his earth magic smashed his own manifested earth elemental.

Disoriented, Adrian shook his head and attempted to stand. A jolt of fear froze him as he realized a cold blade pressing against his throat. Looking up, he met Theron's steely gaze, a dagger glinting in his nephew's hand.

"Do you accept defeat?" Theron inquired in a frigid tone.

Adrian's eyes widened in a mixture of shock and belated comprehension. He'd been so disoriented by Theron's rapid changes in direction that he hadn't realized he'd been tricked into destroying his own elemental. He could only nod, raising his hands in surrender.

A faint smile played on Theron's lips. "I told you, Uncle. I could defeat you without raising a hand to attack or defend."

He stepped back, leaving the stunned crowd speechless. Theron, the magicless boy, had defeated the valley's most powerful soldier – without laying a finger on his uncle. The gravity of his impossible victory sunk in – Theron had defeated a celebrated war hero without any defense or offense.

The crowd erupted into a frenzy of cheers and shouts, each voice blending into a cacophony of disbelief and awe. "*Theron! Theron!*" echoed through the air, a chorus of admiration and astonishment at the unprecedented feat they had just witnessed.

Theron took a step back, the agony he had been suppressing finally overwhelming him.

He crumpled to the ground, unconscious, before he could hit the dirt.

A roar of laughter erupted from Adrian, tears welling in his eyes – a mixture of pride and relief for his nephew's clever victory. But his smile faltered as Theron swayed and collapsed.

The war hero rushed to his nephew's side, scooping Theron's head onto his lap. The boisterous crowd fell silent at once in worry of the boy who had feasted them with a spectacular exhibition of skill, passion, and pure love.

"*Elissa!*" Adrian bellowed, his voice laced with worry.

Elissa materialized on a swirling current of air; her brow furrowed in concern. With a wave of her hand, she summoned water from nearby pools, crafting a shimmering cocoon around Theron. Landing beside Theron's pale form, she placed a hand on his chestplate, her eyes fluttering shut in concentration. Adrian stepped back, granting her space to heal the lad.

Elissa's expression twisted with concern as she surveyed the numerous wounds adorning the young man she had nurtured into a remarkable individual. Suppressing her emotions, she issued commands to her water and spirit elementals, directing them to begin the arduous task of healing Theron's injuries. This was not her first time tending to a loved one's wounds, and her resolve remained steadfast as she focused on her task.

With each gentle touch of her elemental magic, Theron's pallid complexion gradually regained its healthy hue. As Elissa worked to mend his fractured bones and soothe his myriad bruises, the rhythm of his breath steadied, signaling the return to normalcy.

Leaning back once her healing was complete, Elissa used her water elemental to gently rouse Theron from his unconscious state.

The crowd watched in astonishment as she skillfully manipulated the water to envelop and heal Theron's wounds without the need to remove his armor.

Besides, to mend shattered bones, healers preferred to undress and submerge the wounded in a pool of water since water was difficult to contain in one place and always looked for avenues to flow around.

However, they were astounded by Elissa's ability to direct the water to cling to Theron's body and provide nourishment. She used her spirit elemental to urge Theron's spirit to heal his wounds using the water as nourishment.

A murmur of awe rippled through the stunned onlookers. They knew Elissa's reputation as the finest healer in the valley, but healing someone in their armor was a very high level of casting that only a few citizens of the kingdom were capable of.

Theron's eyes fluttered open to the smiling faces of his uncle and aunt. Returning their grins, he attempted to rise, but a wave of delirium washed over him, causing him to pause. Despite the sensation of disorientation, he noticed a profound difference in his body—his wounds seemed to have healed, even though he remained encased within his armor. However, he understood that the healing magic had merely accelerated the natural healing process; his body was the one laboring overtime to mend itself, utilizing the nourishment provided by water.

Given the month's worth of cellular repair his body had crammed into mere minutes, Theron expected a long bout of delirium for many more hours.

While magic compelled the body to knit itself back together, it couldn't overcome certain limitations. No elemental magic could heal amputation. But rumors whispered of Elvan advancements in healing magic spells, allowing the Elvans to mend even mortal wounds, though such high mages were exceedingly rare.

At least he knew that healing mortal wounds were impossible with Sukran's elemental magic. Magic may prompt the body to expedite the repair process in specific areas, but ultimately, it's the body itself that undertakes the healing under the guidance of its spirit.

"Thank you, Aunt, for healing me even though I was wearing my armor. That must have been a fantastic bit of casting," Theron muttered, the exhaustion catching up.

Theron surveyed his surroundings, instinctively looking for a tub of water to gauge the extent of his blood loss. However, to his surprise, there were no water tubs nearby. It dawned on him that his aunt had managed to heal him without the necessity of a water tub.

"By the great one, Aunt! It must have been an incredible feat of casting to heal me without a water tub. I feel as rejuvenated as I did when the day began."

Elissa chuckled. "Removing your armor was the furthest thing from my mind! I was far too worried about you to wait." Elissa caressed Theron's cheeks affectionately before she pulled him into a fierce hug. "What I accomplished today pales in comparison to what you've endured, my boy."

His uncle joined the embrace, a wave of relief washing over them all. The harrowing ordeal was finally over.

The crowd erupted in a thunderous ovation, a wave of appreciation for the breathtaking display of skill and unwavering determination they'd just witnessed. They roared the name of the young man who had defied expectations, his tenacity etching this duel into the annals of their town's history. Never before had they seen a duelist, an unassuming youth at that, triumph over a decorated war hero without resorting to magic or even raising a weapon.

The cheers grew louder for the boy they had so woefully underestimated. The count stepped into the arena, silencing the crowd with a gesture.

"In my five decades of service to the crown," he boomed, his voice filled with awe, "I have witnessed countless duels – clashes between mighty lords and unassuming peasants alike. But

never, in all my years, have I seen anything quite like this duel that transpired today."

He bowed deeply to Adrian. "Sir Adrian, I bow to you for upholding your duty, though the pain of injuring the boy you raised like a son must have been excruciating." The crowd offered a sympathetic cheer for their war hero's valiant, yet emotionally fraught, attempt to defeat Theron.

The count turned to Elissa, another bow gracing his movements. "Lady Elissa, you deserve our highest praise. Raising two such men, so steadfast in their convictions and ideals even in the face of adversity, speaks volumes to the caliber of woman you are."

"Thank you, My Lord." Elissa offered a gracious smile, her eyes acknowledging Marius.

Count Marius' gaze finally settled on Theron, who stood proudly between his uncle and aunt, applauding their well-deserved recognition. A long silence stretched between them before Marius spoke.

"Theron of Adrian-Hold, I have never seen or heard of a young man as resourceful as you are. The exemplary manner in which you were reared by two honorable citizens of the realm adds even more credit to you."

Marius continued, his voice softening, "What truly impresses me is your recognition of their sacrifice. You were willing to forgo your own lifelong dream rather than endanger them or raise your hand against them. That, young man, speaks volumes about your character."

"I am delighted by your victory in this challenge and your ability to triumph over overwhelming odds. If there is one person to whom I would like to bestow all of the world's power, it would be you, given your sacrifice and honor under severe duress. You have demonstrated that you are not a power-hungry man."

The crowd whistled and applauded Theron. Theron gave a grateful nod in their direction.

Marius waited for the commotion to subside. "You have proven yourself to be the best warrior in this valley. This gives me the confidence to entrust you with a quest that I believe will be even more challenging than this ordeal you just passed with flying colors."

A hush fell over the crowd. Surely, no quest could be more grueling than the one Theron had just conquered. They all yearned for him to return victorious and secure his rightful place at the university.

Marius released a slow, heavy breath, his gaze sweeping over the assembled Sukrans. "There's a secret I'm about to share, one known only to a select few in this valley."

He paused again, letting the weight of his words settle before continuing in a measured tone. "Reports have surfaced – whispers of a unicorn sighted near the Mayan border, along the Smoky Mountains."

A collective murmur rippled through the crowd, a spark of surprise igniting hushed conversations.

The count held up a hand, silencing the sudden commotion. "Theron," he addressed the young man, "are you familiar with the pivotal role unicorns played in our history?"

Theron shook his head, brow furrowed in confusion. "No, my lord. I've never heard of their involvement in Sukra's history."

A hint of a smile played on Count Marius' lips. "Indeed. I would be shocked if you had." He launched into a captivating narrative, his voice resonating with the weight of history.

"According to our ancient records, a great number of our ancestors fled to this planet as refugees. They fled here to Orinn as nomads, escaping a race of monstrous beings known as the Maurgs who had ravaged their homeworld, Sukra."

"The king of the Maurgan race, known historically as the Maurg King, was an insanely powerful creature whose sole aim was to devour a world before moving on to the next."

Marius leaned forward, his voice dropping to a dramatic hush. "Legends tell us this Maurg King led his monstrous horde against our ancestors on Sukra. As defeat loomed, our elders, desperate to ensure our race's survival, made a difficult choice."

Marius paused, letting the weight of his words sink in before continuing. "A contingent of our people was chosen to establish a new colony. Through a magic portal, they were transported to this very realm."

"This portal," he explained, his voice grave, "was then destroyed to sever the link to our native world and prevent the Maurgs from following our surviving ancestors to Orinn and annihilate our race."

"Freed from the threat of immediate pursuit," Marius continued, "our ancestors, lacking elemental magic at the time, sought refuge in this realm and began to live alongside the Elvans, Mayans, and Dwarfs."

Dwarfs! A few scoffed at the mention of Dwarfs, a flicker of doubt in their eyes. *Weren't Dwarfs merely figments of legend?*

Marius pressed on. "These Orinn natives, united by their own experiences of fleeing the Maurgs from their own native world, welcomed our Sukran ancestors with open arms, assisting them in building a new life and settle into this new world."

"Peace prevailed for many centuries," he recounted, "until the inevitable day the Maurgs, having devoured Sukra, arrived at Orinn, their hunger for humanity undimmed."

"It is yet unknown how the Maurgs managed to construct another portal into Orinn after so many centuries, but they arrived in force, their dark magic potent and their hearts set on eradicating the remnants of the races that had escaped them."

"They were led by the Maurg King, who possessed powerful dark magic. The Maurg King had an exceptional ability to understand the talents of other races, and he had learned various skills while destroying numerous worlds."

"The Dwarves, unfortunate to be situated at the point of entry of the portal, were the first to fall, their kingdom obliterated before aid could arrive from their allies."

A hush fell over the crowd. The weight of this forgotten history settled heavily upon them. They had believed Dwarfs to be myth, but didn't even think for a second that an entire species were annihilated.

"Our forefathers, whose numbers had increased by the time the Maurgs arrived at Orinn, fought valiantly but were ultimately beaten. On the verge of extinction, the unicorns, the original magical inhabitants of this world, came to our aid."

"One such unicorn," he explained, his voice filled with reverence, "bestowed upon one of our ancestor the knowledge of elemental casting. This gift, shared with others, empowered our people to fight alongside the Elvans and Mayans in equal footing."

"The tide of the battle began to turn. The Maurg King was eventually vanquished along with most of his race," Marius declared, his voice ringing with triumph, "and the remaining Maurgs who surrendered were driven back, chased to their doom across the scorching deserts beyond the Mayan lands."

The crowd called out eagerly to learn the identity of their savior.

"The man blessed by the unicorn with Elemental magic," he concluded, "was crowned the first king of our range. Our savior's lineage has ruled us ever since."

A wave of excited murmurs washed over the crowd. Their savior, a figure shrouded in myth, was now a tangible part of their history.

Marius raised his voice to quell the growing commotion. "Yes, your guesses are spot on." he boomed, "the only Sukran in our history to be blessed by a unicorn was none other than King Evander Primus, a distant forefather of our current King, Valerian Primus. Evander's lineage has ruled us ever since."

"The victory, however, came at a heavy cost," he continued, his expression turning grim. "The war nearly wiped off our race. Years were spent rebuilding after the war's devastation while a new threat rose from the spoils of the wars- the Valkrys which roamed our land unchecked after the great war."

"Valkrys?" The crowd whispered with a frown

"Yes. The Valkrys were monstrous creatures created from the corpses of the fallen Maurgs during the war using the Maurgan's blood magic. As soon as their masters were no longer there, these Valkrys went rogue and began to decimate Sukrans around the realm. According to history, these formidable monsters could camouflage themselves and were difficult to kill." Count Marius' expression was grim as he continued."

"Faced with this brutal new menace, King Evander Primus made a critical decision. He appointed lords and ladies – those possessing exceptional elemental casting – as protectors of the realm, tasking them with safeguarding the populace from the Valkrys threat."

"Although the king sought to protect the less powerful, he unwittingly established a power-based hierarchy that began oppressing the very same people it was designed to protect."

"The lords and ladies married amongst themselves so their offspring would be equally powerful, allowing them to retain their dominance over commoners."

Count Marius locked eyes with Theron, his voice heavy with regret. "Do you understand now, Theron, why a person's elemental magic holds such paramount importance within Sukran culture?"

"Yes, My Lord." Theron nodded in comprehension as their origins were now revealed. "The Sukrans, on the verge of extinction, began to place greater emphasis on the new talent that helped them survive the Maurgs. The war made them turn to those with the most expertise in magic to guide them through turbulent times."

"Evander Primus, however, may have committed a critical oversight," Theron ventured. "Perhaps he failed to recognize that strength was only necessary for those commanding armies, not those governing civilians. Being a soldier at heart, the king might have simply attempted to adopt the same military hierarchy that secured victory against the Maurgs."

Count Marius sighed, a hint of forbearance in his voice. "Let us not be overly critical of Evander Primus. He navigated a tumultuous period of our history to the best of his ability."

"I admire the first Sukran king a lot," Theron countered. "He saved our entire race from annihilation and sought to safeguard our future. I merely point out the inherent flaw in his choice. While establishing a power-based society was a necessary response to the aftermath of the war, Evander Primus failed to consider the long-term consequences of providing powerful individuals more power in the form of law and authority. His actions paved the way for the power-hungry culture we find ourselves in today."

Marius exhaled again, a deep breath that spoke volumes. "Perhaps," he conceded. "But the political landscape we face now is unlike anything witnessed since the first king ascended the throne."

"Do you grasp the significance of the unicorns' reappearance after so many centuries?" the Count pressed.

Theron paused, considering the question carefully. "Given the pivotal role they played in our survival, any unicorn sighting would hold immense weight."

"The current political climate, coupled with the loss of the king's sole heir and the public's perception of Prince Dorian's legitimacy and capability to the throne, imbues the unicorn's appearance with even greater significance," Theron elaborated.

"Many noble lords," Theron continued, his voice laced with hatred, "believe they possess a stronger claim to the throne than Prince Dorian, whom they view as nothing more than a weak, illegitimate bastard of the late Prince Livian. Additionally, none of the noble lords are intimidated by Prince Dorian's magical prowess."

Theron released a weary breath. "Prince Dorian's path to the throne is fraught with challenges. He navigates a society that prioritizes magical prowess over humane values. Besides, he seeks to ascend the Sukran throne amidst the disapproval of both the nobility and the citizenry who have grown accustomed to having the most powerful man from the House of Primus rule them for all these years."

"Despite King Valerian Primus' valiant efforts," Marius lamented, "we are left with the last heir of House Primus – an illegitimate one lacking the formidable power of his father and forefathers. Most noble lords far surpass Prince Dorian in terms of magical might."

A sardonic chuckle escaped Theron's lips. "Ironically, the very power-based hierarchy established by the first Sukran King, Evander Primus, now comes back to haunt his own lineage after all these centuries."

"Our noble lords want to desperately ignore the truth that stares at their face," Theron declared, his voice rising with conviction. "A king need not be the realm's most powerful citizen to reign effectively; virtue is the true mark of a leader. Only the military requires commanders who inspire both respect and fear in their subordinates."

"A strong and well-respected army is all a king needs to ensure the peaceful governance of his nation." He paused for emphasis. "When, in recent history, have we witnessed a king leading the charge on the battlefield? It is their armies who wage war in the king's name, while the kings themselves remain ensconced upon their thrones. Why, then, should a king possess superior

strength? Righteousness and compassion are the qualities a ruler requires to serve his people effectively."

"The key fact seems to elude everyone," Theron continued, his voice growing strained. "A king, even one wielding immense magical power, is doomed to fail against his enemies in a war if he cannot inspire his followers. Conversely, a king even with limited strength, can effectively rule his subjects if he commands their loyalty through his compassionate actions."

Elissa placed a hand on his shoulder and squeezed it as she realized that he was babbling, exhausted from the healing he had received.

"My apologies for rambling, Count Marius." Theron shook his head slightly, attempting to regain his focus. "The lineage of King Evander Primus has been severed," he stated. "The line of King Evander Primus has broken, and the kingdom ruled by the House of Primus now finds itself bereft of anyone as powerful ruling them."

A question gnawed at him. Why had the Count mentioned the unicorn in the context of his quest?

"Sir Marius, do you harbor hope that the unicorn will select a noble lord to ascend the throne, given the failure of the House of Primus after all these centuries?" Theron inquired, his voice quivering as he contemplated the count's calculated decision to reveal this crucial information to the entire crowd.

"As a devoted servant of the kingdom, you seek to avert the looming civil war between the noble lords vying for the vacant throne and safeguard the kingdom from destruction."

The fortress fell into a hushed silence as the implications of the majestic unicorn's arrival in the current political context were scrutinized closely.

Theron's voice resounded with admiration and enthusiasm for the grand strategy devised by the count who was held in high esteem as one of the best generals of his time.

"You aim to leverage the significance of the unicorn's involvement in our history to repeat it, by compelling a unicorn to crown the next king of your choosing. The ambitions of the unselected, power-hungry noble lords will be quelled if the unicorns chooses the next king."

"The unicorns have picked flawlessly in the past, which has guided us through so many centuries, and most people will feel confident with a unicorn's decision for the future king above any other. Given the historical significance of the unicorns, the spurned noble lords won't be able to challenge the unicorn's choice. It would expose their hypocrisy if they disputed the virtuous animal's decision."

The calculated maneuver of the seasoned general left the inhabitants of the stronghold dumbfounded. Their esteemed count had hoped for a bold play against the king and the noble lords engaged in a deadly game for the throne bereft of a powerful heir. Yet, the old count aimed to steal the thunder right from under the noses of these powerful lords.

Marius let out a hearty chuckle. "A splendid deduction, lad. *I could not have phrased it any better myself.*"

Theron's brow furrowed in concern. "My Lord, wouldn't pursuing this course of action constitute an act of defiance against the crown?"

Marius shook his head. "No, I shall never disobey an order from the crown. I, in my

twilight years, was commanded to part from my beloved kin and progeny to assume command of this inconspicuous border outpost."

A pang of nostalgia swept across Marius' visage as he reminisced about his family. "After serving the crown with unwavering honor and fidelity for four decades, I was demoted from the esteemed position of general to a mere count, banished to this border outpost to safeguard the realm against the Mayans, who have not been sighted in two decades."

Marius' tone turned bitter with resentment. "Valerian Primus, once a sword brother since childhood, orchestrated this demotion and personally commanded me to take charge of this fortress under the pretense of preserving the future of the realm at all costs," Marius growled, his suppressed anguish erupting at his best friend's blatant betrayal.

"Oh, my goodness!" Elissa gasped at the pain in Marius' voice.

Marius caught Elissa's horrified expression.

"Yes, Elissa. The person whom I held as a true friend has kept me estranged from my family for too long. It still stings to be backstabbed by the one you trusted more than yourself."

Marius shook his head to dispel his reverie. "Unlike the king, I will not stoop to treachery. However, with the arrival of the unicorn, I intend to jolt this kingdom from its slumber. If numerous witnesses attest to the unicorn's arrival, it cannot be refuted."

"I am still adhering strictly to my orders by safeguarding the future of the kingdom, albeit in a manner that shall catch the old king off guard," he continued, a mischievous grin played on his lips.

Marius surveyed Theron's crestfallen visage, his shoulders slumped in dejection. "By the look of it, you seem to have grasped the nature of your task."

All eyes turned to Theron, who seemed to crumble under the weight of the impending quest even before it was even announced.

"*What is the quest, My Lord?*" Adrian murmured, casting an anxious glance at his nephew.

Before the count could announce the quest, Theron spoke. "My *quest* is to *capture the unicorn* sighted near the Mayan border and deliver it alive to the count so that he may alter the course of history and the fate of the realm."

"I am supposed to capture the creature that spared humanity from annihilation. A creature that has only encountered one Sukran in the annals of our kingdom."

A collective gasp swept through the assembly at the boy's seemingly impossible quest, for which he had valiantly battled throughout the day.

Count Marius raised a hand to silence the gathering. "I fervently hope you succeed in this improbable endeavor, just as you have prevailed against insurmountable odds thus far today."

Marius proceeded with caution. "I am cognizant that unicorns are too proud to be subjugated; thus, the alternative is to procure the unicorn's horn should you fail to capture the creature alive."

Theron's head snapped up in astonishment. "You want me to slay the creature that saved our kind?"

Marius scoffed at the inquiry. "Do you know why the scores of soldiers I dispatched to capture the unicorn failed?"

"Legends speak of the unicorn's ability to detect Sukran elemental magic, for they were the ones who imparted the secrets of elemental magic to humanity. Our soldiers couldn't even approach the unicorn, for it flees when it senses the presence of Sukrans and their magic."

Theron was even more astounded to discover that the unicorn shared his ability to sense the elemental magic of others. How could he possess a skill witnessed only in these mythical creatures? He found himself intrigued and perplexed by the parallels between himself and the unicorn.

"No one can ensnare the mystical creature. I require only the unicorn's horn, which harbors the creature's power," Marius replied somberly.

Theron exhaled in disbelief. "You wish for me to slay the creature and sever its horn? Are we to reward the creature in such a horrific manner for sparing our species from extinction?"

Count Marius shrugged in response. "The choice is yours. I simply do not believe the creature can be captured. They are too proud to surrender. They may resist capture to the bitter end until they are slain. Let us see if you can accomplish yet another improbable feat by bringing an unicorn back to me alive."

Marius straightened into a formal posture, his gaze locking onto Theron with an intensity that brooked no argument. "The choice is yours, lad. Do you accept the quest of bringing the unicorn to me, alive and unharmed, or, failing that, will you retrieve its horn?"

Silence descended upon the crowd, thick and suffocating. Theron, his youthful bravado momentarily extinguished, could only stare back at the Count, the enormity of the task settling heavily upon him.

Theron regarded the count warily. "My Lord, I fail to grasp the purpose of this quest. Only one man in our kingdom's history has ever communed with the mythical unicorn. Why burden me with such an impossible quest, especially when you expressed a desire for me to attend university?"

Marius' shoulders sagged. "I sincerely hope you get the opportunity to enroll in the university, but they may only consider you if you achieve something hitherto unattained. You are fortunate that a unicorn roams these woods precisely when you seek to prove your mettle." Marius responded, feeling bad for not being able to assist the resourceful young man more.

"Do you comprehend why I tasked you with besting five of my finest soldiers?" Marius asked, "This quest transcends your aspirations for university. It is about averting a civil war. Therefore, I couldn't send anybody but the valley's finest soldier to capture the unicorn."

"This quest is of more importance than the entire valley; it holds the key to averting a devastating civil war."

Theron remained silent as he contemplated how he might fulfill this improbable quest without slaying the unicorn.

Well! What was he even thinking? He knew that he didn't need to even worry about slaying an unicorn as he harbored huge doubts on even laying his gaze upon the mystical creature, let alone capturing or slaying it.

A single, gnawing question dominated his thoughts: *was there even a remote possibility of encountering the unicorn in its secluded den?*

Elissa's brow furrowed in thoughtful contemplation, silently acknowledging the count's observation regarding the uncanny timing of the unicorn's reappearance coinciding with Theron's decision to finally announce himself to the world.

"Hmm!!!" Elissa murmured, the gravity of the quest settling upon her. The timing of these events seemed far too serendipitous, leaving her with a bitter recognition that her beloved nephew was ensnared in a tempest seemingly orchestrated by unseen hands. Yet, she quelled her instinct to shield Theron from harm.

Steeling her resolve, Elissa recognized a greater responsibility – *her family's safety*. She wouldn't allow another loved one to be swept away by the machinations of others.

Elissa's mind churned with determination as she grappled with the realization that her family had become pawns in a larger, more sinister game. Though she couldn't yet identify the *puppeteer* pulling the strings, she understood that her loved ones were merely collateral damage in a grander scheme. Nevertheless, she resolved to fight tooth and nail to safeguard her family, even if it meant delving into the murky depths of intrigue that surrounded them.

To protect her family, Elissa knew she must immerse herself in the great game that had been set in motion. She needed to familiarize herself with its rules, discerning friend from foe, if she hoped to shield her kin from the clutches of others' avarice. She refused to stand idly by while the noble who had wronged her sister and fathered a son sought to exploit him for their own gain.

This was not a time for retreat and defense; it was a time for action. Elissa resolved to adopt an aggressive stance, refusing to cower in the shadows any longer. It was time to confront the forces threatening her family head-on, wielding every ounce of strength and determination she possessed.

And if you want to understand the game, it was imperative that she first join the game!

Elissa released a steadying breath and turned to look at her nephew busy contemplating the decision to undertake such an impossible quest.

"Yes, I failed to shield you from the cruelties of this world, Felix," Elissa murmured, her voice laced with remorse. "But I will not falter in protecting your son."

"The time has come. Time to place my trust in the young man I raised with all my heart," she declared, her gaze shifting to Theron who was preparing to announce his decision.

Sensing that Theron was about to respond to the count's challenge, she intervened, stepping forward to lay a reassuring hand on his shoulder.

"He will accept the quest, My Lord," Elissa asserted, meeting the count's gaze with unwavering resolve.

Theron was taken aback by his aunt's unexpected support. He had anticipated her to be the lone voice advocating for his withdrawal from the perilous endeavor that lay ahead, especially given its path toward the Smoky Mountains near the Mayan frontier. Yet, he noticed resolve in his aunt, who had gone against her instincts to protect him.

Count Marius, too, was surprised by Elissa's declaration. "Why, Elissa? I would have thought you, above all others, would dissuade Theron from such a dangerous quest."

Turning to face Theron with a reassuring smile, Elissa replied, "Because I feel Theron is the only one with the necessary talents to even get near the unicorn."

Theron felt a surge of confidence and pride at his aunt's words. His aunt was the smartest person he had ever met. He recognized that her decision mustn't have been driven by emotion but by a genuine belief in his abilities to succeed in the quest.

Did he really stand a chance in the quest? Well, what options did he have otherwise to join the university. The quest was his only chance to accomplish his life-long dream and he decided to give his utmost best to complete it.

Returning his aunt's smile, Theron then addressed the count, "I accept the quest, My Lord."

The Count weighed his words for a moment before nodding. "You will have two weeks to complete this quest. I shall not dispatch any further soldiers to capture the unicorn. The unicorn was last seen in the Smoky Mountains close to the Mayan border."

With a pointed glance at Adrian, Count Marius issued his instructions, "Theron, you must embark on this quest alone. Take a couple of days to recuperate before setting out; it has been a taxing day for you. Remember, your two-week period begins on the day you commence your quest."

Raising his right hand, the count solemnly declared, "By the authority vested in me as count and as a former general and war hero, I swear to Theron of Adrian-Hold that he shall be granted enrollment to the university upon completion of this quest—whether by bringing the unicorn alive to me or securing its horn. I wish you a safe and fruitful journey and eagerly await your return in two weeks' time."

"May the great one watch over you in this perilous quest!"

Chapter 11

A Test of Loyalty

Loyalty isn't gray. It's black or white. For you are either wholly loyal or not loyal at all.

Life is not about those who are real to your face. But who is real behind your back.

And you can always trust a betrayer to betray you.

So, what would I choose? One loyal friend or thousands of enemies?

Unlike most people, I would choose thousands of enemies, for enemies can never betray you. But loyal friends can.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

"Gwen," Dorian murmured hesitantly, leaning in to address the woman nestled comfortably in his lap. "May I trouble you with a question?"

Her eyes remained closed, a gentle smile playing on her lips. Even after two years together,

she marveled at Dorian's lingering formality. It was a curious quirk for a prince, but it only endeared him to her further.

Dorian shut the book he'd been engrossed in, placing it on the marble table in front of the bench. He inhaled deeply, his gaze drifting towards the sprawling magnificence of the royal gardens of Kalistus, the capital city. His fingers brushed against a strand of Gwen's golden hair, a tender gesture belying the weighty question on his mind.

"Gwen," he began, his voice laced with a hint of apprehension, "*Do you know what true love is?*"

Gwen sighed, the question holding a predictable air of rhetorical questions. No surprise he was often referred to as the savant prince, renowned to be notorious for his peculiar queries.

"Silly," she chided, her voice laced with amusement. "*Isn't it obvious?* I feel that the affection we share constitutes true love, wouldn't you agree?"

Dorian scoffed. "Come now, Gwen. Even a novice maid-in-waiting could offer a more profound response than that."

A playful pout formed on Gwen's lips. "I don't suppose you loved your palace maid, did you?"

Dorian huffed. "*Come on, Gwen...*It is not yet your bedtime..." He prodded her to get up from her slumber on his lap.

With a theatrical groan, she complied, settling back onto the bench. "But I simply assumed you desired to bask in the tranquility of nature with me by your side," she teased.

Dorian regarded her with exasperation.

"*Alright, alright,*" Gwen conceded, placating him with raised hands in mock surrender.

"True love is when you love someone more than yourself. It compels you to make sacrifices for their sake, to prioritize their well-being above your own." Gwen explained, sensing his genuine yearning for an answer.

Dorian feigned a snoozing expression. "A textbook answer, delivered with finesse." He held up a hand before she could protest. "But Gwen, *do you truly believe it's possible to love someone more than yourself?*"

Gwen furrowed her brow, a disquietude settling in her gut. Dorian's odd behavior was starting to worry her. "Aren't those what stories depict? Soulmates who would die for each other?"

"How many people do you know who have found their soulmate?" Dorian pressed.

Gwen began to reply flippantly but stopped short. "Not a single one," she conceded, a touch of sadness tinging her voice. Many of the married couples she had met were not the perfect couples one dreamed of.

Dorian replied sullenly. "Because most people don't understand what true love is."

A flicker of annoyance sparked within Gwen. "And does my wise prince know what true love is?" she challenged.

"Knowledge shared isn't always knowledge gained," Dorian replied cryptically.

Gwen frustratedly knotted her hair that was blowing in the breeze. Dorian saw Gwen affixing a clasp to her hair with an elegance he seldom observed among ladies in the city.

"Gwen," he said, his voice turning anxious, "*what is the foundation of all love?*"

Gwen pondered his question thoughtfully. "It's *Affection*. Isn't love simply a strong feeling of affection for another person?"

"No... respect is the true foundation of any love."

"*Respect?*" she echoed, surprised by his answer.

"Indeed," he continued. "How can you truly love someone whom you don't respect in the first place?"

Gwen scoffed. "*Does that mean you love everyone you respect?*" Gwen challenged.

Dorian chuckled. "*Not necessarily*. But respect is a prerequisite for love to blossom between two people. It's the seed from which love grows."

"Not at all," she argued. "I've witnessed many men fall for beautiful women, not because they respect her."

"Indeed," Dorian conceded, "You may respect someone in several ways. Some admire their lover's physical beauty, while others revere their character, and some respect their lover's wealth and power." His gaze darted towards her, a flicker of unease crossing his features.

Gwen's brows furrowed. "Do you think I love you just because you're a prince?"

Dorian sighed, shaking his head and pointed his hand at himself. "This prince," he conceded ruefully, "is not someone many ladies would dare befriend, let alone love."

Gwen grimaced at his sullen demeanor. "What do you mean?"

"You're well aware of how my fellow university cadets regarded me," Dorian confessed glumly. "Not many believe I'll retain my principedom for long. Thus, my wealth and rank offer nothing but fleeting allure."

Gwen sighed, watching Dorian succumb to another bout of melancholy moods. No royal had ever borne such a burden.

It was a cruel twist of fate that the crown prince wouldn't inherit the full extent of his father's formidable magic. To make matters worse, he had no siblings to share the responsibility of safeguarding the legacy of their illustrious and most powerful house in the kingdom.

With a playful toss of her hair, Gwen attempted to lighten the mood. "So, all-knowing prince of Sukra," she teased, "why do you respect me? Is it my beauty that compels you to respect me?"

"Or do you respect my miraculous magical talent?" A mischievous glint sparked in her eyes as she conjured a mesmerizing spectacle of multicolored butterflies swarming around them, a testament to her mastery over air and fire magic to create such beautiful illusions.

Dorian chuckled, captivated by her innocent charm. "Perhaps, my Lord," he replied, "you admire my flirting abilities?"

Dorian waved his hand dismissively. "There are many qualities I admire in you, Gwen. Yet, none surpasses the innate chivalry that radiates from you."

Gwen's grin faltered. "*Chivalry?*" Of all the qualities Gwen believed that Dorian liked in her, she hadn't considered her chivalry to be among them.

"Yes," Dorian affirmed. "You exude an aura of chivalry unlike any I've ever encountered." Noticing her bewilderment, he elaborated, "Countless times, I've marveled at your ability to be chivalrous without consciously trying. You somehow manage to be kindhearted to our classmates

and countrymen without even trying consciously."

His voice deepened with passion. "You treat everyone with fairness and respect, regardless of their station. You don't cower away from those more powerful than you, nor do you exploit and belittle those beneath you."

"You are compassionate, courageous, and passionate, all without even trying. People can't help but admire you," he concluded, his voice soft with admiration.

Dorian's gaze softened as it lingered on Gwen's face. "I've never witnessed you brood over your problems. You confront them head-on with a radiant smile, making me wonder if you even perceive them as problems in the first place."

A brief silence settled between them while Gwen's heart swelled at Dorian's unexpected praise. "No, Dorian, I'm far from chivalrous," she protested modestly.

Dorian chuckled softly. "Don't be modest, Gwen. It would take a truly selfless soul to befriend, let alone love, the most depised man in the kingdom."

"And you couldn't resist being drawn to my solitude," he added, a hint of vulnerability in his tone.

"You embody everything I aspire to be, and you do it effortlessly. You are such a natural that I cannot even attempt to emulate you" he confessed.

"A man always loves a woman he believes is more worthy than himself," Dorian explained. "He may find her beauty, character, or any other trait worthy, but his conviction that she is irreplaceable drives him to do anything to be with her."

"He would even be willing to sacrifice his life for her, knowing he couldn't bear to live without her," Dorian continued.

"Fake love can be replaced, but true love cannot," he concluded firmly.

Gwen frowned. *"Are you saying love is selfish?"*

"No," Dorian replied, shaking his head. "Love is anything but selfish."

He gestured towards Gwen, emphasizing his point. "Look, all selfish traits originate in the mind. Whether it's greed, pride, ego, callousness or anything, they all stem from the workings of the mind."

"Selfish individuals allow their minds to overrule their hearts, prioritizing their own interests and wellbeing above all else."

"However, only genuine love or deep-seated hatred can make one's heart overrule their mind."

"Even hatred?"

Dorian nodded solemnly. "Yes. Love and hatred are two sides of the same coin, separated by a fine line. Just as love can cloud judgment, so too can intense hatred lead one to act rashly in a manner his mind may deem unwise."

"Therefore, Gwen, respect forms the bedrock upon which love can thrive. True love can never exist without respect."

Dorian gazed at the gorgeous blonde girl fidgeting uneasily at the conversation. "I hold deep respect and admiration for every aspect of you, Gwen..."

"I admire your beauty, grace, and compassion, as well as your remarkable achievements as

one of the best skilled cadets trained as a lomer in several decades."

Dorian's gaze bore into Gwen with intensity. "I hold you in such high esteem and respect you so much that I often question if I am worthy of you."

Standing up from the bench, he turned to face her fully. "I have such admiration for you that I find myself that I find myself mimicking your mannerisms in a clumsy attempt to emulate your grace."

"I understand why I love you so deeply," Dorian spoke with a hint of apprehension. "*But do you truly know why you love me?*" His voice laced with anxiety.

Gwen was caught off guard by his question. "Of course, I love you with all my heart. In fact, I love you more than my life itself." she replied, taken aback.

"I am well aware that you believe you love me. *But do you respect me really?*" Dorian pressed further, his tone pleading. "Do you view me in the same light that I do?"

Gwen hesitated, her mind racing. "Yes, I respect you," she answered after a moment, her voice faltering. "I respect your... your heart."

Dorian's face paled, a wave of anguish washing over him. "A lie!" he spat, his voice filled with despair. "What virtue do I possess to merit your respect?" He scoffed at his own worthlessness.

"What have I accomplished in my life apart from living in constant fear, always looking over my shoulder, expecting to be stabbed on the back at every turn?" Dorian's voice cracked with emotion.

"You don't truly respect me, Gwen. You merely pity me and convince yourself that you love me completely. How can you claim to love me if you don't even respect me?" His words carried a mix of anger and hurt as he turned away, wiping away the tears that streamed down his cheeks.

Realizing that Gwen didn't reciprocate his feelings in the same way, Dorian despised himself for understanding the basis of true love. He regretted ever learning that respect was the foundation of genuine love.

He was profoundly aware that he could never earn her respect, and without it, he feared he could never truly win her love.

"I respect you more than you realize, Dor," Gwen whispered, but she fell silent when she noticed two maids approaching with refreshments. They were dressed in white peplos as was customary.

Dorian stepped away from the bench and gazed in anguish at the royal gardens whose beauty couldn't even distract him from the melancholy thoughts swirling within his minds. He hardly noticed the maids curtsying him gracefully, their movements a stark contrast to the turmoil brewing within Dorian.

Gwen stole a glance at a silent Dorian while the maids set the refreshments on the marble table, her mind racing for a solution.

As the maids set down the snacks and ale, Gwen pondered how to knock some sense into her lover and convince Dorian of her love. But his arguments had shaken her belief in her own feelings. She found herself questioning why she loved him at all.

Amidst her inner turmoil, Gwen noticed one of the maids casting furtive glances at Dorian's back.

Did the maid noticed Dorian's sour mood?

Suddenly, she saw the maid reaching for a weapon concealed within the peplos around her hip. A knife glinted in the light of the evening.

"Assassins!" Gwen's warning pierced the air as one of the maids lunged at Dorian. Before she could react, the other maid grabbed her throat, stifling her cry.

Dorian's senses sharpened at Gwen's cry. He sensed movement behind him and swiftly ducked, narrowly avoiding the maid's dagger aimed at his neck. With trained reflexes, he delivered a powerful kick backward to his assailant, sending her crashing to the ground.

Dorian whirled around to take care of the other maid. But he was late. He just turned in time to witness the other maid striking Gwen.

Gwen screamed in agony as she lamented her oversight in neglecting the second maid while focusing on warning Dorian about the first maid's attempt to stab him.

With a snarl, Dorian reached for his sword, only to realize it was absent. His heart sank as he berated himself for not carrying it in his person to the royal gardens.

"Guards!" Dorian yelled, berating himself for lacking air magic that would have allowed him to sound cast his message to the palace guards about the presence of assassins in the royal garden.

Dorian charged at the maid punching Gwen, but the first assailant leaped to her feet, brandishing her dagger. Dorian dodged her strike, intent on swaying past the first maid and reach Gwen's side.

But the first maid was relentless, blocking his path and aiming to exploit his distraction to strike him down.

Frustrated, Dorian summoned his earth elemental from the ground, next to the maid assaulting Gwen. He might not have the talent to control all elementals, but he was a prodigy in at least a few. None more formidable than his earth elemental.

A colossal hand of earth erupted from the ground beneath the second assassin, grabbing her shoulder and flinging her away from Gwen with a sickening thud.

In the meantime, the first assassin intended to use Dorian's distraction to thrust her dagger into his unarmored torso, but Dorian skillfully evaded the dagger thrust and delivered a punch to his adversary's face that was bolstered by the strength borrowed from his powerful earth elemental.

A shriek, a horrifying symphony of shock and pain, ripped from her throat before a well-placed kick to her midriff sent her sprawling a dozen feet away.

Dorian rushed to Gwen's side, his heart hammering against his ribs. "Gwen, are you all right?" he rasped, his voice laced with concern as he checked her battered face for any mortal injuries.

Before Gwen could answer, a prickling sensation alerted her. New threats, cloaked under a light cast veils, were hurtling towards them. She knew that Dorian had no air or light magic to detect the incoming assassins. With a flick of her wrist, she summoned her light elemental,

dispelling the veils of the rushing assassins.

"Dor, watch out! More assassins out there!" she rasped, her voice laced with urgency. Three male assassins materialized from thin air after their veils were removed by Gwen, their faces grim and longsword glinting in the afternoon sun.

Dorian turned to find three more Assassins charge at him a few hundred yards away.

Gwen realized that they needed backup. She used her air elemental to amplify her voice and bellowed, "Assassins in the royal garden! Prince Dorian is in peril!" Her cry echoed through the palace grounds.

Dorian surveyed his surroundings, his eyes searching for a weapon. Only everyday utensils mocked him, a paltry defense against the honed steel of the assassins. There was nothing sharp nearby to even make it a lopsided duel.

With a feral snarl, he snatched a mug brimming with ale and charged, hoping to throw them off guard. As he closed the distance, he flung the contents at the assassin on his left, momentarily hindering him with the sticky ale dripping into his eyes.

The remaining two pressed their assault. Dorian dodged the center attacker's blow and, channeling the earth elemental's strength, smashed his mug into the third assassin's face. The sickening crack of bone echoed as the man flew backward, unconscious.

A swift command sent his earth elemental surging forward and raise numerous pebbles before him and tripping the assassin in the center. The soldier sprawled, his longsword clattering harmlessly away. Dorian snatched a rock, its rough surface a welcome contrast to his bare hands. With a single, brutal blow, he rendered the assassin unconscious.

He barely dodged a horizontal swipe from the ale-soaked attacker, the blade whistling past his ear. As the blade sailed harmlessly above his head, Dorian punched the soldier with all the might he could muster from his earth elemental in a single, fluid motion. The force shattered the assassin's armor, ribs caving under the impact. The man crumpled, dead within a moment of impact.

A strangled cry tore through the air. Gwen! He whirled around to see one of the maids tightening her grip on his lover's throat. Rage, a primal beast, roared to life within him. He lunged forward, only to be intercepted by the second maid, her face twisted in a cruel parody of a smile. The glint of a longsword that she had picked from one of the slain assassins held him at bay.

"Apprehend her, Myryl. We can use her to force this bastard prince to surrender." The second maid growled while brandishing her blade to prevent him from rushing to Gwen's rescue.

Gwen struggled to summon her magic to her rescue, but her mind was in too much pain to assist her in accessing her magic.

Dorian snarled and attempted to maneuver past the woman blocking him, but he became enraged when the maid managed to waylay him with her sword.

Dorian gazed at Gwen, whose face became whiter with each passing second. Time seemed to stretch, each passing second stealing the air from Gwen's lungs. He had to act now, lest these maids kill his soulmate.

Dorian commanded his earth elemental to materialize as a stony hand and slam into the maid assaulting Gwen.

Suddenly, though, two additional earth-cast hands appeared behind Gwen and held Dorian's earth-cast hand in place. This time, the maids were prepared for his elemental assault and collaborated to prevent him from destroying them with his strong earth elemental.

With a growl and no other option but to defend his sweetheart, Dorian sprang at the maid whose blade was pointed at his right chest, a desperate gamble.

He let the sword plunge through his right chest in his bid to reach the maid. He hollered in anguish but smashed his hand over the maid's windpipe and murdered her with a single blow. He shoved the maid aside, sending her sprawling.

With the blade still buried in his right chest, he charged at the maid who was assaulting Gwen and slammed into her midsection.

Dorian seized the stunned maid and flung her a considerable distance from Gwen's vulnerable form. His gaze flickered to Gwen's limp figure, sprawled on the ground with pallid complexion, her breathing shallow and labored.

"Gwen!" Dorian's voice cracked with desperation as he rushed to her side, ignoring the searing pain in his chest. He knelt beside her, his hands shaking as he gently cradled her head in his lap.

Gwen was too pale to acknowledge her beloved.

When he heard the scuffling of feet behind him, Dorian turned around to find the second maid staggering toward him to complete her mission of murdering him.

Dorian was beyond rage as he gazed at the maid who had caused Gwen so much pain. Dorian feared that the maid may have planted a seed of doubt in Gwen's mind regarding her love for him.

Fear, a cold serpent, coiled around his heart. Had he failed? Would he lose Gwen because of these wretched assassins?

As his wrath at the prospect of losing his soulmate surged within his mind, he sprang to his feet and rushed the maid. He grabbed her throat and hoisted her a few feet into the air, planning to punish her in the same manner that she had injured Gwen.

The maid fought in vain to escape his grasp.

"How dare you harm Gwen?" Dorian's voice thundered with indignation as he tightened his grasp on the maid's throat. Yet, even in her final moments, the maid hardly worried about her feeing life and instead grabbed a small knife from her belt and attempted to stab him.

Dorian swiftly deflected the maid's attack with his other hand, shattering her wrist. She cried out in agony, dropping the small knife to the ground. "Die, you treacherous wretch," Dorian growled, tightening his grip on her throat with the aid of his earth elemental's power.

Dorian commanded his earth elemental to assume the form of a wild boar and protect Gwen. Additionally, he directed his earth magic to raise from the ground in the shape of stone hands and restrain the remaining assailants, some already unconscious on the ground.

"*Dorian...no!*" Gwen's strained voice pierced through the chaos, urging Dorian to reconsider his actions. "They must remain alive to testify against the noble lord who sent them to assassinate you," she labored to draw breath.

"I don't care about the noble who dispatched these assassins..." Dorian snarled, heedless to

the searing pain in his right chest, where the sword had been lodged. "This woman has harmed you, Gwen...I could even forgive her for trying to murder me, but I would never forgive her for injuring you."

Gwen watched in disbelief as Dorian's fury consumed him. Did she inadvertently play a part in transforming her lover into a murderer?

Despite the maid gasping and flailing her feet in the air, her entire being was still focused completely on ending him. She continued to attack Dorian by trying to twist the sword plunged into his chest.

However, he hesitated momentarily when he recognized that the maid was still attempting to murder him rather than attempting to flee and rescue herself, as most people would do.

Why was the maid indifferent to her own life yet eager to kill him?

Dorian glanced into the maid's terrified eyes, but her hands were still attempting to murder him while not even attempting to escape from his clutches. It was as though her hand was controlled against her own will.

"*A slave!*" Dorian choked; his voice thick with disbelief. He searched the maid's body for any sign of magical control, a jewel, a collar – anything that might bind her spirit. But there was nothing. But he couldn't find any outward mark of servitude.

Dorian ripped open the front of her peplos at the maid's midsection with his free left hand. His breath hitched. A small, enchanted ring was embedded in her flesh. This woman, this relentless attacker, was no fanatic – she was a puppet, her will stolen, her body an instrument of murder sent by her master with a single purpose of killing him.

Fury surged through him, laced with a bitter truth. This woman wasn't a killer, but a pawn. A puppet compelled by a master's cruel magic.

With a snarl, Dorian flung the maid aside, the urge for vengeance warring with a nascent sympathy. But the maid, driven by her master's commands, didn't waste even a moment to replenish her lungs and rose to her feet yet again. She lunged at him once more like a person who had lost control of her mind, relentless in her pursuit to kill him. Her eyes held no malice, only a chilling emptiness.

Yes...Dorian realized that the maid was definitely a slave ordered by a noble lord to murder him. No wonder she has been compelled by spirit magic to kill him rather than care for her own well-being.

Dorian's resolve solidified as he recognized the extent of the maid's coercion. With unwavering determination, he commanded his earth elemental to intervene, restraining the slave despite her desperate struggles to break free and resume her deadly mission.

"*By the Elementals!*" A guard burst upon the scene, bewildered by the prince standing defiant with a sword protruding from his chest.

"*Are you alright, Your Highness?*" The guard inquired. The guard was soon joined by other royal guards, their faces etched with concern on looking around at the carnage around them. The guards wasted no time in rounding up the surviving Assassins.

"Get a healer!" Dorian rasped, his voice laced with urgency. He stumbled towards Gwen, who had managed to regain her feet on her own, albeit with a shaky breath.

"Gwen, forgive me for placing you in danger," he choked out, tears streaming down his face.

Gwen strained to speak as she realized the slave had crushed her windpipe. She instead placed her palm on his face and smiled at him. "You asked me why I would ever respect you?"

Gwen tried to speak, but a choked wheeze sounded instead. Her hand fluttered to his face, a weak smile gracing her lips. "You asked....me...why... respect you?" she rasped, her voice barely a whisper.

"Not now, Gwen," Dorian shook his head and placed his hands on her lips to stop her speaking with a crushed windpipe.

Gwen clasped his hand tenderly and offered him a smile, her gaze filled with warmth. "How rare it is," she murmured softly, "to encounter a man, let alone a prince, who loves a common girl so profoundly that he would willingly stab himself to rescue her?"

Dorian remained silent, the weight of her words heavy.

"More remarkably still," she continued, her voice barely above a whisper, "is there anyone else who, consumed by anger, sought vengeance against those who harmed his beloved, yet chose to shower mercy and spare the life of an unwitting assassin after realizing the assassins plight as a slave who was bound to do another's bidding?"

"Prince Dorian," she went on, her tone unwavering, "you have displayed your unwavering and passionate love for me by allowing your heart to guide your actions, even to the point of letting a sword plunge to your chest to save my life. Moreover, your ability to temper your fury and show mercy to one who has wronged us both speaks volumes of your character."

"Who could fail to respect a man who allows love to reign supreme over reason, who is willing to lay down his life for the sake of his beloved, yet possesses the strength to overcome his own hatred in his most vulnerable state and extend compassion to those who have harmed him?" she asked, her admiration evident in her gaze.

"It is no wonder that you are hailed as the savant prince, Dorian. No prince like you has existed in Sukra, and no one ever will," Gwen struggled to articulate, her voice faltering with emotion.

"You are unlike any prince this kingdom has ever seen," she added, her words trembling with sincerity. "I count myself fortunate to have found my soulmate in one as unique as you."

"I only hope that I may demonstrate my love for you with the same courage and devotion you have shown me today," Gwen concluded, her voice tinged with reverence.

Dorian's expression softened into a wide grin, though it faltered as exhaustion overtook him, and he collapsed to the ground, drained by the ordeal and the wound in his chest.

"Tell me," he teased gently, despite his weariness, "do you love me more than your mentor, Sylvius?"

Gwen's response was measured, her gaze contemplative as she regarded him. "I love you as if you were my soulmate," she replied sincerely, "yet I adore Sylvius, as if he were the father I never had."

Dorian waved his hands as guards brought a healer and carried a water tub to assist in his healing.

“Gwen, do not make promises you can’t keep.” Dorian grinned at her as he was gently lowered into the water tub by two guards.

“Who would you choose if you had to choose between Sylvius and me?” Dorian whispered the question, afraid of her answer.

Gwen regarded him skeptically before responding with reluctance.

“I would choose...” But the prince surrendered to his pain and let darkness engulf him.

Gwen looked fondly at the man who had risked his life to save hers.

“I would choose...” But out of nowhere, she heard numerous feet bounding towards her. Were there more assassins?

With a jolt, Gwen's eyes fluttered open, momentarily disoriented by the brilliant sunlight blazing on her face. She glanced about in confusion, trying to figure out where she was before she realized with a sinking feeling that she was still imprisoned within the confines of the illegal legion camp.

Every ache and bruise was a grim reminder of her predicament.

The sounds of legionnaires engaged in their daily drills echoed outside, and the silhouettes of guards stood watch beyond the tent flaps, a constant reminder of her captivity.

It was a nightmare depicting one of her most terrifying experiences. No surprise her nightmare haunted her in her sleep as she faced an even more terrifying situation: being captured at an illegal legion camp during her final exam to become a full-fledged lomer.

She pondered the significance of her dream such a particular encounter with featuring Dorian.

Unable to shake off the haunting dream that seemed eerily relevant to her present situation, Gwen arose groggily and sat up against a desk at the edge of the tent. Her gaze swept across the modest furnishings—a bed, a bathtub likely used for healing her whenever she lost consciousness during the torture.

Contemplating her the torment she endured the day before and what awaited her shortly, Gwen recalled the sage advice of old Marian from the university: every crisis held within it the seeds of opportunity.

She scoffed on how she can find any opportunity in such a nightmare.

She observed her soiled garments smeared in filth and slime, a hindrance to accessing her air elemental magic even after the effects of the drug had subsided, and felt the weight of her restraints on her wrists and legs which were still bound.

Her thoughts were interrupted as a waitress entered the tent, flanked by two guards brandishing crossbows aimed at her. The maid placed a tray of food on the ground a few feet in front of her and exited the tent. One of the soldiers then approached her, untying her hands to

allow her to eat.

She refrained from even glancing at the food, instead keeping her gaze on the guards. The guard, puzzled by her behavior, glanced between her and the untouched meal before shrugging.

Refusing to succumb to another dose of sedatives, Gwen remained silent, leaning back against the desk with closed eyes. She searched within herself for the resolve to confront the challenges ahead, determined to escape the clutches of her captors. She felt reassured at the presence of the hairband still not confiscated from her person. After all, her only slim chance of escape lay with the tracking stone and the Oblisque stone concealed within her hairband.

She examined her body for injuries and was somewhat surprised to find that all her broken bones and severe wounds had been healed. Though her ribs still bore bruises from the repeated blows, breathing was no longer painful. Taking a few deep breaths to steady herself, she prepared for the way the forthcoming interrogation would unfold, hastily devising an escape plan.

She contemplated indolently the cruelty perpetrated by some to gain power and wealth by harming, betraying, and murdering others. She shook her head at the futility of the thought.

Despite not yet being officially anointed as a lomer, she steeled herself and resolved not to betray the kingdom and its rulers like others, refusing to yield to the kingdom's enemies even under excruciating torture. Determined to fulfill her mission at any cost, even if it meant sacrificing her own life, she felt a tremendous burden lift from her shoulders as she fully embraced the prospect of death.

She opened her eyes, a calculated nonchalance in her movements as she stretched and pretended to fix her hair. Her fingers brushed the hairband, subtly confirming the Oblisque's presence. With practiced ease, she unfastened it, slipping it into her mouth before retying her hair.

The guards watched intently, oblivious to the sleight of hand as she deftly extracted the Oblisque while pretending to tie her ponytail using her hairband.

With a sigh of relief, she allowed her body to relax, lowering her hands to her sides as she leaned against the wooden desk.

As approaching footsteps echoed, she seized the moment when the guards' attention shifted to investigate the newcomers, she swiftly pushed the Oblisque beneath the desk, adjusting its position to discreetly capture the room's events without drawing notice.

Even though she knew she couldn't summon her air elemental to fly while wearing soiled clothing, the Oblisque needed a tiny amount of wind elemental to be activated. And when the moment came to record the happenings around her, she was certain she could call upon her elemental to activate the Oblisque without anybody noticing.

"Timing is everything," she thought, steeling herself for the upcoming ordeal.

The tent flap billowed open, revealing Erasmus and a beautiful woman, Korinna, by his side.

"Well, well," Erasmus drawled, a cruel glint in his eyes, "seems our little guest is ready for some more entertainment."

Gwen ignored Erasmus, her gaze fixed on Korinna. Gwen recognized that Korinna must be an exceptionally gifted water elemental healer to have healed her wounds so effectively after the brutal attack she endured yesterday. But did the healer have any more potent magic up her sleeve

besides water?

Gwen meticulously assessed the skills of her adversaries, preparing herself for a daring escape if even the slightest opportunity arose. She acknowledged the grim reality that enduring another day of torture was not an option. If no such chance appeared for escape, she resigned herself to make an attempt at fleeing the phalanx, regardless of the odds, so that she could force her captors to end her life before she could divulge any information about her beloved prince.

Though she barely spared a glance for Erasmus, recognizing the vast power gap between them, she understood that she might stand a chance against the two guards and Korinna if circumstances aligned favorably.

"I can see the acceptance of defeat in your eyes," Erasmus remarked. "Are you finally ready to talk?"

Gwen met Erasmus' gaze with a steely resolve and uttered, "I will remain silent until death, Erasmus."

Erasmus gestured to one of the guards, who kicked her in the stomach.

Gwen contorted her belly, but the blow remained painful. She spewed blood from her mouth but never took her gaze away from Erasmus.

"Stubborn girl, I accept that you're a hard nut to crack but, Gwen, why do you defy me?" he snarled, a flicker of something akin to... regret flashing fleetingly in his eyes. "The most you can expect is a quick death."

Gwen frowned on noticing the flicker of regret crossing his face. Was Erasmus truly conflicted about torturing a girl half his age? Maybe Erasmus was not enjoying her torture any bit that she was. Maybe he was obeying orders to coerce her into revealing the truth.

As a decorated soldier, he was by no means a saint, and he had slain several people with his own hands, but murdering someone with a single blow was vastly different from torturing them to death. He despised being cruel to people.

Perhaps Dorian's father - the late Prince Livian, who was renowned for his unwavering compassion, wouldn't have allowed such a monster into his elite Graycloak guard if Erasmus reveled in killing.

And even as she was continued to be kicked all around her torso, Gwen's gaze swept up to the healer who turned her face away from the torture. *Korinna didn't find the torture entertaining either.*

Yes. She confidently deduced that *Erasmus and Korinna were not truly monsters, but were reluctant pawns in a larger game.*

When the anguish from repeated blows left her unable to focus on anything other than pain, she filed this information away for future use.

As the blows subsided, she slowly sat up and spat more blood. One round handled, many to go! Gwen pondered wryly.

Erasmus loomed over her, his voice dripping with frustration. "Still clinging to hope, little lamer? Did you truly believe your pathetic lamer comrades would waltz into my camp and rescue you?"

Gwen raised her head at him with a startled expression.

"The king had dispatched another sloppy old goat to rescue you. He infiltrated the phalanx

camp but was apprehended while trying to discover your whereabouts." Erasmus grinned.

Gwen flinched at his words. Hope, a fragile ember, flickered and nearly died.

Erasmus observed the fear in Gwen's eyes while grinning triumphantly. "Sloppy indeed."

He clapped his hands, and the tent flap whipped open. Two guards dragged in a battered figure. Gwen's breath hitched. It was Sylvius, his face a canvas of pain, his normally vibrant face pale and sunken.

"*Sylvius!*" A strangled cry escaped Gwen's lips while the guards dumped Sylvius roughly on the ground before her. "*Not you too!*" Tears welled up in her eyes, threatening to spill over.

As Sylvius groaned in unconsciousness, Gwen's heart sank as she observed the numerous bruises and wounds marring her mentor's body. It was evident that their captors had subjected Sylvius to far more brutal torture than they had inflicted upon her. With each cough of blood that escaped Sylvius's lips, Gwen's eyes filled with tears, unable to conceal her rage at the profound injustice that had befallen both her and her tutor.

She began weeping at the thought of causing such misery not only to herself but also to the man who had cared for her even when her birth father abandoned her at university just to get rid of her after her mother died.

The sight of Sylvius in such agony stirred painful memories within Gwen, reminding her of the abandonment she had endured from her birth father after her mother's death. It brought back the haunting recollections of her childhood, the torment inflicted by her classmates, and the subsequent beacon of hope that Sylvius had provided in her darkest moments. He had plucked her from the depths of despair, nurturing and guiding her to become the best version of herself.

As Gwen's mind raced through the chronicles of her life with Sylvius, a profound sorrow engulfed her heart, threatening to consume her. Unable to contain her anguish any longer, she was about let out a muffled scream when she stopped herself. Without hesitation, she called upon her weak water elemental to suppress her tears, fearing that any display of weakness would only invite further torment upon Sylvius.

Though clad in filthy garments, Gwen's water-casting abilities remained unaffected, unlike her air casting.

It seemed that their captors either remained unaware or indifferent to her proficiency in water manipulation, deeming it insufficient to pose a threat. However, they had clearly taken measures to neutralize Sylvius's formidable earth elemental by severing his connection to the earth with an air shield, rendering him powerless to aid her.

But Gwen couldn't hide her concern for lot longer. She let out a muffled scream to stop the monsters from mauling her mentor's body.

A cruel glint entered Erasmus's eyes. "*So, we've found your weakness,*" he sneered, gesturing to the guards. "Show her what it's like to witness a loved one tortured for her continued silence."

The guards raised their fists and began pounding Sylvius with the might of their earth elemental. Gwen lunged forward, only to be restrained by the other guards. Her screams were choked back, was forced to stare helplessly at Sylvius with unbridled dread in her eyes.

"*No!* Please spare Sylvius!" Each defiant move Gwen made to rush to Sylvius's aid only resulted in more brutality inflicted upon her beloved mentor.

In despair, she sank to her knees, unable to bear the sight of Sylvius's bloodied torso, and turned her head away.

"Gwen, there is no need for anyone to suffer needlessly. Be practical. Give us the information." Erasmus leaned in, his voice a chilling whisper.

Tears streamed down Gwen's cheeks as she kept her gaze fixed on Sylvius, grappling with the decision before her.

"The choice is yours, girl. Talk, and you both get a painless end. Remain silent, and witness your old friend suffer the consequences for your defiance."

She realized that the nightmare she had in the morning had presented her with the same choice she must now confront.

Whom is she going to choose? Dorian or Sylvius?

Soulmate or father? How could she possibly decide between her caring father and her beloved soulmate? It was an agonizing dilemma; one she knew that her heart alone could not resolve. She made a conscious decision to rely on her mind to guide her choice.

She understood that revealing knowledge about Dorian to these rogues would be fruitless since it would not alter her or Sylvius' fate. As soon as she revealed the information sought by these rogues, Sylvius and herself would be slain at once.

She resolved to resist until her last breath to at least prevent Dorian from sharing their fate.

"*Oh, Sylvius!* Please forgive me, but I cannot disclose the information these fiends seek," she implored with guilt, her voice filled with sorrow and determination.

But as she watched Sylvius endure unspeakable agony, a chilling realization dawned upon her. Could she bear to witness Sylvius's suffering escalate further as they sought to break her resolve? She knew it was only a matter of time before they intensified their torment of Sylvius to compel her compliance. No, it was time to turn the tables if she at least harbored any hope to attempt an escape.

With a fierce glare at Erasmus, Gwen spoke with indignation, "I have always held Prince Livian Primus in high regard for his compassionate heart, rumored to be as pure as gold. I have heard tales of his selfless deeds, aiding those in need and his courage to confront any obstacle with the unwavering loyalty of his valiant and powerful bodyguards."

"Now look at you, Erasmus Berian. Not only have you betrayed a man who entrusted you with his life, but you have stooped to torturing his loyal followers just to carry out your vile plot against his son," Gwen accused, her words cutting like a blade. "*Aren't you ashamed of yourself?* How will you face Prince Livian Primus in the afterlife, knowing you have betrayed him and harmed his kin?"

She struck at Erasmus's most vulnerable spot, targeting the remorse that surely gnawed at his conscience for betraying his true master.

If she was right in her earlier assessment about Erasmus, she was hopeful that Erasmus was not very happy in forcing to betray his previous master.

"Stop!" Erasmus swore vehemently as he relinquished control of his emotions, his rage boiling over evidently. With a menacing growl, he lifted Sylvius into the air, his strength fueled by

the power of his earth elemental. The old lomer dangled helplessly, suspended by Erasmus's merciless grasp.

Using the strength borrowed from his earth elemental, Erasmus began to strangle Sylvius, his voice resonating with thunderous threats. "Old man, if you wish to meet your end swiftly, then knock some sense into the girl!" With a forceful shove, he hurled Sylvius to the ground before storming out of the tent, visibly shaken with guilt by Gwen's affront to his loyalty.

Korinna cast a troubled glance at Gwen before hurrying after Erasmus. Ignoring the couple's departure from her mind, Gwen crawled to Sylvius's battered form, a cry of disbelief escaping her lips as she cradled his head in her lap.

Sylvius lay unconscious, oblivious to his surroundings, as Gwen observed his injuries with a heavy heart. The guards smirked as they exited the tent, leaving Gwen to tend to her mentor alone. With determined resolve, she dragged Sylvius to a nearby water tub, shoved him into the tub before willing her water elemental to aid in his healing.

The water elemental responded sluggishly, and she instructed it to search for fatal wounds. She discovered a cracked rib that had sunk into a lung, puncturing it.

She knew that Sylvius would never regain consciousness if left unattended. Bracing herself, Gwen channeled her spirit and water elemental to heal his mortal wounds, watching as his body slowly began to heal.

As soon as his mortal wounds were healed, Gwen released her water elemental and slumped to the floor, the tendrils of exhaustion finally coiling around her. Healing Sylvius had drained her reserves, leaving behind a dull ache in every fiber of her being.

When she awoke with a gasp, a sliver of panic clawed at her throat on not finding Sylvius within the water tub. She frantically whirled around to look at all corners of the tent for her mentor. Pure relief washed over her as she saw Sylvius slumped against the table, a faint hint of color returning to his face.

The ordeal of torture followed by usage of water and spirit magic had taken its toll. Her body screamed in protest, the aftereffects of her magic a heavy weight on her. But the only thing that mattered to her was that Sylvius was alive. She leaned back against the desk and groaned.

She observed through the gap between the tent flaps that night had already settled. She noted that she had been resting for several hours clearly.

A groan broke the silence. "Not exactly the glorious farewell I envisioned to sign off," Sylvius rasped. "Always thought I'd go out with an arrow in the back, facing the enemy head-on. But I never imagined that I would prefer that death to this." A wry smile flickered on his lips.

"Certainly signing off in style," Gwen replied, her voice hoarse. Despite the pain, a ghost of a smile played on her lips.

A heavy silence descended, thick with unspoken emotions. Finally, Gwen broke it, her voice barely a whisper.

"Syl, I'm so sorry for getting you dragged into this mess."

"No, lass. It is not your fault that we were betrayed."

Gwen's head snapped up, her eyes flashing with surprise. "*Betrayed? By who?* In fact, how in the world did a master lomer like you get captured by these stupid soldiers?"

"They were waiting for me, Gwen. One of the king's lomers must have defected and tipped this phalanx off about our mission." Sylvius sighed, his voice heavy with disappointment. "Primus has serious problems if his own lomers are defecting."

A bitter chuckle escaped his lips. "Perhaps my desire to catch an arrow in the back has come true, but not literally."

He focused his gaze on Gwen, his eyes filled with concern. "How long have you been imprisoned here, lass?"

"Two days," she mumbled, looking away.

Sylvius noticed her skipping to answer how she fared but he didn't press the issue.

The silence returned, heavier this time, laced with despair.

"We're not leaving this place, aren't we?" Gwen finally spoke, her voice devoid of hope.

"Looks that way, lass," Sylvius agreed, his voice a low rumble. "Escape seems like a distant dream at the moment."

A humorless laugh escaped Gwen. "So, they tortured you to the brink of death just because you could resist their truth-seeking spirit casters? Gwen asked"

"Bingo," Sylvius said with a weak grin.

Gwen forced a smile, a flicker of pride battling with the fear gnawing at her insides. "You've always been skilled at lying to truth seekers. That's what makes you the most renowned and greatest lomer amongst us."

"Perhaps once," Sylvius mumbled, his eyelids drooping. "But not anymore as age must have caught up with me if I allowed these fools to lure me into a trap!"

"True enough." Gwen's voice dropped to a whisper. "But what now, Syl?"

Sylvius remained silent, his breaths shallow and labored. The weight of their situation, the harsh reality of betrayal, pressed down on them both. The future stretched before them, an uncertain path shrouded in darkness.

"You know as well as I do, Gwen," Sylvius replied wearily, meeting her gaze with a heavy heart. "We're left with only two options: surrender and divulge all the information they demand, or defy them until we force them to end our lives before they break us piece by piece."

"I will never betray Dorian!" Gwen argued defiantly. "I will rather meet my end with honor than betraying Dorian!"

Despair threatened to consume Gwen, but a flicker of defiance, a spark of her lomer training, ignited within her. She wouldn't give up. Not yet. She had to find a way out, for Sylvius, for Dorian, and for herself.

"What information did these brutes seek from you, lass?" Sylvius rasped, concern etched on his face.

Gwen bit her lip, guilt weighing heavily on her. "They're after information about Dorian!"

Sylvius sighed deeply. "So they know you're his girlfriend! This complicates matters even further and makes it worse for us!"

A tense silence enveloped them, each lost in their own mind.

"I hope you're prepared for what lies ahead," Sylvius said, his tone resigned. "These rogues won't simply let us walk away this camp unscathed."

"Yes, we may face our end," Gwen retorted with a fierce snarl, "but I refuse to betray my beloved. We will meet our end with honor."

Sylvius chuckled softly. "Honor hasn't seemed to have served you well these past two days, has it? Didn't I caution you against getting involved with Dorian? Eventually he would take the fall for being born into the wrong family without its full magical power."

"Dorian may lack the power of the noble lords like those who command this illicit phalanx, but I believe he possesses the potential to evolve into a greater king than any of them," Gwen declared vehemently.

Sylvius studied her intently before sighing. "*So, you choose Dorian over me?*"

Tears streamed down Gwen's cheeks as silence fell between the two lomers.

"I'm sorry, Syl. Even if we divulge what these scoundrels seek about Dorian, we both know won't escape this place alive," Gwen wept in anguish. "At the very least, I want to spare Dorian from sharing our fate."

"Gwen, don't feel guilty about your choice. Your reasoning is sound. If I were faced with the choice between Sukra and us, I would make the same decision. I would have chosen Sukra over us any day." Sylvius agreed with her choice.

"In fact, I believe you have ascended to the rank of lomer from a novice, atleast in my gaze!" Sylvius encouraged his poor daughter.

Gwen stared back at the man she respected more than a father. She had no words except the pure relief on her face. Atleast, her father looked at her like a lomer. Maybe, she will savour those words until she met her end shortly at the hands of the rogues.

After a moment of contemplation, Sylvius faced their grim reality. "If this is your decision, then you know what you must do next."

Gwen shook her head, looking at Sylvius like a father figure. "No, Syl... I can't bring myself to end your life."

Sylvius looked at her imploringly. "If you don't comply to their demands, they'll force you to watch as they hack my body part by part until you relent and reveal information about Dorian."

Tears continued to flow down Gwen's cheeks. She couldn't argue against that eventuality. But the alternative was more than nightmarish to even consider.

"I would rather meet my merciful end at your hands than endure defilement and torture after all I've done for Sukra," Sylvius said with resignation.

It was one thing to choose a lover over a father. But it was another thing to murder your father to save your beloved.

Gwen shook her head in denial of the dreadful act she was being compelled to commit in order to save her beloved. "No, I will not kill you!"

"But-" Sylvius protested, but his ward interjected him.

"There's another way to evade torture," Gwen muttered defiantly as footsteps approached the tent, accompanied by a hushed voice reciting the password.

"I may or may not meet Dorian for dinner at the Ragged Inn during the Wintersend Festival, but we won't face our end meekly, begging our captors for mercy," Gwen declared.

Sylvius was utterly stunned by her confident tone and revelation, but he swiftly quelled his

emotions despite all the beatings he had received. He too heard the footsteps of a visitor about to enter the tent .

He laughed out loud with an impressed nod. "An excellent place to meet with the prince in the most notorious inns in the capital. No one would expect to find the prince in that inn visited by the most hated and reviled rogues."

Gwen nodded with a sullen expression. "True."

She sprang to her feet and melted into the darkness of the tent's corner, veiling herself with the manipulation of light from her light elemental magic.

The tent flap parted, and a maid entered the tent with a tray laden with food.

The maid shuffled deeper into the tent, her movements sluggish, then knelt to set the food down. But before she could rise, Gwen materialized from the shadows, a swift specter startling the unsuspecting maid.

Before the maid could call for aid, Gwen used her elbow to deliver a crushing blow to the maid's neck, sending the woman crumpling. Reacting instinctively, Gwen caught the collapsing figure before she struck the ground, then swiftly dragged her towards the desk in the corner where Gwen had been resting a few seconds earlier.

Silence reigned as Gwen shed her soiled garments with practiced haste. Disguising the maid in her own clothes, she slipped on the maid's attire, an attire that she hoped would hide her identity.

She forced the maid to lie on her side and concealed the maid's face with a cascade of the maid's own hair. If anyone peered through the tent flap, Gwen prayed they'd mistake the maid's heaving form for her own, exhausted after days of torture.

A surge of relief washed over her when her air elemental responded to her summons, albeit with a sluggishness that mirrored her own exhaustion.

With a sullen expression, she activated the Obilisque beneath the desk at the tent's edge.

As the magical device hummed to life, she turned to see Sylvius beaming at her with admiration.

"Not the time to think with your heart, Gwen." Sylvius warned. "I can't escape this camp with these injuries, and Erasmus may return at any moment."

She gave him a reassuring smile. "No, I don't believe he'll be back tonight. When you were being beaten, I pricked him in his most vulnerable spot. I mentioned his affiliation with Prince Livian and how he had betrayed the prince by collaborating with Livian's enemies to murder Livian's son."

"So, tormenting his conscience wasn't just about restraining him from murdering me?" Sylvius' grin stretched even wider.

Pride flared in Gwen's chest, a singular achievement on this otherwise tedious mission. "Why settle for scraps when you can feast on the whole course?"

Sylvius chuckled, a low rumble in his throat. "Flee quickly, lass, before these ruffians return. Inform Primus of this rogue Phalanx."

"I'm not leaving without you, old man. Don't you dare die on me just yet."

Sylvius sputtered protests, but Gwen cut him off. "*Hand over your cloak.* The maid was a

sturdier build than me. I need to increase my bulk to maintain the illusion."

Sylvius stretched, retrieved his discarded cloak on the floor, and tossed it towards her.

Gwen caught it, draped it over her shoulders, and cinched the belt tight. A pouch of coins clinked against her midriff. "I'll snag a water caster from the healer's tent, then return in disguise to patch you up. After that, we will flee this wretched place together."

"*But-*" Sylvius' protests were silenced by Gwen's swift waving her hands. She layered the maid's cloak over Sylvius' and met his gaze with steely resolve. "*No buts, Syl.* This is my mission, and no one's dying for it." Her voice softened a touch. "*Least of all you,*" she added, pointing a finger at him.

"I'll be back within an hour. Rest now." A wink punctuated her farewell as she slipped out of the tent, mimicking the maid's slight limp. The guards paid her no mind, engrossed in their heated debate.

Gwen darted west, aiming to circle towards the healer's tent. Reaching the shadows behind a barrack, she wove a light cast veil around herself. She heard the rumble of carts leaving the supply tent and drifting towards the distant gates at the far end of the camp.

Recalling her recon mission a few days earlier, Gwen recognized the carts as part of a food run to a nearby village ten miles away. Maybe, they need more food for the feast that the maids were gossiping about a few days ago.

She discarded Sylvius' cloak and proceeded to empty its contents. As anticipated, the rogues had stripped Sylvius of all knives and valuables before subjecting him to torture in her presence. However, they remained unaware of her mentor's habit of concealing valuables within a secret pocket nestled within his cloak.

She discovered the hidden pocket on Sylvius' cloak and carefully prised it open. Delving inside, she retrieved an object concealed within.

In her palm gleamed a single gold coin, its surface adorned with the intricate engraving of a majestic unicorn. "*Gotcha!*"

Slipping the gold coin into one of the pockets of the maid's attire she now wore, she murmured to herself, "Now I have a chance of completing this mission successfully!"

She heard the clop of a horse-drawn cart pass her concealed spot. She removed her hairband, tucked it inside Sylvius' cloak, and casually tossed it into the rear of the cart with a nasty smirk.

Skirting the camp's edge, Gwen moved farther away from the healers tent as much as possible and passed by the tents of various soldiers. She came to a halt at the sound of a soldier's boisterous snore. With a silent prayer to Sivi, the Great One, she cautiously peeled open the flap, revealing two slumbering figures. Their swords lay within easy reach by their beds.

With practiced stealth, she crept towards the lighter-looking sword, snatching it along with its sheath and a bonus dagger. She cautiously exited the tent with practiced stealth, careful not to not wake the dozing soldiers.

She dashed to a nearby shadow between the tents and secured the sword belt on her hips. Then she removed the dagger from its sheath and flew toward the cleaner's tent, which had a good view of the tent where she was held captive.

Gwen took cover near the cleaner's tent, its position granting a clear view of the comings and goings around the tent where she was held captive. She waited for a while before Erasmus and Korinna entered then tent.

"*Poor Syl!*" Gwen smirked.

She didn't have to wait for long before she spotted Korinna exiting the tent alone. A grim understanding settled upon Gwen about the fate of her mentor.

She trailed Korinna, meticulously masking her frolicking emotions to avoid alerting the spirit caster.

Reaching her target, Gwen wove a sound veil, a precaution to stifle any alarm Korinna might raise. Korinna whirled around in panic upon sensing a private veil created around her, only to discover Gwen holding a blade to her throat.

Gwen hissed at Korinna to be silent and shoved her into the shadow cast by the neighboring tents.

Terror choked Korinna's voice into a stammer.

"Someone is not so brave now without her husband, are you?" Gwen imitated the sweet and slurry voice of the woman.

Despair contorted Korinna's face. *Here she was, at the mercy of the one she'd helped torture for days.*

"I need your assistance," Gwen stated, her voice forceful and brooking no argument.

"Return to the tent where I was held captive," Gwen instructed, her voice laced with steely resolve. "Deliver this message: I, trained by the finest lomer in the land, am not fooled by your games. Tell your husband that I know who the traitor within the King's ranks."

"*You know who the traitor is?*" Korinna gasped.

Gwen's voice croaked, but she shook her head and hissed at the spirit caster. "*Yes.* During the torture yesterday, Erasmus let slip in his curiosity about the identity of the traitor when he inquired about where I was slated to meet the prince on the Wintersend Festival night."

"I knew at once who the traitor in the king's ranks: *Sylvius*!" Gwen's voice croaked for a moment, her heart still trying to disbelieve her mind.

"*How—*" Korinna sputtered in surprise.

"I disclosed the details of my upcoming date with Dorian to only one person. When Erasmus mentioned it, I realized the traitor was Sylvius. Not even King Primus was aware of our plans for the Wintersend Festival night."

"Deliver another message," Gwen hissed, a new revelation glinting in her eyes. "Tell them I've uncovered not just the traitor, but the true owner of this rogue Phalanx: *Noble Lord Maleficus* himself!"

Korinna's jaw slackened at hearing the name of the true owner of the phalanx.

Gwen decided to make it harder for her mentor in the same vein he had made it harder for her to complete the mission by backstabbing her.

Backstab the backstabber! Gwen decided to twist the knife further. "Tell them all," Gwen continued, "that I have enough evidence to expose Lord Maleficus' involvement with this illegal phalanx army, much thanks to Sylvius' assistance," she added, dripping with sarcasm.

Korinna sputtered, bewildered. "Sylvius helped you discover the legion's owner?"

A smug grin stretched across Gwen's face, relishing the chaos she'd sown to make this phalanx to stop trusting her mentor and make it hard for him to win their trust once more. "Yes. Speaking of the devil, tell Sylvius," she growled, "that I was never planning to meet Dorian at the Ragged inn."

Korinna was completely stunned, finally catching on to Gwen's elaborate deception. Gwen's own fury simmered beneath the surface.

"Tell that snake, Sylvius," she spat, "that he's lost the trust of the realm, the king, and a daughter who would have gladly sacrificed her life for him yesterday." Her voice hitched, choked by the weight of betrayal from her mentor.

"Inform Sylvius I chose him over Dorian when the prince offered a choice to choose between Sylvius and Dorian. After all, I owe so much to Sylvius that I can't ever repay in this lifetime."

Tears streamed down her cheeks, but her grip on the dagger tightened. "Tell him I would have sacrificed myself for him. Now, having exposed the true traitor among the lomers employed to the king, I'll stop at nothing to bring him and his crony, Lord Maleficus, to justice. I've prevented him from betraying any further lomers for his foolish cause."

Gwen swiftly knocked down Korinna unconscious with a forceful blow from the pommel of her dagger.

"Blasted witch, water cast yourself from your unconsciousness," Gwen muttered under her breath as she dragged Korinna into the shadows of the nearby tents.

Gwen looked around to ensure that no one had heard them, and then she sprang into the air and created a gentle breeze to fly toward the cleaners' tent.

She located another shadow cast from the cleaners' tents close enough to use sound casting to eavesdrop on the tent where she was held captive earlier.

When she was trying to escape from the tent, she was proud that she had managed to replace the private sound veil surrounding the tent with her own, unnoticed by Sylvius, who was preoccupied with thoughts of Dorian's planned rendezvous at the Ragged Inn. He remained unaware of Gwen's subtle manipulation, allowing her to listen in on the conversation within the veil from a distance of half a mile.

A self-satisfied smile played on her lips. Phase one of her plan was a resounding success. Now, it was time to wait for Korinna to awaken.

Gwen waited thirty minutes before spotting Korinna rushing toward the command tent. She observed Korinna signaling to the guards to step aside, and they did so immediately.

Gwen activated her sound casting on the command tent's private veil, causing new sounds to surge into her ears.

"My Lord! My Lord!" Korinna cried out, weeping.

"What is it, love?" enquired a concerned Erasmus.

In addition, she heard a rueful chuckle that grew into a burst of roaring laughter.

Gwen bit her lip at recognizing Sylvius' voice.

"What happened?" Erasmus asked.

"Did she pass on a message before she escaped?" Sylvius inquired before Korinna could respond.

Erasmus shifted his gaze between Sylvius and Korinna, who nodded her head in shock.

"Love, what is the message?" Erasmus inquired softly.

Korinna stutteringly relayed Gwen's statement to the others.

"She requested that I remind you that she was trained by the greatest lomer in the kingdom to fall for our cheap antics. When you asked Gwen about the place where she was slated to meet Prince Dorian in the capital, she recognized Sylvius' betrayal, for she had revealed her upcoming meeting with Prince Dorian to none but him."

Erasmus attempted to interject, but she interrupted him. "She stated that she has sufficient evidence to disgrace Lord Maleficus for his involvement with an unlawful legion and would soon share it with the king with Sylvius' assistance."

Erasmus became pale and swung around to face a smiling Sylvius, exclaiming, "What does this mean, old man? Did you assist her escape?"

Sylvius chuckled at Gwen's ability to distort his words and foment doubt among his allies.

Sylvius muttered, "She must have thanked me since she took the coins granted to me by King Primus, as he did for all lomers, so we could reach him by spirit sending if necessary."

He admonished himself. "Sweet Elementals. I was busy mulling over her slip about meeting Prince Dorian in the Ragged Inn and hadn't realized that she was deceiving me. Now, I can't even mislead other lomers without the coins, even if they don't know I betrayed the king."

"I've just lost my opportunity to annihilate all the lomers working for the king and land a crippling blow to Primus." Sylvius chastised himself for committing such an error.

Gwen grinned from the safety of her hiding as she imagined Sylvius' wounded expression.

Korinna stuttered and stared at Sylvius. "She also instructed me to notify you that she is definitely not meeting Prince Dorian at the Ragged Inn in the capital."

Sylvius laughed at how easily he was tricked by his student and motioned to Korinna to continue with the final punch he was anticipating from his ward.

Korinna stated gently, "The girl also indicated that you have not only lost the faith of the kingdom and its lord but also a daughter who would have offered her life for you a day ago."

"Gwen informed me that she had already chosen you over Dorian until she learned about your betrayal. She has vowed to be a hurdle in your campaign to bring down Dorian and King Primus."

A long minute of silence filled the room before Sylvius shook his head.

Sylvius questioned, "How long ago did she threaten you?"

Korinna shook her head, oblivious to the passage of time. "I was ambushed about five minutes after leaving this tent."

"Did you see her fly toward the east?"

"I am not sure." Korinna shrugged.

Sylvius knelt on the ground and touched it. He commanded his earth elemental to track the tracking stone in Gwen's hairband and observed that it was traveling eastward.

"She has certainly fled our camp and appears to be heading east." Sylvius sighed wearily. "She must have escaped half an hour ago, and we must presume that King Primus is notified of our treachery."

Gwen smiled at her brilliant idea to toss her hairband containing the tracking stone into a storage cart heading to the east for restocking from the nearby village.

And Sylvius had fallen for her trap in assuming that she had long fled the legion camp.

Meanwhile, Sylvius wiped his temples and said, "This implies we must accelerate our preparations for the Wintersend Festival in the capital."

Erasmus shook his head in disagreement. "No. Before deciding our next line of action, we must discuss this with Lord Maleficus. Before we embark on our campaign, he has insisted that we meet in person at his residence," Erasmus was sour that Sylvius had let Gwen escape their grasp.

Sylvius lowered his head thoughtfully.

Erasmus motioned for him to exit the tent. "Let's depart immediately in the wind coach prepared for our transport."

Loud noises of a huge object being searched for and retrieved from one of the desks were audible to Gwen.

Gwen observed everyone exit the command tent and make their way to a wind coach waiting near the west gate of the legion camp.

Shortly after, she witnessed Erasmus, Korinna, and Sylvius boarding the airship, a colossal vessel resembling a boat, which, mere minutes later, ascended into the sky and propelled by the wind elementals harnessed by four air-magic-wielding wind riders. The airship was steered towards the west, where Maleficus City, the stronghold of Lord Maleficus' power, awaited.

Gwen watched the departing airship, a maelstrom of sorrow and rage churning within her. The thought of slaying her mentor felt repugnant, yet she harbored no illusions about Sylvius' ruthlessness – she would be killed without hesitation if Sylvius deemed her a threat.

Steeling her resolve, Gwen rushed to the storage tent, securing enough provisions of food for a day's journey.

Under a light-cast veil, she navigated to the rear of the tent where she had been imprisoned. With a quick flick of her knife, a gash appeared in the tent's fabric, granting her access. Slipping inside, she swiftly crept towards the desk.

Her fingers found the Obilisque, its pulsing light revealing its activated state. She deactivated the oblique with a smug smile. Though her previous claim of uncovering evidence against Lord Maleficus had been a lie, it now held a sliver of truth - the surreptitiously recorded conversation between Erasmus and Sylvius.

The camp's sentries appeared to be vigilant against infiltrators, with their focus solely on the perimeter of the camp. Gwen, however, understood their oversight – those sentries' concern lay with those entering the legion, not those slipping away unseen from within the legion. With her mission in this rogue camp complete, she vanished from the forsaken place, leaving no trace of her departure.

She entered this clandestine phalanx camp as a naïve girl, teetering on the precipice of

womanhood. But she departed the camp as a woman awakened to the harsh realities of life.

After breaking free from the phalanx camp, she set her course westward toward the southeastern edge of Sukra, her heart filled with a mix of renewed optimism and profound sorrow.

Chapter 12

The Betrayer Betrayed

Loyalty is not something that you can demand; you can only earn it.

But, you don't earn a betrayal. You pave the way for it by trusting others implicitly and stupidly without questioning their loyalty.

For betrayal is the only truth that sticks forever and maims you from trusting others again.

I'd rather be defeated by my enemies than vanquished by a betrayer.

I never wish even my mortal enemy to have a betrayer in his midst, for confronting a betrayer is more painful than even losing to your archnemesis.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

Gwen fled the illegal legion for twenty miles with her veil before gaining the courage to shed it. She maneuvered east and north to deflect any unlikely wind riders pursuing her from the illegal legion. However, she traveled gradually toward the southeastern city of Ravesia, the holding of the noble lord who had openly denied any interest in ascending the throne.

She contemplated Lord Maleficus and Sylvius' nefarious plan for the Wintersend festivities. She sensed that Maleficus' designs for Dorian extended beyond removing him from the Sukran throne's line of succession.

And why was Erasmus a part of the nefarious group hunting Dorian? He had heard that Erasmus was just as kind as Livian. What had prompted him to hunt the son of his true master?

During her exhausting trip, Gwen groaned and daydreamed about how peaceful her country would have been if only Prince Livian had survived.

The Lemurian Valley was a rural border town not renowned for anything other than its independent, hardy farmers. But, it was where Prince Livian Primus was murdered during the first Mayan War two decades ago.

The prince sacrificed himself to prevent the Mayans from storming the Lemurian fortress since there would have been mass destruction had the Mayans overpowered him and the token legion that accompanied him. The Mayans might have destroyed millions of undefended farmsteads on their route to Titus, the only city of sufficient size for the Mayans to invade and capture its renowned riches.

However, the prince held the line until the Crown Legions and Titus Legions arrived to augment their power.

Unfortunately, he was murdered shortly before the arrival of the backup legions.

She had always puzzled why Livian opted not to flee the war and sacrificed his life to protect a remote border town. But, after meeting and getting to know Dorian, she realized that Livian was not someone who ran away from his problems at the expense of innocents.

Livian's moral code was just as inspiring as Dorian's. After learning of his father's rigorous adherence to his moral code, Dorian had imbibed the same code in his life.

How could a mighty prince live with the humiliation of fleeing at the first hint of war and sacrificing millions of innocent border farmers just to save his hide?

It is preferable for one man to suffer rather than thousands.

Gwen pondered what life in the kingdom might have been like if the prince had survived that accursed war with the Mayans. She had overheard the old lomers describe the compassionate nature of the king's only son, who was so kind that even his adversaries adored him.

He would have become the greatest ruler of the kingdom that Orinn had ever seen in its thousands of years of existence. Numerous lords admired him and considered him a close friend.

At the very least, Livian would have spawned offspring apart from Dorian, freeing Dorian of the responsibility of carrying the legacy of the House of Primus on his shoulders alone.

Moreover, if Livian had been present, Dorian would not have been hunted by so many assassins.

Gwen shook her head at her regretful musings. Life had just taught her how cruel it could be. Her father-like mentor had betrayed her to the enemy just to obtain knowledge about Prince Dorian's routine. She was cast aside like unwanted collateral damage in their bid to slaughter Dorian.

If Livian had survived, he would have been a boon to the world, but his death had left the realm without a legitimate heir. She knew the kingdom was headed for an inevitable civil war between aristocratic lords vying for the throne. And her soulmate, Dorian, was at the center of the storm brewing around the Sukran throne.

Would the storm sweep him away, or would he endure it and rise like a phoenix? She realized with certainty that the throne ought to be ascended by someone like Dorian. Not because she was Dorian's lover. But due to his impeccable moral code, he was the most qualified applicant for the job.

The necessity of the hour was not a strong leader but a righteous leader who could restore the kingdom to its former grandeur.

King Primus was too elderly to bear another son, and the noble lords were squabbling with each other to poise themselves to become the next king. This had resulted in several conflicts between cities, with commoners paying the price for the aspirations of their liege lords.

Gwen began to tire, given that she had flown nonstop from the illegal legion for several hours. She noticed the Mara river running beneath her and descended from the skies in the river's direction.

She landed on the bank and approached the river on foot. She smothered her hair, tousled from the flight, and reached into her pocket to grab the fabric containing Sylvius' possessions.

She took a gold coin bearing the inscriptions of a crown encircled by two crossed swords.

"Hasten my message to thy lord," she said as she hurled it on the ground.

She waited a while before she noticed a disturbance in the air above the coin bearing the spirit of the Sukran she had invited to a meeting. She witnessed a man's spirit emerge from the coin. The form was constructed of turbulent air yet was substantial enough to resemble King

Valerian Primus' features.

The king had a strong jaw and a sharp nose, and his white beard was neatly maintained. He had a beautiful white mane that cascaded down to his shoulders. He had emerald eyes and a flawless visage that belied his age of eighty. Even though he appeared more like a man in his fifties than an elderly man, his face revealed the experience behind them.

Gwen knelt and bowed deeply.

The king's emerald eyes studied Gwen and her attire for a long minute before muttering, "Gwen, I didn't expect you in this spirit sending."

Gwen steeled herself and responded, gazing into the eyes of the king. "Your Majesty, I regret to inform you that Sylvius has defected from your employment."

Valerian nodded after pausing at the unexpected charge made on his best lomer. "Explain, Novice."

Gwen observed the king's emphasis on the last word and comprehended her dire situation. The king had gently reminded her that he had no reason to assume Sylvius had deserted him instead of her. In any case, she was using Sylvius' coins to communicate with the king, and Sylvius was not present to counter her claim.

She nodded and informed him about the events of the previous two days.

The king's face grew ragged as her updates continued. Finally, the king remarked in an impressed tone. "That is one heck of a tale on your final exam, Novice."

"Tale?" The word 'tale' made Gwen realize that the king would need more than her word to be convinced that Sylvius had betrayed him.

She couldn't fault the king, as she, too, found it difficult to comprehend how a devoted vassal like Sylvius could betray his liege lord.

"Erasmus questioned me about where I was supposed to meet prince Dorian at the Wintersend Festival. I understood from this question that Sylvius was the traitor, as I had only shared this knowledge with him."

"Once I understood Sylvius had betrayed me, I knew that even if I were to escape, my allegations about Sylvius' defection would never be believed unless I had evidence of his treachery."

"I anticipated Sylvius would appear as a prisoner under the guise of being apprehended while attempting to rescue me, as I had not yielded to their interrogation," she said.

"I played along when they started beating Sylvius."

"I was able to unsettle Erasmus sufficiently for breaking Prince Livian's confidence, causing him to rush out of the tent, leaving me alone with Sylvius. I anticipated Sylvius to interrogate me more discreetly when assuming my guard would be down."

Valerian's smile curled his lips, and he urged her to continue. "Knowing that you couldn't escape with Erasmus present, you alienated Erasmus by hurting his feelings in order to isolate Sylvius?"

"Yes, My Lord," Gwen smiled in response. "My clothing was filthy, and I could not summon my air elemental, but I was able to heal Sylvius' fractured ribs with my feeble water casting."

Valerian admired her brilliance and nodded in her direction. "By healing Sylvius, you persuaded him that you had not deducted his treachery."

"Yes, Your Majesty. When I heard a maid bringing meals, I revealed that I might meet Dorian at the Ragged Inn in the capital.

"While he pondered the prospects of finding the prince in such a notorious inn, I overpowered the maid and stole her garments along with those of Sylvius, which I knew contained your spirit sending coins. As he appeared mortally wounded and unable to flee, I volunteered to find a water caster to heal him so we might flee together."

"Sylvius played along with me, knowing he could track me with his tracking stone, which he must have ordered not to be confiscated."

Valerian smiled and nodded at her. "Once clear of the sentries, you escaped."

"No, Sire. Not until I had proof of his treachery and information about the lord behind the unlawful legion."

"I didn't want to fail my first assignment, Sire," Gwen asserted.

"I surmised that Sylvius had left bogus letters pointing to another lord like Ravesian because he did not want me to discover the true lord behind the unlawful legion if I escaped my captors."

"And the way I was imprisoned in the command tent makes me question whether it was a real command tent or a tent put up with fake paperwork in case I managed to escape. They wanted to incriminate Lord Ravesian, who is more sympathetic to Dorian's cause."

"A nice tale indeed." Primus arched his eyebrow.

"Not a tale, Sire." Gwen bowed before the monarch. "And here is your evidence, Your Majesty."

Gwen drew the Obilisque from her pocket and set it free in the river. A few seconds passed before she triggered the stone. The Obilisque projected the collected pictures and sound onto the surface of the Mara river in front of Valerian Primus.

Valerian's countenance darkened as he observed Sylvius, Erasmus, and Korinna conversing. He stayed silent for a moment even after the Obilisque displayed the entire discussion regarding Sylvius' involvement in the illegal legion.

He raised his head to gaze at Gwen and gave her an impressed smile. "Gwen, excellent work. Deceiving Sylvius at his own game was the icing on the cake."

He regarded her with a glint in his eye. "I sincerely appreciate the loyalty to Dorian and me you have demonstrated to me today. Loyalty appears to be on the verge of extinction these days."

Primus extended his spirit hands toward Gwen's shoulders and adopted a more official tone. Gwen's entire being was surrounded by the warmth exuding from the king's hands. She realized that the king was greeting her spirit, which made her body shiver in anticipation.

"Lad Gwendolyn, I hereby anoint you as a Lomer of the First Degree and welcome you to the office of my personal envoy with admiration for your splendid performance so far."

"Thank you, Your Majesty!" As tears streamed down Gwen's cheeks, she expressed her joy at being promoted to the first degree. She had become not just any lomer but an elite lomers in the realm. She was pleasantly surprised by the king's reward for her loyalty. It usually took many

decades of service to be promoted to first-degree status. Her loyalty under extreme pressure had won her the most coveted job for a lomer.

"Rise, Lomer."

Gwen climbed to her feet, smiling widely.

Valerian became pensive. "So, Maleficus has started the game now...But why would Sylvius join Maleficus of all noble lords? I would have expected him to ally with..."

Maleficus may have initiated the game well before anybody anticipated it. However, it was his time to surprise his adversaries.

It's time for Dorian to use his fallback plan. The Wintersend Festival in the capital is anything but safe for Dorian.

"Is Dorian safe in the capital, Your Highness?" Gwen questioned anxiously.

"Yes, for the time being, he is safe in the capital. But, Gwen, you need not be concerned. I will take care of my grandson in your absence. I'm sure he misses you dearly."

Gwen blushed and battled to contain her emotions as she eagerly anticipated meeting Dorian as a First Degree Lomer at the Wintersend Festival.

Valerian finally regarded Gwen. "Gwen, how are you feeling now? Are you game for your next mission?" Valerian inquired with a sudden glint in his gaze.

Gwen said, "I am fine, My Lord, and fit for the next mission."

"Thank you, Gwen. Would you be able to fly to the Lemurian Valley, survey the border region, and notify me and the local fortress of any weird events transpiring in that border town?"

"Lemurian Valley, My Lord?"

"Yes. I suspect that something is brewing in that border town. I have lost all communication with my lomers stationed there. I am uncertain if they have defected from me and joined Sylvius or if Sylvius has killed them to prevent me from learning of the events at the border."

Primus exhaled. "I can't trust any lomer but you for the time being till I ascertain the loyalty of the other lomers. Considering that many of my lomers hold Sylvius and his accomplishments in high regard, it may not be difficult for Sylvius to convince them to defect from my service and join him."

"But, Dorian..." Gwen sputtered when she realized that her new mission would prevent her from attending the anticipated rendezvous with Dorian during the Wintersend Festival.

Primus glanced pitifully at her.

"I am sorry, Gwen. I'm certain Dorian would miss you, but I have no other choice."

"But that's the price we pay for doing our duties." Gwen controlled her disappointment.

"Well, said. You might even give Sylvius a run for his money as our best lomer in history." Primus supported her.

"Sir, do you not feel betrayed by Sylvius?" Gwen inquired, unable to suppress Primus' continued admiration for Sylvius.

"Yes, it pains me to discover that one of my closest confidantes has betrayed me. However, his treachery cannot erase his past achievements. He has saved Sukra several times, and I respect him for all his actions undertaken for the welfare of Sukra."

"Sylvius is acting on his convictions, and I am acting on mine. We have just crossed paths where our goals for Sukra do not align anymore."

"Sylvius remains the finest lomer in Sukran history despite his treachery. He is no longer a lomer in my service, yet he is still the greatest there is." Primus looked glum as he explained.

Primus, who coordinated with most of the lomers in the king's service, deduced that Sylvius must have a nefarious plan for the border town. The town where his son had laid his life to save the Lemurian townsmen from a gruesome fate in the Mayan war.

Primus shook his head to regain control of his thoughts.

"Gwen, I intend to save the residents of the border town at any cost. Because I don't want Livian's sacrifice to be in vain."

Gwen nodded in understanding.

Primus' voice grew formal. "Lomer, fly to the Lemurian Valley and inspect the region for any unusual happenings. Particularly, keep an eye out for any Mayan activity, and inform me and the fortress as soon as you become aware of any strange occurrences in the border town."

"I shall not disappoint you, My King," Gwen responded with resolve.

Primus smiled at her dedication, "Take a day to recover from your wounds before beginning your quest." Primus waved his arms at the spirit coin.

"Good luck, Gwen." Valerian wished her, and the king's spirit sank into the coin and vanished.

Gwen exhaled deeply and collapsed on the ground in exhaustion. She had yet another lengthy travel to take, and it was unlikely that she would be able to rest in the following days.

Chapter 13

Once a spy, always a spy

For any ruler, a coup d'état is not a possibility; it's an eventuality.

I may not fear a dreaded warrior to oust me from ascending my rightful throne, but I would be circumspect about any spies affecting my chances to ascend the throne.

I can gather information on all dreaded warriors, but no one can discover the identity of a good spy until the last moment.

A good spy never fails, for his failure is most likely a deception.

My grandfather used to say that we would be fools if we were not prepared for a coup d'état at any moment.

And we are not fools.

-- From the journal of Prince Dorian Primus

Sylvius grimaced even as the chilly night wind howled into his face through the open tent flaps. The expansive greenery of the Althea forest greeted him as he waited for his new liege lord, who had gone hunting.

"Do you realize that he won't be pleased to learn that the crown is alerted of his plans?" Erasmus murmured from the couch that had been placed up within the tent.

"Yes," Sylvius said, tired, turning to face Erasmus, lying comfortably on the couch in the guest tent.

Sylvius gazed at the furnishings and decorations adorning the tent in the middle of a dense woodland. If the guest tent was so magnificent, he wondered how magnificent and opulent the royal tent of their master would be.

Erasmus sighed at their failure to imprison Gwen. He also started to miss his wife Korinna, who had retired to sleep in the tent set up for her. He squinted at Sylvius and proclaimed the obvious. "He will not be pleased with your failure."

"I'll take care of it, Erasmus." Sylvius exhaled.

"Damn sure you will, old man. It is not my neck on the line." Erasmus grinned at him innocently.

Sylvius nodded in response. He was still smarting over the ingenious way his student had thoroughly duped him at his own game.

He chuckled ruefully at the expected expression on the king's face when Valerian heard how Sylvius' student had fooled his old friend.

Granted, Valerian would have inferred the reason behind his betrayal and would even respect him for it, but it would not prevent Primus from slaying him without hesitation if Sylvius became a threat to his plans.

"Let the crows take you, Valerian!" He cursed Valerian furiously in his mind. He'd been forced to betray the only person he'd ever loved, and he knew Gwen would never forgive him.

"After everything I've done for you and Sukra, you've even stolen my daughter as well..." Sylvius

was glum as he waited for his master to return.

However, he was pleased with how Gwen had unearthed his treachery; rather than confronting him with a useless emotional response, she had used the information to deceive him thoroughly.

He was content with the notion that he had at least trained her to be one of the finest lomers in the realm, even though he was no longer one.

"My Lords..." The valet of their liege lord entered the guest tent and bowed to them. "Our lord has returned from hunting and will receive you shortly."

Sylvius looked up at the pokey-nosed valet for a moment before nodding. "Thank you for the update."

"My Lords, I have brought your dinner," the valet replied.

"It's about time..." Erasmus barked and rose from the couch.

With a slight nod, the valet turned to summon the maids lingering outside the tent.

Ten maids entered the tent carrying a variety of dishes, the aroma of which irresistibly tempted Erasmus.

The maids set up all the dishes on a huge round table and prepared to depart when the valet called out to one of the maids.

"Garcy, will you kindly wait?" The valet called out. "The remainder of you may depart."

Except for one skinny and timid maid, all the others departed the tent. Garcy approached the valet apprehensively.

The valet approached the maid and placed his hand on her waist. He faced the two visitors who were looking back at him.

"Let me introduce you to my wife, Garcy, who will attend to your needs."

"I shall depart to serve my lord. If you require my service for any reason, please have Garcy fetch me."

"Thank you," Sylvius answered as the valet departed the tent.

Garcy approached the dish-laden table with an apprehensive look to assist Erasmus, who was hovering about the table to seek out the menu for the night.

"Old Lomer, do you want to join me for what may be your last dinner?" Erasmus ridiculed his fellow countryman.

"I hope it's not my last, Erasmus. Anyway, I appreciate you asking," Sylvius gestured for Erasmus to continue.

Erasmus shrugged, wandered to the table, and glanced over the delicious-smelling dishes. "Hmm...a feast worthy of a king," Erasmus remarked.

Sylvius disregarded the remark, which he perceived as an attempt to lure him into partake in the dinner.

Erasmus returned to the couch with a platter containing a variety of dishes.

"Ahh...what a scrumptious roasted bear leg!" Erasmus attempted to infuriate the lomer.

"My Lord, if you're interested, we have salted and baked deer thighs available," Garcy was eager to serve their visitors.

"Why not? Please serve me some of the baked deer thighs," Erasmus responded with his mouth full.

Garcy poured bits of cooked deer leg into a dish and dashed to serve Erasmus.

The maid hurriedly selected a golden plate from the far end of the table, loaded it with roasted deer thigh, and almost sprinted to Erasmus before handing him the dish. Her boots made a faint noise as she rushed to serve her visitors.

The sound distracted Sylvius from his thoughts. Perhaps his failure was distracting him the entire time. He couldn't still accept the fact that his student had outwitted him.

Erasmus accepted the golden plate and tried the roasted deer thigh.

"Well, this baked thigh of a deer outshines the roasted bear by a mile," Erasmus declared.

Sylvius sighed and decided to stop Erasmus from pestering him to join his dinner.

"If you have time to ponder about anything other than your lovely dinner, have you given our legion marching orders to close shop and vacate the current location immediately?"

Erasmus nodded, concentrating on consuming the buck. "Yes...I've requested that they march south as you suggested."

"Yes...it would be foolish for our unlawful legion to linger in the same place where Gwen may bring additional king's forces to assault us."

His thoughts wandered to the noble lord he was about to meet. If he wanted to see the sunlight tomorrow, he had to play the game wisely. He rubbed the package in his makeshift cloak for reassurance.

When he heard the flaps of the tent open, Sylvius turned around, and a burly man entered. The man had a powerful and attractive face with a square jaw that would make any lady swoon. In addition, the woman would fawn over his big, firm muscles, plainly visible through his short doublet with a gold-threaded collar. He donned the finest silk pants available in the kingdom. A gray surcoat was draped over his shoulders, with a golden signet of a dragon, representing the House of Alectans, proudly embroidered into the surcoat.

Sylvius shuddered at the aura exuded by the man, whose very presence stifled the confidence of the other occupants of the tent. No surprise he was regarded as the most powerful of the kingdom's noble lords—Augustus Alectan.

As soon as Alectan and his valet entered the guest tent, Alectan's gaze furrowed. The noble lord surveyed the other occupants with a discerning gaze.

The noble lord's lips twisted into a tiny grin when he observed his commander, Erasmus, devouring a deer.

Soldiers and their appetite for delicious food.

His attention shifted to Garcy who rearranged the food on the table. Garcy was always Garcy-like: a timid and fearful maid who had been married to his valet for more than a decade. The noble lord took a closer look at the lone individual who appeared to have noticed his subtle entrance into the tent.

His smile faltered when he stared at the countenance of the seasoned old lomer, who was expressionless.

Well, he wouldn't have employed any lomer who used to be in Primus' service if the spy wasn't a lomer worth his salt.

He was playing a perilous game, and playing against their king, Valerian Primus, was risky.

"My Lord..." Sylvius knelt to the ground and bowed to his new master. He never bowed to the king, who regarded him like a friend. But he'd rolled the dice with this noble lord, and he had to be formal until he earned the trust of this noble lord, who was as deadly as Primus if not more.

Erasmus turned upon hearing Sylvius' voice and saw their master standing before him.

Erasmus placed his dish quickly on the couch and sprang to his feet. He knelt before his liege lord, and Garcy promptly followed suit.

"Rise..." Alectan said.

The trio climbed to their feet.

Alectan shifted his gaze from the emotionless lomer to his commander, who plainly had not been schooled to coach his demeanor.

"From the expression on your face, Erasmus, I infer that things didn't go as planned." Alectan frowned.

"No, My Lord," Erasmus responded, briefly glancing at Sylvius.

"Go on then...Let's find out what mishap you've gotten me into," Alectan responded in a tone that demonstrated his displeasure with his men's failure.

"Hmm...so, not only have you failed to detain the prince's girlfriend, but you have also allowed her to flee our legion camp and warn Primus about our illegal legion?" Alectan questioned his henchman with barely contained rage.

Erasmus nodded before directing his finger toward Sylvius. "I am uncertain as to how she escaped, My Lord. But I suspect this old lomer played a part."

Alectan's attention shifted to Sylvius, who continued to look back at him expressionlessly.

"So, after capturing her, you let the prince's girlfriend escape the legion camp."

"Yes, Lord...I had a hand in her escape from our legion camp." Sylvius responded without fear of the noble lord, who was not pleased with his service so far.

A stone spear suddenly erupted from the ground, pointing an inch from Sylvius' throat. Sylvius was stunned by the swiftness with which the noble lord had used his earth magic.

Alectan wasn't regarded by most as the most powerful noble lord for nothing.

Alectan was enraged when Sylvius smiled at him. "So, you continue to spy for Primus. You dare to gain my trust and betray me?" Alectan was infuriated that this lomer had duped him into allying with him.

"My Lord, why do you think I'm still working for Primus?" Sylvius inquired but stayed motionless to prevent Alectan from spearing him.

"You not only promised me your student who was the prince's lover, but you also let her flee with information about my legion to warn Primus," Alectan growled.

Sylvius was impressed by the noble lord's self-control despite Alectan's desire to execute him for his failure and, more crucially, his suspected treason.

He had definitely chosen the ideal noble lord to ascend the Sukran throne.

"I concur with both of your statements, My Lord," Sylvius answered.

Alectan remained silent for a few seconds after realizing that this lomer had tricked him.

Erasmus, who had remained silent until this point, drew his longsword in rage. "Shall I behead the traitor, My Lord?"

Sylvius halted Erasmus by raising his hand. "Stop right there, Erasmus."

Erasmus hesitated in surprise at Sylvius' confident tone. "If our lord had wanted me dead, he would have impaled me with his spear by now."

Erasmus grumbled at the veracity of Sylvius' claims.

"Lord Alectan has not yet slain me because he has yet to get an answer to one nagging question."

"Nagging question?"

Sylvius gave Erasmus a wink before shifting his attention to his master. "Lord Alectan has yet to ascertain why I chose to present myself to him after betraying him when I could have easily fled with Gwen. If I were a traitor, I wouldn't have come here to face Lord Alectan."

Alectan nodded, impressed by the lomer's disinterested demeanor, which exuded confidence despite being held at sword point.

This lomer was not a man who feared his death.

"Yes, lomer. After betraying me, I could not help but wonder why you did not flee with your student and, instead, dared to face me."

Sylvius shrugged his shoulders. "I've come to meet you because I haven't betrayed you."

"You haven't betrayed me?" Alectan frowned.

"Yes, Your Grace. In fact, I have served you a great service by assisting you in apprehending the bastard prince and preventing Lord Maleficus from claiming credit for Dorian's assassination during the upcoming Wintersend Festival in the capital," Sylvius answered.

Erasmus, the valet, and Garcy glanced at their master, unable to grasp why their lord had not yet killed the arrogant lomer.

No one had ever been so brazen and arrogant with their master and survived to tell the tale.

"A great service! You call your failure a great service?" Alectan bellowed.

"Yes, Your Grace."

"You have strayed from the actual aim of your mission, which was to frame Maleficus for raising unauthorized legions and inviting the Mayans to assault a high city." Alectan hissed.

"I have already fulfilled that responsibility. This new plan was only a bonus to convince Primus that Maleficus is the one plotting a coup."

"Can you enlighten me, lomer?" Alectan scowled at the lomer's arrogant demeanor.

"Indeed, My Lord," Sylvius responded. "Who are the two most significant obstacles to your accession to the Sukran throne?"

"King Primus and Noble Lord Maleficus," Alectan answered.

"Yes, Your Grace. I realize that you, like many noble lords, seek to eliminate the bastard prince to pave your road to the Sukran throne."

Sylvius continued as Alectan remained silent. "Even if you vanquish the prince, how will you keep Maleficus from challenging you for the throne?"

"Furthermore, you would be doing a favor to all the other noble lords vying for the Sukran crown by killing the bastard prince, only to be caught in the act and eliminated from the race to ascend the

throne."

Alectan pondered on the question quietly.

"Furthermore, do you believe you can kidnap the prince in the capital, which is the seat of power of King Primus?" Sylvius questioned. "You are undoubtedly aware of the stringent security procedures in place to protect the prince at all times after his attack in the royal gardens a few years ago."

"What alternatives do we have if we intend to slay the prince?" Alectan shrugged. "It has become an unspoken contest among all the noble lords to determine who can slay the prince despite the king's protection."

Alectan continued, "Whoever dispatches the prince with his powerful grandfather around will earn the right to be regarded as the most powerful of all noble lords and may receive support from other lords to ascend the throne for accomplishing such a feat."

"We have heard rumors of Maleficus establishing a spy among the highest echelons of lords tasked with killing the prince during the Wintersend Festival in the capital."

"True. We have to overtake Maleficus in capturing the prince in the capital."

"Hmm. Would the backing of others prevent Maleficus from vying for the Sukran throne if you eliminate the prince?" Sylvius asked.

"Definitely not. Maleficus is my greatest rival, and he will not rest until he ascends the throne, regardless of who kills Dorian."

"So, Lomer, the goal is to capture the prince. Not stall Maleficus."

"However, My Lord, how could you possibly approach Dorian in the capital, which is the seat of power for his incredibly powerful grandfather, King Valerian Primus?"

"It is not a job for the faint-hearted." Alectan shrugged.

"There is an ancient adage, My Lord. If you cannot meet someone, you must draw that person to meet you. If you can't reach Dorian inside the capital, you have to make him leave the capital." Sylvius grinned.

Alectan ridiculed Lomer's solution. "There is no chance. Primus will not send his grandson away from the capital, where Dorian has the best chance of survival."

"Not any longer..." Sylvius brushed aside Alectan's plan confidently.

Alectan saw the elderly Lomer's assured tone. *Was he again being tricked?*

"Explain!" Alectan demanded.

"Your Grace, I want you to clarify one misconception concerning Erasmus' report," Sylvius smirked with assurance. "Gwen didn't escape from our legion camp."

Sylvius proceeded. "Gwen was allowed to escape from our legion camp, but she has assumed she outwitted me and fled the camp."

"I wanted Gwen to escape our camp so she might inform Primus of my treason." Sylvius grinned.

Sylvius nodded in response to his master's inquisitive gaze. "Yes, Your Grace. I requested Erasmus to interrogate Gwen about where she was scheduled to meet Prince Dorian at the Wintersend Festival in the capital."

"I wanted her to recognize her betrayer as her mentor, myself."

"Why would you want to warn your student about your betrayal?"

"Because I wanted Gwen to believe she had escaped our legion's camp on her merit. Primus will not be convinced that she has outsmarted me until she feels she has."

"I chose Erasmus to divulge my identity in the face of her lengthy interrogation so she would not realize that I desired my treason to be exposed."

"What do you gain by disclosing your treachery to the crown? Primus may..." Alectan halted as the old lomer's revelation of the full plan began to sink in.

"Yes, Your Grace. Primus needs to think that all of his lomers have been compromised. If he learned that I was willing to kill my student, whom I had raised like a daughter, he would be sure I would do my utmost to convert the rest of his renowned lomers, who admire me for my past achievements."

"At a minimum, he would need some more time to determine the allegiance of his lomers." Sylvius winked mischievously. "Time is an entity in low supply with the Wintersend Festival slated to start in a week."

Alectan nodded in acknowledgment of this old lomer's brilliant coup. "Primus would have relied on his faithful lomers to watch for assassins assigned to kill Dorian during the festival."

"And without faith in his lomer's allegiance, Primus would assume that the capital had been transformed from a safe haven into a trap for his grandson. After all, at the Wintersend Festival, the capital will be the most congested city in the realm."

Sylvius nodded. "True. With the loss of the trust in his lomers, who are Primus' greatest source of power in the capital, I am certain Primus knows he cannot protect his grandson among the swarming masses of Ristan city during the Wintersend Festival."

Alectan smiled as he retracted the spear from Sylvius' throat. "Primus would be compelled to sneak the prince out of the capital city."

"However, Primus cannot accompany his grandson out of the capital since the king is required to preside over the Wintersend Festival, or it would fuel the notion that he is too old to fulfill his responsibilities as king."

"And when the prince ventures out from the capital's protection and his grandfather's magical strength, Dorian will be ripe for the plucking," Sylvius responded with a malicious grin.

"Your plan is excellent, but how do you incriminate Maleficus with this plan of yours?"

"I have planted suspicions in Gwen's mind that Noble Lord Maleficus is the mastermind behind this coup."

Alectan furrowed his brows.

"Because I knew Gwen was going to play a false maid while infiltrating your illegal legion, I assumed she'd attempt to loiter around the cleaner's tent to avoid attracting attention elsewhere in the legion camp."

"Therefore, I instructed the maids to spread rumors about the banquet planned by Noble Lord Maleficus to sow doubt in Gwen's mind."

"After being set up and captured while entering the command tent, I am convinced that Gwen would dispute the legitimacy of the forged paperwork incriminating Lord Ravesian as the true owner of the illegal legion."

"She knows I would never risk placing a document from my true master in the command tent

where I planned to capture her on the odd chance that she escapes," Sylvius added.

Alectan nodded his head in agreement.

"Obviously, your student would conclude that you are attempting to frame Lord Ravesian while believing the maid's rumor that Lord Maleficus owns the unlawful legion."

"Yes, Your Grace. She notified Korinna that she had identified Lord Maleficus as the leader of the unlawful legion."

Sylvius nodded. "Through this strategy, we prevent Maleficus from slaying the prince in the capital using his well-placed spy and sow doubt in Primus' mind over Maleficus' attempted coup when Gwen shares her suspicions with the king."

"And when we employ our initial plan to invite the Mayans to attack any of our high cities and frame Maleficus for allying with the Mayans, Primus will believe Maleficus is responsible for the coup since Primus is already predisposed to believe the worst of him." Alectan nodded, pleased with the strategy. "So, we prevent Maleficus from capturing Prince Dorian in the capital, blame Maleficus for the imminent Mayan invasion, brand the insane noble lord a traitor, and remove him from the race to the Sukran throne."

Meanwhile, a soldier entered the tent and bowed to Alectan.

"We have received a word from our spy in the capital, My Lord," the soldier mentioned.

"What is the message?"

"Prince Dorian has been secretly spirited away from the capital. Our spy has dispatched agents to follow the Prince and discover his whereabouts," the soldier announced.

Alectan turned and smiled broadly at Sylvius. "You have truly outfoxed one of the most cunning kings in our history."

"So, your student shared her suspicions with Primus, prompting the old king to smuggle Dorian from the capital just like you expected him to do."

"Should something befall the prince during the next few days, Primus would confront Maleficus in wrath over his grandson's death."

"Kill two birds with one stone by pitting your two deadliest foes against one another," Sylvius declared his plan.

Alectan burst out laughing at his new ally's wicked idea.

"You have set Maleficus up to face the wrath of the Sukran King's rage." Erasmus chipped in as realization dawned on him.

"However, if I know Primus well enough, he could yet have a few surprises in store for us." Sylvius frowned, wondering for the umpteenth time about possible countermeasures taken by the king.

It was too difficult to predict a devious man like Primus.

Alectan waved his hands at Sylvius. "We are unconcerned with the king's response to Maleficus."

Another guard burst into the tent and bowed to Alectan.

"My Lord...the most recent message from our spymaster in the capital states that he has verified reports of King Primus sneaking fifteen Dorians out from diverse locations of the capital."

A tense hush crept over the room's occupants before Alectan found his words. "Fifteen Dorians!"

"Yes, Your Grace. The spymaster has informed us that they were unable to differentiate the actual prince from the imposters who water cast themselves to resemble Dorian to deceive the spies and assassins of various noble lords."

"How will we ascertain the whereabouts of the original Dorian if there are fifteen of him wandering the kingdom?" Alectan snarled at the twist added to the tale by the king.

"We cannot abduct all fifteen Dorians without revealing our identity and intent to slay the prince."

Sylvius was stunned by the unexpected turn of events.

Expect Primus to alter the rules of the game as he sees fit.

Fifteen Dorians...Why fifteen Dorians? Why not ten or twenty? Primus never did anything without reason.

Sylvius snapped out of his reverie.

What have you done, Primus? How could you have stooped so low to do this?

"Your Grace, we cannot slay the prince anymore and frame Maleficus for the wicked deed with our original plan. For there are fifteen Dorians...fifteen." Sylvius emphasized the last word. "We have fifteen high cities, each ruled by a noble lord."

Alectan spun around to look at the lomer, who was straining to comprehend the king's plan. "What exactly do you mean, lomer?"

"Oh my goodness..." Sylvius exclaimed as he realized the king's ingenious toss of his dice to alter the game when pushed into a corner. "Primus is provoking all the noble lords to start a civil war."

"Civil war?" Alectan scowled in confusion. "Granted, sending fifteen Dorians makes it difficult to apprehend the prince. But why would smuggling fifteen Dorians from the capital force noble lords to battle each other?" Alectan halted mid-sentence upon understanding the king's nefarious plan.

"My Lord, could you please check with your contacts in Alectus city to determine whether Dorian has arrived and requested a meeting with you?" Sylvius inquired anxiously.

Alectan quickly flipped a coin and called his wife through a spirit sending.

A spirit of the kingdom's most beautiful woman sprang from the gold coin.

The woman had a beautiful, thin nose and pink lips, enhanced by her blonde hair and fish-like black eyes. The occupants of the room stared upon Lady Valentina Alectan, the definition of beauty.

"Darling," Alectan murmured to a woman who appeared flustered. "I wish to ask..." But Valentina's spirit interrupted her husband in mid-sentence.

"I have been trying to get in touch with you for so long!" Valentina hissed angrily at her spouse.

Alectan frowned at his wife's demeanor.

"Primus has sent his grandson, Dorian, to our city with a written order to protect Dorian from anybody wishing the prince harm if we are to prove worthy of succeeding him to the throne." Valentina snarled.

"What!" Alectan was astounded by the king's message.

Valentina kept her seething emotions under control. "Primus has set in motion a plan to make our city of Alectus the focal point of the other noble lords' attention."

"No, My Lady..." Sylvius approached the spirit and bowed before it. "Primus has dispatched a Dorian to each of the high cities with orders to guard the prince at all costs,"

"Oh, my God," Valentina exclaimed. "Primus has started the civil war."

Sylvius remained silent in deep contemplation.

By the Great One...Primus was punishing him for deserting his service by sparking the same civil war he was attempting to avert at all costs. Sylvius' shoulders sagged in response to the king's masterstroke.

"Does our city have the real Dorian?" Alectan inquired.

"No...I managed to ascertain that he was an impostor." Valentina sighed.

"What if the noble lords forged a truce and agreed not to attack each other in a bid to hurt the Dorian in their possession?" Erasmus asked out loud.

"Then, Primus triumphs by compelling the noble lords to perform his duty of guarding the real Dorian while we all lose," Sylvius answered.

"Lose?" Erasmus frowned.

Alectan nodded in agreement. "True. Then, all the noble lords would establish that they are worthy of ascending the throne, bringing us back to square one, where the noble lords would bicker amongst themselves."

"Most greedy but foolish noble lords would consider this an opportunity to prove themselves worthy of the Sukran throne." Sylvius sighed.

Erasmus rubbed his chin thoughtfully. "Hmmm. What if we inform all the noble lords that an impostor is acting as Dorian in our city? If each noble lord reveals whether or not they possess the true Dorian, the rest of the noble lords won't need to squabble and fight, right?"

Sylvius shook his head. "None of the noble lords will divulge the truth. They'd be scared of the rest of the noble lords banding together and storming their city to slay the original Dorian, rendering him unworthy of the throne," Sylvius replied as he realized the king knew more about his noble lords than they did about themselves.

"Therefore, every noble lord would be compelled to deny having the real Dorian. None of the noble lords would trust the other noble lords even if they stated the truth that an impostor was in their city." Valentina nodded with a sigh.

"The king has once again had the last laugh. He has tied the hands of each of the noble lords by forcing them to focus on protecting the Dorian sent to their city rather than even considering attacking the Dorians in other high cities and making the other noble lords unworthy of ascending the Sukran throne for not possessing the talent to protect the prince."

Erasmus gasped in disbelief. "The king has forced the noble lords hellbent on murdering Dorian to back down and guard the charge assigned to them, lest they be found unworthy of the Sukran throne."

"Yes...The old man has altered the rules of the game yet again." Alectan growled before he gathered his composure and addressed his wife's spirit.

"Valentina, take personal responsibility for Dorian's safety until I return," Alectan instructed his wife.

Valentina nodded with a sigh and left the meeting. Her spirit eventually returned to the coin.

Alectan heaved a sigh as a gloomy silence crept upon the tent. "Garcy, bring me some wine to improve my disposition."

Garcy nodded and poured ale into a golden cup. She was so anxious to serve her lord that she

practically raced to offer him the cup.

"Change the game's rules like Primus," Sylvius pondered. *But could he change the rules of the game without implicating Lord Alectan in Dorian's murder?*

"Cheers to Primus for once again schooling us all in the art of politics.

I acknowledge that he is, in fact, a maestro of intrigue and politics." Alectan swore and was ready to sip his ale when Sylvius approached Alectan and snatched his ale glass.

"My Lord, I wouldn't drink that ale." Sylvius turned to gaze at his master. "After all, your ale is poisoned."

He abruptly threw the contents of Alectan's glass of ale on Garcy's chest, who recoiled in shock.

Garcy shrieked in agony as the ale began to burn through her shirt and into her flesh.

"It's poison!" Erasmus gasped.

Suddenly, Garcy's features began to change. The slim and beautiful woman was transformed into a middle-aged woman with a humble appearance. The transition left the other occupants of the room utterly astounded. zz

Sylvius willed two earth-cast hands to rise from the ground and restrain the maid before she could react. He raised a spear made of stone and aimed it at the throat of the imposter.

"What?! Garcy...no..." The valet stammered in disbelief.

Alectan wasted no time in commanding his earth elemental to detain the valet, who stared in astonishment at his alleged wife. A stone spear rose from the ground and pointed at the valet's throat.

"Who are you?" The valet questioned the irate impersonator.

The impostor was anguishing from the poison scorching her chest.

"A spy of Noble Lord Maleficus, if I am not mistaken," Sylvius responded.

The imposter neither refuted nor confirmed his claim.

"Guards..." Erasmus yelled out as he stood in front of Alectan and attempted to shield him from more assailants.

Ten guards entered the tent and set up guard around their noble lord.

Alectan regarded the imposter before addressing Sylvius. "Lomer, how did you determine that Garcy was an impostor?"

"It's simple, My Lord. She arduously attempted to depict herself as a maid. Unfortunately, she exceeded expectations in her portrayal of a maid."

"She committed several glaring errors. None greater than her selection of boots," Sylvius responded while he paced around the imposter in a circle.

"Boots?" Alectan questioned in surprise.

"Yes, Your Grace. No true maid will wear heavy boots when moving about the premises to avoid drawing attention to herself. They all favor silent, lightweight footwear that does not make any sound. When I noticed this maid impersonating an anxious lady to perfection and raced to bring Erasmus a plate with the roasted leg of deer, I heard the sound of her boots, which verified that she was not, in fact, a maid, as I had feared."

Sylvius knelt to the impostor's restrained legs and removed a thin knife from her boot's heel. "Anyone could notice this maid's deceit if he is familiar with the sound made by a boot concealing

a knife."

Erasmus gazed at the knife and then turned to examine the dish of food that the imposter had served earlier.

"Did she also poison the meal she served me?" Erasmus frantically caressed his throat.

Sylvius casually waved his hands. "No, she didn't. She would not have wished to reveal her false identity until she was sure she had poisoned Lord Alectan. So, she would not have poisoned you until she had poisoned Lord Alectan."

Alectan nodded in approval at lomer's explanation. "Spoken like a man who had plied the same trade elsewhere."

Sylvius shrugged. "In most cases, the primary responsibility of a spy is not merely to gather information but also to act on it...Therefore, most spies also ply the trade of an assassin."

"Where is my Garcy?" The valet sobbed.

Everyone ignored the valet before Erasmus found his voice. "How did you discover this imposter is a spy for Noble Lord Maleficus rather than any other noble lord?"

"I have been noticing that Maleficus was tailing us with every move. I had long believed that there was a spy in Lord Alectan's inner circle, so I had instructed my men to spy on your advisors. I spied on even your valet, who turned out to be innocent."

"However, I did not anticipate that your valet was so dumb as not to recognize that this impostor had long since murdered his wife and taken her place," Sylvius mentioned.

Erasmus approached the impostor and stabbed her in the thigh with his sword. "It's your turn to talk, spy."

The imposter cried in agony but declined to respond to the swordsman. "Is she a slave?"

"No..." Alectan answered. "No one is permitted to enter my premises with any ornament adorning their bodies. She would have been caught red-handed if she had any jewelry used to bind and imprison her spirit."

Erasmus twisted the plunging blade, threatening the impostor to speak, but she suppressed her agony and refused to respond.

Sylvius saw that one of the maid's buttons on her waist appeared different from the others. "There is only one way to determine who her actual master is." Sylvius smiled as he approached her and gently touched the peculiar-looking button. The entire visage of the impostor changed as she looked back at him in surprise.

"No, please," implored the fake.

With a flick of his hands, Sylvius removed the button from her tunic and tossed it to the ground.

"Hasten my message to thy master," Sylvius declared.

After a few moments, a spirit coalesced and rose from the button.

The spirit portrayed a man with narrow cheekbones and a lean, scary visage that surveyed the surrounding area. With a malicious smirk on his thin lips, he surveyed his surroundings with dark gray eyes. Blonde, wavy hair swept over his lean, bony face as he turned to face Alectan.

He shifted his gaze to savor the chill air.

"My Lord...Please, save me..." the impostor croaked, but the spirit paid her no heed.

"Hmm...where exactly are we?" The spirit inquired.

"Yet another unsuccessful attempt to kill me, Maleficus." Alectan chastised his adversary's spirit.

"Hey! That's unfair. My spy was able to get rather close to you this time. Perhaps they might get lucky and be successful the next time," Maleficus snorted.

Erasmus snarled and attacked the spirit with his sword, but the sword harmlessly plunged through Maleficus' torso. "Erasmus, I don't like looking at a failure like you. You failed by allowing your true master, Prince Livian, to perish in the First Mayan War."

"I will shatter every one of your bones and drink your blood in retaliation for what you did to Livian. I know that you orchestrated the Mayan war." Erasmus snarled.

Maleficus reprimanded the swordsman for his stupid attempt to harm his spirit using a sword. "Unfortunately for you, no one can harm another spirit during a spirit sending."

Maleficus switched his attention to Alectan. "It appears that you have not yet leashed this dumb swordsman."

"So, you are hell-bent on slaying Prince Dorian no matter the cost." Alectan sighed at the tenacity of his rival.

"I will hunt that timid prince and crush him with my fist while I punish the old king, making him watch his grandson's life drain in front of him," Maleficus bellowed. "Then I shall assume my rightful place on the Sukran throne."

Meanwhile, Sylvius remained silent in contemplation.

Change the rules of the game. But how can the rules of a game be altered?

Yes...

Change the cards that were dealt, and you can alter the game's rules.

He had found a means to change the cards that were dealt by the king—Lord Maleficus.

Sylvius smirked wistfully. "You must be joking, Lord Maleficus. I know you're insane, but I don't expect you're insane enough to confront the most powerful man in the realm."

Maleficus tilted his head to view the source of the voice. "Ahh...The notorious rodent of Primus...so, you have migrated from Primus' service to the Alectans."

Sylvius shrugged. "One must always do what one is capable of doing."

"You are no longer safeguarded by the powerful shadow of Primus. Perhaps it's time for me to teach you a lesson or two for interfering too much with my affairs."

"Well, I'm a hard man to track, Lord Maleficus. But I am certain you would not expend the efforts to abduct an inconsequential rodent like myself when you have bigger fish to fry."

"Killing Dorian would be a piece of cake. I've already made plans to remove Dorian from the picture at the capital's Wintersend celebration."

It was time to reel in the big fish and alter the cards dealt by King Primus.

Sylvius scoffed at Maleficus. "True...It would have been a piece of cake for you to kill Dorian in the capital. But unfortunately, your information has become obsolete and is no longer useful. I have altered the equation in the capital, rendering your preparations completely worthless."

Maleficus frowned at the lomer while Sylvius proceeded in a sarcastic tone. "If your spies were any good, you would have known by now that Dorian was smuggled out of the capital several hours ago."

"What! You are definitely lying." Maleficus barked before he briefly went back to converse with

someone in his employ.

They observed the spirit's countenance lose all composure upon discovering that his carefully orchestrated preparations for the Wintersend Festival were rendered worthless.

"Lord Maleficus, perhaps you should teach your spies a lesson or two before you attempt to school me for meddling in your affairs." Sylvius ridiculed.

Maleficus' spirit turned to glare at Sylvius, who continued to provoke the noble lord.

"Had you been vigilant in evaluating the competence of your spies, you would not be surprised to discover Dorian descending on your city with a message from the king?"

"What!" Maleficus was stunned by the unexpected turn of events. "Is Dorian visiting my city?" Maleficus smiled, believing that the old king had made his task of killing the prince simpler.

"Do not be avaricious or impetuous, Lord Maleficus. Dorian is arriving with protection and instructions from the king that you defend him from any noble lord who attempts an assassination."

Maleficus shrugged. "Accidents do happen. I can't babysit the prince, can I?" he inquired with a wicked smirk.

"Well, you are a fool to disregard the contents of the king's message, which I am certain would tell you to defend Dorian from the other noble lords to prove that you are worthy to ascend the throne."

Maleficus frowned. "Perhaps I shall deny that Dorian has arrived in my city and execute him at my leisure."

"You would not only reveal yourself unworthy of the crown but also a fool to the rest of the noble lords," Sylvius responded indifferently. "In any case, unlike your useless spies, the spies of the other noble lords would have notified their noble lords of Dorian's arrival in your city."

Maleficus hissed and soared toward Sylvius in rage at being insulted, but the lomer persisted in taunting the noble lord.

"You were right, Lord Maleficus, that no one can hurt another spirit during a spirit sending. However, you have also forgotten that your spirit is only an observer and cannot affect the physical realm. Therefore, you cannot harm us with anything but your gruesome growls into making us throw up the dinner we had earlier."

Maleficus' anger increased beyond the limit after he was humiliated by a lowly spy. "You dare belittle me."

"You are really a fool, Maleficus. Primus has dispatched Dorians to each of the fifteen high cities and tasked its lords with protecting Prince Dorian to demonstrate their competence to ascend the throne."

"What!" Maleficus was stunned upon hearing the news.

"Unlike a fool like you, who boasts that he can assassinate princes in the cities of other noble lords, Lord Alecan has attempted to convene a meeting with the noble lords to secure a truce against harming Dorian in another lord's city."

"We have chosen to safeguard Dorian and prove our worthiness to ascend the throne in the future." Sylvius scoffed as he cast a glance about. "We do not dislike Prince Dorian as much as you do...We just detest the idea of him assuming the throne."

It was time to plant additional doubts in the noble lord's mind frothing at the incompetence of his spies.

"Therefore, we have all agreed to spare Dorian his life until after the Wintersend Festival. But, unfortunately for you, our spies have informed us that the prince has called a senate meeting after the Wintersend Festival to petition for the abolition of slavery in Sukra."

"What! You are jesting." Maleficus was so surprised by the latest revelation that it moderated his anger somewhat.

Sylvius shrugged his shoulders. "Suit yourselves. Ultimately, you stand to lose the most if slavery is abolished, as you employ slaves in your most crucial positions as you can control and trust them implicitly not to backstab you. Furthermore, you would lose a lot of revenue considering your city exports the most slaves each year."

"You're lying, Lomer. If Dorian had planned such a plot, my lomers would have alerted me." Maleficus objected, albeit a bit unsure.

"Well, we are all aware of your spies' proficiency. They are the last to know the latest developments around Prince Dorian that we informed you about."

"Impostor?" Maleficus had a frown. "How would you know that the Dorian you brought to my city is not the true prince?"

"We have the greatest spies in your inner circle since you are Lord Alectan's chief rival. It may be time to check with your contacts to verify our claims."

Maleficus stayed silent for a minute as he used spirit casting to contact his wife in Maleficus city, his capital.

Sylvius winked at an amazed Alectan, who understood the old lomer's plan to make the insane Noble Lord Maleficus mistrust everyone in his inner circle. Maleficus was a skeptical and mistrustful individual at the best of times, but now, due to Sylvius' well-crafted lie, he might even suspect his wife.

Remove the credibility of his spies with one truth and then sow doubt by telling more lies. With no more trust in his spies, Maleficus would have no means to ignore his lie as nothing but falsehoods with certainty.

After a few minutes of extended silence, Maleficus returned to stare at Sylvius with hatred and uncertainty. "Lomer, you have once again foiled all my plans...I am beginning to dislike you as much as Primus."

Time to provoke the noble lord into action and alter the game rules established by Primus.

"What else can you do, My Lord, but brag? Due to Primus' masterstroke, no one knows where the real Prince Dorian is. He has once again deceived us all." Sylvius laughed at himself and praised the king to annoy Maleficus further.

"I will not be duped by Primus once more." Maleficus snarled.

Sylvius brushed aside the crazy lord's claim with contempt. "What option do you have now, Lord Maleficus? The only way to defeat Primus in this game is to kill the real Dorian, but without knowing his whereabouts, the only choice is to kill all the Dorians from all the high cities."

Maleficus frowned at the lomer as Sylvius proceeded in a somber tone. "No noble lord possesses the power and influence to assault all the high cities and kill all the Dorians. In fact, I doubt that even Primus could accomplish this feat."

"The job of simultaneously invading all the high cities may seem insurmountable to you, Primus, and even Alectan, but not to me," Maleficus hissed.

A momentary smile appeared on Sylvius' lips before being replaced with a hint of bewilderment.

"Not at all possible, Lord Maleficus. You can no longer send slaves to slay Dorian in all the high cities, as the noble lords of each high city would personally guard the Dorian within their city. No noble lord would want to be disgraced and deemed unfit to claim the kingdom if they allowed the Dorian in their charge to be slaughtered in their city."

"I do not require slaves to murder those noble lords," Maleficus scoffed.

"Well, you can't also slaughter the noble lords during this fight, as doing so would brand you a tyrant and cause all the high cities to unite against you."

Sylvius cocked his head and gave an evil smile. "Can you defend yourself against the united power of the entire Sukran kingdom if you are labeled insane and a traitor?"

Maleficus hesitatingly pondered the veracity of the knowledgeable lomer's statements. *The lomer may be irksome, but he was no fool. He was the kingdom's best lomer.*

"We have no choice but to acknowledge that King Valerian Primus has tricked us all when we were so close to ousting the Primus bloodline from the Sukran throne," Sylvius declared.

Maleficus hissed in denial. "I'm not going to let that old fool get the final laugh. I'll show you lomer that I'm worthy of the Sukran throne by doing the impossible. I shall kill Dorian before the end of the Wintersend Festival."

Sylvius regarded Alectan closely, who recognized his cue, albeit with some reluctance.

Alectan approached the spirit of Maleficus. "Maleficus, I will not allow you to murder Dorian. Dorian may be an obstacle to my ascension to the throne, but he is my best friend's son. I will not allow you to dishonor my friend's memory by murdering Dorian."

"Not allow me! Do you dare to challenge me by claiming that you will avert Dorian's murder at my hands?" Maleficus snarled.

"Yes...I will defend Dorian against you until the Wintersend celebration."

Maleficus clapped enthusiastically. "Now we are talking. Two genuine throne contenders on opposing sides of the coin. I accept the challenge, Alectan."

Maleficus turned to scowl fiercely at Sylvius. "Lomer, after I have slain Dorian and won this challenge, you shall face my vengeance."

Sylvius cocked his head and grinned at the enormously strong noble lord, who was also outrageously mad. Within a day, he had gained yet another formidable foe.

"I am waiting!"

Sylvius summoned his earth elemental and broke the button assisting Maleficus with the spirit transmission.

Maleficus' spirit evaporated into thin air when the spirit of the noble lord was expelled from their presence.

Tense silence pervaded the room as Sylvius approached the confined imposter acting as Garcy.

He lightly touched the spy's cheeks with a broad smile. "You've assisted me in turning the tables on Primus."

His smile faltered and broke the edge of his stone spear pointing at the spy's throat. He used the spear to slit the spy's throat.

He waved his hands, and the stone spear in his palms and the earth-cast hands disintegrated into

dust. Blood spilled from her throat as she fell to the ground. The spy struggled for a few seconds before succumbing to her fate.

Sylvius switched his attention to Alectan. "I protected you from Maleficus' spy, My Lord. However, it is up to you to decide how to punish your foolhardy valet."

Alectan commanded his earth-cast hands to drag his valet over. Alectan drew his dagger from its sheath at his hip and used it to lift the weeping man's face so he could study it.

"My Lord, please have mercy on me...I'm not a traitor..."

"Yes, you lack the courage to be a traitor. You are simply a moron for not realizing you were living with a fake woman posing as your wife."

Alectan tapped the flat part of the dagger on his cheeks. "I can accept even a traitor, but I cannot bear the scent of an idiot in any circumstance."

"You are expelled from my city. You shall be executed on the spot if you ever so much as enter my city," Alectan declared.

"Thank you, My Lord..." The valet bowed humbly before his master's kind heart.

"Remove this idiot from my presence," Alectan commanded his guards.

The soldiers quickly dragged the valet out of the tent.

Alectan tucked his dagger away before turning to give the lomer a long, silent look.

"Do you realize what you've begun today, Lomer?"

Sylvius kept his silence.

"For God's sake, you have started the bloody civil war." Alectan hissed at the old lomer.

"No, Lord..." With a shake of his head, Sylvius refused. "Primus was the one who initiated the bloody civil war."

"No...Primus just wanted the noble lords to back down from killing his grandson. But you have provoked Maleficus, the wildest of all the noble lords, to slaughter every Dorian in every high city."

"My Lord, Primus established the rules of the game because he can no longer rely on his lomers. Now, I have altered the rules of the game by unleashing a lunatic such as Maleficus into the mix."

"Your action to goad Maleficus will result in the noble lords attacking each other." Alectan hissed.

"No, Your Grace. Even if I had not provoked Maleficus, Primus would have initiated a civil war as a punishment for my betrayal and defection from him," Sylvius answered.

"What do you mean? Why would Primus punish you by starting a civil war?" Alectan questioned in shock.

"My Lord, Primus would have realized that I have betrayed him and joined you to prevent the civil war from destroying Sukra," Sylvius sighed.

"Therefore, he has decided to start a civil war to punish me for betraying him and safeguard his grandson without the assistance of his lomers, whom he can no longer trust."

Alectan shook his head. "Primus didn't aspire to win this game as long as the noble lords remained at peace with one another. He just delayed the noble lords from seeking Dorian's life. But he can't expect the noble lords to protect Dorian forever."

"True...Which is why Primus would have tasked the soldiers sent to accompany a water caster imposing as Dorian in one of the high cities to be killed after the Wintersend Festival."

Alectan was stunned by the lomer's understanding of the king's devious plan. "He wouldn't!" Alectan gasped.

"All Primus must do is murder a single Dorian in a high city. That noble lord would have no choice but to attack other cities and kill the Dorians there, lest the others are deemed worthy of the throne while he was proven unworthy." Alectan contemplated out loud.

"Yes. The noble lords may agree to a truce if each lord ends the game as a worthy successor to the throne, but as soon as one impostor posing as Dorian is murdered, civil war will erupt," Sylvius stated.

"And I am convinced Primus would have ordered his guards escorting the fake Dorian to the cities of Alectus and Maleficus to eliminate their respective impostors once the Wintersend Festival concluded. After all, you two are the noble lords with the power and will to fight the others when cornered."

Alectan nodded in agreement about the king's brilliant and devious plan. "And Primus would use the time between now and the Wintersend celebration to reclaim control of his lomers and better guard his grandson."

"Precisely the king's plan. So, I provoked Maleficus into action so that he would murder all of the Dorian sent to various high cities."

Alectan frowned. "Then why did you urge me to accept Maleficus' challenge to defend Dorian?"

"I forced you to accept the challenge so that we might provoke Maleficus into expending his best to kill all the Dorians in all the high cities. He wants to prove that he is more powerful than you by winning this challenge."

"Maleficus would view this as an opportunity, as Primus will not be able to defend Dorian in the high cities, remaining in the capital and presiding over the Wintersend celebration." Sylvius outlined his plan to counter the king's plan.

"Yet, I cannot win this challenge since I do not know in which high city the original Dorian is protected. If Maleficus succeeds in killing every Dorian in every high city, I will lose the challenge."

"You will not lose this game, My Lord. You are in a win-win position," Sylvius answered.

"Explain..." Alectan leaned forward, intrigued.

"It is unnecessary to safeguard the impostor Dorians in all high cities. All we need to do is defend the original Dorian, who is easy to identify." Sylvius smiled wittingly.

"Inform all the other noble lords that Maleficus is hell-bent on killing the Dorians in their cities. They may join your cause if Maleficus keeps his word and murders all the Dorians, making them unworthy to ascend the Sukran throne."

"My Lord, Even if you prevail in this challenge with Maleficus, you will only gain pride. Will your pride and honor assist you in ascending to the throne? How do you anticipate Primus to react if Maleficus kills the original Dorian during his quest to eliminate all the Dorians?"

"Primus has communicated in his message that the noble lord who safeguards the Dorian in his custody is deserving of the throne."

"But must one be worthy to take the throne? Has every member of the House of Primus been worthy of the throne?"

"Moreover, it is irrelevant who Primus believes is worthy. None of the other noble lords will step

aside and allow Primus' choice to ascend to the throne. If they had obeyed Primus' orders, they would have welcomed Dorian as their new ruler. But hardly a single noble lord can tolerate the prospect of Dorian sitting on the Sukra throne."

"True." Alectan nodded his head in agreement.

"How do you anticipate Primus to react if Maleficus kills the real Dorian?"

"Primus would be beyond enraged if the last scion of the House of Primus were murdered. Primus would stop caring about his reign and try to assassinate Maleficus and his entire household to exact vengeance," Alectan responded after a moment of contemplation.

"Try to avenge?" Sylvius chuckled. "No, Your Grace. I have witnessed Primus in close proximity. Primus is the most powerful man in our realm, notwithstanding his age. He will smother the entire Maleficus city in rage."

"Dare I assert that Primus is more powerful than all the noble lords combined?" Sylvius noted. Alectan's brows furrowed.

"However bitter it may seem, My Lord, it is the truth. I'm sure you agree deep down because none of the noble lords have opted to oppose Primus openly."

"Everyone is only attempting to prevent Dorian from attaining the throne so they may take over following Primus' passing. Despite his old age, nobody is attempting to dethrone Primus, who is simply too strong."

"True, no rational man would directly oppose Primus." Alectan accepted, but it left a bad taste in his mouth.

"No rational man would oppose Primus, but Maleficus is not rational," Sylvius smirked.

"Even if Maleficus stupidly murders the real Dorian, he is a fool to think he can withstand Primus' wrath," Sylvius answered. "Besides, every noble lord would try to discredit Maleficus by proving that he is unworthy of the crown."

"But how can we discredit Maleficus?"

Sylvius opened his arms wide. "By adhering to our original plan, we will invite the Mayans to assault a high city and frame Maleficus as the perpetrator in order to assassinate Dorian in that high city."

"We may portray Maleficus as the mastermind behind the Mayan invasion, who allied with our foes to assault a city where the real Dorian was present."

Alectan laughed despite himself. "It wouldn't be difficult to disgrace Maleficus and label him a traitor for siding with the enemies."

"True. If all the noble lords discovered that Maleficus was responsible for the death of the Dorian under their custody, they would attempt to prevent him from ascending to the throne. Maleficus is not as powerful as Primus. Thus, the newly anointed king can unite the strength of the noble lords to overcome Maleficus."

The plan devised by the lomer left Alectan pleased. He had thought Primus had tricked them once more. But this old lomer was clever enough to turn the trap against Primus.

"Sylvius, you certainly deserve the widespread acclaim you have received as the finest lomer in our history." Alectan complimented his new lomer.

"So, I don't win anything but the challenge if I protect Dorian from Maleficus." Alectan

contemplated.

"No, your lord. You will have the best outcome if you protect Dorian from Maleficus," Sylvius responded.

"Explain."

"Even if we disgrace Maleficus for allying with our enemies to assassinate Prince Dorian and prevent Maleficus from ascending the throne, it won't help you ascend the throne, My Lord."

"This scenario just aids us in preventing your greatest rival from succeeding to the throne according to our original plan," Sylvius noted.

"Not exactly true. If Maleficus is eliminated from the throne, I can persuade all the other noble lords to choose me, as I am regarded as the second-most-powerful Sukran after Primus."

"Yes, Your Grace. You may ascend the throne, but you won't be able to prevent other avaricious noble lords from coveting your throne. That's a threat that comes with the job."

"The family of Primus has always been blessed with kings who were more powerful than all the noble lords put together," Sylvius explained. "You might not enjoy stability even if you ascend the throne."

"True, no one is as powerful as the scions of the House of Primus." Alectan shrugged. "The new king must exercise extreme caution for a few years as he consolidates his authority over the kingdom. No noble lord would covet the throne after the new king consolidates authority and places his trustworthy men in the most critical posts throughout the realm."

"But what if you had the power to keep the noble lords at bay until you secure your reign in the first few years?" Sylvius inquired. "The power known as Valerian Primus."

Alectan was stunned by the lomer's answer.

"Why would Primus defend me against other noble lords? He despises me as much as he despises Maleficus for attempting to ascend the Sukran throne?" Alectan responded.

"True...But what if we could compel Primus to safeguard you against all noble lords?" Sylvius inquired, a nasty smirk on his face.

"Ahh...slavery once more. You want me to enslave the spirit of Valerian Primus and make him dance to my tunes." Alectan understood the lomer's plan. "No one can enslave a stronger spirit than himself. And it is common knowledge that Primus is the most potent spirit in the realm." Alectan rejected Sylvius' suggestion.

"You have misunderstood me, My Lord. I am not suggesting you enslave Primus, who is more powerful than you and every other noble lord combined. You must rescue Dorian and enslave him to your will!" Sylvius replied with excitement.

"All the noble lords are naively attempting to eliminate Dorian because they do not comprehend what a true miracle he is. Why slaughter your golden goose when you can use it to produce more golden eggs?" Sylvius answered.

The room was filled with stunned silence until Alectan shook his head. "No, it won't work. Primus would threaten to kill me and my entire household if I do not free his grandson."

"Yes, he would attempt to intimidate you into freeing Dorian. However, you may prevent Primus from threatening you if you order the enslaved prince to kill himself if his grandfather threatens you." Sylvius grinned.

"If Primus realizes that Dorian would kill himself even if Primus threatened you, we can leash Primus and make the king dance to your tunes."

A stunned silence greeted the lomer's revelation of his actual plan.

"You can bargain with Primus that Dorian will be named a noble lord and permitted to sire sons a few years after Primus' demise to ensure the continuing existence of the House of Primus. In exchange, we can compel Primus to crown you king and anoint you as his successor."

Alectan barked in admiration of the lomer's plan. "And the other noble lords would be terrified of plotting against me because we might force Primus to use his powerful magic to protect me."

"We can even convert Primus into an assassin who will kill any noble lord who plots against your reign." Sylvius pointed out excitedly, thrilled with his plan. "No noble lord would dare scheme for your throne lest they be visited by the most formidable assassin who has ever roamed this kingdom."

"I can use the time we gained until Primus' demise to consolidate my reign." Alectan also nodded enthusiastically. "All I must do is ensure Dorian's safety from other noble lords until Primus meets his end in old age."

Sylvius spread his arms wide. "Yes, Your Grace. My ultimate goal is to prevent the impending civil war in Sukra. If we succeed in enslaving the prince, we can prevent the civil war, and you will ascend to rule the Sukran kingdom unopposed." Sylvius revealed his most brilliant scheme to date.

Alectan glanced at Sylvius after a long silence, during which he savored a real and feasible plan to claim the throne. "We cannot enslave Prince Dorian if we cannot locate him in the first place. So, how do we determine the high city where the true Dorian will be sent to be protected?"

"True, My Lord." Sylvius nodded and paced around the room. He needed to locate Dorian for his master plan to succeed.

It was a touch of good fortune that Dorian lacked water casting and was unable to assume a new persona and flee the capital city. If he possessed water magic, Primus would not have been forced to use duplicate Dorians to prevent the spies from locating the real Dorian.

Sylvius shook his head to clear his thoughts.

Consider what you would do if you were Primus, and you couldn't rely on any of your spies.

Contrary to the noble lord's opinion, Primus would never send the real Dorian to the most powerful lords in the realm who might betray the king, imprison his grandson, and threaten Primus to crown them in exchange.

No, Primus wouldn't hand over Dorian to a noble lord who is greedy for the throne.

Yet, were there any noble lords in Sukra who did not seek the throne?

There are three such noble lords: Ravesian, Titus, and Marcian.

Sylvius directed his gaze toward Lord Alectan. "My Lord, please have your spies bring me information about any known associates of the king now residing in Ravesia, Titus, and Marcia."

He turned to face Erasmus with a nod. "Erasmus, can you collect the details from our spies in those cities which Sylvius has requested?"

Erasmus nodded and departed to liaise with Alectan's lomers.

Meanwhile, Alectan turned to see Sylvius pacing in thought.

"How have you excluded Maleficus from your list of places where the real Dorian might have been sent?" Alectan inquired.

"Maleficus didn't refute my claim that Primus dispatched an imposter dressed as Dorian to the

city. Lady Valentina has confirmed that the Dorian dispatched to your city is likewise an impostor.”

“Primus would not send his grandson to be safeguarded by the most powerful lords vying for his throne.”

“Since you and Maleficus would assume that Dorian was sent to the next powerful group of noble lords, I am confident that Primus would have sent Dorian to a city ruled by a noble lord not vying for the throne, but powerful enough to halt you temporarily.”

“Makes sense. Ravesian is a noble fool who feels it is his highest duty to serve the crown. Titus and Marcian lack the clout necessary to vie for the crown.”

After a little pause, Erasmus returned with a scroll and began to read aloud.

“General Giles Tamican, commander of all crown legions, is in the Ravesian city, Lomer,” Erasmus read aloud.

“Commander Logan Nelarius...” Erasmus hesitated with a knot in his throat before continuing, “Logan Nelarius, commander of the Prime Crown legion, is currently in Titus city.”

“General Silias Barcian, ex-general of the crown legions and Primus’ close friend, is in Marcian city for the Wintersend Festival.”

Alectan mused aloud as Sylvius continued to ponder. “Of the three noble lords, Ravesian is the apparent choice, but Primus would want the noble lords to predict Ravesian as the most obvious choice for protecting Dorian. Ravesian is the only noble lord powerful enough to fend off the other noble lords, yet is not avaricious for the crown.”

Sylvius nodded in accord.

“Lord Bearian Titus is more of a scholar than a fighter, so we can rule him out. I am aware that Logan is the second-best swordsman in this country after Erasmus, but I doubt that Primus would expect Logan to defend Dorian alone.”

“So, ideally, Dorian should have been transported to Marcian city,” Alectan contemplated.

“No, Your Grace. Lord Marcian is a capable and reasonably powerful noble lord. But General Silas displeased when Primus demoted him from the general of the crown legions and promoted Giles Tamican to that position. So, I wonder if he'd send Dorian to be guarded in a city where Silas is present.”

Alectan shrugged. “Primus had no option except to send the real Dorian to Marcia. He cannot send Dorian to Ravesia for obvious reasons, nor to Titus, where only Logan can protect the prince.”

“We are missing something. If Primus thought that Dorian wouldn't have a better chance in another high city except for the capital, he would have taken the risk to safeguard his grandson himself in the capital,” Sylvius stated.

“No single noble lord and his army could withstand the united strength of the other noble lords,” Alectan grumbled.

“Primus would seek something that can withstand the power of all the noble lords for a few days so he may fly to his grandson's aid.”

Primus, what would you be searching for?

What am I missing?

Alectan sighed. “Primus only has three choices. Ravesian is the most apparent candidate, Titus is a timid scholar, and Marcian is an elderly guy.”

Timid scholar...

Yes...

One noble lord can never defy the united magic of all other noble lords. No, the answer that Primus must have been searching for is not in the strength of the magic possessed by the noble lord. Primus must have been looking for a high city and its noble lord with the ability to neutralize the primary strength of the other greedy noble lords—elemental magic.

Sylvius exclaimed in disbelief at having missed the obvious. "Lord Belarian Titus used to boast about his impregnable bunker made of a metal widely rumored to be impervious to magic."

Alectan frowned, trying to recall the information. "True...I recall Belarian bragging that he has the means to safeguard his progeny and avoid the civil war by entering a bunker that cannot be breached using magic."

Alectan also became animated as he pointed his hand toward Sylvius. "Spot on, Lomer. Lord Titus is a scholar and a distinguished architect who sculpted a thousand-foot-tall metal statue of himself."

"Yes...Titus city possesses the finest blacksmiths and armory in the country, supplying other cities with the finest weaponry and unique elemental casting designs. What if Lord Belarian Titus had indeed succeeded in inventing a metal impenetrable to magic?" Sylvius questioned.

Alectan waved his hands. "We can obtain further information on the bunker from our spies in Titus city. But how can we draw Dorian out of a bunker built of metal impervious to magic?"

Sylvius' mind worked on solving the new puzzle that would bring his master plan to fruition.

"We can have the Mayans assault Titus city. When Titus attempts to repel the Mayans, you might bring your legions to his aid and become the realm's hero."

"Meanwhile, Maleficus would be accused of allying with the Mayans as per our original plan," Alectan stated.

"And while Lord Titus is busy defending against the Mayans' surprise invasion, our soldiers may sneak into the palace and abduct Prince Dorian from his bunker," Sylvius answered.

"Hmm...Why would Dorian leave the bunker that safeguards him? We don't know how to demolish the bunker without using magic."

Sylvius smirked with malice. "Dorian would surrender to us if he wanted to save his girlfriend."

Erasmus chipped in with a frown. "Lomer, Gwen has already slipped our grasp. It is improbable that we can capture her again anytime soon."

"Yes...she did slip our grasp. But I've already slain several lomers of the king stationed on the Lemurian fortress to prevent the king from learning about the Mayan foray into Sukra."

"What have those lomers in the border town got to do with Gwen?" Erasmus voiced his thoughts.

"Primus would have no choice but to dispatch one of his trusted lomer to the border town to gather and report on the events in the valley." Alectan chipped in.

"And Gwen is the only lomer that the king can trust at the moment." Sylvius added, "I had already laid the trap to capture Gwen should we need her again."

Alectan grinned in comprehension. "We now know where to find Gwen. But does Dorian love your student enough to surrender himself to our mercy?"

"I hope so for Gwen's sake. If not, we will simply uproot the bunker from Titus and haul it to the nearby Elvantis Ocean, where we can threaten Dorian to surrender if he doesn't want to die at the bottom of an ocean while confined to a big metal box."

Alectan shook his head and stated, "I favor the first plan of using your student to coerce Prince Dorian to surrender."

"Certainly, My Lord." Sylvius bowed in response.

Erasmus, who had remained silent so far, finally spoke. "Although the strategy is sound, how can we be confident that we can control the Mayans to coerce them to assault Titus city?"

Sylvius extracted the bundle from his coat and displayed a sword box. "We can't keep those barbarians under control. But I've struck a deal with an Mayan chieftain, Jurak of the Wolf clan. I've informed him that I hold one of the oldest Mayan artifacts, a sword that may assist him in conquering the other Mayan clans."

Sylvius pulled a sword with an unusual appearance from the sword box and offered it to Lord Alectan. "This is the sword that pushed Sukra into this political quagmire."

Sylvius proceeded with gravity. "This sword was confiscated by King Valerian from the vanquished Mayan chieftain at the conclusion of the First Mayan War following the death of Livian, who perished defending the same Lemurian Valley we are attempting to breach MayaMayaMaya. The irony is that the same sword that spiraled the entire country into inevitable civil war may eventually usher in peace."

Lord Alectan admired the intricate craftsmanship of the sword. The distinctive pommel of the sword appeared to be composed of various gleaming metals. "This is one of the most well-balanced swords I've ever held. How did you acquire such a masterpiece?"

Maya "I had this sword stolen from the king's armory. I was able to find only one of the double swords. I do not know where Valerian hid the second sword."

Erasmus, who had been silent, regained his voice suddenly. "With only one of the two swords, how will you convince this Mayan chieftain to assault Titus?"

Sylvius grinned nefariously at him. "I shall offer him this sword as a sign of trust and ask him to assist us in bringing Titus city to its knees."

Alectan cocked his brow. "What will you do if he deceives you after acquiring the sword from you?"

Sylvius nodded at him. "A genuine possibility, but I'll tell him the twin sword is within the Titus city bunker. The wolf clan chieftain He has no option but to assist us in razing Titus City and obtaining the other sword if he wants to rule the barbarians as king."

"You are really devious, lomer. However, I cannot help but wonder why you want me to ascend to the throne. I have just observed you devise a strategy that could beat Primus at his own game."

Alectan gazed carefully at Sylvius. "I can't help but wonder whether you're still employed by Primus to entrap Maleficus and me with your plan."

Sylvius smiled at the lord. He had chosen wisely, indeed.

"I would have thought less of you if you had agreed to use my plan without knowing my genuine allegiance."

Sylvius held out his hand. "My Lord, do you want to truth-seek me?"

Lord Alectan fiercely grasped his hands and questioned him astutely. “Do you really want me to ascend the throne, and are you willing to sacrifice your life to ensure my ascension onto the Sukran throne?”

Sylvius raised his voice and declared. “Erasmus is dead.”

Lord Alectan gaped at the lomer while Erasmus snarled. “Are you out of your mind, old man? I am obviously still alive and breathing.”

“Yes, he lied. But I was unable to detect his lie.” Alectan replied with even greater admiration for this old lomer.

Sylvius shrugged. “I’ve been in this profession for far too long, and you tend to pick up a few skills along the way.”

Alectan huffed. “A rare ability possessed by only a handful of noble lords and ladies in the entire world. But why did you reveal to me that you could lie to a truth seeker if necessary, raising even more questions about your true allegiance?”

Sylvius smiled in response. “Precisely, My Lord. I don’t need to disclose my actual loyalties if necessary since I could simply lie, and you might not even realize I could lie to you. I want you to know I am as committed to this cause as you are.”

“How can I be sure you are so devoted to my cause? How can I be sure that you won’t abandon me just as you abandoned King Valerian?”

Sylvius allowed the spirit-casting abilities of Lord Alectan to feel his emotions. “In my estimation, you are the only noble lord with the compassion and ruthlessness required to succeed to the throne. Either there are noble lords like Maleficus who would destroy the entire kingdom to satisfy their hunger for power, or there are noble lords like Titus who lack the requisite ruthlessness to stand firmly against their adversaries. In addition, the fact that Prince Livian never concealed the fact that you were his best friend lends further credence to your claim.”

Alectan, who was attempting to uncover the truth behind Sylvius’ emotions, was taken aback.

“My Lord, none of us in this room are your friends,” Sylvius answered. “We are only your acquaintances with a shared goal.”

“What exactly do you mean, Lomer?” Erasmus hissed as Sylvius questioned his loyalty to Lord Alectan.

“Yes, Erasmus. You, like me, are acquainted with Lord Alectan to help him ascend the throne.”

“You allied with Lord Alectan to avenge the murder of your friend, Prince Livian, as you lack the army needed to defeat Maleficus, the true architect of the First Mayan War.”

Erasmus nodded in agreement. “True...I have joined Lord Alectan to safeguard not only Sukra from an impending war but also to save Livian's son—Prince Dorian. Livian saved me several times. Therefore, I owe it to him to save Dorian to the best of my abilities. But I can’t allow Dorian to ascend the throne and destroy the peace in the kingdom.”

"I chose you, Lord Alectan, since you were Livian’s friend and would be open to hearing a different strategy for using Dorian to seize the throne instead of killing him."

"Dorian is a poor elementalist compared to noble lords, and he would never scheme to gain the throne as he doesn't have sufficient magic to defend himself," Sylvius spoke out clearly and let his emotions be sensed for truth.

"Additionally, My Lord, I learned that you entered the contest for the Sukran throne only after Prince Livian's demise."

Alectan nodded remorsefully. "Yes, I chose to dethrone Valerian because he forfeited his right to govern when he failed to protect Livian, who may have become one of the greatest kings in our race's history."

"True...Nevertheless, the past cannot be undone. We have no choice except to look to the future."

Sylvius bowed before his new master. "I surrender to you and will lay down my life if necessary to assist you in ascending to the throne."

"Do you want us to gather that you are so devoted to the realm that you would even sacrifice your life?" Erasmus questioned Sylvius in disbelief.

"I am prepared to sacrifice not only my own life for the greater benefit of the realm but also a few other innocent lives. Although I had raised Gwen as a daughter, I have already betrayed her for this purpose so we might use her to ensnare Dorian. I was even willing to sacrifice her for our noble cause," Sylvius answered with a steely calm.

Alectan let go of Sylvius' hand. "It appears that you are speaking the truth, Lomer. After recognizing your shrewd knowledge, I will forever defend my back against you and have my spies constantly monitor you during this campaign."

"I know you had me under surveillance from the moment I approached Erasmus' legion."

Alectan chuckled at the audacious lomer. "It's no wonder you're regarded as the greatest lomer in our history. Maybe Primus' continued defiance of the noble lords' nefarious plans was attributed to your success."

Sylvius preserved his silence.

Lord Alectan offered the lomer a grin. "You are a highly skilled lomer, Sylvius. You ought to be able to handle everything that Primus throws at you. When do you plan to meet the Mayan chieftain?"

Sylvius regarded his master. "My Lord, I will meet him in three days, at which point we must have procured a signet weapon belonging to Maleficus himself. I want to hasten our invasion to prevent the king from taking unanticipated measures once he learns of the impending invasion."

Lord Alectan nodded thoughtfully. "I know someone who could obtain Maleficus' signet weapon. I shall request that he meet you in the Lemurian Valley with the weapon before you meet with the Mayan clan chief. This signet weapon can be employed to frame Maleficus."

Silence descended amongst the trio.

"Well done, Lomer. Take the night off and begin early tomorrow morning. Erasmus will aid you in your endeavors. You will serve as an advisor and strategist for this campaign, while Erasmus will command my legions," Lord Alectan declared.

He stiffened his voice. "Make sure you don't botch up this plan, which appears to be my greatest chance to claim the throne without civil war and the slaughter of too many innocents."

"Remember that, like the king, I am one of the most dangerous and powerful persons in the realm, and I will not take your failure lightly."

Sylvius bowed before Lord Alectan. "No, Your Grace. The future of the realm depends on this

mission, and I will ensure that the realm has a future.”

Lord Alektan nodded and returned to his quarters.

Erasmus whistled softly. "I did not expect you to witness tomorrow's sunrise, old man."

Sylvius grinned at the threatening swordsman. "Like the king and Lord Alektan, I am dangerous in my own way, Erasmus."

"True...I appreciate your clever plan, Lomer. I felt uneasy with so many great lords hunting Livian's son. Even though I know Dorian has little prospect of ascending the Sukran kingdom, I never wished for his death. I just wanted him to be eliminated from contention for the throne." Erasmus grimaced.

"In addition, I know Livian. He would never have..." Erasmus became speechless as he reflected on the great prince who had given him everything. The least he could have done was to save Livian's son from a horrible fate.

Perhaps the House of Primus will flourish after several centuries.

Meanwhile, Sylvius gazed at the supper placed on the dinner table. He wanted to partake in some of the delights following the meeting. Now that he knew the food was tainted, however, he would have to travel on an empty stomach once more.

"All right, let's commence my campaign to save Sukra," Sylvius grunted.

"We should begin immediately...however, I cannot shake the feeling that this campaign will not be as straightforward as you imagine," Erasmus replied.

Sylvius arched his brows. "The king will be too preoccupied with saving his grandson to care about the Mayan invasion. Other noble lords would be too preoccupied with defending their own interests and spend all their efforts to protect the Dorian sent as their charge. They would have no idea what struck them." Sylvius nonchalantly waved his hands.

"Who else has the resolve and determination to halt my quest to save Sukra?" Sylvius scoffed.